

RADICALIZATION PATHWAYS IN THE ONLINE CONTEXT: ACCOUNTING FOR
USER TRAJECTORIES ACROSS EXTREMIST SPACES

by

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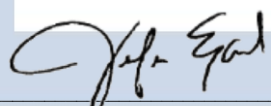
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ABSTRACT

The issue of radicalization has drawn significant attention over the last decade, as high-profile mobilizations and far-right violence grow increasingly prevalent in the United States. This has been accompanied by a particular interest in radicalization in the online context, as far-right recruitment and organizing increasingly leverages the affordances of digital platforms. In this dissertation, I advance theoretical understandings of online radicalization processes by analyzing differential participation within one growing and under-examined segment of the far-right: secular male supremacist movements. Based on prior literature identifying increasing extremism in these spaces, and increasing instances of users moving between distinct but related communities, I address two specific research questions: 1) what individual and community-level factors drive differences in engagement in male supremacist communities; and 2) what individual and community-level factors predict user migration to more extreme male supremacist communities?

To answer these questions, I draw on data from five male supremacist groups active across 52 forums on Reddit, drawing on longitudinal data from the Pushshift Reddit dataset to analyze three radicalization-related outcomes: rates of engagement, migration to new and more toxic communities, and disengagement. I draw on literatures on secular male supremacist ideology, differential participation and radicalization in the online context, and online engagement more generally to develop and test hypotheses regarding factors expected to predict these outcomes; I then utilize quantitative analysis, including fixed-effects negative binomial regression and discrete-time event history analysis, to identify significant predictors of differential participation and radicalization.

Overall, results show that radicalization within secular male supremacist communities on Reddit is shaped primarily by group identity, certain individual features of engagement or extremity, and the qualitative components of users' interactions within these spaces, all of which

work in concern to ‘push’ or ‘pull’ users through—or anchor them within—secular male supremacist spaces. These factors then operate alongside platform-level repression efforts to influence differential participation and user trajectories into extremism. Taken together, the analysis advances scholarship by highlighting the bolstering effect of having a diverse set of extremist spaces in which users can engage, identifying important effects of toxicity on extremism, determining which features of interaction are important for driving differential participation, and implicating platform-level repression efforts in driving radicalization.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

The issue of radicalization has drawn significant attention over the last decade, as high-profile mobilizations and far-right violence grow increasingly prevalent in the United States (Anti-Defamation League Center on Extremism 2023). Historically, the bulk of work on the processes driving such mobilizations have come from two key literatures: social movement scholarship has aimed to uncover processes that lead movements on the far left or far right to embrace increasingly extreme beliefs and practices (della Porta 2018), while the field of terrorism studies has sought to identify the mechanisms through which individuals connect with extremist groups or ideologies, and to understand when and how the acceptance of extreme beliefs translates into acts of extremist violence (Borum 2011; Vergani et al. 2020). More contemporarily, there has also been an emergent interdisciplinary interest in how information and communication technologies are shaping the tactics and efficacy with which extremist movements organize, disseminate, and recruit members (Conway 2017; Odağ, Leiser, and Boehnke 2019). This shifting focus towards the role of the internet in facilitating extremism is highly warranted, as many notable far-right mobilizations or instances of violence do indeed appear to have been previewed or organized in the online context—acts of misogynist terrorism have often been accompanied by social media posts corresponding with mass violence (DiBranco 2020, 2022a), and the January 6th attack on the Capitol in 2021, following the election of former Democratic President Joe Biden, was organized via social media (Frenkel 2021). Online spaces have also been heavily identified as salient sites for alt- and far-right recruitment and organizing more generally (Caren, Jowers, and Gaby 2012; Daniels 2018; DeCook 2020; Miltner 2014).

The disparate disciplines concerned with radicalization processes diverge some in their theorizing, but all are concerned with both the ideological and behavioral dimensions of extremism. Because these two facets of radicalization are not always as neatly coupled as one

might predict, a primary focus of much of the literature has also been on identifying what underlying processes drive some, but not other, individuals or groups to radicalize, and in which particular ways (Borum 2011; della Porta 2018).

Broadly speaking, previous work does point to a number of micro-, meso-, and macro-level factors that drive radicalization. Individual characteristics create a sense of openness to extreme messaging, which group dynamics reinforce and amplify; the acceptance of extreme views may become further entrenched by structural inequalities or state repression (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018; Vergani et al. 2020). However, this generally accepted model still leaves questions regarding some of the specific mechanisms that undergird radicalization; in particular, the factors that drive differential participation—i.e., the specific degree to which individuals become cognitively radicalized or participate in extremist movements—are not entirely clear.

Understanding such processes is not only theoretically necessary in order to provide robust accounts of how individuals become radicalized into extremism, but are also highly necessary in order to develop interventions. Further, additional opportunities for advancement are present in the area of online radicalization specifically, as extremist groups increasingly leverage digital tools (Conway 2017; Odağ et al. 2019). Critiques of work on online radicalization have rightly noted that the processes themselves are often under-attended to, and that much of the literature is either “laden with direct inferences from Web content to user radicalization” (Odağ et al. 2019:282), or tends to privilege analysis of the ideologies or media present in virtual spaces, rather than focusing on user behavior (Odağ et al. 2019).

In this dissertation, I set out to advance theoretical understandings of radicalization in both of the above areas by analyzing differential participation in online engagement within one growing segment of the far right: secular male supremacist movements. Specifically, I ask: 1) what

individual and community-level factors drive differences in engagement in male supremacist communities; and 2) what individual and community-level factors predict user migration to more extreme male supremacist communities? To address these questions, I conduct a quantitative analysis of three key waypoints within the radicalization process—rates of engagement, user migration into more extreme spaces, and disengagement from extremist communities—and highlight key factors that shape pathways into extremism for users in secular male supremacist communities on Reddit. In doing so, I identify key mechanisms that motivate or hinder extremism in the online context, and contribute to literatures on differential participation in extremist movements by moving beyond mere descriptive accounts in order to emphasize how interactions and relationships between users and their communities encourage (or discourage) radicalization.

Overview of Chapters and Findings

The substantive portion of this dissertation begins with a review of the relevant empirical and theoretical work informing the research questions. Chapter 2 provides a comprehensive overview of secular male supremacism and its associated subgroups, chronicling their emergence during the early days of the web and their evolution into a complex constellation of online communities housed within a network of websites, blogs, and forums colloquially known as ‘the manosphere.’ I also map the contours of the red pill philosophy shared throughout the manosphere, highlighting the foundational beliefs accepted by all secular male supremacist groups, as well as the differences with which they apply this particular misogynist ideology; in doing so, I synthesize a typology of grievances, goals, and harms present within, or emerging from, the varying secular male supremacist groups. In Chapter 3, I then return to discussions of online radicalization, identifying in more detail the limitations of current scholarship in this area, and situating engagement, user migration, and disengagement as key components of the processes that drive

trajectories into extremism. Throughout, I also present extensive hypotheses regarding the identifiable factors expected to predict these outcomes. Chapter 4 subsequently provides a detailed account of the data and methods used to test these proposed relationships, while Chapter 5 provides additional context on case selection and the development of secular male supremacist communities on Reddit specifically.

Empirical results from the main analyses testing proposed hypotheses are then presented in Chapters 6 through 8. Chapter 6 presents and interprets results from regression analyses predicting rates of engagement, while Chapters 7 and 8 present and interpret results of event history analyses modeling user migration to new male supremacist communities, and disengagement from participation in the Reddit manosphere, respectively. Overall, findings show that radicalization within secular male supremacist communities on Reddit is shaped primarily by group identity, certain individual features of engagement or extremity, and qualitative components of users' interactions, all of which work in concert to determine engagement and 'push' or 'pull' users through—or anchor them within—secular male supremacist spaces. These factors internal to the secular male supremacist groups under study then operate alongside platform-level repression efforts to influence differential participation and user trajectories across these spaces.

What does this mean, more concretely? First, findings show that users in older, more established communities engage more, and are less likely to disengage; in contrast, users in newer male supremacist communities post at rates that are significantly lower, and also frequently show higher odds of disengagement. Findings also show that user trajectories across spaces are influenced by the communities in which users participate. These findings build on previous work on secular male supremacist movements by highlighting the impact of group identity on user behavior, moving beyond mere comparisons of group ideologies.

Second, individual features of engagement—specifically tenure within male supremacist spaces and posting frequency—appear to have an anchoring effect, decreasing the odds of migration across communities or disengagement from the Reddit manosphere. Individual extremism in the form of toxicity also appears to have a radicalizing effect, increasing the likelihood of movement into more extreme spaces; alignment between the toxicity of users and the toxicity of the spaces in which they primarily engage is also shown to drive radicalization in this way, even when most measures of reception to user contributions are shown to have little impact. This suggests that both aspects of toxicity matter for radicalization, with more toxic users, or users encouraged by toxicity alignment, being pulled towards more extreme spaces, rather than pushed out of communities based on the reactions of other members. Taken together, these findings affirm previous work showing that toxicity at the individual level encourages radicalization within these spaces (Ribeiro et al. 2021); they also deepen understandings of online radicalization specifically by highlighting which factors known to drive online engagement more generally operate similarly in extremist spaces, and which are less relevant in the extremist context.

Third, and relatedly, measures of fit and reception appear to matter relatively little as determinants of differential participation or radicalization in the form of movement into more extreme spaces; reception metrics captured by Reddit’s unique affordances—such as posts scores or gildings—consistently show no effect. At the same time, users with posts marked as controversial by the Reddit algorithm were more likely to migrate to any new community, and users receiving more comments were more likely to disengage; users who received comments after a lengthier period of time were simultaneously *less* likely to disengage. This suggests that user interactions are at times relevant for pushing users out of, or anchoring them within, these spaces, but that the unobserved qualitative components of these interactions are more significant than the

quantifiable factors captured through Reddit's interface. These findings suggest that shallow measures of fit identified as salient in more general online interactions are not necessarily as significant in the online extremist context, but also support work indicating that a sense of belonging is an important determinant of engagement with extremist movements (della Porta 2018).

Finally, platform-level repression efforts, such as community bans, were shown to have a significant but mixed effect; users engaged less in the wake of community bans or other repressive measures, but were also more likely to migrate to more toxic communities. They also became less likely to disengage entirely. These results align with previous work finding that repression efforts may have a bifurcating effect, successfully discouraging more moderate movement members, while increasing the commitment and extremity of others (della Porta 2018; Zwerman, Steinhoff, and Porta 2000); it also suggests that the efficacy of platform-level interventions into extremism need to be considered from a number of angles in order to truly understand the impact repressive measures have on extremist online communities.

After presenting and interpreting the above findings in more detail in Chapter 6 through 8, I then return to the bigger picture in Chapter 9, synthesizing results from each individual set of analyses to highlight what the identified relationships indicate about online radicalization processes; there, I also discuss limitations, directions for future research, and the broader implications of the findings presented here.

CHAPTER 2: MALE SUPREMACISM, THE MANOSPHERE, AND MISOGYNY IN THE FAR-RIGHT

We begin, as we so often must, with definitions. In the introductory chapter, I briefly referenced the web of digital connections—influential websites, blogs, forums, and more—that have come to comprise the great bastion of male supremacism termed ‘the manosphere.’ The manosphere is organized misogyny or, if one wishes to more accurately capture the decidedly digital nature of the phenomenon, it is networked misogyny (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016)—misogyny made possible via the web thanks to the anonymity, interconnectivity, and reach that it affords.

The manosphere is also a perhaps unavoidable consequence of a confluence of factors: the long-standing, ever-evolving backlash that has repeatedly challenged feminism and its victories (Jordan 2016; Menzies 2007; Messner 2013); a shifting sociopolitical landscape wherein minority gains are juxtaposed against increasing economic strain and an uncertain future for traditional forms of (predominantly white) masculinity (Berbrier 2000; Gray 2018; Kaiser 2022); and the early and enduring development of a particular ‘geek’ masculinity that positions digital technologies and online spaces as rightfully under men’s purview (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016; Kendall 2000; Massanari 2017; Salter 2018). Indeed, the earliest groups present within the manosphere include pickup artists and men’s rights activists, the former of whom represent, at least in a part, a subset of geek-aligned men seeking to overcome a perceived disadvantage in the sexual marketplace (Almog and Kaplan 2017), and the latter of whom exist as a continuation of the (decidedly antifeminist) men’s rights movement that emerged in the 1970s (Ging 2017; Messner 2016). Over time, these seemingly disparate groups converged, expanded, and evolved, contributing to the subsequent development of the other communities housed within the manosphere. During this time, the respective ideologies of the groups within the manosphere have

also diffused and cross-pollinated, both with each other and with broader far-right ideologies that reflect similar sentiments regarding contemporary gender relations and masculinity's supposedly threatened status within contemporary society (Kaiser 2022; Mamié, Ribeiro, and West 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2021; Rothermel, Kelly, and Jasser 2022).

In this chapter, I begin my substantive discussion by reviewing the defining features of the manosphere. Male supremacism is a foundational ideology—it undergirds patriarchy, positioning men as more competent, valuable, and important than women; it generates notions of male superiority and male entitlement (Manne 2018). The ideology of organized male supremacism is all this and more. Within the manosphere, as well as within other far-right groups, the everyday sexism of patriarchal life is exaggerated and expanded, molded into a rallying point around which men organize and mobilize.¹ Understanding the unique contours of the manosphere's shared ideology is thus a requisite first step in understanding its perniciousness. So too is understanding the variation housed within the manosphere; it is comprised of distinct groups with distinct origins and interests, and while these groups share an ideology, they do not all share it exactly, nor are they identical in its applications. These differing interpretations and applications must be addressed in order for differences in the consequences of this worldview to be acknowledged, teased out, and theorized. As such, after overviewing the particular form of male supremacist ideology present within the manosphere, I review its variation, detailing the origins, belief systems, and

¹ In her work on organized white supremacy, Blee (2002) invokes the concept of everyday racism, which “reflects negative, stereotyped views of minority groups [but] lacks any systematic explanatory force” and which is “pernicious but unremarkable among whites in a racist society” (75). She juxtaposes this against what she terms ‘extraordinary racism,’ through which “everyday racism is intensified, made explicit, and mobilized against specific enemies” (75). Misogyny can be thought to operate similarly, present in more mundane fashion in patriarchal societies and transformed into something more virulent by male supremacist groups.

consequences of each group contained therein. After addressing these foundations, I then turn to the connections between the manosphere and other forms of organized male supremacism. As will be addressed, the groups housed within the manosphere align with, connect to, and bolster other sociopolitical forces aiming to enshrine misogyny and codify male dominance within Western culture. As cannot be overstated, the manosphere did not emerge in a vacuum, but is the product of a range of technological and social factors that have come together to create a unique opportunity for hate. Some of these factors—antifeminist backlash, gender essentialist views, male dominance in online spaces—are old and enduring, while others are contemporary developments, including the increasing economic precarity that threatens the status of white men, and the subsequent rise of the alt-right and its reinvigoration of far-right politics (Kaiser 2022).

Finally, after situating the manosphere as one significant piece of the contemporary political landscape and its alarming turn towards far-right extremism, I overview the theoretical benefits of studying this particular branch of organized male supremacism. I note the manosphere's unique potential as a means of recruitment into far-right extremism; its unique structure that facilitates increasing visibility of the radicalization process; and its undertheorized position relative to other far-right ideologies. Through this, I position organized male supremacism more broadly as a subject direly in need of focus in order to better understand the alarming spate of far-right political activity that has marked the last decade.

THE FOUNDATIONS OF THE MANOSPHERE

The origins of the manosphere are modest. The term itself appeared in 2009 as the title of a Blogspot post; it was later popularized through the 2013 publication of manosphere personality Ian Ironwood's book *The Manosphere: A New Hope for Masculinity* (Ging 2017). Ironwood is the author of the blog theredpillroom.com, which served as one of many hubs in the early manosphere, alongside sites such as Return of Kings, a men's interest website boasting articles such as “5

Reasons to Date a Girl with an Eating Disorder,”² and PUAhate.com, a misogynist forum for failed pickup artists (Ging 2017). In the decade and a half since the manosphere’s inception, the views, jargon, and interests expressed within have expanded alarmingly—what was once a niche corner of the web has moved increasingly towards the mainstream, with manosphere influencers such as former kickboxer and noted misogynist Andrew Tate amassing millions of followers on social media,³ and mainstream news outlets publishing dozens of articles aimed at defining the manosphere and its associated jargons for a general public more removed from the web’s misogynist underbelly. The term ‘Incel’, a portmanteau for ‘involuntary celibate’ and the label for one of the five primary groups housed within the manosphere, even made the shortlist for Oxford’s Word of the Year in 2018,⁴ highlighting the relevance of these communities in the public consciousness. (That Oxford ultimately chose ‘toxic’ for 2018’s Word of the Year instead is, perhaps, also illuminating.)

This increased attention has been accompanied by growing academic interest in the manosphere as well, though existing literature varies in how it defines the nature of the phenomenon. For some, it is viewed as a subculture or set of subcultures (Ging 2017; Nagle 2017), or as a space in which new hybrid masculinities are being constructed (Ging 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022). Others, more concerned with social movement processes or pathways into extremism, often treat the manosphere as a site of radicalization that incites violence (Baele, Brace, and Coan 2019; Hoffman, Ware, and Shapiro 2020; Jaki, Smedt, and Gwó 2019; Zimmerman, Ryan, and

² <https://www.buzzfeednews.com/article/ryanhatesthis/meet-the-author-behind-the-viral-5-reasons-to-date-a-girl-wi>

³ https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Andrew_Tate

⁴ <https://languages.oup.com/word-of-the-year/2018-shortlist/>

Duriersmith 2018), or as an affective public contributing to the emergence of a white, male identity politic (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Ging 2017; Kaiser 2022; Kelly 2020; Lyons 2017, 2022). The manosphere can, of course, be more than one of these things at once—the complexity of the social world allows any phenomena to be explored from a range of theoretical perspectives. Yet, the nature of theory-building also demands one commit to a body of theory on which to build; thus, I approach the manosphere as a new, digitally-mediated and extremist iteration of the men’s movements that have long organized in reaction to feminist activism (Jordan 2016; Messner 2013, 2016). Such men’s movements have historically operated on two different levels. Those such as the mythopoetic men’s movements of the 1980s and 1990s have worked to redefine what it means to be men in the wake of changing gender dynamics (Heath 2003); they encouraged men “to pursue a deeper, essentialized essence of masculinity through fraternal, ritualized identity processes that utilize support from other men” (Schmitz and Kazyak 2016:2)—a legacy that continues within certain manosphere communities. Other groups, such as the men’s rights movement, have focused squarely on organizing a backlash against feminist gains, and positioning men as the real victims of gender inequality (Gotell and Dutton 2016; Menzies 2007; Messner 2013, 2016); this approach too is represented within the manosphere. Further, the manosphere also represents a new iteration of organized male supremacism, one wherein male supremacist views are placed explicitly at the forefront of the movement; this exists in contrast to other far-right movements, such as organized white supremacist or religious fundamentalist movements, wherein male supremacism is embedded more covertly alongside notions of duty to God, race, or country (DiBranco 2020; Kaiser 2022). The term *secular* male supremacism has been used to distinguish manosphere groups, for whom misogyny is the explicit rallying point, from these previously existent groups

for whom misogyny is aspectual or supplementary (DiBranco 2020); I follow this convention at times to distinguish these groups from other forms of organized male supremacism.

The secular male supremacism of the manosphere is distinguished from other forms of organized male supremacism not only through its divorce from religious fundamentalist values or explicit white supremacism, but also through its own embrace of a particular brand of male supremacist ideology, often referred to by adherents simply as ‘the red pill,’ or ‘red pill philosophy’ (Ging 2017), or sometimes as or sometimes as ‘red pill theory.’⁵ The red pill metaphor is not unique to the manosphere, but rather is shared across many right-leaning and fringe communities; it is used by alt-right adherents and conspiracy theorists alike (Lewis and Marwick 2017). The analogy draws from the film *The Matrix*, wherein the protagonist, Neo, swallows a red pill that awakens him to the dystopian reality of human enslavement by machines (Ging 2017; Lewis and Marwick 2017). Among the far-right and conspiracy theorists more generally, taking the red pill refers broadly to accepting counterfactual views as objective truths; within the manosphere, it refers specifically to a complex set of misogynistic beliefs regarding the nature of contemporary gender relations (Lewis and Marwick 2017). The manosphere’s red pill supposedly awakens men to a particular biological and social reality wherein gender essentialism is natural law, and feminism is rooted in the denial of gender difference in order to secure female advantage and oppress men (Ging 2017; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016; Van Valkenburgh 2018). It is these dually-held beliefs that then allow men within the manosphere to construct the shared sense of victimization and

⁵ Indeed, ‘Red Pill Theory’ is one of the many flairs available to users posting on <https://www.reddit.com/r/TheRedPill/>.

masculinity under threat that undergirds their political identity and links them to other segments of the far-right (Kaiser 2022; Kelly 2020).

‘All Women are Like That’: The Biological Essentialism of the Red Pill

Red pill philosophy is, at its core, an ideology that serves to uphold narratives of male superiority—a feat that is in large part accomplished through the initial positioning of men and women as not only innately different,⁶ but also inherently unequal in their capabilities and moral underpinnings (Ging 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Adherents draw on biological essentialism—and evolutionary psychology more specifically—to bolster this view and construct a pseudoscientific foundation for their misogynistic beliefs (Hoffman et al. 2020; Krendel 2020; Lin 2017; Mountford 2015; Sugiura 2021; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Members of the manosphere grant particular primacy to sexual selection and mating strategy as biological imperatives that subsequently drive gender essentialist behavior and shape gender relations more broadly (Krendel 2020; Mountford 2015; Van Valkenburgh 2018).

A defining feature of the red pill worldview is an understanding of sexual politics as a zero-sum game; men and women are viewed as having distinctly different biological imperatives that exist in opposition to one another. Men are seen as having a base urge to mate widely, preferably with high-value (i.e., conventionally attractive) women (Menzie 2020; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Women, in contrast, are portrayed as having somewhat disparate instincts, which are seen as reflecting women’s dual role as both the (supposed) predestined gatekeepers of physical reproduction, and the primary party responsible for attending to offspring that result from said

⁶ This is a departure from the earlier notions of sex roles or gender complementarianism that were commonly present in earlier iterations of the men’s rights movement (see Messner 1998).

couplings (Van Valkenburgh 2018). As such, men are seen as having a singular desire to attain sex with lots of different women, while women are viewed as having a dual biological imperative to (1) secure quality genetic material for conception (i.e., to mate with a high-value partner) and (2) secure material resources to support said offspring. Within the red pill framework, men who are suitable for the former are not necessarily the same as those suitable for the latter, leading to a worldview wherein

women hold a biological imperative to have sex with a certain type of man and to marry a man with a different set of traits. In particular, women are presumably driven to marry men who are emotionally and economically supportive and who will help them raise their children. At the same time, women are thought to have a contradictory biological urge to sleep with men who will provide them with ‘good genes’ but who won’t necessarily help support offspring (Van Valkenburgh 2018:9).

These supposedly different biological imperatives—and individuals’ ability (or inability) to meet them—then serve as a basis for red pill constructions of masculinity and femininity. Further, the emphasis on mating strategy creates a framework wherein individuals are irrevocably situated as players within a sexual marketplace, and wherein the respective genders are seen as being in competition both with each other and among themselves; this sense of competition is seen as shaping both gendered behavior and social relations more broadly (Menzie 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Men become defined and ranked according to their ability to succeed in attaining sex, and are thus divided into either ‘alphas’—the high value men who demonstrate the good genes women desperately wish to access (i.e., men whom women want to fuck)—or ‘betas’—lower value men who may be exploited for economic and familial support, but whom women do not actually desire (Ging 2017; Lilly 2016; Menzie 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022;

Van Valkenburgh 2018). This sentiment is so foundational to red pill philosophy that it is pithily summarized in the manosphere maxim ‘alpha fux, beta bux’ (Eddington 2020; Ging 2017; Wasniewska 2020).

The manosphere construction of masculinity is reductive, but under close inspection reflects little more than the employment of pseudoscientific tropes to reinforce traits—strength, affluence, dominance, stoicism, etc.—long associated with a dominant hegemonic masculinity; alpha men are seen as embodying these characteristics, while beta men are not (Ging 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022). Manosphere constructions of women, however, reflect something slightly different than traditional gender stereotypes or notions of an ascendent femininity that complements a dominant masculinity (Schippers 2007); instead, red pill philosophy draws on the biological essentialist view to portray women in an intensely unfavorable fashion, and to position women as incapable of overcoming the shortcomings of their sex. One might assume that women’s dual need for good genes and childrearing support would require them to engage in a form of mental calculus to select a mate with a balanced blend of genetic suitability, emotional intelligence, and material resources; instead, secular male supremacism positions these biological imperatives as polluting influences, drawing on them to “support a recurring catalogue of claims: that women are irrational, hypergamous, hardwired to pair with alpha males, and need to be dominated” (Ging 2017:649). Krendel (2020) similarly identifies that “assumed biological drives lead to both animalistic and mechanistic parallels, in that women are both predetermined to view partners as an animalistic ‘mate,’ and lack the ability to act otherwise due to their ‘programming’” (620).

In either case, the narratives present reduce women to something less than truly agentic beings—a discursive twist that is not directed at men to nearly the same degree, despite them being noted as having their own natural instincts regarding sex and reproduction. The manosphere

perspective, then, is one in which women are rendered uniquely incapable of behaving in ways that do not connect to or serve their reproductive goals; even women not consciously seeking to engage in childbearing are seen as unable to help their sexual attraction to alpha males, or their desire to attain the *most* alpha partner. It is here that the concept of hypergamy becomes most clear: women are viewed as having an unavoidable propensity to ‘mate up’ at any given opportunity, rendering them not only hapless slaves to their biological drives, but also disloyal sluts incapable of honoring sexual fidelity, or of declining opportunities to serve their own desires, thus leaving men vulnerable to exploitation or abandonment. This tendency is heavily discussed across the manosphere, where women are, with alarming frequency, “described as selfish or exploitative... deceptive... and incapable of controlling such behavior” (Krendel 2020:619). Indeed, hypergamy has been identified as one of the most commonly used pieces of jargon with the manosphere, and is often invoked in connection with disloyalty or selfishness (Farrell et al. 2020; Mountford 2018).

Key within these claims is a resolute view that biology dictates behavior on all levels—at least so far as women are concerned. Biological imperatives are viewed as guiding behavior even when women attempt to conceal or deny that this is the case, so that within the red pill framework any sense of agency or alternative goals on the part of women are illusions at best and outright deceptions at worst; manosphere forums are replete with claims such as “most women are miserable having careers, because female instinct revolves around ‘manipulating men to build a home’” (Lin 2017:89). As with ‘alpha fux, beta bux’ this sentiment is so common as to have its own shorthand in the form of the reductive acronym ‘AWALT’—short for “all women are like that” (Furl 2022).

Men, perhaps thanks to the comparable simplicity of their reproductive agenda, are not viewed as limited by their reproductive instincts. Instead, narratives of women’s selfishness,

deceitfulness, and irrationality are accompanied by “a simple worldview, according to which men function as the pillars of all culture and civilization while women can only exercise their power in one way—with their biologically female bodies” (Kaiser 2022:31). This is held to be true despite the alpha-beta divide, both because this divide does not impact men’s relatively simple biological imperative to sleep with women, and because beta status in particular is, more often than not, treated as a mutable trait—one that may be inflicted on men by social conditions that denigrate or aim to eliminate alpha masculinity, and that may be cured through the embrace and application of red pill philosophy (Rothermel et al. 2022; Van Valkenburgh 2018).

Biological essentialism, then, serves as a foundation for a belief in male superiority, accomplished largely through the construction of women as so limited in practical and moral capability as to leave men the only worthwhile sex. Importantly, this narrative does more than validating misogyny and male supremacist beliefs; it also serves as a foundation for the second key tenet of red pill philosophy: antifeminism.

From Essentialism to Antifeminism: The Construction of Male Victimhood

It is perhaps unsurprising that a worldview positioning women as innately biologically inferior then serves as a basis for antifeminism—after all, where is the credibility in fighting for gender equality, if one rejects the very notion that the sexes are equal? Yet, red pill philosophy also moves beyond positioning feminism as a misguided notion by those who fail to understand the reality of gender essentialism; rather, the red pill treats feminist gains and increasing attention to gender issues as part of an organized, calculated and intentional campaign to secure female advantage at a societal level (Lewis and Marwick 2017; Lin 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016). This is in part because the logic of secular male supremacism is reductive, viewing relations between the sexes as inherently competitive; feminism, then, becomes

synonymous with female sexual strategy and is viewed as a means through which women strengthen their social position via a coordinated effort to disadvantage and oppress men (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Lewis and Marwick 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Put differently, the red pill perspective views the social and legal gains afforded by feminism as tantamount to state capture by feminists and the embedding of misandry in the cultural milieu, so that ultimately

in a dazzling reconstitution of recent political history, feminist women are thereby seen as to have succeeded in inscribing their gender-slanted beliefs and practices into the very foundations of state policy... feminists have become the imperial colonizers and engineers of the modern state, while their male counterparts are left to fend for themselves in an increasingly peripheral private realm (Menzies 2007:77).

It is important here to note that this perspective is not wholly unique to the red pill; indeed, the anti-progressive narratives of other far-right movements frequently also treat feminism as unseemly and a threat to national order (Blee 2012, 2020; Kaiser 2022; Menzies 2007; Wilson 2020). Within the red pill framework, however, this narrative is at the forefront rather than highly-coupled with religious fundamentalism, white supremacy, or vague concerns over the ‘traditional family’ (Kaiser 2022). The concept of misandry is also one that is most highly invoked by secular male supremacist groups in particular, and that serves as a key discursive mechanism through which men unify and attempt to discredit the feminist movement; Marwick and Caplan (2017) note how “misandry serves as a boundary object, serving to coordinate and convey meaning amongst ingroup and outgroup participants” (546) and that men within these communities “share a central belief that feminine values dominate society, that this fact is suppressed by feminists and ‘political correctness,’ and that men must fight back against an overreaching, misandrist culture to

protect their very existence” (546). Indeed, one of the purported benefits of ‘taking the red pill’ is that it can supposedly “awaken men to feminism’s misandry and brainwashing” (Rothermel et al. 2022:122). This belief in feminism as a not merely detrimental but seemingly *malicious* force is somewhat distinct, and reflects an intensification of the claims of earlier antifeminist movements, which were originally more prone to argue that patriarchy harmed both men and women, or to reject the claim that patriarchy benefitted men at women’s expense (Gotell and Dutton 2016; Messner 1998, 2016). Secular male supremacism would instead have one believe that feminism specifically and intentionally benefits women *at men’s expense* (Lewis and Marwick 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022), and that the push for gender equality is nothing more than “a self-serving attempt by women to subvert natural power dynamics and establish (and maintain) women’s dominance over men” (James 2024:527).

This framing is evidenced in much manosphere discourse, which repeatedly and emphatically positions men as victims of this unjust order and thus facilitates “building virtual communities founded on malice against feminists and mobilizing men on the basis of a claimed identity as victims” (Gotell and Dutton 2016:72). These victimization narratives present men as suffering unduly at the hands of an aggressive, misandrist ideology that leaves them institutionally and culturally disadvantaged. Such disadvantages include labor market discrimination against men, driven by affirmative action policies and DEI efforts; a lack of attention to men’s health issues; unfair expectations within contemporary dating norms; perceived inequities in the areas of family law (particularly around child custody proceedings and alimony obligations, the latter of which is seen as a salient enough inequity to have been termed ‘divorce rape’ by some manosphere groups); and an overall attack on masculinity as a whole (Carian 2022; Gotell and Dutton 2016;

Lewis and Marwick 2017; Mountford 2018; Rothermel et al. 2022; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016; Van Valkenburgh 2018).

Again, these claims are not wholly unique—many have been expressed by either other segments of the far-right concerned with the declining status of white masculinity in particular (Berbrier 2000; Blee 2012; Gray 2018), or by previous iterations of antifeminist men’s movements (Jordan 2016; Messner 2013, 2016). What is novel, however, is the degree to which these claims connect to the aforementioned narratives of intentional male oppression (thus becoming imbued with a conspiratorial logic) and the ways in which such claims are undergirded by the biological essentialism of the red pill. Women are, within the red pill framework, treated as innately prone to irrational and unscrupulous behavior in an attempt to serve their biological imperatives; men within the manosphere then attempt to discredit the feminist movement through practices such as sharing content and anecdotes perceived to show evidence of inconsistencies and irrationalities in feminist thinking, which is seen as reflective of the limited capabilities that accompany women’s true nature (Schmitz and Kazyak 2016). Feminism is also, in its supposed quest to invert natural dynamics and secure female advantage, viewed as a social force responsible for generating increasing swathes of ‘beta’ men in contemporary society, thus connecting antifeminist narratives to the alpha/beta dichotomy that defines manosphere constructions of masculinity. Here, societal and cultural efforts to redefine masculinity are seen as the result of a coordinated feminist campaign to ‘beta-ize’ men and make them more exploitable (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Lilly 2016; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Such changes are seen as granting women greater power in sexual relations (by making women’s pursuit of sex with alpha men more permissible), and as rendering men more willing to support offspring that are not theirs, permitting women to ‘have it all’ (Lilly 2016).

Biological essentialism and antifeminism, then, combine to create narratives of female inferiority that are paired with pre-existing antifeminist tropes to discredit the feminist movement and those who support it. Feminist women are viewed as self-serving, while feminist men are seen as victims of a feminist campaign to create exploitable ‘betas’. The shared sense of victimization that emerges from the manosphere’s staunch antifeminism then bolsters their third foundational belief: a need for a male identity politic aimed at combatting feminist forces.

COMBATting FEMINIST FORCES: MANOSPHERE GROUPS AND THEIR (A)POLITICS

Taken together, the biological essentialism and staunch antifeminism of secular male supremacist groups paints a bleak picture: men—the innately superior sex—are under assault by conspiratorial feminist forces, which aim to secure female advantage through a coordinated attack on men and masculinity. Traditional masculinity is vilified as part of an effort to render men into more exploitable betas and deny them their rightful dominant social position, while women secure social benefits for themselves.

Within this framework, ‘taking the red pill’ is arguably a political act—it becomes a necessary first step to preserving a hegemonically masculine ideal, undoing men’s systemic disadvantage, and combatting the covert female dominance attained by feminism. However, the degree to which this politic is collective in character—or even outwardly acknowledged—does vary some across manosphere groups, and is in part informed by manosphere adherents’ differing understandings of both the nature of their victimization, and the potential solutions to it (Lilly 2016; Rothermel et al. 2022). While all groups are unified in viewing feminism as a detrimental social force, previous work shows that this sense of victimization operates at two levels. On the one hand, certain men within the manosphere come to view themselves as *collectively* victimized thanks to the threat feminism poses to men at the structural level; on the other hand, men also

construct accounts of *personal* victimization as feminism is seen as reshaping not just society, but men themselves (Lilly 2016; Rothermel et al. 2022). Similarly, groups within the manosphere differ in whether they advocate for collective or individual action in response to their plight.

Both these perspectives are present to varying degrees across the manosphere. At the personal level, men within the manosphere engage in work not dissimilar to that found in previous mythopoetic or Christian men's movements such as Promise Keepers, which emphasized personal development as a means of adapting to changing gender politics (Heath 2003). This perspective calls on men to combat feminism's negative effects by embracing an ethos of personal responsibility for overcoming grievances; indeed, manosphere forums show heavy evidence of discussion on personal growth and the political nature of personal relationships (Mountford 2018). Here, men come to see the red pill as the means through which they as individuals can recognize the beta-izing effects of contemporary society, and then reshape themselves into alphas in order to achieve personal fulfilment and sexual success with women; achieving a more alpha masculinity may be seen as both personally and politically beneficial, as personal resistance and the increasing number of alpha males in society offers hope for combatting the ill effects of feminism (Ging 2017; Mountford 2018; Rothermel et al. 2022).

Other segments of the manosphere, rather than focusing on individual action, emphasize the assertion of rights as the solution to perceived social problems caused by women's personal and legal gains (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016; Lodhia 2014; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016). Such discussions may also advocate for engagement in personal enrichment to allow men to cease living as unhappy betas, but these are combined with claims that men's rights are being violated or are under threat; here, there is an emphasis on how the devaluation of masculinity by feminism has impacted broader social institutions rather than individual experiences or interpersonal

relationships (Lilly 2016; Menzies 2007; Rothermel et al. 2022). However, it is also important to note that members of these communities are still primarily focused on the collective expression of *grievances*, rather than any significant activist efforts (Ging 2017).

It is at this point that further discussion becomes impossible without attending more deeply to the variation present among secular male supremacist groups. The manosphere at its core is comprised of five distinct segments—pickup artists, men’s rights activists, misogynist incels, men going their own way, and the red pill. Each of these groups vary some in their diagnoses and solutions to the perceived problem of feminist victories and women’s nature run amok; they also vary in their misogynist activism and negative social impact. For each group, then, I trace their origins and highlight their primary concerns, reviewing what is unique about their particular understanding or application of red pill philosophy, and identifying what—if any—negative outcomes have been connected to their particular segment of the manosphere. It is important here to note that while the histories of these groups may at times seem to suggest that movements between specific groups should be more common, prior work on migration between manosphere communities has shown that men often flow through these communities in counterintuitive ways (Ribeiro et al. 2021); this is discussed in greater detail in Chapter 5.

Pickup Artists (PUAs)

The PUA community represents one of the founding communities within the manosphere, and holds a relatively unique position in that it boasts no connection to pre-existing social movements, and included no initial stake in organized struggles over sexual politics. Instead, the

PUA community emerged in the 2000s as a pop culture phenomenon,⁷ based largely around a booming self-help industry that promised to teach heterosexual young men sexual strategy techniques colloquially referred to as ‘game’ (King 2018). The initial premise of the PUA community and its accompanying materials was that, through the application of specific presentational and interactional techniques, men who were unsuccessful in navigating dating and hookup culture could ultimately become sexually successful (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; King 2018). Given that the industry’s target consumers are men who previously had little luck with sex or relationships, it is perhaps unsurprising that “the target audience for such groups is primarily socially awkward men, who are often stereotyped as nerds” (Almog and Kaplan 2017:31). This demographic base, and the general dominance of a ‘geek’ masculinity in early online spaces, also contributed to early the development of PUA communities in the online context specifically (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Denes 2011; King 2018).

The PUA community, and the gender-reductive logics of ‘game,’ provided a key part of the foundation upon which red pill philosophy was born. From its earliest inceptions, the PUA perspective was rooted in an essentialist and transactional worldview, wherein men and women existed within a sexual marketplace; men then ‘invested’ in performing the particular brand of masculinity women ostensibly desired—a feat which typically involved learning to align with more stereotypically hegemonically masculine traits—in order to generate ‘returns’ on the dating market in the form of success with women (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Denes 2011;

⁷ Pickup artistry as a concept existed prior to this time, and can ultimately be traced back to the 1970s publication of Eric Weber’s *How to Pick Up Girls*. However, it wasn’t until the late 1990s and early 2000s that a more organized PUA community emerged, in large part thanks to the connectivity afforded by the web. For a more detailed history, see King 2018.

Rothermel et al. 2022). A key presupposition of ‘game’ was that—due to biology and the principles of evolutionary psychology—all women find the same base characteristics desirable, and respond relatively uniformly to particular seduction strategies (Denes 2011). Over time, this belief evolved to reflect the particular biological essentialism and supposed gender dynamics espoused by the red pill; PUA artists now explicitly draw on red pill philosophy to serve the goal of attaining sex with women (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Ging 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022).

Notable thus far is the absence of any particular structural concerns regarding modern gender politics, and for good reason. While the PUA community, like all other segments of the manosphere, espouses views critical of feminism (Cousineau 2020; Ging 2017), their primary concerns operate at the individual level and are relatively myopic in focus given their specific emphasis on sexual strategy. The result is that

PUAs have no shared diagnosis of society. What unites them is that they strive for individual success to attract women and become involved with them, either aiming at sexual encounters or seeking long-term relationships... Aside from temporary obstacles to their sexual success, which are to be solved individually through self-improvement, PUAs are not actively advocating against the society and economy in which they live.

Their explicit social diagnosis only seems to concern gender relations, which they tend to frame in the economic language of ‘investment’ (Rothermel et al. 2022:125–26) .

The ‘explicit social diagnosis’ here refers to the red pill conception of contemporary gender relations; men within this community seek to attain sex with women, and do so in a social context where feminism and its gains are viewed as creating a disadvantage (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Rothermel et al. 2022). Put differently, feminism is viewed as a negative force by PUAs, but their primary concern in this regard is its impact on the field in which ‘game’ is played. The red

pill, then, is the solution to this particular problem, because it helps men to embrace biological essentialist principles and develop the alpha masculinity women desire (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Ging 2017). Here, women's biological imperatives become viewed as making women not only manipulative, but manipulatable. As such, much PUA advice focuses on both outer and inner transformation, presenting lessons on not only self-presentation, but also shifting thought patterns and expectations to increase men's general sense of confidence and ease when interacting with women (Almog and Kaplan 2017; Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; King 2018).

The relatively narrow and individualist focus of the PUA community may at first glance appear limited in its ability to cause harm, but previous work highlights both social and interpersonal negative consequences coming from this community. The PUA community's roots in a lucrative self-help industry mean that some of the earliest manosphere influencers, and some of its most problematic content, came out of PUA spaces. For example, the website Return of Kings, a highly popular website in the manosphere's earliest days, was owned and popularized by prominent pickup artist Roosh Valizedah, and was an early hub through which red pill philosophy was developed and spread; articles posted to this site included "No One Would Have Died if PUAHate Killer Elliot Rodger Learned Game," and "27 Attractive Girls Who Became Ugly Freaks because of Feminism."⁸ Valizedah later drew a great deal of negative attention for a 2015 essay entitled "How to Stop Rape," which proposed the legalization of rape on private property as a solution to sexual assault through the claim that this would teach women to "protect themselves from easily preventable acts and... take responsibility for their actions."⁹

⁸ <https://archive.org/details/returnofkings>

⁹ <https://web.archive.org/web/20180117191527/http://www.rooshv.com/how-to-stop-rape>

Indeed, much of the concern over the PUA community specifically has focused on the red pill's problematic understanding of consent, and its frequent advocacy of 'sexual strategy techniques' that resemble or outright constitute rape (Carlo 2023; Ging 2017; Wright 2020). The sexual strategy presented by the red pill suggests that, in part due to women's irrational nature and irreversible biological imperatives, women's words and actions are often unaligned, and that men should focus on physical rather than verbal cues when assessing whether women desire sex; men are also frequently encouraged to attempt to manipulate physical responses to induce desire regardless of verbal consent (Carlo 2023; Denes 2011; Wright 2020). The concept of 'token resistance' or 'last minute resistance' is also heavily embedded in pickup artist teachings—the idea here is that women will frequently say no when they truly mean yes, due to a desire to not appear 'slutty,' a desire to see their male partner 'prove' dominance by pushing through resistance, or some combination thereof (Carlo 2023; Denes 2011; Wright 2020). As such, one of the primary harms that can be seen to come from the PUA segment of the manosphere is the reproduction of ideologies that reproduce and perpetuate rape culture, and that directly contradict feminist efforts to instill broader social norms of enthusiastic consent.

Men's Rights Activists (MRAs)

MRAs can be considered the second founding group of the manosphere; they are also the group with the longest organized history, as the MRAs associated with secular male supremacism represent a digital iteration of the antifeminist men's rights movement that emerged in the 1970s alongside second-wave feminism (Menzies 2007; Messner 2016). Early iterations of the men's rights movement organized around claims that men, alongside women, were victims of gender inequality; they "stressed the costs of narrow conceptions of masculinity to men, and either downplayed or angrily disputed feminist claims that patriarchy benefitted men at women's

expense” (Messner 2016:8). At the time of its inception, a major focus of the movement was perceived disadvantages in the area of family law, with a particular emphasis on father’s rights and perceived inequalities relating to child support payments and child custody (Gotell and Dutton 2016; Messner 2016). While other men’s movements did originate at the same time focused primarily on addressing the harms patriarchy inflicted upon men,¹⁰ the men’s rights movement was distinct in that developed in *opposition* to feminism, rather than as a complementary movement, and can be primarily considered a reactive or ‘backlash’ movement (Jordan 2016; Messner 2016). Over time, MRA talking points have also developed to at times incorporate a postfeminist narrative of achieved equality to justify decreasing attention to women’s issues (Carian 2022).

The men’s rights movement lost a great deal of steam between the 1980s and early 2000s, but the past decade and some has shown a resurgence of MRA activity, driven by structural changes including the institutionalization of feminist policies; a postfeminist neoliberal ethos that eschew systemic explanations for social inequalities; and economic shifts including deindustrialization that leave men—and working class men, in particular—in a more precarious position than they found themselves three decades ago (Kaiser 2022; Messner 2016). It is this resurgent iteration of the men’s rights movement that is present within the manosphere, and that operates alongside the other secular male supremacist groups; the contemporary men’s rights movement is also defined by qualitative distinctions that set it apart from the movement’s previous waves. In particular, contemporary men’s rights discourse is more intensely antifeminist and overtly misogynistic, and heavily employs adversarial and injustice frames to position men as victims of a heartless feminist

¹⁰ For an overview of the distinctions between the men’s rights movement and its political foil, the men’s liberation movement, see Messner 1998 and 2016.

agenda (Lewis and Marwick 2017; Lumsden 2019); it also constructs feminism specifically as a tool for male oppression, and positions the institutionalization of feminist policies as a reflection of a misandrist state (Carian 2022; Ging 2017; Lewis and Marwick 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016). Finally, the contemporary men's rights movement is also more loosely networked, digitally mediated, and hostile, and has shifted away from pushing for legal change, instead focusing on "building virtual communities founded on malice against feminists and mobilizing men on the basis of a claimed identity as victims" (Gotell and Dutton 2016:72).

Altogether, then, the MRA segment of the manosphere demonstrates a greater preoccupation with the second aspect of red pill ideology: antifeminism. For MRAs, "to be a man in a culture of misandry is evidently to be perpetually beleaguered, reviled, and endangered. For its part, in ways both moral and epistemological, feminism is, at its core, about the promotion of hatred and untruth" (Menziez 2007:73). At the same time, MRAs do embrace red pill constructions of masculinity and femininity as well; the supposed heartlessness of feminists is viewed as the result of women's biological inferiority and the negative traits attributed to women by red pill ideology, and feminism is also often positioned as driven by women's irrational, self-serving nature (Ging 2017; Lilly 2016; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016).

While contemporary MRAs show little involvement in actual political activism, they have been identified as engaging in detrimental forms of collective action, including a number of high-profile online harassment campaigns aimed at feminist figures; these campaigns are distinguishable from more mundane forms of online harassment in that they share six distinct characteristics: the participation of numerous individuals; the employment of gender-based insults; the use of vicious language; the purveyance of credible threats; an unusual intensity, scope, or longevity; and a reaction to women speaking out (Mantilla 2013). The credible threats included

here frequently include threats of violence, including sexual violence, and have on multiple occasions led feminist writers or cultural critics to temporarily leave their homes or relocate entirely (Mantilla 2013; Sobieraj 2020).

Misogynist Incels (Incels)

The term Incel—a portmanteau for ‘involuntary celibate’—and its associated communities first originated in the 1990s, on a website and forum founded by a queer woman seeking support for her lack of success finding sex and relationships (Taylor 2018). The original intentions of this community were neither extremist nor misogynistic—open to all genders, it was meant as a space where individuals could connect with others who shared their struggles (Taylor 2018). By the 2000s, however, a number of decidedly misogynistic Incel spaces had emerged within the manosphere (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Ribeiro et al. 2021), in no small part because the PUA industry was, for many young men, failing to fulfill its promise of confidence and sexual success (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019). Disillusionment with the PUA industry ultimately transformed into increasingly hostile misogyny as “the blame for failure quickly and vehemently move[d] from the [PUA] con game to the recalcitrant instruments for self-confidence: women” (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019:5013). Bratich and Banet-Weiser (2019) note the 2014 renaming of the website *PUAHate.com* to the decidedly more misogynistic *Sluthate.com* as evidence of this shift.

Incels serve as a fatalistic foil to pickup artists. Where the ‘game’ of the PUA industry asserts that anyone can learn to embody the qualities women desire, and thus become sexually successful, Incels instead came to view sexual success with women as hinging on a number of predetermined biological characteristics—and to view themselves as lacking these traits (Maxwell et al. 2020; Menzie 2020). Put differently, rather than embracing red pill ideology as a means

through which one can become more alpha, Incels view alpha status as an innate and immutable characteristic, and see themselves as thus irreversibly excluded from the sexual marketplace due to women's hard-wired desire for alpha men (Maxwell et al. 2020; Menzie 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022). Further, Incel men view themselves as so undesirable as to not even achieve the status of exploitable betas, which contributes to a broader narrative of sexual, romantic, and social exclusion (Hoffman et al. 2020; Maxwell et al. 2020; Menzie 2020). Incel men thus have the most deterministic application of the red pill, one that has been refined into its own specific metaphor of the 'black pill'. The black pill metaphor contrasts with the red pill in that

the 'red pill' reveals the truths about women and society. It empowers those who take it to fully recognize the inherently shallow nature of women, but also to understand better how men can manipulate and exploit these supposed female characteristics. The black pill, however, is completely nihilistic—taking it means accepting a harsher reality than the red pill reveals, a reality where women and society are intrinsically biased against men who lack specific physical attributes, and who therefore have no hope of ever being attractive or even accepted by society. 'Taking the black pill' is critical to the incel identity, as it means recognizing 'inceldom' as a permanent condition (Hoffman et al. 2020:568).

Incels, then, start from a similar position as PUAs in that they are concerned with the consequences of failing to achieve a more hegemonic, alpha masculinity. Incels depart from PUAs, however, in that they do invoke a 'shared diagnosis of society,' espousing narratives of structural disadvantage similar to those found amongst MRAs—albeit with a relatively narrower focus. Incels view themselves as victims of women's shallow, hypergamous nature, but they also view feminism as largely responsible for their social and sexual exclusion because "its influence on social and cultural norms has allowed women to be even more hypergamous now than they

previously were able to be with stricter patriarchal norms in place” (Rothermel et al. 2022:131). The crux of this claim is that feminism, by affording women more personal, economic, and sexual freedom, has allowed women to develop unrealistic standards and only pursue alpha men, and to be constantly in pursuit of a more desirable partner (Menzie 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022). Incels believe that a return to a more rigid patriarchal social structure—one that stringently controls female sexuality and leaves women economically dependent on men—would cure their plight by forcing women to be less selective about their sexual and romantic partners (Hoffman et al. 2020); this framework also treats sex as a right to which Incel men are entitled, and from which they have been unfairly denied by feminism (Baele et al. 2019; Hoffman et al. 2020; Srinivasan 2018). Incels thus see themselves as personally victimized by women and feminism, and buy in to red pill notions of feminism as an effort to secure female advantage, particularly in the sexual marketplace.

The fatalism of the black pill has also contributed to some of the most egregious negative consequences to originate from secular male supremacist groups. Incels’ sense of personal victimization at the hands of women, and their understanding of themselves as members of a disadvantaged class excluded from and ignored by society, means that Incel spaces have served as a breeding ground for aggrieved entitlement (Kalish and Kimmel 2010), wherein Incels’ belief that they are entitled to sex has been “used to justify mass violence as retribution to being denied sex” (DiBranco 2020:2). This belief has ultimately contributed to numerous acts of mass violence committed by Incel-identified men (Baele et al. 2019; Hoffman et al. 2020; Zimmerman et al. 2018), the most notable of which includes the 2014 Isla Vista shooting, in which six people were killed by a 22-year-old man who cited sexual frustration and resentment towards women as the primary motivator for the attacks (DiBranco 2020; Vito, Admire, and Hughes 2018). In 2018, another Incel-identified man killed ten people in Toronto by driving a van into a crowd; his final

Facebook post before the attack mentioned the Isla Vista shooter by name, and included the line “The Incel Rebellion has already begun!” (DiBranco 2020). Altogether, at least six other instances of Incel terrorism have been identified since 2014 (DiBranco 2020; Kaiser 2022), contributing to debate amongst scholars and policymakers about whether misogynist Incels should be classified as a terrorist threat or terrorist group (Baele et al. 2019; Hoffman et al. 2020; Zimmerman et al. 2018).

Men Going Their Own Way (MGTOWs)

The MGTOW community is best defined as an offshoot of the men’s rights movement—one which embraces a more individual ethos in addressing the perceived problems posed by female inferiority and the impacts of feminism. Like MRAs, MGTOW men focus on the perceived harms feminism causes to men, and view taking the red pill as an appropriate response to the supposed structural disadvantages men face (Lin 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022). However, where MRAs ostensibly focus on activism in the form of building collective identity and drawing attention to perceived inequalities, MGTOW men espouse a staunch masculinism that locates the solution to these problems within men as individuals; central to the MGTOW interpretation of the red pill is the foundational belief that modern conditions have rendered cross-gender relationships untenable for men, and that the appropriate response is for men to ‘opt-out’ of relations with women or broader society in response (Lin 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022). MGTOW men thus see themselves as apolitical, and at times specifically draw discursive boundaries between themselves and the more politically-minded MRAs (Lin 2017; Wright, Trott, and Jones 2020). In their own words

The [men’s right’s movement] is the ‘change’ wing... they are seeking legal and social avenues to redress [men’s] issues... MGTOW is the ‘abandon’ wing: seeing that men are disenfranchised in numerous very real and potentially lethal ways, MGTOWs are opting

out of those aspects of life which are statistically most likely to result in extremely negative consequences for men: sex (false rape accusations), marriage (divorce/family court bias), traditional male jobs (high mortality rate due to assumed male disposability), etc. (Lin 2017:85–86).

This push for separatism is combined with a belief that women and feminist-influenced society serve as a barrier to male greatness—another key MGTOW claim is that men have always been the driving force in creating civilization and advancing society, and that contemporary feminist thinking undermines or denies these contributions (Rothermel et al. 2022). Embracing MGTOW life, then, is seen by these men as a path to personal development that allows for greater personal achievement and fulfillment; rather than cultivating a more alpha masculinity in pursuit of sex, as is seen amongst PUAs, cultivating a more alpha masculinity and eschewing contact with women becomes an avenue through which men reclaim their natural superiority (Lin 2017; Wright et al. 2020). The MGTOW interpretation of the red pill’s biological essentialism leads them to

firmly believe that men are naturally more likely to be risk-takers, creators, and do-ers than women, which has allowed men to be the ‘creators of civilization.’ However, they believe that men have not been given the proper credit or respect that they deserve.

Instead, they feel that they are persecuted, that any attempt to acknowledge pro-male sentiment is wrongfully labeled ‘toxic and misogynistic,’ and that society is increasingly ‘gynocentric,’ i.e., favoring women at the expense of men (Rothermel et al. 2022:127)

The MGTOW community, then, echoes MRA and Incel sentiments in that it perceives the existence of a structural problem, but it mirrors the PUA community in placing the impetus for addressing these issues at the individual level. MGTOWs individualism means there is less focus within the community on any kind of collective or retributive action (Jones, Trott, and Wright

2020; Wright et al. 2020); their separatism also limits the degree to which interpersonal harms to women can arise from this community. As such, the negative consequences originating from the MGTOW community are, on the whole, less notable than those identified within other communities thus far. However, previous work does note the tension in cultivating a shared identity based on inaction—in this case, the eschewal of interactions with women (Jones et al. 2020). To combat this, the MGTOW community does produce some degree of online harassment aimed at women; however, rather than the coordinated harassment campaigns associated with the MRA community, MGTOW men have been shown to engage in more passive harassment specifically as a means of performing their antifeminism and misogyny (Jones et al. 2020). This passive harassment lacks any specific victim, and instead involves the posting of misogynistic content on platforms where this content is visible to general audiences, including members of the groups being targeted; such content includes lobbying homophobic slurs against male feminists as a group, or repeating common sexist sentiments like that women should ‘get back in the kitchen’ (Jones et al. 2020). Notable here is that MGTOW men do not only lobby this passive harassment at women and feminists, but also other groups within the manosphere; MRAs and Incels in particular are also at times referred to as betas or losers, with MGTOW men thus distinguishing themselves as superior not only to women or beta men, but also to other segments of the manosphere as well (Jones et al. 2020).

The Red Pill (TRP)

The last of the secular male supremacist groups, TRP, can arguably be viewed as the result of a synthesis of MRA and PUA sensibilities (Ribeiro et al. 2021; Rothermel et al. 2022). It originated online in 2012, with one of its first prominent hubs, the subreddit *r/TheRedPill*, created and moderated by a Republican state lawmaker with previous ties to the men’s rights movement

(Romano 2017). However, previous work also notes that TRP has expanded to include “elements from several Manosphere communities” (Ribeiro et al. 2021:199)—for example, prominent post flairs (i.e., tags identifying the broad topic a post covers) on TRP forums include both MGTOW and strategy (a reference to PUA strategy or ‘game’) (Ribeiro et al. 2021). The result is a common discourse that combines content and discussion on PUA techniques with MRA’s structural focus on perceived societal disadvantage against men, with the primary orienting worldview of TRP being that feminism is sexual strategy for women played on a macro level, and that the male sexual strategy presented within TRP is thus necessary not only for success in sexual relationships, but also “for men to contend with a feminist-centric society” (Rothermel et al. 2022:129). Here, then, the red pill-informed ‘game’ of the PUA community is expanded in its scope and presented as an individual-level solution to a culture ostensibly polluted by feminist dogma; feminism is viewed as an effort by women to secure “the best position they can find, to select mates, to determine when they want to switch mates, to locate the best dna [sic] possible, and to garner the most resources they can individually achieve” (Rothermel et al. 2022:129). This quest is viewed as having sociocultural consequences well beyond sexual marketplace, and as such the development of a competent masculinity—i.e., the cultivation of male sexual strategy using red pill ideology—is seen as both granting men access to sex and also providing broader skills for navigating a feminist society that is hostile to men (Rothermel et al. 2022). Dignam and Rohlinger (2019) note that

The initial focus on establishing a sexual strategy for men was consequential for two reasons. First, it focused forum users’ attention on their personal behavior relative to women rather than politic... Second, and related, the emphasis on feminism—rather than institution politics or collective action—created an ‘empowering mental state’ or oppositional framework through which men could understand their lives (598-599).

TRP, then, is similar to the PUA community in that it places a strong emphasis on alpha masculinity as the key to sexual success (Rothermel et al. 2022; Van Valkenburgh 2018). Unlike the PUA community, however, TRP's concerns expand beyond this narrow focus; it also echoes some of the sentiments found within the MGTOW community, such as eschewing notions of collective political action in favor of an individualized solution to the woes faced by men in contemporary society (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Rothermel et al. 2022; Van Valkenburgh 2018). TRP users were also similarly critical of MRAs, striving to distinguish themselves from "traditional men's rights groups, which were regarded as both insufficiently critical of feminism and too focused on political action" (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019:601). It is important to note here that TRP is not staunchly and definitively apolitical, despite a general criticism of political focus; active members of the community did rally support for President Trump in the 2016 U.S. election, though this was in large part achieved by convincing users that Trump embodied the sort of alpha masculinity venerated within the TRP community (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019).

Unlike many other manosphere groups, TRP specifically has rarely been solely implicated in potential negative social outcomes. However, its broader focus and overlap with other secular male supremacist groups suggests it may contribute to the harms originating from these communities as well, including the online harassment produced by the MRA and MGTOW communities, and the perpetuation of ideologies that may contribute to sexual assault.

MISOGYNY AS A THROUGHLINE: THE MANOSPHERE AND FAR-RIGHT POLITICS

A nuanced review of the secular male supremacist groups active within the manosphere thus demonstrates the varying ways red pill ideology can be interpreted, adapted, and applied. It also demonstrates how men's embrace of this ideology can contribute to a range of harms, including the spread of gendered myths contributing to sexual assault (Carlo 2023; Denes 2011; Ging 2017; Wright 2020); the production of both passive and ongoing, coordinated harassment

against women and feminist figures (Jones et al. 2020; Lumsden 2019; Mantilla 2013; Sobieraj 2020); instances of mass violence (Baele et al. 2019; Hoffman et al. 2020; Vito et al. 2018; Zimmerman et al. 2018); and support for far-right political figures (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Kaiser 2022). These harms, alongside the regressive and extremist views expressed by the varying segments of the manosphere, have led to the categorization of red pill ideology as a decidedly far-right ideology—it is at its core a patriarchal politic rooted in a desire to institutionalize male dominance, justify male entitlement to women’s bodies, and preserve ‘traditional’ gender relations that privilege men (DiBranco 2020; Kaiser 2022; Lyons 2017). Equally alarming is that secular male supremacist groups have been shown to not only espouse their own variation of far-right ideals, but also to serve as an entry point into other segments of the far-right, such as the alt-right (Lyons 2017; Mamié et al. 2021). The relative palatability of misogyny compared to other far-right ideologies like white nationalism means misogyny is frequently employed “as the first outreach mechanism... Once you engage with the idea that a social-justice-warrior club and the feminist movement have increased the precarity of men, that moves over time into the increased precarity and endangerment of the West” (Wilson 2020:7).

Misogyny more generally has also been identified as a throughline that helps to connect seemingly disparate groups—such as Incels and religious fundamentalists—in ways that bolster far-right political action (DiBranco 2022b; Kaiser 2022; Wilson 2020). Kaiser (2022) notes that the male supremacism found within the manosphere aligns enough with that of other far-right movements to create a common enemy, such that “masculinists, right-wing extremists and fundamentalists are networking together with the common authoritarian goal of subordinating women with violence” (85). Right-wing political parties have also been shown to increasingly draw on misogynist narratives as part of their discursive strategies, echoing common claims of

masculine victimhood, leading to a shared ideology that “requires the construction of feminism as an omnipotent enemy, prevents masculine victimhood from being interpreted as individual weakness [and promotes] traditional, essentialist gender norms as part of the suggested solution” (Träbert 2017:276).

This connection between secular male supremacism and other groups within the far-right is to some degree intuitive—visible in red pill narratives of feminism as a destructive force are hints of the preexisting, wider-spread sentiments regarding progressive politics that have long bolstered far-right participation (Blee 2012; Lyons 2022; Ralph-Morrow 2020; Träbert 2017). Notions of male superiority, and support for the reproduction of traditional patriarchal authority, are also present alongside the racial ideologies espoused by white nationalist movements, with scholars frequently identifying these movements’ implicit focus on protecting not just whiteness, but white masculinity in particular (Berbrier 2000; Blee 2002; Gray 2018). It is also, then, perhaps unsurprising that discourse within the manosphere also frequently evinces a racist character alongside concerns over multiculturalism (Hoffman et al. 2020; Zimmerman et al. 2018); narratives of the structural precarity facing men in contemporary society often center notions of white male victimization specifically (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Ging 2017; Kelly 2020; Schmitz and Kazyak 2016), and explicitly racist speech has been identified within these communities (Jaki et al. 2019; Kelly 2020). However, racial ideologies also operate in complex ways within these spaces; one of the most notable Incel terrorists, for example, was half-Asian, and identified his biracial identity as one of the key barriers to attaining sex and relationships (Vito et al. 2018). This sense of racial disadvantage in sex and relationships is shared by a number of Incel men, enough so that some adherents position whiteness as a protective factor *against* Incel status (Gheorghe 2024; Jaki et al. 2019). At the same time, these claims are often couched in

language venerating whiteness due to its perceived desirability, and racial marginalization is often positioned as the result of women's racist preferences, which are allowed to be consequential thanks to feminist gains (Kelly 2020). As such, race is not absent within the secular male supremacist worldview, but rather is simply less at the forefront of the ideology compared to many other far-right ideologies, and is often invoked to bolster misogynist views.

In many ways, then, secular male supremacism can be thought to operate in a way inverse to white nationalism—where white supremacist groups offer an explicit focus on race and a more implicit focus on masculinity, the groups within the manosphere offer an explicit focus on gender and a more implicit focus on race and nationality. This inversion is not simply intellectually interesting, but also has practical consequences for far-right recruitment. Men of color, who might otherwise be excluded from the far-right due to white nationalist narratives of racial superiority, have been shown to participate in the manosphere to a non-negligible degree (DiBranco 2022b; Hoffman et al. 2020; Jaki et al. 2019; Liu 2021). This suggests that secular male supremacism provides expanded avenues for far-right participation, and that improved understandings of these groups may hold explanatory power in understanding the increasingly multiracial character of groups within the far- and alt-right, such as Patriot Prayer or the Proud Boys (Cooper and Jenkins 2019; Park 2022).

IN SUM: MISOGYNIST RADICALIZATION MATTERS

Let us now return to the theoretical concerns regarding radicalization processes that were briefly articulated in the introductory chapter—namely, concerns over differential participation in extremist movements, and questions regarding what may drive some individuals, but not others, to engage more, or to move from less to more extreme spaces within the far right. Addressing these questions requires a number of conditions. Firstly, the study of radicalization processes requires, at a minimum, the presence of an extremist ideology. It also requires moving beyond studying

pathways into a particular movement, and instead focusing more squarely on differential participation within and across related extremist groups and communities. Finally, both differences in extremism and a substantial amount of movement between a set of ideologically distinct spaces through which actors can flow is a necessary prerequisite for understanding the relationship between radicalization and user migration. The distinctions between these spaces may be broad—such as different movements or communities—or narrower, as when spaces within a common movement differ in terms of the degree of their radicalization.

The secular male supremacist groups of the manosphere fulfill these three criteria. As previously noted, while misogyny and notions of male superiority permeate the broader culture within a patriarchal system (Manne 2018), secular male supremacism espouses relatively unique extremist narratives via their red pill ideology, which combines biological essentialism and myths of male oppression with conspiratorial logics in order to ground claims that “the *masculine nature* of society is being undermined and disrupted by feminizing forces” (Lilly 2016:83). Further, these groups share a fragmented yet networked character—all groups share a belief in red pill ideology, but diverge some in their substantive foci and proposed solutions to perceived injustices. This combination of connectivity and disparity may create tensions that are of interest; della Porta (2018), for example, notes that “within a relational field, the interactions between different groups and organizations [within the same movement] can trigger processes of escalation as groups attempt to outbid each other by the adoption of more radical positions” (465). As such, a case study that includes competing but highly interconnected groups may yield especially valuable insights by allowing for a nuanced analysis of the mechanisms that drive users from one group to another.

Moreover, previous work on secular male supremacist communities has identified increasing participation in these spaces (Ribeiro et al. 2021; Vu et al. 2021), alongside escalating

extremism (Mamié et al. 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2021); this has been accompanied by a notable migration of users from less to more extreme manosphere spaces (Mamié et al. 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2021). For example, manosphere participants appear to be migrating from older communities, such as the MRA community—which is appreciably less extreme based on measures of both general toxicity and misogynistic speech specifically—and towards the Incel and MGTOW communities, which are “appreciably more toxic and misogynistic” (Ribeiro et al. 2021:196). These shifts also signal a migration towards communities with somewhat different ideological orientations, given the very different applications of red pill ideology found among Incels and MGTOWs.

Altogether, then, previous work on secular male supremacism points to three trends of interest: (1) more men being radicalized into these movements, and then continuing to develop increasingly extremist beliefs; (2) an overall escalation of extremism across these groups as a whole; and (3) shifts in which factions are effectively recruiting participants. The first of these two trends provide the salient opportunity to connect individual and group radicalization processes, as radicalization appears to be occurring at both levels, while the final trend offers an opportunity to develop a more in-depth understanding of how variations in extremist ideology shape user trajectories across these movements.

In addition to granting insights into radicalization processes, the study of secular male supremacism—as both an ideology and a movement—also offers the opportunity to generate deeper insights into a relatively undertheorized form of extremism. Male supremacism is granted a great deal less attention in the existing literature than other forms of far-right extremism such as white nationalism (DiBranco 2020; Ging and Murphy 2021; Ging and Siapera 2018), and is often treated as a secondary or ‘gateway’ ideology that pairs with, or leads to, participation in other far-

right movements such as the alt-right (DiBranco 2020; Ging and Murphy 2021; Mamié et al. 2021). Further, contemporary work on secular male supremacism has largely focused on descriptive accounts of male supremacist beliefs, or on linking embrace of these beliefs with the aggrieved entitlement of white male victimization that drives participation within other segments of the far right (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Ging and Siapera 2018; Kelly 2020). I argue that this gap limits broader understandings of far-right movements, and that a myopic focus on understanding ideologies or ‘gateways’ alone obscures the ways in which these belief systems intersect to create new opportunities for participation in far-right extremism. Far-right politics are primarily positioned as resulting from anxieties regarding the losses of power or privilege historically associated with whiteness in general, and with white masculinity in particular (Berbrier 2000; Blee and Yates 2014; Boehme and Isom Scott 2020; Gray 2018), and male supremacist narratives do continue to valorize white masculinity by drawing on racialized tropes of masculinity in addition to constructing hierarchies based on gender alone (Farrell et al. 2019; Menzie 2020). At the same time, as previously addressed, a non-negligible number of non-white men do participate in secular male supremacist groups (Jaki et al. 2019; Liu 2021), and this is true even when preliminary analysis for this project indicates that red pill ideology at times invokes white supremacist narratives as a means to bolster male supremacist views and justify male dominance. These synergies suggest that deepening our understandings of participation in secular male supremacism may grant more general insights into how white and male supremacism operate together to not only uphold white male dominance, but also to provide avenues through which far-right recruitment can be broadened. This dissertation thus has the potential to advance not only understandings of radicalization, but also to substantively contribute theoretical insights into how male supremacism operates as one of several intersecting ideologies within the far right.

Finally, this project will also deepen our collective understanding of secular male supremacism specifically. The previous emphasis on descriptive work in this area has led to calls for work that moves beyond mere description, advancing knowledge by modeling the pathways through which men become involved in secular male supremacism and through which the ideology of secular male supremacism is spread. In a call for such research, Ging and Murphy (2021) specifically argue that “there is a need to consider a number of pathways, both spatially and temporally, [including] the spread and extremization of ideas *within* different components of the incel/manosphere over time” (2). As such, studying the secular male supremacist movement helps to advance not just understandings of far-right movements writ large, but also to contribute substantive theoretical insights into how secular male supremacism operates at the ideological level and in practice. Such understandings are especially important given the previously-addressed negative consequences to come out of the manosphere in the past decade.

CHAPTER 3: RADICALIZATION IN THE ONLINE CONTEXT

In Chapter 2, I outlined the five distinct male supremacist groups present within the manosphere, situating their shared red pill ideology as a unique form of far-right extremism. In this chapter, I shift focus to overview literature on radicalization in the online context. To begin, I discuss how the internet has impacted radicalization processes, highlighting where these processes are eased, minorly adjusted, or substantively altered. Then, I discuss two areas in which differential participation—that is, participation in different ways and to varying degrees—may manifest when it comes to participation in online extremist movements, situating degrees of engagement and trajectories through increasingly extremist digital spaces as components of radicalization that are fruitful for further study. Finally, I address disengagement as an alternative to continued or intensifying participation in extremist online communities. Throughout, I synthesize scholarship on radicalization with relevant work on online engagement more generally. Connecting these disparate literatures facilitates the generation of testable hypotheses regarding factors driving (or hindering) radicalization, even in the absence of information regarding the sociodemographic and biographical characteristics that have been shown to shape differential participation or social movement disengagement. Hypotheses are developed and described below, with several broad trends expected. First, characteristics of users’ posting behaviors are expected to have a mixed relationship with the outcomes under study: tenure within communities and degree of engagement in the form of posting rates and post length are expected to encourage higher engagement, and/or offer a protectant effect against migration or disengagement, while toxicity is expected to reduce engagement and encourage migration to more extreme spaces. Second, measures of fit and reception, when positive, are similarly expected to increase engagement, while decreasing the likelihood of migration to new communities or disengagement from the Reddit manosphere; when reception results in individual experiences of repression, this is also expected to increase the

likelihood of migration to more toxic communities. Finally, community context is expected to matter, in that users in more active communities are expected to engage more and be at lower risk of migration or disengagement, while users in newer manosphere communities may similarly be expected to engage more and migrate less; users in more established manosphere communities, in contrast, may be expected to be at higher risk of migration to more toxic communities, but at a lower risk of overall disengagement. At the same time, community level experiences of repression are expected to have an attenuating effect in terms of engagement rates or continued engagement, while simultaneously increasing the likelihood of users migrating to more toxic communities. Analyses testing these hypotheses are presented in Chapters 6 through 8.

THE IMPACT OF THE INTERNET ON RADICALIZATION

The internet has been increasingly implicated in cognitive and behavioral radicalization processes in recent years (for a review, see Conway 2017, and Odağ et al. 2019). The general, and sensible, consensus of such work is that the internet does not fundamentally *cause* radicalization, but rather that extremist movements are shifting tactics to leverage the affordances offered by digital media (Caren et al. 2012; Daniels 2018; De Koster and Houtman 2008; Winter et al. 2020). At the individual level, the internet's impact on radicalization processes appears primarily to be one of easing. Work on radicalization has long identified individual traits as increasing susceptibility to radicalization by creating openness to extreme messages. Such attributes include ideological background or personal beliefs (della Porta 2018); psychological factors (i.e., depression, low self-esteem, alienation, or isolation) (Borum 2011; Vergani et al. 2020); perceptions of unfairness regarding oneself or one's in-group (van den Bos 2020); and demographic characteristics such as being young, male, and—in the case of far-right participation specifically—white (Vergani et al. 2020). Openness then pairs with existing social ties or a 'seeker mentality' to expose individuals to extremist movements, and individuals may become radicalized

as movement frames align with their perceptions of injustice, or as the group provides a sense of belonging that leads to personal identification with the movement (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; Vergani et al. 2020).

Extremist messages may be encountered through social networks or personal searches for meaning, but in either case the internet may help facilitate this process. The low cost and relative reach of websites and social media make it easier for extremist movements to spread their views (Bowman-Grieve 2009; Caren et al. 2012; De Koster and Houtman 2008), while newer movements such as secular male supremacist groups and the alt-right rely heavily on elements of digital culture such as web videos or memes to develop and disseminate their ideologies (Daniels 2018; Ging 2017; Kelly 2017; Munn 2019). The latter may ease recruitment beyond merely allowing for the broad distribution of movement messages; Munn (2019) notes that as these ideologies are “repackaged in the visual vernacular of the Web: animated GIFs, dumb memes, and clever references” (n.p.) they become more palatable and thus help normalize the claims and views expressed by the alt-right, acclimating individuals to racist, sexist, or otherwise troubling views. Odağ et al. (2019) similarly cite findings that individuals are less likely to reject propaganda when it is presented in a humorous way.

Increased access to information also allows for the greater possibility of self-radicalization as individuals seek out worldviews to help them make sense of perceptions of alienation or injustice, as seems to be the case with many lone perpetrators of extremist violence (Odağ et al. 2019). These processes may, at times, be helped along by site algorithms that guide individuals towards increasingly ideologically extreme content; previous work, for example, found that users engaging with the ‘intellectual dark web’ on YouTube—i.e., content that “discusses controversial subjects like race and I.Q. without necessarily endorsing extremist views” (Ribeiro et al.

2020:131)—then received suggestions for content that embraced alt-right concepts such as white genocide and that users also, upon viewing such videos, were then given suggestions for channels with explicitly racist content.

In any context, the radicalization process continues in part when these individual characteristics or behaviors become linked to group participation. Once exposed to extremist messages, individuals become radicalized as movement frames align with individual perceptions of disadvantage or injustice (van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018; Vergani et al. 2020), and/or as a sense of belonging leads individuals to identify with the in-group (Vergani et al. 2020). Group-level processes then solidify or exacerbate these extremist views for the group as a whole: in general, groups tend to trend towards “increased agreement about the issues at hand and shift toward the extremity of the average group opinion” (van den Bos 2020:569), while in-group bias, the establishment of internal group norms, and perceived social or material rewards for holding more extreme views also contribute to cognitive radicalization (Borum 2011), as do echo chambers (della Porta 2018). Extremism may also be exacerbated by competition between groups as organizations with similar beliefs and goals work to outbid each other (della Porta 2018).

These processes play out similarly on the web. Work on online extremism, for example, shows that “ingroup identities are coupled with outgroup derogation of social groups” (Odağ et al. 2019:268), and that postings become more polarized over time (Odağ et al. 2019). At the same time, radicalization may be exacerbated by the sense of anonymity and immersion the internet offers, as it can “strengthen the salience of social identity and lead to a decrease in the perception of individual features of oneself and others” (Odağ et al. 2019:281). Platform policies and branding that align with shared political identity may then further encourage mounting group extremism; for example, the social media site Gab—which is popular among the political right—has branded

itself as a censorship-free alternative to other platforms such as Reddit and Twitter, but also hosts notably more hate speech than many other sites, potentially contributing to the echo chambers and pools of misinformation that cultivate ideological extremism (Kor-Sins 2021; Zannettou et al. 2018).

While the individual and group-level processes that contribute to radicalization are primarily eased or intensified by the online context, structural forces may play out very differently in this environment. Structural inequalities, real or perceived, are one of the primary macro-level forces that motivate extreme views and actions, particularly at the start of the radicalization process (van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018). After group formation, however, instances of repression—typically defined in terms of state violence against movement actors—are one of the primary drivers of increasing extremism; in such instances, perceptions of unjust or differential use of military or police force are seen as one of the main factors that increase movement militancy or extremism (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018). Repression, however, looks very different in the online context. Governments may engage in repression through the weaponized spread of misinformation or efforts to drown out movement messages (Earl et al. 2021), or by shutting down internet access, as was the case during the Arab Spring (Tufekci 2017), but in many cases—and especially in democratic nations with protections surrounding free speech—repression is most likely to occur not via state actors, but instead through the implementation of community standards or platform policies that censor extreme views. Deplatforming—removing users or entire communities for engaging in particular behaviors or expressing particular views—is the most dramatic tactic used to suppress extremism, but other forms of perceived repression, such as community-level moderation or perceptions that site leadership is unfairly targeting specific

groups, also appear to drive radicalization and increase extremism (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016).

RADICALIZATION BY DEGREES: DRIVERS OF UNEQUAL ENGAGEMENT

The processes outlined above situate engagement as the first step in any radicalization process, regardless of whether it occurs online or off. At the same time, it is well understood that not all individuals engage with extremist movements to the same degree; instead, participants may come to be radicalized to different extents, either cognitively (i.e., in terms of the degree to which they ‘buy in’ or espouse a particular ideology) or behaviorally (i.e., in terms of their actual active participation) (Borum 2011; della Porta 2018). Even so, much general work on differential participation—that is, on differences in active engagement—tends to focus on distinguishing engagement from nonengagement, rather than on assessing differences in participation levels, with even less work centering differential participation as it relates to online extremism. As such, advancing understandings of degrees of engagement in online extremist spaces may help to further knowledge of how radicalization processes operate in the digital context.

Generally speaking, differential participation in terms of levels of engagement has been connected to several factors that also shape radicalization risk, including biographical availability (Gundelach and Toubøl 2019; Saunders et al. 2012); preexisting motivations and values (Barkan, Cohn, and Whitaker 1995; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019; Yu and Zhao 2006); characteristics of individuals’ social networks (Passy and Giugni 2001; Yu and Zhao 2006); and the presence of participation incentives (Barkan et al. 1995). In the online context, however, it is also reasonable to suspect that differential participation in extremist spaces may be influenced by the same factors that drive online engagement more generally. Understanding whether and when these factors shape engagement also offers utility for developing more comprehensive models of online radicalization processes.

What factors, then, have been identified as driving rates of online engagement more generally? Prior literature highlights characteristics of both individual users and online communities as salient for driving participation rates—an overview of these factors and their expected relationships to user engagement are presented in Table 1. Key predictors that are listed without a corresponding hypothesis reflect factors expected to shape other outcomes of interest—either user migration, user disengagement, or both—and are included in summary tables for all sections as a throughline and point of comparison. A side-by-side overview of all expected relationships is presented in the concluding section.

First and foremost, unique aspects of group identity have been connected to differences in rates of participation, with users in certain spaces posting more frequently or heavily than others (Sadeque and Bethard 2019). In considering engagement with the Reddit manosphere specifically, this suggests that user engagement patterns may be shaped by where the bulk of a user’s participation occurs—a suggestion that is supported by prior research. Ribeiro et al. (2021) found substantive differences in activity levels across manosphere communities, with the PUA community having the lowest number of posts, followed by the MGTOW, MRA, TRP, and Incel communities.¹¹ As stated in row 1 of Table 1, it can thus be expected that:

Hypothesis 1: Users in the MGTOW, MRA, TRP, and Incel communities will post at higher rates than users in the PUA community.

¹¹ As a reminder, these acronyms represent the pickup artist (PUA), men’s rights (MRA), misogynist Incel (Incel), men going their own way (MGTOW), and the red pill (TRP) communities.

Table 1. Key Variables Expected to Predict Rates of Engagement

		Radicalization Area
		Engagement Rates
Key Predictors		
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
1	Primary community	(H ₁)
	PUA	Reference
	MRA	Positive
	Incels	Positive
	MGTOW	Positive
	TRP	Positive
2	Tenure	Positive (H ₅)
3	Number of posts	Positive (H ₄)
4	Posting frequency	--
5	Average toxicity	Negative (H ₆)
6	Toxicity alignment	--
7	Average post length	--
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>		
8	Average post score	Positive (H _{7a})
9	Comments received	Positive (H _{7b})
10	Gildings received	Positive (H _{7c})
11	Post removal	Negative (H _{7d})
12	Controversiality	--
13	Average time to first reply	--
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
14	Number of active users	Positive (H ₂)
15	Activity level	--
16	Percent new users	--
17	Average toxicity	Positive (H _{3a})
18	Toxicity spread	Negative (H _{3b})
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
19	Quarantines implemented	Negative (H _{8a})
20	Bans implemented	Negative (H _{8b})
21	User toxicity x quarantines implemented	Negative (H _{8c})
22	User toxicity x bans implemented	Negative (H _{8d})

Prior research on political engagement on Facebook has also shown that the production of extremist content increases as groups receive more engagement from users (Davidson 2024), and that the increased presence of negative tonality similarly correlates with greater participation (Heiss, Schmuck, and Matthes 2019). Taking these factors together, this suggests that greater activity within the Reddit manosphere should create a feedback effect wherein individuals users are encouraged to post more in response, and that higher rates of toxicity—which here can be viewed as representative of the negative speech considered in prior research—should similarly drive higher rates of engagement. Further, given that the Reddit manosphere is comprised of distinct groups which vary some in their toxicity levels (Ribeiro et al. 2021), and that group identity is also expected to drive posting rates, it is reasonable to assume that not only the average levels of toxicity, but also the general spread of toxicity across communities may impact engagement; particularly, greater consistency in toxicity may be expected to further increase rates of engagement, while a greater spread may reduce engagement rates. In considering the Reddit manosphere specifically, this suggests the following relationships (see Table 1, rows 14, 17, and 18):

Hypothesis 2: Individual rates of participation will increase as the number of active users in the Reddit manosphere increases.

Hypothesis 3a: Higher rates of negative speech within the Reddit manosphere will increase user engagement.

Hypothesis 3b: User engagement will increase as the difference in the degree of negative speech across communities decreases.

Literature on user engagement also highlights characteristics of users' posting behaviors and online interactions as salient predictors of engagement in online spaces. Intuitively, users' past

rates of engagement have a positive relationship with current engagement rates, both in online communities in general (Mahmud, Chen, and Nichols 2014; Sadeque and Bethard 2019), and for Twitter users engaging in non-extremist digital activism during Occupy Wall Street (Chen and Pirolli 2021); users have also been shown to post more the longer they have been active in an online community (Heiss et al. 2019; Sadeque and Bethard 2019). This suggests that past participation serves as a salient predictor of current participation within online communities, and that users who have greater tenure within online spaces can similarly be expected to engage more. Additionally, the qualitative components of users' posts—and choice of word usage in particular—has been shown to have an impact on levels of posting activity on Twitter, with users' whose posts contain more negative terms posting less often (Mahmud et al. 2014). Note that this contrasts with the previous study which found that greater negative tonality at the group level spurs participation, and suggests that users who are individually more toxic should thus be expected to post *less* often than their less toxic peers. Taken together, these previous findings again suggest several relationships summarized in rows 2, 3, and 5 of Table 1.

Hypothesis 4: Users with higher levels of past engagement will have higher levels of current engagement.

Hypothesis 5: Users who have been active longer will engage at higher rates.

Hypothesis 6: Users whose posts contain more negativity will engage at lower rates.

Receptions to contributions have also been shown to encourage or discourage participation. Previous work indicates that for many users, online engagement is motivated by a desire for social interaction; this is supported by findings showing that receiving engagement on posted content from other users encourages individuals to post more, while a lack of engagement may lead users

to post less (Khan 2017). Being rewarded for contributions via virtual incentives has also been shown to increase participation (Claussen, Kretschmer, and Mayrhofer 2013).

In the case of Reddit, interactions and incentives may be evidenced in several ways. First, users may receive interaction in the form of comments on their contributions. Second, a both interactive and incentive-based element of the Reddit of its ranked-voting system, which allows users to determine which content is most visible on both the site's front page and within a given subreddit; users can 'upvote' and 'downvote' content, with content receiving a higher score—i.e., a greater proportion of upvotes to downvotes—becoming more highly visible. In addition to impacting visibility, receiving upvotes also earns users 'Reddit karma'—points that offer little benefit but serve as a measure of status within the site (Richterich 2014). Receiving downvotes similarly loses karma for users. Upvotes, then, may serve as an incentive encouraging participation. They are not, however, the only incentive available; Reddit also allows users to purchase 'Reddit gold' to gift to other users whom they believe have made an especially valuable post contribution to the site. Unlike Reddit karma, receiving Reddit gold (also sometimes referred to as being 'gilded') offers both actual and symbolic benefits; a special badge is displayed on posts that are awarded Reddit gold, making the gilding visible to anyone who views the post, and the user who receives the reward also gains access to some paid Reddit features for a short period of time. At the same time, users subject to negative interactions or incentives should, conversely, be expected to engage *less*; as such, users who are subject to post removals are expected to ultimately see lower rates of engagement. Given previous findings regarding the role of interaction and incentives in driving participation, and as stated in Table 1, rows 8-11, it can then be expected that:

Hypothesis 7a: Users who receive higher average post scores will engage at higher rates.

Hypothesis 7b: Users who receive more comments on their posts will engage at higher rates.

Hypothesis 7c: Users who receive Reddit gold will engage at higher rates.

Hypothesis 7d: Users who have a post removed by a community moderator will engage at lower rates.

Finally, user participation in extremist communities specifically has been shown to decrease after the implementation of community-level sanctions by platform administrators (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; Copland 2020). As a platform, Reddit sanctions communities in two key ways: through the banning of entire subreddits (smaller forums hosted within the site), and through the ‘quarantining’¹² of certain subreddits deemed ‘highly offensive or upsetting.’ As such, the implementation of these measures may be expected to impact participation and lower user’s rates of engagement. Simultaneously, repression events have been shown to have a radicalizing effect, particularly for more committed members of movements (della Porta 2018; Zwerman et al. 2000); as such, it can also be expected that this relationship may be diminished for more toxic users, and the effect of bans or quarantines on engagement will be lower for more toxic users—see rows 19 through 22 in Table 1.

Hypothesis 8a: The implementation of subreddit quarantines will lower users’ rates of engagement.

¹² On Reddit, a subreddit being quarantined means that subreddit posts are not visible unless a user is logged into a Reddit account, directly visits the subreddit, and confirms that they want to view the content. Posts from quarantined communities also do not appear on the site’s front page, where the highest ranked content from the overall site is typically displayed.

Hypothesis 8b: The implementation of subreddit bans will lower users' rates of engagement.

Hypothesis 8c: The effect of subreddit quarantines will be weaker for users with higher average toxicity.

Hypothesis 8d: The effect of subreddit bans will be weaker for users with higher average toxicity.

'PATHWAYS' AND 'PIPELINES': USER MIGRATION AND RADICALIZATION

One insight that has emerged from the literature on online radicalization is that the radicalization processes outlined above frequently also involve user trajectories through multiple online spaces—sometimes referred to as 'pipelines' (Munn 2019) or 'pathways' (Ribeiro et al. 2020). Such trajectories may guide users through different communities within a single platform (Mamié, Ribeiro, and West 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2020, 2021) or across multiple platforms (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016; Ribeiro et al. 2021), and may be voluntary or—as is the case when deplatforming occurs—involuntary (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016; Ribeiro et al. 2021).

Despite this finding, theoretical work exploring user migrations in the radicalization context is relatively thin, and focuses largely on descriptive accounts. As previously noted, Ribeiro et al. (2020) found that site algorithms may facilitate radicalization across increasingly extreme ideological spheres; Kor-Sins (2021) also found that right-wing users were drawn to Gab's anti-censorship branding after many far-right accounts were deplatformed on Twitter and Reddit, and suggests this may contribute to radicalization through the spread of misinformation and the creation of echo chambers. The relationship between migration and extremism may also be multi-directional; Ribeiro et al. (2021) found evidence that members of the manosphere become more extreme *after* migrating to more extreme communities, suggesting migration as a driving force behind increased radicalization, while Mamié et al. (2021) indicate that male supremacists on

Reddit “tend to drift towards more extreme content significantly more than [other Reddit users]” (10), and that members migrate not only towards more extreme male supremacist spaces, but also to alt-right spaces. This suggests that migration may also be the result of increasing extremism or shifts in extreme views.

These insights point to a need for additional work on the link between user migration and radicalization. As primarily descriptive accounts, they offer little explanatory power in understanding *why* extremist users may voluntarily migrate across communities or platforms, or why they may migrate across ideological spheres in the absence of algorithmic encouragement. A more complete model of radicalization processes must account for the mechanisms that guide some individuals, and not others, towards greater ideological extremism, and must also provide an explanation for when and why radicalization occurs primarily in place (i.e., through existing groups growing more extreme) versus through migration (i.e., through individuals moving from less to more extreme groups).

Work on user migration outside the radicalization context provides a useful starting point for developing such a model. Research on platform switching and research on online community migrations frequently draw from the literature on geographic migration to explain such trends, emphasizing the importance of ‘push’ and ‘pull’ factors in shaping individual decisions to migrate (Chang, Liu, and Chen 2014; Fiesler and Dym 2020; Hou et al. 2011; Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016). Push factors are those that motivate users to leave or seek out alternative platforms, while pull factors are characteristics of the destination community that may appeal to users. This body of literature points to a number of push and pull factors that may help to explain migration across extremist spaces; an overview of these factors and the expected direction of the relationship are presented in

Radicalization Area		
Migration		
Key Predictors		
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
1	Primary community	(H19)
	PUA	Positive
	MRA	Positive
	Incels	Negative
	MGTOW	Negative
	TRP	Negative
2	Tenure	Negative (H18)
3	Number of posts	Negative (H16)
4	Posting frequency	Negative (H17)
5	Average toxicity	Positive (H15a)
6	Toxicity alignment	Negative (H15b)
7	Average post length	--
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>		
8	Average post score	Negative (H11)
9	Comments received	Negative (H13)
10	Gildings received	Negative (H14)
11	Post removal	Positive (H9)
12	Controversiality	Positive (H12)
13	Average time to first reply	--
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
14	Number of active users	Negative (H20)
15	Activity level	Negative (H21)
16	Percent new users	--
17	Average toxicity	--
18	Toxicity spread	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
19	Quarantines implemented	Positive (H10a)
20	Bans implemented	Positive (H10b)
21	User toxicity x quarantines	Positive (H10c)

Table 2.

Radicalization Area		
Migration		
Key Predictors		
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
1	Primary community	(H ₁₉)
	PUA	Positive
	MRA	Positive
	Incels	Negative
	MGTOW	Negative
	TRP	Negative
2	Tenure	Negative (H ₁₈)
3	Number of posts	Negative (H ₁₆)
4	Posting frequency	Negative (H ₁₇)
5	Average toxicity	Positive (H _{15a})
6	Toxicity alignment	Negative (H _{15b})
7	Average post length	--
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>		
8	Average post score	Negative (H ₁₁)
9	Comments received	Negative (H ₁₃)
10	Gildings received	Negative (H ₁₄)
11	Post removal	Positive (H ₉)
12	Controversiality	Positive (H ₁₂)
13	Average time to first reply	--
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
14	Number of active users	Negative (H ₂₀)
15	Activity level	Negative (H ₂₁)
16	Percent new users	--
17	Average toxicity	--
18	Toxicity spread	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
19	Quarantines implemented	Positive (H _{10a})

20	Bans implemented	Positive (H_{10b})
21	User toxicity x quarantines	Positive (H_{10c})
22	User toxicity x bans	Positive (H_{10d})

Table 2. Key Variables Expected to Predict Migration

Platform characteristics and community policies appear to be the most salient push factors driving users to new online spaces. Poorly-received policy changes are frequently cited by users as a reason for migrating to new platforms (Fiesler and Dym 2020; Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016), and concerns that new policies unfairly target specific ideologies or censor particular groups appear especially salient among both Reddit users and the far-right (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016). Qualitative analysis of user’s stated reasons for seeking alternative platforms (or considering doing so) also point to content removal and site policies banning certain views as a significant factor (Newell et al. 2016).

The bulk of this work focuses specifically on platform-level policies and cross-platform migration. Reddit, however, is somewhat unique in that individual subreddits (smaller forums hosted within the site) can suppress or encourage particular types of participation, such as by drafting rules prohibiting content or behavior that is not otherwise in violation of site-wide policies. These rules are then enforced by volunteer moderators who may choose to remove offending content or ban rule-breaking users.¹³ Subreddit-level moderation then operates alongside site-wide sanctions, such as the banning of users from Reddit as a whole, the banning of entire subreddits that violate Reddit policies, or the quarantining of problematic subreddits.

¹³ It should be noted here that varying reasons for content removal within communities means that post removal can be considered a measure of fit *or* repression, depending on the motivations for removal. While assessing the reasons for post removal is outside the scope of this project, it is still important to acknowledge the potential dual role of this form of sanctioning.

Whether at the subreddit or platform level, the types of sanctions identified above can be expected drive migration. Site-wide actions such as community bans may drive some users off-site completely, and to more extreme spaces tolerant of their views (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016). As such, while migration due to concerns over content removal, censorship, or the suppression of unpopular views has largely been studied at the platform-level (Fiesler and Dym 2020; Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016), it is reasonable to expect that subreddit-level policies or actions may similarly shape users' decisions to migrate to new subreddits within the same platform.

As previously noted, deplatforming and user-level sanctions are some of the primary ways through which repression may operate in online spaces. Given that repression has been shown to drive extremism in part as perceptions of unfair targeting or unjust sanctions lead to an escalation of views (della Porta 2018), it is further reasonable to expect that users who do migrate across subreddits in response to site-wide or subreddit-level sanctions would be drawn to more ideologically extreme spaces. Again given that more extreme movement members may be more predisposed to be further radicalized by repression efforts, it also stands to reason that more toxic members may see stronger effects. Based on these links between censorship and migration, and between repression and radicalization, I propose the following hypotheses, summarized in row 11, and rows 19 through 22 of Table 2:

Hypothesis 9: Having posts removed by community moderators will increase the likelihood of migration to a more extreme community.

Hypothesis 10a: Implementation of a quarantine within a user's primary community will increase their likelihood of migration to a more extreme community.

Hypothesis 10b: Implementation of a ban within a user’s primary community will increase their likelihood of migration to a more extreme community.

Hypothesis 10c: The impact of quarantines on migration to more extreme communities will be stronger for users with higher levels of extremity.

Hypothesis 10d: The impact of bans on migration to more extreme communities will be stronger for users with higher levels of extremity.

Community fit has also been identified as both a push and pull factor; users who have trouble understanding community norms, or who feel they do not fit within particular online communities, may choose to leave those spaces (Fiesler and Dym 2020; Kor-Sins 2021). This may be an especially potent consideration for individuals undergoing the radicalization process, for whom a sense of belonging, and of alignment between movement frames and personal experiences or views, is an important motivation for joining an extremist movement (van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018; Vergani et al. 2020).

While ‘fit’ or ‘belonging’ are somewhat nebulous concepts, Reddit’s design provides subreddit members with the power to evaluate their peers’ contributions in ways that may facilitate (or hinder) a sense of belonging. As previously mentioned, the ranked voting system allows users to evaluate others’ contributions via upvotes or downvotes. Ostensibly, upvotes are reserved for quality content, and downvotes for content that is low quality or that doesn’t contribute to the subreddit¹⁴. In reality, upvotes and downvotes are often a reflection of pure agreement or

¹⁴ The Reddit Help Desk includes a section on ‘Reddiquette’ that asks users not to “downvote an otherwise acceptable post because you don’t personally like it. Think before you downvote and take a moment to ensure you’re downvoting someone because they are not contributing to the community dialogue or discussion. If you simply take a moment to stop, think and examine your reasons for downvoting, rather than doing so out of an

disagreement, rather than reflecting the quality of the content (Richterich 2014). As such, users may view scores on their contributions as reflective of their relative belonging within a given community, or as a signal of how well their own views or experiences align with movement frames, potentially shaping decisions to migrate to other communities.

Post scores alone are, however, an imperfect measure of content's reception; because these scores reflect the ratio of upvotes to downvotes, it is difficult to determine whether a post with a low score simply received few upvotes and few downvotes, or a high proportion of both.¹⁵ Posts with a high proportion of both are deemed 'controversial' in Reddit's algorithm and controversiality, like post score alone, may similarly signal to users how well they fit in with a particular community's norms or views. As such, both negative and ambivalent response to user's contributions may serve as push factors driving users to other communities. As highlighted in rows 8 and 12 of Table 2, this suggests that:

Hypothesis 11: Receiving lower average scores on posts will increase the likelihood of migration to a new primary community.

Hypothesis 12: Having a contribution marked controversial by the Reddit algorithm will increase the likelihood of migration to a new primary community.

Other forms of engagement, such as comments or gildings, may similarly encourage a sense of fit within communities and make users less likely to migrate—see Table 2, rows 9 and 10.

emotional reaction, you will ensure that your downvotes are given for good reasons.”

¹⁵ For example, a submission with a post score of two may have received two upvotes; or, it could have received one hundred upvotes and ninety-eight downvotes, pointing to very different receptions. One is relatively neutral, the other is somewhat polarized.

Hypothesis 13: Receiving a higher number of comments on posts will decrease a user's likelihood of migrating to a different primary community.

Hypothesis 14: Having a post gilded will decrease a user's likelihood of migrating to a different primary community.

Previous work has also noted that migration across male supremacist spaces trends in a particular direction, with users migrating to spaces that are more extreme and that utilize more misogynistic language, and noting there may be a multi-directional relationship between extremism and migration (Ribeiro et al. 2021). As such, overall extremism prior to migration may play a role in these processes, both because users may be pulled towards spaces that better reflect their own attitudes, and because greater extremism may play a role in pushing users out of more moderate spaces as they are subject to moderation or informal sanctions. This generates the following hypotheses, summarized in rows 5 and 6 of Table 2.

Hypothesis 15a: Greater ideological extremism in the form of more toxic posts at the user level will increase the likelihood of migration to a more ideologically extreme community.

Hypothesis 15b: Increased alignment in the extremity of users and their primary community will decrease the likelihood of migration to a new community.

Finally, loyalty to online communities—i.e., commitment to engagement in a particular community over others—has been shown to be related to a number of factors, and thus may similarly impact the likelihood of migration to a new community. At the individual level, posting rates, posting frequency, and loyalty in the form of longer engagement have been identified as salient predictors of continued engagement (Hamilton et al. 2017; Sadeque and Bethard 2019), and are highlighted in rows 2-4 in

Radicalization Area		
Migration		
Key Predictors		
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
1	Primary community	(H19)
	PUA	Positive
	MRA	Positive
	Incels	Negative
	MGTOW	Negative
	TRP	Negative
2	Tenure	Negative (H18)
3	Number of posts	Negative (H16)
4	Posting frequency	Negative (H17)
5	Average toxicity	Positive (H15a)
6	Toxicity alignment	Negative (H15b)
7	Average post length	--
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>		
8	Average post score	Negative (H11)
9	Comments received	Negative (H13)
10	Gildings received	Negative (H14)
11	Post removal	Positive (H9)
12	Controversiality	Positive (H12)
13	Average time to first reply	--
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
14	Number of active users	Negative (H20)
15	Activity level	Negative (H21)
16	Percent new users	--
17	Average toxicity	--
18	Toxicity spread	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
19	Quarantines implemented	Positive (H10a)
20	Bans implemented	Positive (H10b)
21	User toxicity x quarantines	Positive (H10c)

Table 2.

Hypothesis 16: Posting more in a primary community will decrease the likelihood of migration.

Hypothesis 17: Posting more frequently in a primary community will decrease the likelihood of migration.

Hypothesis 18: A longer tenure within a primary community will decrease the likelihood of migration.

At the community level, overall group size, and activity levels have also been shown to have a positive effect on persistence, as has group identity (Hamilton et al. 2017; Sadeque and Bethard 2019). Further, research on migration between manosphere communities has indicated that users are following trajectories from older, less extreme communities like PUA or MRA to newer, more toxic spaces within the Incel, MGTOW, and TRP communities (Ribeiro et al. 2021). The following hypotheses are summarized in rows 1, 14, and 15 in Table 2:

Hypothesis 19: Users in the PUA and MRA communities will be more likely to migrate to more toxic communities than users in the Incel, MGTOW, or TRP communities.

Hypothesis 20: A higher number of users active within a primary community will decrease the likelihood of migration.

Hypothesis 21: As activity levels within a primary community increase, the likelihood of migration will decrease.

THE OTHER POSSIBLE TRAJECTORY: SHIFTS TO NONPARTICIPATION

While degrees of participation in, or trajectories through, extremist spaces are useful for theorizing online radicalization, there is another outcome of interest for those seeking to understand these processes—disengagement. Just as some users may participate more heavily than

others, some users may engage for longer while others cease participation entirely. As such, understanding factors that seem to discourage participation is also of use when attempting to understand how radicalization processes operate in the digital context. Here, it should be noted that *disengagement* should not be taken as synonymous with *deradicalization*; the former can be viewed as a strictly participatory development, while the latter represents an ideological shift. Summarily put, “disengagement does not mean individuals renounce their belief system, but rather, they are no longer motivated to participate in group activities” (Windisch et al. 2016:4). While both may be identifiable in the online context, disengagement is a more appropriate concern given this dissertation’s general focus on participatory trajectories rather than purely ideological developments. A summary of the factors expected to drive user disengagement is presented in Table 3.

Disengagement from extremist movements has been linked to a range of factors. At the macro level, these include sociopolitical developments, changes in public perceptions of movements, or experiences of repression; at the meso-level, salient considerations include group heterogeneity, the structure of recruitment networks, and the absence of institutional incentives (Fillieule 2012). At the micro level, disengagement may be driven by changes in biographical availability (such as shifts in employment or familial obligations), disillusionment, or disagreement with the use of ideologically-based violence (Fillieule 2012; Windisch et al. 2016). Little work focuses on disengagement in the online context specifically, but as with user migration, the implementation of platform sanctions such as bans or quarantines has been shown to lead some users to disengage from online extremist spaces, though it should be cautioned here that these users may not be disengaging from a particular movement, but instead shifting to other platforms that are more accepting of their views (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017, 2021; Newell et al. 2016). Once

again, the potentially uneven effects of repression must also be accounted for—users who are more extreme may be less likely to disengage in the wake of quarantines, as repression can have a bifurcating effect that renews commitment for more extreme movement members (della Porta 2018; Zwerman et al. 2000). Altogether, this does suggest disengagement may be driven by the

Table 3. Key Variables Expected to Predict Disengagement

		Radicalization Area
		Disengagement
Key Predictors		
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
1	Primary community	(H ₂₈)
	PUA	Reference
	MRA	Negative
	Incels	Positive
	MGTOW	Positive
	TRP	Negative
2	Tenure	Negative (H ₂₄)
3	Number of posts	Negative (H ₂₃)
4	Posting frequency	Negative (H ₃₁)
5	Average toxicity	--
6	Toxicity alignment	--
7	Average post length	Negative (H ₂₉)
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>		
8	Average post score	Negative (H _{25a})
9	Comments received	Negative (H _{25b})
10	Gildings received	Negative (H _{25c})
11	Post removal	--
12	Controversiality	--
13	Average time to first reply	Positive (H ₃₂)
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
14	Number of active users	Negative (H ₂₆)
15	Activity level	Negative (H ₂₇)
16	Percent new users	Positive (H ₃₀)
17	Average toxicity	--

18	Toxicity spread	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
19	Quarantines implemented	Positive (H _{22a})
20	Bans implemented	Positive (H _{22b})
21	User toxicity x quarantines	Negative (H _{22c})
22	User toxicity x bans	Negative (H _{22d})

implementation of such sanctions—see rows 19 through 22 in Table 3.

Hypotheses 22a: The implementation of a quarantine in a user’s primary community will increase the likelihood of user disengagement.

Hypotheses 22b: The implementation of a ban in a user’s primary community will increase the likelihood of user disengagement.

Hypotheses 22c: The effect of quarantines on disengagement will be weaker for users who are more toxic/extreme.

Hypotheses 22d: The effect of bans on disengagement will be weaker for users who are more toxic/extreme.

There is little other literature on differential participation and disengagement in the online context specifically; however, it is reasonable to suspect that disengagement from extremist movements in this context may also be subject to the processes that lead users to cease participation in online communities more generally. Intuitively, many of the factors shown to predict degree of engagement also appear to impact whether continued engagement occurs at all; these again include prior degree of engagement (Sadeque and Bethard 2019), receptions to contributions (Arguello et al. 2006; Karnstedt et al. 2011; Sadeque and Bethard 2019); users’ tenure within communities (Arguello et al. 2006; Hamilton et al. 2017); the linguistic features of posts (Arguello et al. 2006; Hamilton et al. 2017); and community characteristics such as group size, levels of activity, or identity. As such, many prior hypotheses may be reformatted to define the expected relationships

between the above factors and disengagement, and are included in Table 3, rows 2, 4, 8-11, 14, and 15.

Hypothesis 23: Higher rates of prior engagement will decrease the likelihood of disengagement.

Hypothesis 24: The likelihood of disengagement will decrease as users' tenure increases.

Hypothesis 25a: Receiving higher post scores will decrease the likelihood of disengagement.

Hypothesis 25b: Receiving a higher number of comments will decrease the likelihood of disengagement.

Hypothesis 25c: Having a post gilded will decrease the likelihood of disengagement.

Hypothesis 25d: Having a post removed will increase the likelihood of disengagement.

Hypothesis 26: The likelihood of disengagement will decrease as a user's primary community size increases.

Hypothesis 27: The likelihood of disengagement will decrease as activity within a user's primary community increases.

Previous work and hypotheses also inform expectations regarding the role of primary community in shaping the odds of disengagement. On the one hand, bans and quarantines are expected to *increase* the likelihood of disengagement, meaning one might expect a higher likelihood of disengagement for users in the most affected communities; on the other hand, activity levels are also expected to *decrease* the likelihood of disengagement, meaning that newer communities seeing more activity may offer a protective effect. Communities experiencing lower activity and higher sanctions, such as the MGTOW community (Ribeiro et al. 2021), may then be

expected to have higher likelihoods of disengagement, as may communities subject to especially high numbers of sanctions, such the Incel community (see Table 3, row 1).

Hypothesis 28: The likelihood of disengagement will be higher for members of the MGTOW and Incel communities, and lower for users in the PUA, MRA, and TRP communities.

At the same time, some unique additional characteristics may shape whether users disengage. Post length has been shown to impact continued engagement, though the direction of this relationship is not always clear: Hamilton (2017) found that more longstanding users have longer posts than others and are simultaneously less likely to disengage, while Arguello (2006) found that longer posts were less likely to receive replies and thus decreased users' probability of posting again. Arguello (2006) similarly found that users in communities with a higher number of new users were more likely to disengage. As stated in rows 7 and 16 of Table 3, it may then be expected that:

Hypothesis 29: Users with a lower average post length will be more likely to disengage.

Hypothesis 30: As the percentage of new users in a user's primary community increases, the likelihood of disengagement will increase.

Finally, the temporal characteristics of users posting habits have also been identified as significant. Sadeque et al. (2016) found that duration between posts impacted the likelihood of future participation, while Karnstedt et al. (2011) found a positive relationship between the likelihood of disengagement and the length of time it took for users to receive replies on posts. Given these factors, two additional hypotheses can be formulated (see Table 3, rows 4 and 13).

Hypothesis 31: Users who post more frequently will be less likely to disengage.

Hypothesis 32: A longer average time to first post reply will increase the likelihood of disengagement.

CONCLUSION

A summary of the expected findings outlined in the prior sections is presented in Table 4, and highlights the predicted importance of posting characteristics, measures of fit and reception, and community context, including platform-level repression efforts, in shaping radicalization pathways. Altogether, review of the above literatures

Table 4. Summary of Expected Relationships

		Radicalization Area		
		Engagement Rates	Migration	Disengagement
Key Predictors				
		<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>				
1	Primary community	(H ₁)	(H ₁₉)	(H ₂₈)
	PUA	<i>Reference</i>	Positive	<i>Reference</i>
	MRA	Positive	Positive	Negative
	Incels	Positive	Negative	Positive
	MGTOW	Positive	Negative	Positive
	TRP	Positive	Negative	Negative
2	Tenure	Positive (H ₅)	Negative (H ₁₈)	Negative (H ₂₄)
3	Number of posts	Positive (H ₄)	Negative (H ₁₆)	Negative (H ₂₃)
4	Posting frequency	--	Negative (H ₁₇)	Negative (H ₃₁)
5	Average toxicity	Negative (H ₆)	Positive (H _{15a})	--
6	Toxicity alignment	--	Negative (H _{15b})	--
7	Average post length	--	--	Negative (H ₂₉)
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>				
8	Average post score	Positive (H _{7a})	Negative (H ₁₁)	Negative (H _{25a})
9	Comments received	Positive (H _{7b})	Negative (H ₁₃)	Negative (H _{25b})
10	Gildings received	Positive (H _{7c})	Negative (H ₁₄)	Negative (H _{25c})
11	Post removal	Negative (H _{7d})	Positive (H ₉)	--
12	Controversiality	--	Positive (H ₁₂)	--
13	Average time to first reply	--	--	Positive (H ₃₂)
		<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>				
14	Number of active users	Positive (H ₂)	Negative (H ₂₀)	Negative (H ₂₆)
15	Activity level	--	Negative (H ₂₁)	Negative (H ₂₇)
16	Percent new users	--	--	Positive (H ₃₀)
17	Average toxicity	Positive (H _{3a})	--	--
18	Toxicity spread	Positive (H _{3b})	--	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>				
19	Quarantines implemented	Negative (H _{8a})	Positive (H _{10a})	Positive (H _{22a})
20	Bans implemented	Negative (H _{8b})	Positive (H _{10b})	Positive (H _{22b})
21	User toxicity x quarantines	Negative (H _{8c})	Positive (H _{10c})	Negative (H _{22c})
22	User toxicity x bans	Negative (H _{8d})	Positive (H _{10d})	Negative (H _{22d})

also points to a number of areas in which theorizing on online radicalization stands to be strengthened through the accompanying analyses. First, there is a relative dearth of work on differential participation in extremist movements, particularly as it relates to degrees of engagement in the online context. Second, user trajectories across extremist spaces have been shown to be a salient component of online radicalization processes (Kor-Sins 2021; Mamié et al. 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2020, 2021), yet many of the processes that encourage some users—but not others—to migrate between communities are not well understood. Finally, the processes that drive disengagement from extremist movements may not be the same as those that drive other aspects of radicalization or disengagement in the offline context; this may be especially true given the relative ease of digital participation compared to offline engagement. As such, applying previous insights on users’ digital engagement to the extremist context has potential to substantively advance understandings of online radicalization, and to address the questions posted in the introductory chapter of this dissertation, which asked: 1) what individual and community-level factors drive differences in engagement in male supremacist communities; and 2) what individual and community-level factors predict user migration to more extreme communities?

In the remaining chapters, I move towards analyses testing the sets of hypotheses generated here. Chapter 4 overviews the data and methods used, while Chapter 5 presents background on Reddit as a context, and overviews the development of the five secular male supremacist groups under study. Chapters 6 through 8 then present results of hypotheses testing for the three radicalization areas discussed in this chapter. Chapter 6 presents results from negative binomial regressions predicting user rates of participation, while Chapters 7 and 8 present findings from event history analysis predicting migration and disengagement, respectively. In each chapter, I highlight which of the hypotheses formulated here are supported by empirical results, identify

gleaned insights, and connect back to the relevant literatures. In the final chapter, I then discuss these findings in the context of the broader theorizing on radicalization processes, and highlight limitations and directions for future research.

CHAPTER 4: DATA AND METHODS

In Chapter 3, I overviewed literatures on radicalization processes, connecting them to previous findings on online engagement and proposing a number of expected relationships between user post characteristics, measures of fit and reception, community context, and differential participation in extremist movements. To test these relationships and address the specific research questions posed, I conduct a series of regression analyses aimed at predicting the three outcomes under study: degrees of engagement, migration to different or more toxic communities, and disengagement from extremist spaces. This chapter overviews the data and procedures used in the analysis, with empirical results presented in Chapters 6 through 8. To begin, I briefly overview Reddit as a useful site for study, and describe in detail the secondary data used in the analyses. After overviewing the data, I discuss data preparation procedures and the operationalization of key concepts; I then provide summary statistics for all variables included in the three analyses. Finally, I detail the analytic procedures used for predicting each of the three outcomes under study.

DATA COLLECTION AND PREPARATION

Case Selection: Reddit

Reddit is a social media platform oriented around both content aggregation and user-generated content; within the site, users post to smaller topical forums termed ‘subreddits,’ and can share images, links to media, or text posts while receiving comments on posted content from other users. A detailed account of the logic behind focusing on Reddit as a case, and of the platform’s relationship to, and history with, organized misogyny, is presented in Chapter 5, alongside a descriptive account of the evolution of the Reddit manosphere. However, there are two key reasons for selecting Reddit as a site for analysis which can be highlighted here. First, it has been identified as a prominent home for far-right communities in general (DeCook 2022; Gaudette

et al. 2021; Grover and Mark 2019; Lagorio-Chafkin 2018; Massanari 2020; McLamore and Uluğ 2020), and for misogynist organizing in particular (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016; Massanari 2017; Ribeiro et al. 2021). Second, Reddit platform administrators have frequently strived to balance a libertarian ethos of permissiveness with social demands to curb the purveyance of extremist content (Gallo and Cho 2021; Lagorio-Chafkin 2018), while also offering pseudonymity to users. As a result, Reddit is less permissive of extremism than sites with no platform-level restrictions on speech, but also facilitates extremism to a greater degree than sites that implement stricter content policies or require identifying information, which may have an attenuating effect on extremist speech (Hogan 2013). Taken together, this situates Reddit as a usefully moderate site for studying extremism, even outside of its more personal relationship with far-right organizing and misogyny discussed in Chapter 5.

The Pushshift Reddit Dataset

Data for the analysis comes from the Pushshift Reddit dataset, a data project that utilized Reddit's official API to archive submissions (content posted directly by a user to a subreddit) and comments (responses to submission content, or to other comments).¹⁶ Each submission and comment stored within the dataset is accompanied by a range of metadata and summary characteristics, including date and time of posting, author name and id, post scores (the cumulative total of upvotes minus downvotes), whether the post was made in a quarantined community, and whether the post was marked 'controversial' by Reddit's sorting algorithm (applied when a post receives a relatively equal proportion of upvotes and downvotes, though this feature was only

¹⁶ Throughout the remainder of this dissertation, I distinguish between submissions and comments where relevant, and use the more general term 'posts' to encapsulate both types of user contributions more generally.

introduced in 2014) (Baumgartner et al. 2020). The Pushshift Reddit dataset was constructed in 2019, and initially contained more than 6.2 billion submissions and comments from more than 2.8 million subreddits; it was updated monthly through June 2023, at which point the data was rendered unavailable to the public in response to changes in the Terms of Use for Reddit’s API.¹⁷ It is important here to note that the decision to curtail API access was widely criticized, for several reasons: it severely impacted the ability of third-party Reddit browsing apps—some of which included greater accessibility options for disabled users—to continue operating; temporarily impacted many popular moderation tools used by subreddit moderators; and disrupted research utilizing API data, including some federally-funded projects.¹⁸ Given the connection between Reddit and extremist content overviewed in Chapter 5, this move on the part of platform-administrators may also prove problematic for continued assessments of digital platforms’ role in support far-right extremism.

At the time of first access in June 2022, the dataset contained all submissions and comments posted to Reddit between June 2005 and June 2021, excepting submissions or comments removed by moderators or deleted by the original poster prior to data collection. In May 2023, prior to the data being rendered inaccessible, a second round of data covering July 2021 to December 2022 was acquired for incorporation into the analysis. At time of data acquisition, the Pushshift dataset offered several analytical advantages over the data accessible through the Reddit API alone. Most notable was the speed of availability for large amounts of data: while the Reddit API had comparatively smaller query limits for accessing data, Pushshift offered monthly ‘data dumps’

¹⁷ <https://www.redditinc.com/policies/data-api-terms>

¹⁸ <https://independenttechresearch.org/reddit-survey-results/>

containing all submissions and comments, which were made available for download to researchers seeking access to more comprehensive Reddit data. For an analysis spanning many years, this was the most efficient means of data acquisition. However, while almost indisputably the best source for large-scale Reddit analysis, the data is not without limitations. The most notable of these is the emphasis on textual content; Reddit submissions may include text, links, images, or videos, but only the first two types of content are captured in the data set, though links to images or videos are also included, and may be viewable provided that the original content has not been removed from its source. A second key limitation is that the Pushshift dataset is subject to shortcomings that impact many forms of longitudinal data—the specific variables included in the dataset vary year to year, largely as a consequence of an expanding degree of metadata encoded by Reddit as the platform has developed and evolved.

Third, and finally, the dataset is also subject to the common difficulties associated with social media data. This includes the inability to neatly and confidently identify unique individuals; Reddit relies on pseudonymous usernames, and individuals are not limited to a single user profile, meaning that the number of user profiles present cannot be said to map neatly on to the actual number of individuals represented. Similarly, the dataset itself does not distinguish between content generated by earnest users, and that posted by bots, shills, or moderators. This latter issue is partly, though not wholly, addressed in the initial data preparation.

Data Preparation

The Pushshift Reddit dataset monthly data dumps were, at the time of data acquisition, freely available for download on Pushshift.io; the data was stored in monthly subsets, separated into separate files for submissions and comments, and formatted as compressed .JSON files. Accessing and preparing the data for download was a multi-step process. The individual files were

downloaded using Python, and Python was similarly used to decompress the files and extract information on submissions and comments posted to manosphere-related subreddits. Relevant subreddits were selected for inclusion based on their identification in previous work on manosphere communities (Liu 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2021). After relevant posts were identified, Python was again used to format the data for analysis. The data cleaning that occurred at this stage included creating consistent variable headers across all months and years for later appending, the creation of clear month and year information for each post in addition to the UTC timestamp variable included in the data, and the removal of extra spacing, line breaks, and special characters from posts texts to prepare the data for both toxicity analysis and import into Stata.

Toxicity scores were then generated for each submission or comment text using Detoxify,¹⁹ an open-source toxicity detection package available for Python that allows users to identify potentially toxic content within online comments.²⁰ The Detoxify models for toxicity detection utilize the same basic approach and training data as the Google Perspective API while improving on limitations regarding bias in classification, drawing on pre-trained models to identify toxicity within user-generated comments. It is also not subject to the Perspective API's limit of one query per second—a substantial advantage given the large scale of the data utilized in this project. Similar to the Perspective API, it also provides scores for a range of attributes, quantifying toxicity, severe toxicity, obscenity, threats, insults, identity attacks, and sexual explicitness. Each attribute value can range from 0 to 1, with scores representing the probability that a reader would identify a

¹⁹ It should be noted that not all Reddit submissions contain texts; some are comprised only of links, images, or video. As such, toxicity scores are marked as 0 for these posts.

²⁰ <https://github.com/unitaryai/detoxify>; <https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/can-ai-identify-toxic-online-content/>

specific post as evincing the specific attribute; a higher score thus indicates a higher level of toxicity.²¹ Definitions for each attribute as defined by the original Perspective API documentation, and examples of texts from the analytic data set scoring in the top 1% for each attribute, are presented in

²¹ https://support.perspectiveapi.com/s/about-the-api-faqs?language=en_US

Attribute	Definition	Example Text
<i>Toxicity</i>	A rude, disrespectful, or unreasonable comment that is likely to make people leave a discussion.	<i>Fucking diffusion of responsibility. This is fucking disgusting and a god damn shame. I can't wait till this fucking #metoo shit just fucking collapses and falls flat on its face. The only reason this shit is still going is because of the fucking male feminist shits out there that won't shut the fuck up and stop SIMPING. Fucking Christ just die already. (MGTOW)</i>
<i>Severe toxicity</i>	A very hateful, aggressive, disrespectful comment or otherwise very likely to make a user leave a discussion or give up on sharing their perspective. This attribute is much less sensitive to more mild forms of toxicity, such as comments that include positive uses of curse words.	<i>Holy shit, go fuck yourself you everloving ugly cunt, nobody wants you here and nobody wants your insults, please fuck the fuck off and go die, you stupid bitch. "But the people here are vile human beings..." NO YOU'RE THE FUCKING VILE SCUM, YOU'RE THE JUDGEMENTAL ASSHOLE. GET THE FUCK OUT YOU UGLY STUPID WHORE. (Incels)</i>
<i>Obscene</i>	Swear words, curse words, or other obscene or profane language.	<i>A fucking bitch rejected me months ago at a pub. I saw her again at the same pub and she didn't even recognize me from the time that she rejected me beforehand. I hope she gets hit by a fucking train, fucking cunt ass bitch fucking cunt.... I hope she gets raped by a Sasquatch. [...] Yes, I'm a fucking misogynist and I'm proud as fuck. Women made me who I am, I hope they all get their clits ripped out and raped million times over. (Incels)</i>
<i>Identity attack</i>	Negative or hateful comments targeting someone because of their identity.	<i>Fuck a Persian. They're Muslim and slutty as fuck. They're dying to be un-oppressed. (TRP)</i>
<i>Insult</i>	Insulting, inflammatory, or negative comment towards a person or a group of people.	<i>It's disgusting the way these whores describe and try to justify abortion aka killing your own child. "Clump of cells," parasite," "doesn't have right to live in my body without my consent." Whores are pathetic, vile, psychopathic creatures. (Incels)</i>
<i>Threat</i>	Describes an intention to inflict pain, injury, or violence against an individual or group.	<i>This bitch needs to be shot and killed. (MRA)</i>
<i>Sexually explicit</i>	Contains references to sexual acts, body parts, or other lewd content.	<i>That big dick is literally one of the most superior genes any man can be born with in this modern society. If your penis is below 6 inches then not only will your sex-life suck, but your girlfriend will gossip to all of her friends about how you have a small penis. (Incels)</i>

.²² The community of origin for each quote is indicated in parentheses following each excerpt; some communities—namely the Incel community—are included more frequently because they were more frequently represented among the highest scoring posts, which reflects overall higher levels of toxicity within the community (further discussed in Chapters 5 and 6). Excerpts are presented as written, save for minor editing for clarity, and explicit language is not censored in order to accurately represent the intense misogyny (and racism) present within the communities under study.²³ To provide additional context for what toxicity levels mean from a substantive perspective, Table 6 also presents examples of post texts representing different levels of the standard toxicity score which, as is discussed later in greater detail, is ultimately the metric included in relevant analyses.

After initial cleaning and generation of toxicity scores, data were imported into Stata for additional preparation. Monthly data files for submissions and comments were compiled into an aggregate data set, and each post was coded for inclusion in one of the five manosphere communities based on the subreddit in which it was initially posted. Previous work has classified

²² https://support.perspectiveapi.com/s/about-the-api-attributes-and-languages?language=en_US

²³ I draw on Jane (2014) here, who notes that virulent misogyny "must be spoken of in its unexpurgated entirety because euphemisms and generic descriptors such as 'offensive' or 'sexually explicit' simply cannot convey the hostile and hyperbolic misogyny which gives [online misogyny its] distinctive semiotic flavor...Furthermore, the anonymous or quasi-anonymous producers of such discourse are likely to benefit from the fact that their utterances and actions are considered too abhorrent to repeat or discuss in mainstream contexts" (559).

Table 5. Detoxify Attributes and Examples

Attribute	Definition	Example Text
<i>Toxicity</i>	A rude, disrespectful, or unreasonable comment that is likely to make people leave a discussion.	<i>Fucking diffusion of responsibility. This is fucking disgusting and a god damn shame. I can't wait till this fucking #metoo shit just fucking collapses and falls flat on its face. The only reason this shit is still going is because of the fucking male feminist shits out there that won't shut the fuck up and stop SIMPING. Fucking Christ just die already. (MGTOW)</i>
<i>Severe toxicity</i>	A very hateful, aggressive, disrespectful comment or otherwise very likely to make a user leave a discussion or give up on sharing their perspective. This attribute is much less sensitive to more mild forms of toxicity, such as comments that include positive uses of curse words.	<i>Holy shit, go fuck yourself you everloving ugly cunt, nobody wants you here and nobody wants your insults, please fuck the fuck off and go die, you stupid bitch. "But the people here are vile human beings..." NO YOU'RE THE FUCKING VILE SCUM, YOU'RE THE JUDGEMENTAL ASSHOLE. GET THE FUCK OUT YOU UGLY STUPID WHORE. (Incels)</i>
<i>Obscene</i>	Swear words, curse words, or other obscene or profane language.	<i>A fucking bitch rejected me months ago at a pub. I saw her again at the same pub and she didn't even recognize me from the time that she rejected me beforehand. I hope she gets hit by a fucking train, fucking cunt ass bitch fucking cunt.... I hope she gets raped by a Sasquatch. [...] Yes, I'm a fucking misogynist and I'm proud as fuck. Women made me who I am, I hope they all get their clits ripped out and raped million times over. (Incels)</i>
<i>Identity attack</i>	Negative or hateful comments targeting someone because of their identity.	<i>Fuck a Persian. They're Muslim and slutty as fuck. They're dying to be un-oppressed. (TRP)</i>
<i>Insult</i>	Insulting, inflammatory, or negative comment towards a person or a group of people.	<i>It's disgusting the way these whores describe and try to justify abortion aka killing your own child. "Clump of cells," parasite," "doesn't have right to live in my body without my consent." Whores are pathetic, vile, psychopathic creatures. (Incels)</i>
<i>Threat</i>	Describes an intention to inflict pain, injury, or violence against an individual or group.	<i>This bitch needs to be shot and killed. (MRA)</i>
<i>Sexually explicit</i>	Contains references to sexual acts, body parts, or other lewd content.	<i>That big dick is literally one of the most superior genes any man can be born with in this modern society. If your penis is below 6 inches then not only will your sex-life suck, but your girlfriend will gossip to all of her friends about how you have a small penis. (Incels)</i>

Table 6. Standard Toxicity Levels and Examples

Toxicity Level	Threshold	Example Text
<i>Very Low</i>	< .10	<i>PUA is a person's hobby / job, "Game" is the application of human psychology to sexual interactions with women. I'm a living testament to how useful it can be as a tool. (PUA)</i>
<i>Low</i>	.30 - .35	<i>The feminist movement is a worldview and a belief system that thrives on pedestalizing women as a group and demonizing men as a group. There is very little of what I would call "policing the movement" coming from within feminism itself. NOW and other groups get up to some seriously fucked up shit, with very little criticism directed their way from other feminists. (MRA)</i>
<i>Moderate</i>	.45 - .55	<i>Feminism is global war against men and boys. Men are not even allowed to speak. (MRA)</i>
<i>High</i>	.65 - .70	<i>The patriarchy existed for a reason. Men realized the true nature of women, and segregated them from society. Pussy is a resource, meant to be distributed among men equally. They knew in an open society all women would run after chads, so they made it so that to acquire a female you would have to speak to her father. Men realized the frail loyalty of women in LTRs, and their tendency to divorce, so they made virginity a virtue, so no one would marry a divorced woman, thus protecting themselves and their children from divorce. And then there were laws against adultery. What I am saying is that our forefathers realized something about women, and made society a certain way. They did that across all cultures unanimously, even though these cultures were developing without much interaction between each other. (Incel).</i>
<i>Very High</i>	> .90	<i>"But my misogyny!!" Got the right to vote in 1919 along with males that didn't own land, but the males got the draft and bucket brigade duty and women got...the vote. Rights without responsibility, that's what women got. But that isn't enough, they want the right to tell everyone else how to live and fuck you, you scum if you oppose them .(MGTOW)</i>

Subreddits within communities based on self-identifications available in forum sidebars and FAQs (Liu 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2021; Rothermel et al. 2022); that convention is followed here, such that subreddits are coded as part of a broader community based on their self-definitions. Comments made by identifiable moderators and known Reddit bots were then also removed to ensure as genuine a sample of actual users as possible.²⁴ A number of duplicate posts from 2017, present in the initial Pushshift Reddit dataset, were also removed at this time, as were posts made by deleted user accounts. The end result of data preparation is an analytical dataset of 31,325,065 submissions and comments posted by 1,100,554 unique user profiles across 52 public manosphere subreddits between April 2008 and December 2022.

VARIABLE CONSTRUCTION

The Pushshift Reddit dataset contains information at the submission and comment level. As such, constructing user and community-level measures for inclusion in the analysis required significant data aggregation and transformation. Variable construction focused on three areas: characteristics of user's posts and posting habits, measures of fit and reception, and characteristics of primary communities or the Reddit manosphere as a whole, depending on the particular stage of the analysis. Individual users were identified based on unique author names and alphanumeric IDs included in the initial data; alphanumeric IDs were then used to generate a unique numeric user ID for each active profile, and post-level data was then aggregated into user-years via the

²⁴ A crowd-sourced list of common Reddit bots is available at: <https://github.com/eliassjogreen/Reddit-Bot-List/>. Moderator posts replying to removed comments were identified and excluded based on standardized text phrases included in the posts (e.g., "Your post has been removed for violating subreddit rules"; "Your comment has been removed...").

collapse command in Stata. The end result was a dataset of yearly and overall characteristics summarizing users' post histories and the reception to their contributions. The specific approach to construction of individual variables is detailed below; descriptive statistics for all variables are also included in Table 7 (categorical/dichotomous measures) and Table 8 (continuous measures). Summary stats for primary community are broken down by user-years (i.e., they represent the percentage of users for whom a community was their primary community across all user-years in the data), and descriptives for posting rates are presented for both the overall and yearly average number of posts made by users; all other variables are summarized at the user or community level, (i.e., as averages/percentages across all years a user or community was active).

Table 7. Frequency Counts for Categorical and Dichotomous Variables

	Count	Percent	Cum. Percent
Primary Community			
PUA	357,657	20.93	20.93
MRA	419,322	24.54	45.47
Incels	363,711	21.28	66.75
MGTOW	141,141	8.26	75.01
TRP	266,659	15.60	90.61
No primary	160,486	9.39	100.00
Received gilding			
Yes	4,084	0.37	0.37
No	1,096,470	99.63	100.00
Controversial post			
Yes	124,122	11.28	11.28
No	976,432	88.72	100.00
Post removal			
Yes	492,847	55.22	55.22
No	607,707	44.78	100.00
Ever Migrated			
Yes	64,511	5.86	5.86
No	1,036,043	94.14	100.00
Disengaged			
Yes	998,276	90.71	90.71
No	102,278	9.29	100.00

N = 1,100,554

Table 8. Summary Statistics for Continuous Variables

	Median	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
<i>User-Level Variables</i>					
Manosphere tenure (years)	1	1.68	1.44	1	15
Primary community tenure (years)	1	1.53	1.22	1	15
Total Posts	2	23.30	199.31	1	44,556
Yearly Posts	2	16.36	108.10	1	23,086
Posting frequency (months)	1	2.05	2.04	1	12
Post length (words)	26.80	49.30	81.47	0	7254
Toxicity	.10	.2011428	.2581077	.0000868	.9997219
Toxicity alignment	.18	.2039497	.1631343	0.000000	.8769872
Post score	2.25	7.31	46.28	-266	13,687
Comments Received	0	18.72	236.52	0	69,132
Time to first reply (hours)	.2575	12.40	479.317	.000027	121,829
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>					
Active users	28,504	26,712.85	18,024.78	1	70,999
Activity level	313,246	481,924.10	506,079.00	1	2,827,944
Percentage of new users	76.12	77.45	14.62	17.10	100
Toxicity	.1077881	.2011428	.2581077	.0000868	.9997219
Toxicity spread	.1013635	.0910638	.0312006	.0340830	.1275516
Quarantines implemented	0	.43	.79	0	2
Bans implemented	2	1.71	.76	1	3

User Characteristics

Primary community. Rates of engagement in each of the communities under study were measured through creation of a count variable summarizing the number of posts a user made within each community in a given year. This number was then divided by the total number of posts made across *all* communities each year; the community that received the greatest proportion of a user's contributions—that is, the community in which the plurality of their participation was occurring—was coded as a user's primary community in a given year. Users for whom participation was evenly split across multiple communities were coded as having no primary community.

Tenure. Measures of tenure were constructed for both users' overall tenure within the Reddit manosphere, and their tenure within each primary community in which they were active. For tenure within the Reddit manosphere, tenure reflects the sum of the *span* of years a user is present in the Pushshift dataset. Note that these are not necessarily years a user was *actively* posting—some users saw periods of abeyance lasting a year or more, and these spans were included when calculating the length of time users were present. For example, a user who posted in 2012, and then did not post again until 2015, was coded as having four years of tenure within the Reddit manosphere. Tenure within a primary community, in contrast, reflects the number of consecutive years a user was actively posting in a given community, excepting any years with no posts made. Put differently, activity within primary communities needed to be consecutive in that tenure reset to zero if a user left a primary community and came back after a period spent in another primary community, but years of no posting were not treated as impacting tenure at all assuming that a user returned to the same primary community after a period of abeyance.

Number of posts. The total number of posts a user made in a given year was calculated by totaling the number of unique submission or comment IDs associated with a given user ID. Yearly post counts were generated similarly, totaling the number of posts within each year present.

Posting frequency. Posting frequency was operationalized as the number of months in a given year that a user posted. This was calculated by identifying the month and year each post was made, based on the month and year of each individual data dump downloaded for initial preparation in the analysis. The first post in any given month was then flagged using an intermediary dummy variable, and the number of positive post months was summed to get the total number of months in which a user posted in a given year.

Average post length. The length of each post text was calculated using the wordcount feature in Stata. The average length of users' post was then calculated by taking the mean value across all posts within a given year.

Average toxicity. Throughout the analyses, extremism is operationalized as the level of toxicity present in users' text contributions. As previously discussed, toxicity scores for each post text were generated using the Detoxify package in Python; a user's average toxicity for each year was then created based on the mean toxicity score across all of their posts for that year. Early model tests showed similar patterns across all toxicity measures, and no improvement to model fit when including metrics beyond the standard toxicity score. As such, only standard toxicity is reported throughout the remainder of this dissertation. To ease interpretation, toxicity values, which range from 0 to 1, are transformed by a factor of 10 prior to inclusion in analyses, so that coefficient results correspond with a .1 increase in toxicity rather than a .01 increase. As toxicity values ultimately indicate the probability that a user would find content offensive or upsetting, increases in toxicity values can be interpreted as a linear increase.

Toxicity alignment. Toxicity alignment was calculated by subtracting a user's mean toxicity in a given year from the average toxicity of all posts within their primary community. The absolute value of the difference was then taken to reflect the degree of difference between a user's toxicity and that of their primary community. This variable is also transformed by a factor of 10 prior to inclusion in the analyses to facilitate easier interpretation.

Measures of Reception and Fit

Average post score. Average post score was calculated as the mean of all a user's post scores within a given year.

Comments received. The number of comments received may be identified two ways. For submissions, the Pushshift Reddit dataset includes a variable indicating the number of comments received; this variable is not included for comments, even though they may also receive responses from other users. For comments made on submissions or other comments, the Pushshift Reddit dataset includes a parent ID variable, which includes the prefix 't1_' for comment replies to other comments, and 't3_' for comments on user submissions. The prefix is then followed by the ID for the post receiving the reply, allowing for matching comments to the submissions or comments to which they are responding. To generate comment counts for each post, including both submissions and comments, I generated a total count of each parent ID using the collapse command in Stata. I then used the substr command to trim the prefix from the parent ID; the result was a post ID and the corresponding number of comments, which was then matched to each individual post via the merge command. Details on which comment count variable is used in which analysis are discussed in the section on analytic procedures.

Gildings received. The number of gildings associated with each post is included in the Pushshift metadata. Initial assessment showed that receipt of Reddit gold was a relatively rare occurrence for users, with the average number received being well below one. As such, gildings were coded as a dichotomous variable indicating whether a user had a post gilded in a given year.

Controversiality. Metadata for posts similarly includes a variable indicating whether a comment was marked controversial by the Reddit algorithm. Controversiality was similarly a relatively rare occurrence, and thus was also constructed as a dummy variable indicating whether a user had a post marked controversial in any given year after the feature was implemented in 2014.

Average time to first reply. A UTC timestamp for each post is included in the data, indicating the date and time at which the post was made; timestamps are formatted in Unix time, representing the number of seconds that have passed since 00:00:00 UTC on Thursday, 1 January 1970. To identify time to first reply, I reduced the full dataset to a subset of only comments; the earliest UTC timestamp associated with each parent ID was then identified using the collapse command in Stata, resulting in a dataset of parent IDs and earliest post times. The subinstr command was then used to trim the prefix from the parent ID, creating a list of post IDs and the UTC timestamps for their earliest reply; post IDs were then used to merge reply UTCs onto the full data. The duration in seconds between an initial post and its first reply was then calculated by subtracting the UTC for the first reply from the UTC for the initial post; seconds were then divided by 60 twice over to create a variable reflecting the number of hours it took for a post to receive a response. After identifying the time to first reply in hours, the average time to first reply across all posts made by a given user was generated by calculating the mean in hours across all their posts. Overall, the mean time to first reply was 12 hours, with only around 5% of users receiving replies after this point. For analysis, a series of dummy variables was then constructed indicating whether respondents received no replies, fast replies (less than one hour), average replies (received between one and 12 hours after posting), or slower than average replies (received more than 12 hours after posting).

Post removal. Posts removed by subreddit moderators have their text replaced with '[removed]' and were thus identified using string searches in Stata. A dummy variable was then constructed indicating whether a user had a post removed by a moderator in a given year.

Community Characteristics.

Number of active users. The number of active users within both individual communities and the broader Reddit manosphere was identified by summing the number of unique user IDs that made at least one post in each community in a given year, and by summing the total number of unique users present within the Reddit manosphere each year.

Activity level. Activity levels for communities and the Reddit manosphere were calculated by summing the number of posts made to each community or across all communities in a given year.

Percentage new users. To calculate the percentage of new users in a given community, data was first broken into subsets containing all the posts for each community. Data was then collapsed by user ID and year to obtain a list of all users active in the community in a given year; an intermediary dummy variable was then created to identify the first year in which each user appeared within a given community. For each year, the number of users for whom it was their first year present was then divided by the total number of users, and converted to a percentage.

Average toxicity. As with user-level average toxicity, the average toxicity for a primary community or the Reddit manosphere was taken by calculating the mean toxicity value across all posts for a given year. Toxicity is again transformed by a factor of 10 in all predictive analyses so that reported coefficients correspond to a .1 increase in toxicity.

Toxicity spread. Toxicity spread for the entire Reddit manosphere was calculated by subtracting the lowest mean toxicity value across the five communities under study from the highest mean toxicity value; this metric was calculated for each year to reflect the spread of toxicity across all communities. This variable is again transformed by 10 for regression analyses to facilitate ease of interpretation.

Quarantines implemented. The Pushshift Reddit dataset includes a dichotomous variable indicating whether a post was made in a quarantined subreddit. To calculate the number of quarantines implemented in a given year, I identified the subset of posts made in quarantined subreddits; data was then collapsed by subreddit and year to generate a list of quarantined subreddits for each year. I then created an intermediary dummy variable indicating the first appearance of each individual subreddit on the list of quarantined subreddits; the number of quarantines implemented was then calculated as the total of newly quarantined subreddits within each community or the broader Reddit manosphere each year.

Bans implemented. Data on community bans is not included in the Pushshift Reddit dataset. To identify bans, I first identified the last posting date associated with each of the 52 subreddits included in the analysis. Any subreddit that did not have an associated post in the last month of the study period—December 2022—was then manually reviewed. For subreddits that had been subject to a ban, attempting to navigate to their associated Reddit page displays a message stating that the subreddit had been banned, and providing information on the reason for the ban. Reasons include a range of content policy violations, and a subreddit being unmoderated. Because the primary interest in bans is as a measure of repression, subreddits were counted as banned in the analysis specifically when the displayed reason for the ban emphasized a violation of Reddit’s content policies. For each subreddit determined to have been subject to a ban, I then utilized the UTC timestamps to identify the last year in which posting activity occurred. The total number of subreddits identified as being banned in each year was then totaled for each primary community and the broader Reddit manosphere.

Dependent Variables

User engagement. User engagement is measured based on a user's total number of posts in a given year, calculated as identified in the above section on user characteristics.

Migration. User migration is conceptualized as a change in where a user's primary participation is occurring. Note that a user is only identified as migrating if they switch primary communities; users who shift from having no primary community to having a primary community, or vice versa, are not identified as migrants. The decision to not include these shifts as migrations was informed by review of users with no primary community, which indicated that an overwhelming majority (98%) maintained relative consistency in their participation even when shifting to or from having no primary community; this is to say, users who had a primary community in a given year overwhelmingly either previously or subsequently participated in that same community alongside other communities, even when they had no identifiable primary community in a prior or future year. (Put differently, users whose primary community was the Incel community in a given year, for example, overwhelmingly continued to participate in Incel spaces even if their participation shifted to being evenly split between Incel and another community in the subsequent year.) As such, shifts in their degree of participation do not necessarily reflect a significant shift in engagement.

Migration to more or less extreme communities was identified by first identifying the overall average toxicity for each manosphere community across all the years in which they were active (discussed in greater detail in Chapter 5). Toxicity showed that communities could be ordered from least to most toxic in the following order: PUA, MRA, Incels, MGTOW, and TRP. Users were then identified as moving to a more toxic community if they moved from a primary community at the lower end of this ranking to one at the higher end, while migration to a less toxic

community is operationalized as a shift in the converse direction. It is important to note here that this also means migration from the PUA and TRP communities may only occur in one direction; PUA users cannot migrate to less toxic spaces, while members of the TRP community cannot migrate to more toxic communities.

Disengagement. Users were identified as disengaging if their participation ended or experienced a period of abeyance prior to the end of the study period—December 2022. Disengagement was constructed as a dummy variable, coded 1 for any year in which a user is not activate in the subsequent year. Note that, based on the previous discussion of tenure that indicated some users experience period of abeyance before resuming participation, this does allow for users to experience multiple periods of disengagement, which may last for a year or more.

ANALYTIC PROCEDURES

Separate sets of regression analyses were conducted for each outcome under study: levels of engagement, user migration to new or more toxic communities, and user disengagement. The specific key predictors included in each set of analyses reflect those factors expected to shape that particular outcome, as discussed and summarized in Chapter 3; a review of the specific measures included in each analysis is presented in Table 9. For each set of regression analyses, models proceed in four stages, with Model 1 assessing the effects of user and post characteristics alone, Model 2 incorporating measures of fit and reception, Model 3 including the addition of all community-level variables, and Model 4 examining interaction effects between user extremity and repression measures. In all cases, log likelihoods indicating model fit improved with the addition of each subsequent set of variables. Sample size and selection varies across each stage of the analysis, and is determined by both methodological and theoretical considerations. Details on sample selection, size, and specific methodological approaches, including any additional required data preparation, are detailed below.

Table 9. Summary of Predictor Variables by Analysis

		Radicalization Area		
		Engagement Rates	Migration	Disengagement
Key Predictors				
<i>User-Level Variables</i>				
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>				
1	Primary community			
	PUA	✓	✓	✓
	MRA	✓	✓	✓
	Incels	✓	✓	✓
	MGTOW	✓	✓	✓
	TRP	✓	✓	✓
2	Tenure	✓	✓	✓
3	Number of posts	✓	✓	✓
4	Posting frequency	--	✓	✓
5	Average toxicity	✓	✓	--
6	Toxicity alignment	--	✓	--
7	Average post length	--	--	✓
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>				
8	Average post score	✓	✓	✓
9	Comments received	✓	✓	✓
10	Gildings received	✓	✓	✓
11	Post removal	✓	✓	--
12	Controversiality	--	✓	--
13	Average time to first reply	--	--	✓
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>				
<i>Context Characteristics</i>				
14	Number of active users	✓	✓	✓
15	Activity level	--	✓	✓
16	Percent new users	--	--	✓
17	Average toxicity	✓	--	--
18	Toxicity spread	✓	--	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>				
19	Quarantines implemented	✓	✓	✓
20	Bans implemented	✓	✓	✓
21	User toxicity x quarantines	✓	✓	✓
22	User toxicity x bans	✓	✓	✓

Modeling User Engagement Rates

As previously addressed, user engagement is operationalized as the number of posts users made in a given year. Because the outcome under analysis is a count, either a Poisson or negative binomial regression model may be an appropriate choice, with the latter often considered preferable in situations with a high number of zeroes or an extremely large variance, which can create issues of overdispersion (Rabe-Hesketh and Skrondal 2012). Initial comparisons of fit between the Poisson and negative binomial models did indicate issues of overdispersion, and a negative binomial model was selected. Additionally, because the data is comprised of user-years, and because the ultimate analytic goal is to make *causal*, rather than purely descriptive claims regarding predictors' impacts on outcomes related to differential participation and radicalization, I employ multilevel models with fixed-effects to account for the unobserved individual-level characteristics that may shape users' activity levels.²⁵ Fixed effects offers advantages over a random-intercept model, in that it “does not make any assumptions regarding the person-specific intercepts. The estimated regression coefficients represent within effects, where persons serve as their own controls” (Rabe-Hesketh and Skrondal 2012:713). With the exception of tenure and primary community, all user-level variables are also lagged to the previous year to avoid issues of mutual influence or correlation with community-level variables. Additionally, because subreddit

²⁵ Previous work has indicated that fixed-effects Poisson regressions are largely robust to issues of overdispersion, and may actually be preferable to a fixed-effects negative binomial model, which has been cited as not including ‘true’ fixed effects (Guimarães 2008; Wooldridge 1999). Additional tests on the data, however, indicate a fixed-effects Poisson does not meet the assumption of correct specification of the mean, and that the fixed-effects negative binomial is indeed preferable. It should be noted here that a primary concern regarding the fixed-effects negative binomial—namely that it allows for the incorporation of time invariant predictors—is of less concern in this analysis, which does not contain any time-constant covariates.

bans and quarantines can occur at any point during the year, and because these policies are meant to have a longer-term impact on extremist activity, variables for the number of bans or new quarantine implementations are similarly lagged. Finally, a lagged post count measure is also included as a control variable in all models; the percentage of user posts that were submissions is similarly included as a control for models incorporating number of comments received as a variable of interest, as this piece of the analysis relies on the Pushshift variable indicating the number of submission comments received.²⁶ For this phase of the analysis, tenure reflects users' tenure within the broader Reddit manosphere, rather than within any primary community; measures of community context, such as overall toxicity and toxicity spread, or the number of bans and quarantines implemented, similarly reflect the state of the Reddit manosphere as a whole, rather than any specific community.

To facilitate an analysis incorporating multiple user-years, additional data preparation was required. As previously noted in the discussion on construction of a variable measuring disengagement, some users experience periods of abeyant activity, ceasing participation and then resuming participation at a later date. Because years in which users are not active are not represented in the Pushshift Reddit dataset, which contains only information on posts made, which

²⁶ When initially conducting analyses on engagement rates and migration, comments and their parent IDs had not been matched, and it was unclear whether doing so would be feasible; as such, the default variable included in the Pushshift dataset was used as the metric for comments received. When preparing data for disengagement analysis, the inclusion of reply times necessitated digging further into the presence of parent IDs. Matching between comments and their parents was ultimately successfully implemented, and this more comprehensive comment variable was used in the analysis of disengagement. However, later tests comparing the inclusion of submission comments only versus total comments for the analyses on engagement rates and migration determined that the different specifications for comments received yielded very similar results, with no substantive impact on the strength or direction of any identified relationships, and that updating the previously completed analyses offered no real analytical gains.

were then aggregated into user-years, additional rows were constructed in Stata to reflect periods of nonparticipation bookended by periods of engagement; values of predictor and outcome variables here are set to zero.

The incorporation of lagged variables and fixed effects into the regression models also necessitates that the analysis focus on a subset of users present for more than one year. Additionally, calculation of coefficients for the negative binomial regression model requires complete observations for at least two periods per panel ID (Allison 2009). Combined with the inclusion of lagged variables in the analysis, this ultimately limits the sample to a subset of users present in the data for at least three years, yielding a total sample size of 133,662 users and 472,660 user-years. Results from the analysis are reported in Chapter 6; there, I also provide some additional descriptive accounts of user participation, as well as significant mean or percentage differences in yearly participation patterns across primary communities.

Modeling User Migration

To analyze the factors driving user migration, I utilize event history analysis—also sometimes referred to as survival analysis, duration analysis, or hazard analysis (among other terms) (Vermunt 2012). Event history analysis is, broadly put, concerned with explaining “why certain individuals are at higher risk than others of experiencing the event(s) of interest” (Vermunt 2012:1); this is accomplished through analysis of time to event, treating individuals as embedded within a temporal process that ultimately shapes the risk of an event occurring (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves, Gould, and Marchenko 2016). Event history analysis, then, is especially useful when the goal is analysis of a particular process—as is the focus of the current study. It also offers benefits relative to other approaches to analyzing panel or longitudinal data; in particular, it is better able to account for both time-dependent and time-varying covariates that may shape the

risk of an event occurring, and also does not assume that risk of an event occurring is consistent over time (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves et al. 2016).

These features make it an appropriate choice for studying processes of user migration as part of the online radicalization process. Here, individual users within the Reddit manosphere may be viewed as moving between distinct states (participation in particular primary communities) and changes in this state (i.e., movement into a new primary community) can in turn be expected to be impacted by time-dependent and time-independent factors. Also useful is that event history analysis allows for multiple changes in a particular state—in this case, where a user’s primary participation is occurring—over time, as well as for movement into more than one destination state (e.g., it is possible to model not just migration events, but the direction of the migration to a more or less toxic community) (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves et al. 2016). Event history models accounting for more than one possible destination state may be referred to as *multistate models*; those with more than one possible event occurrence are similarly referred to as *multiepisode models* (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves et al. 2016). These may be combined to model *multistate-multiepisode* processes, which is the approach taken here. The Reddit users included in this analysis may choose between two migration destinations—a more or less toxic community—and may change primary communities more than once.

There are also potential pitfalls to event history analysis that must be acknowledged. One of the most common considerations is the issue of *censoring*. Censoring occurs when “it is known that [an observation] did not experience the event of interest during a certain amount of time, but the exact time at which it experienced the event is unknown” (Vermunt 2012:3). Censoring can occur in two different directions. *Right* censoring occurs when it is not known if or when an event occurred *after* the observation period; put differently, for some observations an event may not

occur prior to or during the observation period, and after observation it will remain unknown whether this event will occur, or when (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves et al. 2016). Right censoring is generally considered unproblematic, as there is generally no expected relationship between the process being studied and when the observation period ends (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves et al. 2016). *Left* censoring occurs when it is unknown whether an event occurred *prior* to an observation period; this type of censoring is more problematic, because the duration in which an observation is in its origin state may influence the risk of an event occurring (Blossfeld and Rohwer 2019; Cleves et al. 2016). Fortunately, right and left censoring are of little concern in the current analysis. As the analytic dataset draws on Reddit user's full post histories, there is no potential for left censoring in the observations under study. Right censoring can be considered present for users who were active beyond the end of the period under study (December 2022), but again, this form of censoring proves unproblematic because there is no expected relationship between user migration and the end point of the analysis.

Event history analysis can also be conducted utilizing either continuous-time or discrete-time models, the selection of which is driven by the structure of the data; continuous-time models are appropriate when time is measured in relatively small units such as days or months, while discrete-time approaches may be employed when the time variable is less precise. This is most commonly the case when conducting survival analysis using panel data or other forms of data collection that occur at yearly intervals (Mills 2011; Willett and Singer 1995); the loss of information that occurs when the exact timing of an event is not known is also often referred to as *interval censoring* (Mills 2011). Continuous-time and discrete-time data then require different approaches because this less specific measurement leads to more individuals who share the specific time value at which an event occurred, which is sometimes referred to as “grouped ‘survival’

times”(Vermunt 2012:5). Discrete-time models “are typically estimated by means of maximum likelihood methods” (Vermunt 2012:19), most typically generalized linear models (GLM), and involve “regressing the conditional probability of occurrence of an event on the l th time interval given that the event did not occur before this period” (Vermunt 2012:16–17). Discrete-time models also offer certain advantages, including ease of inclusion for time-varying covariates and the ability to utilize more familiar methods such as logit or probit models (Allison 1984; Willett and Singer 1995). Models with more than one destination state may similarly rely on methods for categorical outcomes, such as multinomial logistic regression or pairwise binomial logit models (Steele 2008; Steele, Goldstein, and Browne 2004; Willett and Singer 1995).

For this section of the analysis, discrete-time models were chosen because this approach best aligns with how this project conceptualizes user migration—as a year-to-year to change in where a user's primary participation is occurring. Unlike changes in outcomes often studied using event history analysis, such as employment or marital status (which can definitively be identified as occurring at a particular moment in time), changes in where users participate are only identifiable through the construction of some definitive point that can be labeled migration. This left two viable options for measuring migration—identifying changes in where a plurality of a users' participation was occurring within some bounded unit of time (either months or years), or tracking users' cumulative post histories and identifying specific time points where the plurality of their cumulative participation shifted from being in one community to being in another. The former approach was selected in large part due to its decreased sensitivity, with this same rationale guiding the structuring of the data into discrete years rather than months—users can participate in multiple communities, and examining cumulative participation over time, or looking at posting activity at

the level of months rather than years, runs the risk of over-identifying migration as users' post histories grow and they 'settle in' to a primary space.

Because users can migrate more than once, and may migrate to either a more or less toxic community, the data also necessitates a multistate, multiepisode model, where the analytic data is formulated as a *person-period-spell* dataset (Willett and Singer 1995). This data structure accounts for the discrete-time approach and the possibility of multiple episodes by dividing each user's individual histories into spells and periods, where each individual spell starts at the time of entry into the risk set (in this case the user's second year present, which is the first year a migration is identifiable) and ends at the occurrence of the event of interest. Each period then reflects one individual unit in time, however it is measured, within a given spell. Concretely, this means that: (1) the data under analysis includes one or more rows for each manosphere user; (2) each user's history includes one or more spells spent within a primary community, which either conclude with a user migration into a different community or end in right censoring; and (3) each spell is composed of one or more periods, in this case years, spent within that primary community. Take, for example, a user present in the data who was active for five years, and who migrated twice to a new primary community: their first spell began when they entered the MRA community in 2016, where they were active for a period of one year. In 2017, they migrated into the MGTOW community, beginning their second spell within the data, which lasted for three years (i.e., three periods). In 2020, the user then migrated back to the MRA community, beginning a third spell that lasted a single year, after which they disengaged entirely. This user is represented in the data by a single user-id (i.e., *person*), broken down into individual years (i.e. *periods*), that are aggregated into durations of time (i.e., *spells*) spent within their primary communities.

In terms of application, discrete-time models rely on the previously described person-period-spell data structure and then draw on non-specialized GLM methods—such as the logit or probit models—in order to generate predictions. This is important to note, as the resulting coefficients are interpreted somewhat differently than in continuous-time event history models. Summarily put,

whereas the dependent variable in the continuous-time model is a hazard rate, in the discrete-time model it is the odds (if modeled using standard logit/probit models). The central difference with discrete-time models is that the discrete-time hazard function is the probability of an event occurring during interval t , conditional on the fact that the event did not occur before t (Mills 2011:181).

For models with multiple possible destinations states—termed *competing risks* models—estimates may be obtained either through a series of binomial logit models or through employment a multinomial logit (Steele 2008; Steele et al. 2004; Tutz and Schmid 2016; Willett and Singer 1995); models with recurring events may similarly be achieved by utilizing a multilevel model that includes subject-specific random effects to account for unobserved heterogeneity (sometimes also referred to as a frailty model) (Callens and Croux 2009; Steele 2008; Steele et al. 2004; Tutz and Schmid 2016). The analysis here employs a paired set of logit models to estimate the effects of key predictor variables on user migration to more or less extreme communities. Binomial logits were selected over a multinomial model to account for variation in users’ possible outcomes due to their primary community; namely, because the models seek to predict migration into more extreme versus less extreme communities, users who are already active in the least and most extreme communities—PUA and TRP—may only migrate in one direction, while users in the MRA, Incel, or MGTOW communities may migrate to either more or less extreme spaces. As

such, each series of binomial logit models also excludes users for whom the outcome under study was not possible. To account for within-subject differences that may shape migration, a random intercept is also included to allow for a subject-specific random effect, following recommended procedures for survival models that include frailty (Allison 1982; Steele 2008; Steele, Diamond, and Wang 1996; Steele et al. 2004; Willett and Singer 1995).

This segment of the analysis also focuses specifically on a subset of highly-active users. The summary statistics for engagement presented in Table 8 indicated relatively low levels of participation across most users, with a median tenure of 1 year and a median post count of 2. On the one hand, it is somewhat reassuring to know that most user engagement within the Reddit manosphere is relatively limited, with an overwhelming majority of users participating for a year or less, and making very few posts during their time participating. On the other hand, the prevalence of limited participation has salient implications for an analysis seeking to situate user migration as part of a radicalization story—namely, that one must determine at which point a user's activities can be viewed as meaningful engagement with an extremist ideology, in order for changes in where this engagement is occurring to be viewed as part of a radicalization trajectory.

In order to analyze only a set of users for whom trajectories may be considered a meaningful part of radicalization, inclusion in the analytic sample for the migration analysis was predicated on two conditions. First, because migration is conceptualized as a year-to-year change in where a user's primary participation is occurring, users present for less than two years were excluded from the sample. Second, users who did not meet sufficient criteria for engagement were similarly excluded; guided in part by literature that conceptualizes the top 1%-20% of posters as 'highly engaged' (Brandtzaeg and Heim 2011; Nielsen 2006), I choose to focus this analysis on

those who posted at or above the mean yearly rate of 16 posts (representative of the top 13% of posters). The result is a total analytic sample of 53,208 users and 107,295 user-years.

In this stage of the analysis, users' tenure and the number of bans/quarantines implemented incorporate information from a user's primary community specifically, rather than the overall Reddit manosphere. This also means that users with no primary community are omitted from the analysis. Because the person-spell-period data structure is such that a particular spell's final period corresponds to the period in which an event occurs—i.e., when a change in a users' primary community is observed—all variables excepting number of previous events are lagged to the previous year to reflect the user, reception and fit, and community characteristics in the year *before* a user's activity shifted to a new primary community. Here, tenure is also incorporated using dummy variables rather than a continuous measure, which allows the effect of time to vary across periods; the effect of other covariates is expected to be consistent across all periods. Because event history analysis also requires a sufficient number of events in all periods, user tenure of ten years or more was collapsed into a single category. The number of previous migration events and the percentage of a user's posts that were submissions, rather than comments, are also included as control variables, and the analysis again incorporates submission comments specifically as the measure of comments received. Results from the migration analysis are presented in Chapter 7, and are accompanied by descriptive statistics highlighting differences between migrating and non-migrating users.

Modeling User Disengagement

Analysis of user disengagement also employs event history analysis to assess the odds of disengagement in a particular period. Instead of the competing risks framework used to assess migration into more or less toxic communities, I here employ a multilevel logit model

incorporating random effects to model the probability of user disengagement from the Reddit manosphere during a particular period; this facilitates the inclusion of users experiencing multiple disengagement events.²⁷ Measures related to community context, such as toxicity alignment or the number of bans and quarantines implemented, are again set at the level of users' primary community rather than the Reddit manosphere as a whole. User-level predictors excluding primary community and tenure are also again lagged to avoid issues of reverse causality or mutual influence, and the number of prior disengagement events is included as a control. Again, the effect of time is allowed to vary across periods, while a consistent effect is assumed for other predictors. While user toxicity was not hypothesized to effect disengagement, it is included as a control due to the testing of interaction effects between user toxicity and platform-level repression events. In this section of the analysis, I also utilize the comment count variable created through matching comments with their parent IDs. The inclusion of lagged variables necessarily excludes users who are only present in the data for a single year, resulting in a total analytic sample of 266,206 users and 458,724 user-years. Results from the analysis on user disengagement are presented in Chapter 8, alongside summary statistics on user disengagement and periods of abeyance.

CONCLUSION

A summary of the outcome, methods, and results chapter for each section of the analyses are presented in Table 4. To summarize, I analyze engagement rates, migration into more or less extreme communities, and user disengagement from the Reddit manosphere, utilizing a

²⁷ Comparisons of models that included or excluded repeat disengagement events yielded similar coefficients, indicating that the relationships between key predictors and disengagement were similar across groups with without periods of abeyance.

combination of fixed-effects negative binomial regression and discrete-time event history analysis with random effects to assess the impact of key predictors on outcomes related to differential participation and radicalization into extremist movements. Before reporting results from the regression analyses, I present findings from a descriptive analysis of the development of the Reddit manosphere, which is detailed in Chapter 5.

Table 10. Results Overview

Outcome	Sample Size	Method	Results Chapter
Engagement Rates	$n = 133,662$	Fixed-effects negative binomial regression on yearly post rates	6
Migration	$n = 53,208$	Discrete-time competing risks event history analysis with random effects predicting odds of migration to more or less toxic communities	7
Disengagement	$n = 266,206$	Discrete-time event history analysis with random effects predicting odds of disengagement in a given year	8

CHAPTER 5: REDDIT, MISOGYNY, AND THE DEVELOPMENT OF THE REDDIT MANOSPHERE

CONTEXT: REDDIT, EXTREMIST IDEOLOGIES, AND ONLINE MISOGYNY

Reddit offers multiple practical and theoretical advantages as a case study for understanding user trajectories across the manosphere, in no small part because of its unique relationship with organized male supremacism. While members of male supremacist groups are active across a range of social media platforms, including YouTube (Ribeiro et al. 2021), Twitter (Jones et al. 2020), and private forums (Ribeiro et al. 2021), Reddit has drawn particular attention over the last decade for its connections to far-right organizing, both misogynist and otherwise (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016; Grover and Mark 2019; Massanari 2020). These connections were most visible in the lead up to the 2016 U.S. presidential election, during which time the now-banned subreddit r/The_Donald amassed nearly 150,000 subscribers and earned a prominent spot on Reddit's main site page, r/all; by the third month of former President Trump's tenure, this number had grown to nearly 350,000 (Peck 2020).

The popularity of r/The_Donald raised numerous criticisms from those concerned with the increase in far-right activity that accompanied Trump's campaign and subsequent presidency. The subreddit was evidenced to be a hotbed of nationalist sentiments, with users expressing high degrees of racism (McLamore and Uluğ 2020), sexism (Lagorio-Chafkin 2018), and xenophobia (Gaudette et al. 2021), alongside arguable calls for violence or extremist action (Lagorio-Chafkin 2018). As a result, Reddit was also thrust into the spotlight as part of national conversations regarding the extent to which digital platforms are responsible for addressing ideological extremism and political misinformation (Gallo and Cho 2021). In an attempt to address such critiques, r/The_Donald was quarantined by Reddit administrators in June 2020, a practice that limits visibility without outright banning communities, and was ultimately banned a year later for

violating newly-implemented policies regarding extremism and hate speech—though not before its userbase had once again more than doubled to nearly 800,000 subscribers (Peck 2020).

While some considered the rise of r/The_Donald to be anomalous, subsequent analyses of the subreddit's rise and fall implicate platform features in its ability to flourish (Gaudette et al. 2021; Massanari 2020); this echoes sentiments previously expressed in digital feminist scholarship, which has long highlighted how Reddit's platform affordances and unique technoculture create opportunities for extremism in the form of collective misogyny (Braithwaite 2016; Massanari 2017; Salter 2018). It is impossible, then, to account for Reddit's prominence as a site for ideological extremism—male supremacism included—without first understanding the platform's history, structure, and underlying ethos. In this chapter, I begin with such a history, outlining how Reddit's guiding platform logics and core features reflect the same masculine-coded, technolibertarian paradigm that has dominated virtual spaces since the early days of the web (Herring 2003; Jane 2014; Kendall 2000; Massanari 2017). Then, I move into a concrete discussion of the manosphere's history on Reddit—its inception, evolution, and enduringness. I combine this discussion of previous scholarship with my own descriptive findings to identify trends and raise new questions regarding user participation within the Reddit manosphere.

Platform Affordances and Extremist Content

Founded in June 2005, Reddit initially branded itself as 'the front page of the internet',²⁸ a reflection of its primary function as a content aggregation site where users could view and discuss media linked from other parts of the web (Lagorio-Chafkin 2018). The site is structured around

²⁸ In 2020, reflecting changes to the site as its userbase grew and developed, Reddit changed this slogan to "Dive into anything."

subreddits—individual forums hosted within the broader site that focus on topics ranging from the general (such as r/Movies or r/News) to the highly specific (take r/DogsWithJobs or r/SnakesWithHats as innocuous and enjoyable examples). To date, Reddit has cumulatively served as host to more than a million subreddits and hundreds of millions of users (Baumgartner et al. 2020), and is the third most popular website in the United States (Lagorio-Chafkin 2018).

Reddit is defined by several distinguishing features, both technological and cultural. As a platform, it has long subscribed to meritocratic, libertarian ethos wherein freedom of expression is prioritized over avoiding unsavory content, and users are ostensibly valued for the quality of their contributions to the overall Reddit community (Copland 2020; Lagorio-Chafkin 2018; Massanari 2017). A number of platform affordances reflect these ideals, including pseudonymous usernames, a community voting system for determining content visibility, and decentralized moderation that places control of subreddit content in the hands of select user-moderators rather than site administrators. Pseudonymity potentially cultivates a meritocratic environment by protecting privacy and reducing bias based on user characteristics such as race or gender (providing, of course, that users choose pseudonyms that do not disclose such characteristics) (Hogan 2013); it may also encourage candor while still allowing for some degree of accountability via consistent user identities (Massanari 2017). Reddit's system of upvotes and downvotes similarly speaks to the platform's values, in that users themselves determine the prominence of content on the site: they may choose to click an up or down arrow accompanying each post to indicate whether they personally found the content valuable. Posts that collect more upvotes are then moved to the top of the Reddit feed, while those receiving downvotes are moved further down the page. User contributions are also rewarded and penalized through this same system, as users gain or lose 'karma'—meaningless points which are accrued at the rate of one point per upvote (and that are

lost via downvotes in similar fashion). Karma does not provide actual benefits, but users' karma scores are visible on their Reddit profile page, and may serve as a sign of status within the Reddit community (Richterich 2014).

Reddit's libertarian bent, however, is perhaps *most* visible in the site's approach to content moderation. Reddit leadership has long taken a hands-off approach, initially permitting any form of legal content on the site and relying on volunteer moderators to police contributions on any given subreddit.²⁹ Rules surrounding appropriate contributions or engagement with the community have similarly been left to subreddits themselves, with some implementing few rules about hateful or abusive speech, and others severely restricting not only what content can be posted, but also what users' discussions and responses may include.³⁰

While Reddit leadership has historically framed their approaches as beneficial (Lagorio-Chafkin 2018), previous scholarship has noted that many of Reddit's key features and policies also contain substantial pitfalls. Pseudonymity, for example, comes with detriments, as anonymity more generally may encourage trolling (Hogan 2013), as well as the development of what Massanari (2017) terms *toxic technocultures*—digital cultures that are “enabled and propagated through sociotechnical networks... which often rely heavily on implicit or explicit harassment of others” (333). Toxic technocultures are also often oriented around negative sentiment towards marginalized groups and/or progressive values (Massanari 2017). Ranked voting for determining content visibility also has downsides, as contributions may at times be assessed based on the

²⁹ <https://www.redditinc.com/policies/moderator-code-of-conduct>

³⁰ The only permissible post title or post response on r/CatsStandingUp, for example, is the single word ‘Cat.’ (<https://www.reddit.com/r/CatsStandingUp/>)

popularity of the poster, or based on limited information such as post titles; this system may also make it difficult for marginalized users to push back against platforms norms that reflect a dominant white geek masculinity among the user base (Massanari 2017; Muchnik, Aral, and Taylor 2013).

Reddit's conservative approach to moderation has also proven somewhat problematic for deterring detrimental behaviors, extremist ideologies, and hate speech. Prior to the rise of r/The_Donald, there were a number of other instances of unsavory content being permitted to exist or flourish on the site. The most notable of such communities include r/CoonTown, a subreddit devoted to Confederate pride and overt racism against African-Americans (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; Schmitz, Burghardt, and Muric 2022); r/fatpeoplehate, where users collectively engaged in shaming images of overweight individuals (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; Russo et al. 2022); and r/jailbait, a forum dedicated to sharing and sexualizing suggestive photos of underage girls (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; DeCook 2022). While these subreddits, and many others like them, were ultimately banned by Reddit administrators, such bans came only in the wake of public pressure, and the reasons Reddit leadership cited for the bans focused not on the nature of the content, but on legal issues or violations of site rules surrounding harassment (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; DeCook 2022). The r/jailbait subreddit, for example, was only banned after drawing platform-wide attention when a nude photo of an underage girl was shared; at that time, Reddit did ultimately update its content policy to prohibit sexualizing images of minors.³¹ Similarly, r/fatpeoplehate was banned not due to the presence of hate speech, but was instead removed for

³¹ <https://www.redditinc.com/policies/content-policy>

violations of platform rules surrounding harassment after subreddit subscribers began antagonizing other users outside the subreddit (DeCook 2022).

The aforementioned subreddits serve as exemplars of the struggles Reddit leadership has faced in attempting to maintain a platform committed to free and open expression. Their ideal of permitting any form of legal content has, on multiple occasions, butted up against a need to avoid negative publicity and protect users outside of controversial subreddits from other users who may not be operating in good faith. To balance these considerations, Reddit leadership has also often erred on the side of reducing the visibility of troubling content, rather than removing it entirely; in 2015, Reddit introduced ‘quarantines’ as an alternative to outright banning controversial subreddits. Content from quarantined subreddits is not visible on Reddit’s front page regardless of how highly upvoted it is, and users must confirm that they agree to seeing potentially controversial content before they can visit quarantined subreddits (Davey 2015).

The nuances and varying approaches to content moderation on Reddit offer two primary analytical advantages for understanding not only extremist content, but radicalization into male supremacist communities specifically. First, Reddit’s platform affordances and overall reluctance to actively remove hate communities has been implicated in previous work attempting to analyze and explain the site’s role as a particularly fruitful space for alt-right and far-right activity (DeCook 2022; Gaudette et al. 2021; Grover and Mark 2019; Massanari 2017, 2020). In this sense, it can be expected that Reddit communities host more extreme views and virulent misogyny than sites such as Facebook, where anonymity is discouraged, hate speech is more widely policed, and platform employees are more actively involved in removing content that violates the site’s Terms of Service (Daniels 2009). At the same time, quarantines and community bans have contributed to an exodus of users with the most extreme views, who have at times opted to move to other, less-regulated

forums such as 4chan, Voat, or Incels.net in response to perceived censorship (Jaki et al. 2019; Newell et al. 2016; Zannettou et al. 2018). This suggests that Reddit communities likely represent neither the most conservative nor most extreme far-right viewpoints—a useful factor because this middle ground provides a set of spaces through which actors can flow, and because studying only extreme or conservative cases would not allow for a robust analysis of the differential participation and user migrations that are ultimately centered here.

Second, and highly significant for this dissertation, is that previous research has identified *misogynist* subreddits in particular as providing a significant foundation upon which alt-right and far-right activity can flourish (DeCook 2022; Mamié et al. 2021; Massanari 2020; Ribeiro et al. 2021). Misogynist subreddits outside the manosphere have been identified as early points of origin and adoption for much alt-right vernacular (Bezio 2018), and participation in manosphere subreddits often appears to precede participation in other far-right online spaces (Mamié et al. 2021). Certain manosphere subreddits, such as r/TheRedPill, have also been identified as playing a role in helping mobilize Trump’s base during the 2016 election (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019). Additionally, increases in both male supremacist and far-right activity on Reddit was also preceded by less politically charged—but equally misogynistic—events that have been connected to broader misogynist and far-right activity (Bezio 2018; DeCook 2022; Massanari 2020; Salter 2018). As such, Reddit’s unique history of misogyny and misogynist community is an important foundation for the development of the manosphere’s increasing prominence on Reddit. It is towards a more specific discussion of these earlier communities and events—their histories and notable activities—to which I now turn.

Organized Misogyny on Reddit

Reddit's role as a hub for online misogyny is perhaps most widely discussed in connection with two high-profile events that occurred in August 2014: Gamergate, a largely online movement ostensibly focused on ethics in gaming journalism, and The Fappening,³² a large scale leak of private celebrity photos that included a substantial number of nude images of female celebrities (Braithwaite 2016; Massanari 2017; Salter 2018). Gamergate originated within the gaming community, when indie game developer Zoe Quinn was accused by her ex-boyfriend—another game developer—of trading sex for positive reviews; the result was a movement that claimed to advocate for transparency and ethics in gaming journalism, but that functionally served as a coordinated campaign of harassment against Quinn and other prominent women and feminist figures connected to the gaming industry (Braithwaite 2016; Massanari 2017; Salter 2018). Quinn and other targets were subjected to discursive violence, including rape and death threats, and had their personal information posted publicly online (Bezio 2018; Massanari 2017; Salter 2018). The Fappening, in contrast, involved little active harassment; instead, it enabled the coordinated distribution of private images, and was accompanied by a blatant disregard for the ethics of sharing private material originally obtained through an illegal hack.

These events evince two comparatively different forms of misogyny, the first being the policing and punishment of women attempting to encroach on traditionally male domains (Manne 2018; Massanari 2017) and the second being the rife sexualization of, and entitlement to, women's bodies (Manne 2018; Moloney and Love 2018). What they share, however, is a certain *collective*

³² 'The Fappening' is a combination of The Happening—a reference to the M. Night Shyamalan film—and 'fapping'—internet slang to describe (primarily male) masturbation.

character enabled through digital platforms. Both these events transcended Reddit, drawing participants and attention from across a range of social media sites, but Reddit played a notable role in their organization, with associated subreddits forming and booming in rapid fashion (Braithwaite 2016; Massanari 2017; Moloney and Love 2018). Additionally, and in keeping with Reddit’s permissive moderation policy, these communities were *permitted* to flourish on the site: Massanari (2017) notes that despite the trading of illegally acquired photographs and the filing of copyright infringement notices, r/thefapping was once again not banned by Reddit administrators until it was discovered that content of minors was included among the leaked images. Reddit has also continued to serve as the primary hub of discussion for the Gamergate community since 2014, even after other platforms—including the notably permissive 4chan—banned discussions related to the movement (Massanari 2017).

Misogynist or not, Gamergate and The Fapping may at first glance appear disconnected from concerns with organized male supremacism or broader alt-right organizing. Yet, in their own ways, both these events exist as reactions to threats to male dominance, much in the same way that groups within the manosphere orient themselves towards these same challenges. In addition to providing a space for misogynist views and behaviors to flourish, Moloney and Love (2018) note that much of users’ behavior during The Fapping reflect *virtual manhood acts*—symbolic acts meant to reaffirm men’s dominance over women. Such acts “replicate the existing sex, gender, and sexuality stratification of in-person interactions in online social spaces” (Moloney and Love 2018:8) through behaviors like objectification and socialization. The implications of Gamergate are even greater; prior research on the movement has drawn connections between it and the alt-right, with Salter (2018) noting how the gendered base of technological advancement, in which both games and digital platforms become seen as rightful sites of male dominance, contributed to

the organized harassment accompanying the movement. This sense of entitlement, and the sense of male dominance in these spheres as being under threat, also contributed to the intensity of the Gamergate backlash in much the same way that a broader sense of entitlement drives participation in the far-right more broadly (Wilson 2020). Bezio (2018) similarly notes parallels between the language used in Gamergate communities and the lexicon adopted by the far right in recent years, identifying that “pejorative use of the terms ‘safe space,’ ‘snowflake,’ ‘unicorns,’ and ‘cry bullies’ all had their origins in Gamergate threads and forums like *Breitbart*, 4chan, 8chan, and Reddit’s r/RedPill” (563). This overlap has even led some scholars to conceptualize certain segments of the gamer community, Gamergaters included, as part of the broader manosphere; Ging (2017) notes that Gamergate “garnered widespread support from PUAs, MRAs, [and] MGTOWs” (645)—so much so that “PUA Roosh [Valizedah] has used it as an opportunity to launch a gaming website called *Reaxxion*, devoted to hosting Gamergate’s antifeminist propaganda, while Christian science fiction writer and game designer Theodore Beale (Vox Day) perceives it as symbolic in the fight against threats to Western values” (645).³³ O’Donnell (2022) similarly notes how far-right personalities including MRA blogger Mike Cernovich and alt-right personality Milo Yiannopoulos involved themselves in the movement despite having previously disparaged the gaming community; she takes this as evidence that the root of Gamergate was in antifeminism rather than legitimate concerns over gaming ethics.

Gamergate and The Fappening, then, serve as exemplars of high-profile instances of organized misogyny, simultaneously offering insights into the breadth of its collectivity and the

³³ Vox Day is a relatively known personality within the manosphere; in addition to his writing and game work, he has served as a highly prominent far-right blogger and personality.

meagerness of Reddit administrators' interventions. Further, understanding the connections between these high-profile incidents and the broader Reddit climate is important, because their permissibility and accompanying culture of misogyny paved the way for what were once fringe subreddits to move into the mainstream when far-right sentiments later intensified during the 2016 U.S. election (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019; Mamié et al. 2021).

The Development of the Reddit Manosphere

The above discussion provides insights into how Reddit's ethos, features, and history have created a safe space for misogyny to flourish. However, this gives little insight into the Reddit manosphere's communities in particular—their inception, development, and relations to one another. It also says little about how Reddit's continued efforts to balance platform values with content moderation have impacted secular male supremacist spaces. As a final step before presenting my own descriptive findings, I overview previous research on the Reddit manosphere, with a particular emphasis toward: 1) trends in community extremity, activity, and participation; and 2) analyses of platform developments and notable incidents that may have shaped these trends.

As addressed in Chapter 2, which detailed the ideology and origins of secular male supremacism, the manosphere is a broad constellation of websites, blogs, and forums, and cannot be said to be limited to, or have originated on, Reddit itself. Manosphere communities did, however, take hold there very early on, and many are firmly entrenched on the site. The first manosphere subreddits—*r/PUA*, *r/seduction*, and *r/MensRights* —appeared in 2008, just three years after the platform's inception, and represented two of the earliest manosphere groups—PUAs and MRAs (Ribeiro et al. 2021). It should be noted that the timing of these subreddit's creation corresponds with Reddit's introduction of users' ability to request subreddits, rather than users being limited to posting on subreddits created by platform administrators (Lagorio-Chafkin 2018).

By 2018, Reddit had hosted a cumulative total of 57 subreddits related to the PUA, MRA, Incel, MGTOW, and TRP communities (Ribeiro et al. 2021).

Previous research notes several developments within these communities over time, related to both the quantity and quality of user participation. In terms of the former, not only does participation appear to be increasing overall, but there also appear to be significant shifts in which communities see the highest degree of user activity. In their examination of community development over time, Ribeiro et al. (2021) identify three rough periods in the data: “a first period (2006-2011) where the Manosphere was mostly about men’s rights and pickup artistry, and where the Incel community was in its infancy, a second period (2012-2016) where there was a growth of the MGTOW and the TRP community and the decline of PUAs, and a third period (2016-2018) where Incels and MGTOW rose to prominence, and the TRP-related subreddits lost their momentum” (201). Notably, these shifts do not appear driven purely by influxes of new users into specific communities; rather, members of longer standing manosphere communities, such as MRA or PUA, appear to be migrating into newer communities like Incel and MGTOW (Ribeiro et al. 2021).

These shifts in where participation is occurring are significant because they reflect more than simple changes in user preference over time; rather, they reflect movement between spaces that are qualitatively distinct in many ways. Previous findings indicate that not only does the manosphere itself appear to be grow more toxic and misogynistic over time (Farrell et al. 2019; Ribeiro et al. 2021; Vu et al. 2021), but also that user migration predominantly involves user shifts from less toxic and misogynistic communities such as MRA and PUA, and towards communities that are more toxic and misogynistic, such as MGTOW and Incel spaces (Ribeiro et al. 2021). This is accompanied by what Farrell et al. (2019) identify as “an *ideological shift* away from men’s

rights topics that used to unite members towards more misogynistic and violent ideas” (87). Put succinctly, much user migration then appears to be happening as users move from less to more extreme spaces within the Reddit manosphere, and as users move towards spaces with different applications of male supremacist ideology. MGTOW users, for example, appear to be migrating to Incel spaces, which is a somewhat perplexing trend given that these communities have quite different substantive concerns: MGTOW communities have primarily focused on social conditions being unfavorable to men, advocating for a separatist lifestyle that eschews contact with women (Lin 2017; Rothermel et al. 2022; Wright et al. 2020), while Incels are foundationally concerned with an inability to secure sexual or romantic relationships with women (Furl 2022; Menzie 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022). In this case, one might expect migration in the *opposite* direction, as Incel users give up on securing romantic relationships and opt instead to pursue a separatist lifestyle, but the reverse—a shift from MGTOW’s intentional separatism to Incel fatalism—is somewhat more puzzling.

Explanations for these shifts are scant; previous work focuses primarily on describing trends, calling for further research to develop explanatory accounts (Farrell et al. 2019; Ribeiro et al. 2021). At the same time, the increasing extremism of the Reddit manosphere has ultimately not gone unnoticed by Reddit administrators, nor have these communities been unaffected by platform policy changes across the years. The first wave of updates to Reddit’s policies surrounding hate speech (implemented in 2015) had little initial impact on manosphere spaces, but such communities did ultimately come to face sanctions under these revised guidelines; the initial Incel subreddit, r/Incels, was banned from Reddit in 2017 for inciting violence against women (Hauser 2017), and in 2018 its successor, r/Braincels, was quarantined alongside TRP subreddit r/TheRedPill when Reddit again updated its content policies (Copland 2020). 2019 brought

additional action from administrators, including the eventual ban of r/Braincels and the quarantining of the initial MGTOW subreddit r/MGTOW (Binder 2019; Copland 2020); r/MGTOW was also ultimately banned in August 2021 for violating Reddit’s “policies regarding the promotion of violence and hate” (Thalen 2021:5).

The impact of Reddit’s interventions into problematic communities appears modest, and the Reddit manosphere is no exception. Previous work on the banning of controversial subreddits outside the manosphere has shown that, overall, many users discontinue platform (i.e., Reddit) use following deplatforming, and that remaining users who migrate to other unassociated subreddits do not appear to continue engaging in hate speech or toxic behaviors after migrating (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017); in contrast, users who discontinue on one platform often migrate to other online spaces that are more permissive of extremist views (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016). These trends appear somewhat true within manosphere subreddits: quarantines have been shown to reduce engagement in some subreddits by nearly half, though previous work was unable to clarify whether users stopped participating or merely shifted participation to more accessible subreddits (Copland 2020). Notably, however, there was a slight uptick in the use of misogynistic language among participants who remained in quarantined subreddits, potentially highlighting an intensifying effect (Copland 2020). Further, quarantines and bans of specific subreddits did not appear to have longstanding effects on broader communities; Gillett and Suzor (2022) note that when r/Braincels emerged to replace the original Incel subreddit, some moderators did attempt to maintain community standards that adhered to Reddit’s content guidelines. However, because many other moderators also tended to be active users who ‘bought in’ to community ideologies, the same ideologies and behaviors present on the original Incel subreddit were ultimately present in its replacement, and often went unaddressed. As such, the effect of quarantines and bans appear

limited, particularly when only individual subreddits are targeted and when new subreddits emerge to replace those that have been removed.

Previous work, then, points to an interesting combination of factors. First, trends in manosphere participation show that: 1) more men are becoming active in male supremacist communities; 2) these men are developing increasingly extremist beliefs; 3) there is a corresponding escalation of extremism within these groups as a whole; and 4) there are shifts in which groups within the manosphere are effectively recruiting participants. Second, users' patterns of behaviors appear shaped, at least in part, by not just the internal conditions of these communities, but also by platform policy changes that seek to limit or outright eliminate participation within certain subsections of the Reddit manosphere. Taken together—and to restate from previous chapters—this raises two key questions: 1) what individual and community-level factors drive differences in engagement in male supremacist communities; and 2) what individual and community-level factors predict user migration to more extreme communities?

The remainder of this chapter serves as a necessary precursor to addressing these questions. Here, I present my own descriptive findings on participation trends within the Reddit manosphere, reproducing and expanding on earlier work as a starting point for developing explanatory accounts of the previously identified shift in participation. I connect, where relevant, to both the findings in previous literature and to notable events in Reddit history that may account, in part or in whole, for changes in user behavior over time. I then end with discussion of specific lingering questions, setting the stage for the explanatory analyses presented in the subsequent chapter.

PRELIMINARY ANALYSES: COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT OVER TIME

The manosphere communities under investigation all have unique trajectories in terms of their formation, growth, and character. In this section, I discuss each community's development in turn, moving from the least to the most toxic community. The use of toxicity as an orienting point

for discussion is in part informed by previous findings on the Reddit manosphere, which—among other key claims—suggests that the manosphere overall is growing more extreme or toxic, and that user participation is trending towards more toxic communities (Farrell et al. 2019; Ribeiro et al. 2021). Analysis of user migration specifically also indicates that individual users are actively moving away from less toxic communities, and towards those that are more toxic or extreme (Ribeiro et al. 2021).

For initial context, Figure 1. Average Values for Toxicity Attributes, by Community

Figure 2. PUA Subreddits over Time**Figure 3. Average Values for Toxicity Attributes, by Community**

Figure 4. PUA Subreddits over Time

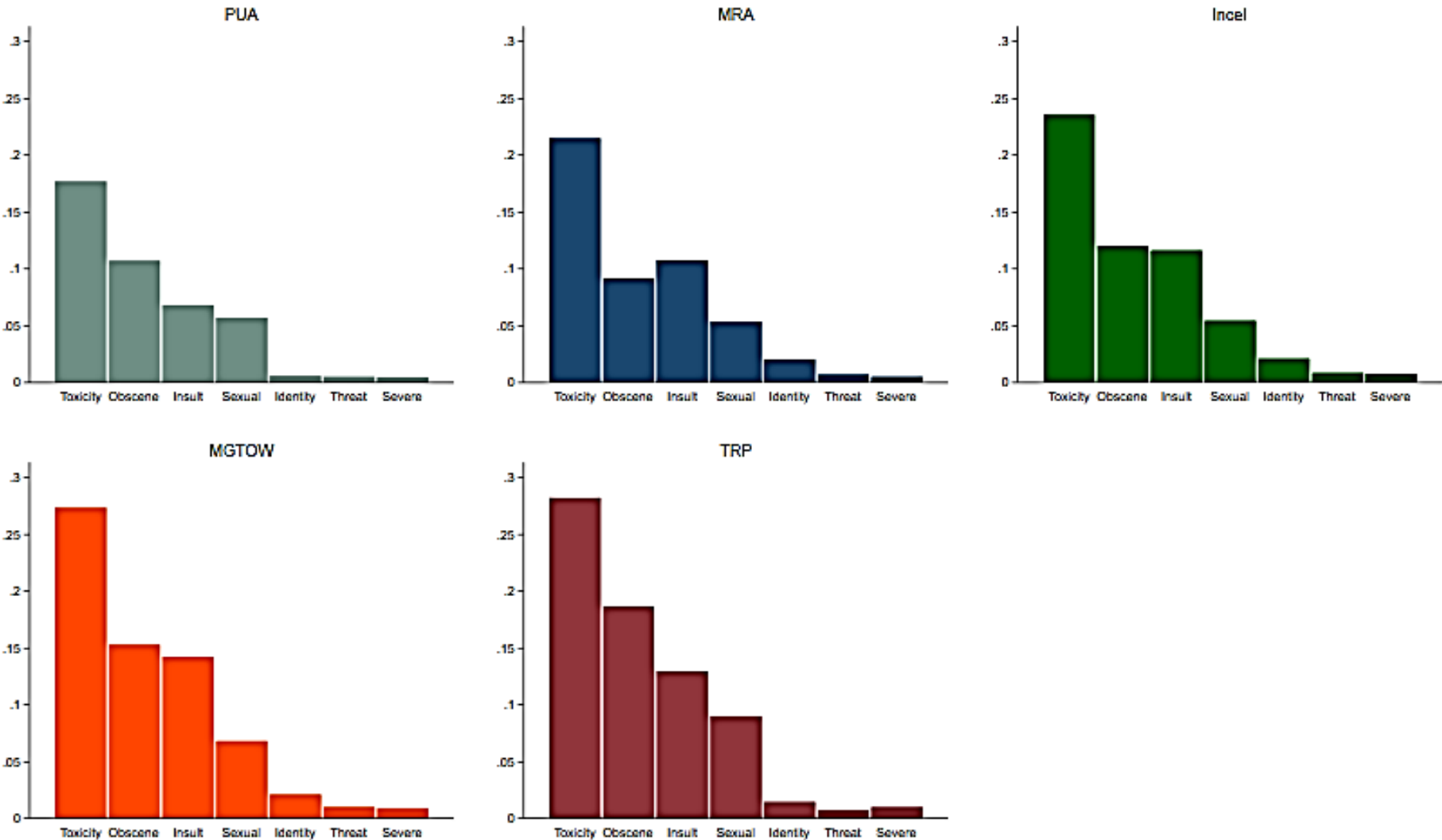
Figure 5**Figure 6. PUA Subreddits over Time****Figure 7. Average Values for Toxicity Attributes, by Community**

Figure 8. PUA Subreddits over TimeFigure 9 presents mean toxicity scores across the five communities under study, broken down into the different attributes measured by Detoxify— toxicity, obscenity, insults, sexual explicitness, identity attacks, threats, and severe toxicity. As a reminder, scores represent the probability that a reader would identify a specific post or comment as evincing the specific attribute, and thus range from 0 to 1, with a higher score indicating a higher

probability.³⁴ Overall, scores support the notion that certain later-emerging communities are more toxic, though in some cases these differences are substantively small. Attribute scores are highest for toxicity, obscenity, and insults, and in all cases the scores for the Incel, MGTOW, and TRP communities exceed those of PUA and MRA, reflecting increasing toxicity as new communities emerge. PUA and MRA were the two original communities within the Reddit manosphere, founded in 2008, while the Incel, MGTOW, and TRP communities emerged later—and in that order. Ranking communities by their toxicity is thus also equivalent to ranking them chronologically in terms of their emergence, which lends *prima facie* support to previous works' claims that newer communities within the Reddit manosphere are more toxic or extreme.

³⁴ https://support.perspectiveapi.com/s/about-the-api-faqs?language=en_US

Figure 1. Average Values for Toxicity Attributes, by Community



For each of the five communities, I address a number of elements of community development. I begin with a discussion of each community's formation and growth, assessed using three key metrics, the first of which is the number of subreddits associated with each segment of the Reddit manosphere; each of the five communities under study are connected to multiple subreddits, and the exact number of active subreddits changes over time, both as new communities emerge and new subreddits are created, and as other subreddits are rendered defunct following Reddit policy changes and/or subreddit bans. After assessing growth in the number of subreddits associated with each community, I then move on to addressing the degree of participation within these spaces, conceptualized two ways: first is the *activity* within a community—that is, the degree to which users are posting in these spaces—and second is the *popularity* of the community—that is, the number of active users engaging across a given community's subreddits. In theory, any given community may boast a user base that is highly active without being in itself large; addressing both the rates of posting activity and the number of users participating addresses these distinctions.

After summarizing community development, I assess overlap between communities, as trends in participation alone say little about the relationships *between* the communities under study—a key consideration if one ultimate goal is to understand the drivers and impacts of user migration between online spaces. Understanding the degree to which users in one community are posting in other communities serves as a precursor to analyzing flows of users between communities, which is useful for two reasons. First, spikes and dips in overlap may capture processes related to user migration—overlap may increase as users in one community begin participating in other spaces, and then decline as those users migrate out of their original communities. Evidence of overlap that does not correspond to migration, however, may be useful

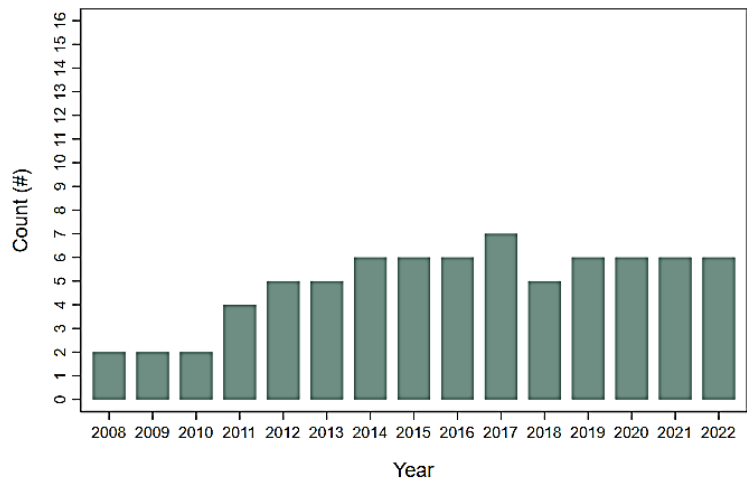
for identifying cases where users have potential to migrate, but ultimately do not. After assessing overlap, I then shift focus explicitly to migration, presenting a comprehensive analysis of users’ movements between communities. For the purpose of this analysis, remember that user migration is conceptualized as a change in where a user’s *primary* participation is occurring, operationalized as a year-to-year shift in where the plurality of a user’s posting activity is taking place. A user, then, is considered to have migrated when their primary community in a given year is different from their primary community in the previous year.

Finally, I end my discussion by referring back to community toxicity. While toxicity is the orienting point around which this discussion is organized, it is best contextualized as part of a broader story surrounding manosphere participation on Reddit; it allows changes in toxicity to be better connected to shifts in community growth and user participation, and better depicts how community changes over time correspond to changes in the relative extremity of each community.

Pickup Artists (PUA)s

Community development. The PUA community first appears on Reddit in 2008, with the creation of two subreddits—r/seduction and r/PUA. This is the first year in which any manosphere community is active on Reddit, and corresponds with Reddit’s introduction of user-created

Figure 10. PUA Subreddits over Time



subreddits. **Figure 10. PUA Subreddits over Time**

Figure 11Figure 12. PUA Subreddits over Time

Figure 13. PUA Activity over Time

Figure 14Figure 15Figure 16. PUA Subreddits over Time

Figure 17Figure 18 presents the number of active subreddits by year as a preliminary indicator of the growth of the community, which is relatively modest over time—additional subreddits are not introduced until 2011, and the community peaks at a total of seven subreddits in 2017. From here there is a slight dip, and a leveling off at six active PUA subreddits from 2019 to 2022, the last year for which data is available.

In terms of popularity and activity, the trajectory of the PUA community is more uneven. Results show that PUA begins with relatively low levels of participation—small enough to be

Figure 19. PUA Activity over Time

rendered nearly invisible in Figure 19. PUA Activity over Time

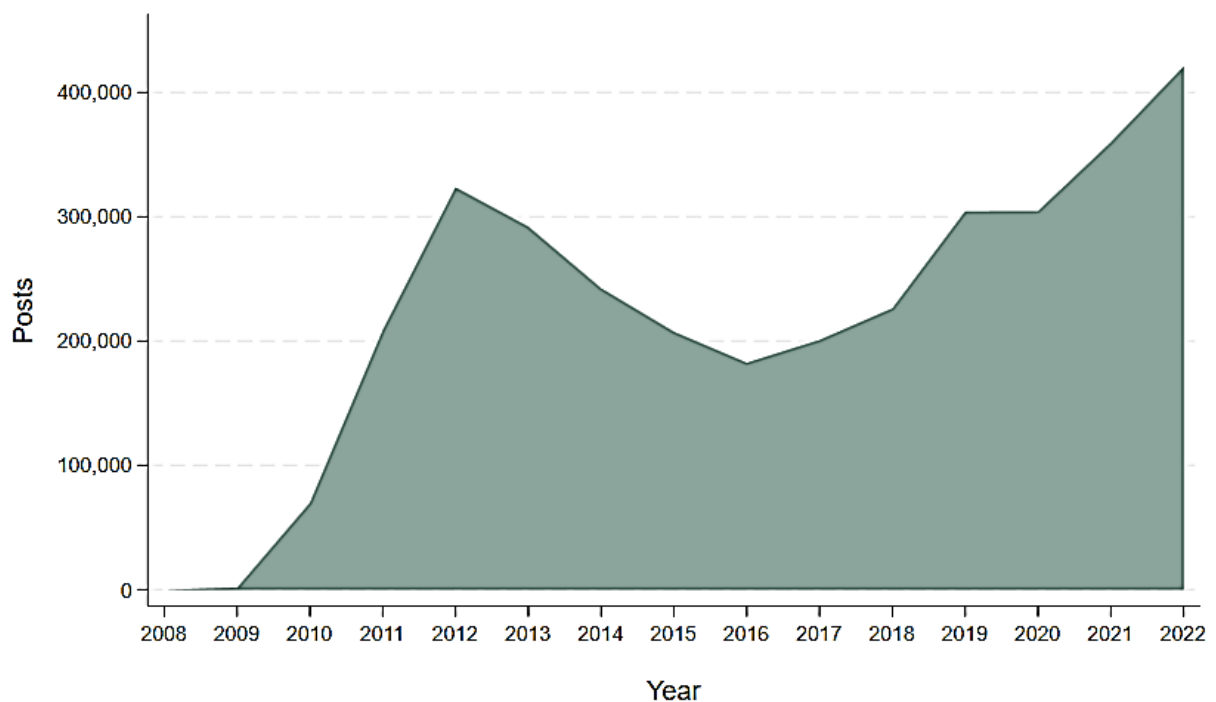


Figure 20Figure 21. PUA Activity over Time

Figure 22. PUA Users over Time

Figure 23Figure 24. PUA Activity over Time

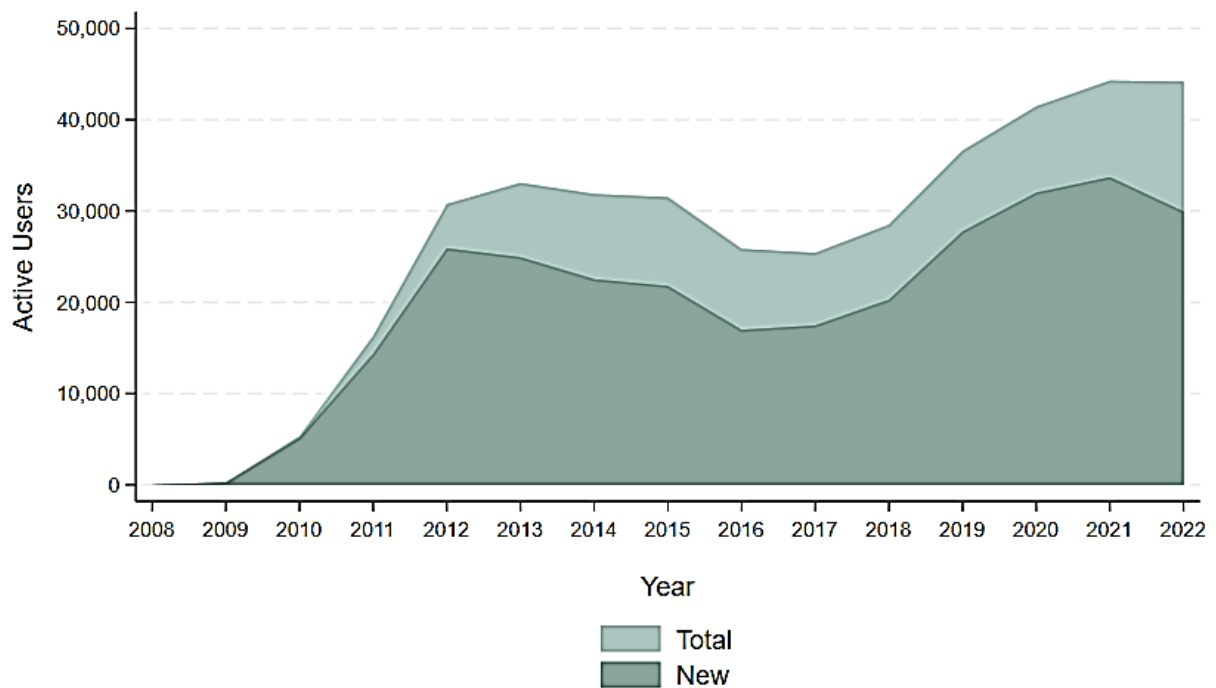
Figure 25Figure 26 and Figure 27. PUA Users over Time

Figure 28. PUA Users over Time

Figure 29. PUA Users over Time

Figure 30, with only 31 active users and 97 posts in 2008. PUA participation then increases substantially over the next two years; more than 50,000 posts are made to PUA subreddits in 2010 alone, and activity continues to increase until it ultimately surpasses 300,000 posts in 2012. PUA popularity also sees steady growth during this period; the community surpasses 30,000 members.

Figure 27. PUA Users over Time



From 2013 to 2017, posting activity then declines and the user base levels off, with the community once again seeing growth in both activity and popularity from 2017 to 2022. It surpasses its previous popularity by 2019 (and then surpasses itself yet again in subsequent years) before reaching all-time highs in posting activity in 2021 and 2022. Interestingly, Figure 27. PUA Users over Time

Figure 28. PUA Users over Time

Figure 29. PUA Users over Time

Figure 30 also shows that for any given year, the bulk of the PUA user base is composed of new users—that is, users who participated in the community for the first time in the specified year. This suggests not only growth in popularity, but a high turnover in the user base, with new users rapidly entering spaces but not necessarily participating for more than one year. More detailed discussion of individual users’ length of participation in manosphere communities is presented in Chapter 6.

Community overlap. **Error! Reference source not found.** through **Error! Reference source not found.** present user overlap for the PUA community, broken down as the percentage of PUA users who also posted in each of the other four communities under study. Results show that in the beginning, PUA shares substantial overlap with the MRA community—in 2008, nearly 20% of PUA users are also posting in MRA spaces. However, this number declines sharply and steadily over time, ending at only 3% overlap by 2022.

PUA overlap with other communities, in contrast, grows by varying degrees—an intuitive finding given that the later emergence of the other communities allows only for growth of this overlap in earlier years. In all cases, this period of growing overlap is ultimately followed by decline, though the particular patterns and degrees of overlap vary some. The percentage of PUA users also posting in the Incel communities rises immediately after the Incel community’s initial appearance in 2010, hovering around 5% from 2011 to 2012, which aligns with prior work indicating the Incel community emerged in part as a response to disillusionment with PUA tactics. This overlap then decreases to around 2% in 2015, rises again to nearly 6% in 2018, and subsequently dwindles once more. Overlap with the MGTOW community, in contrast, grows

slowly and does not quite meet that reached with the Incel community; overlap starts at under 1% in 2012 and gradually increases to 5% by 2019. It then tapers off in the final few years of the data.

PUA overlap with TRP sees more robust growth compared to other communities, and remains consistently high—a trend which likely evidences TRPs early origins in the PUA community, and the alignment of these communities’ primary goals (Rothermel et al. 2022). The first TRP spaces appear in 2012, and only two years later 11% of PUA users are also posting in TRP. This figure continues to increase to 14% by 2017, after which overlap declines slowly and evenly back down to around 2%.

Figure 31. PUA-MRA Overlap over Time

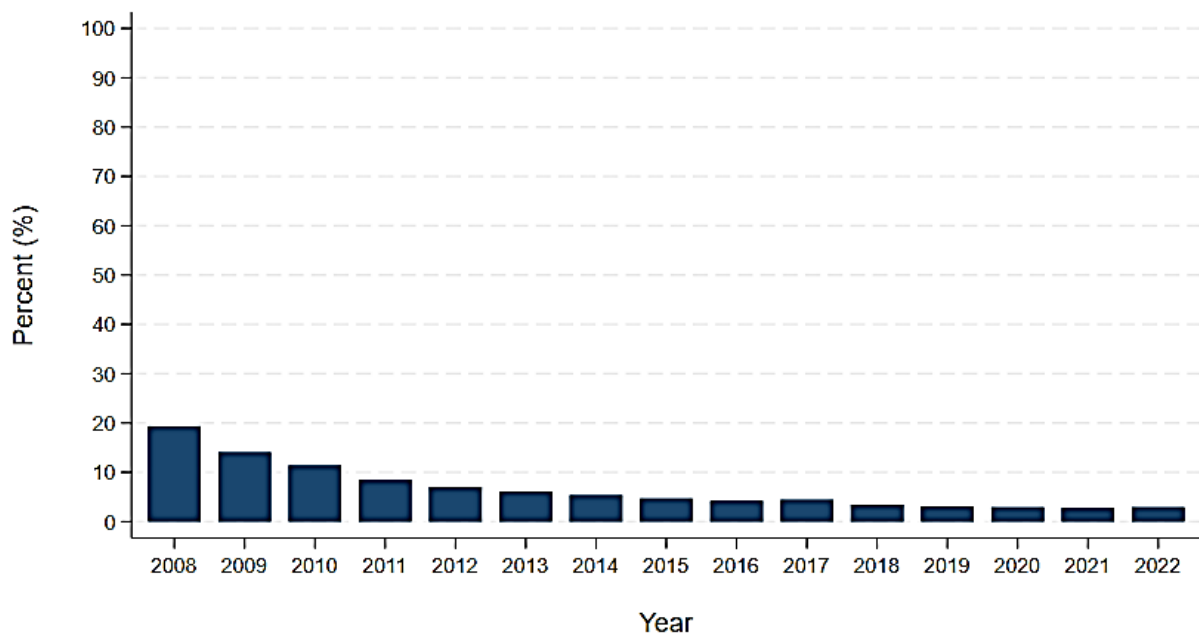


Figure 35. PUA-Incel Overlap over Time

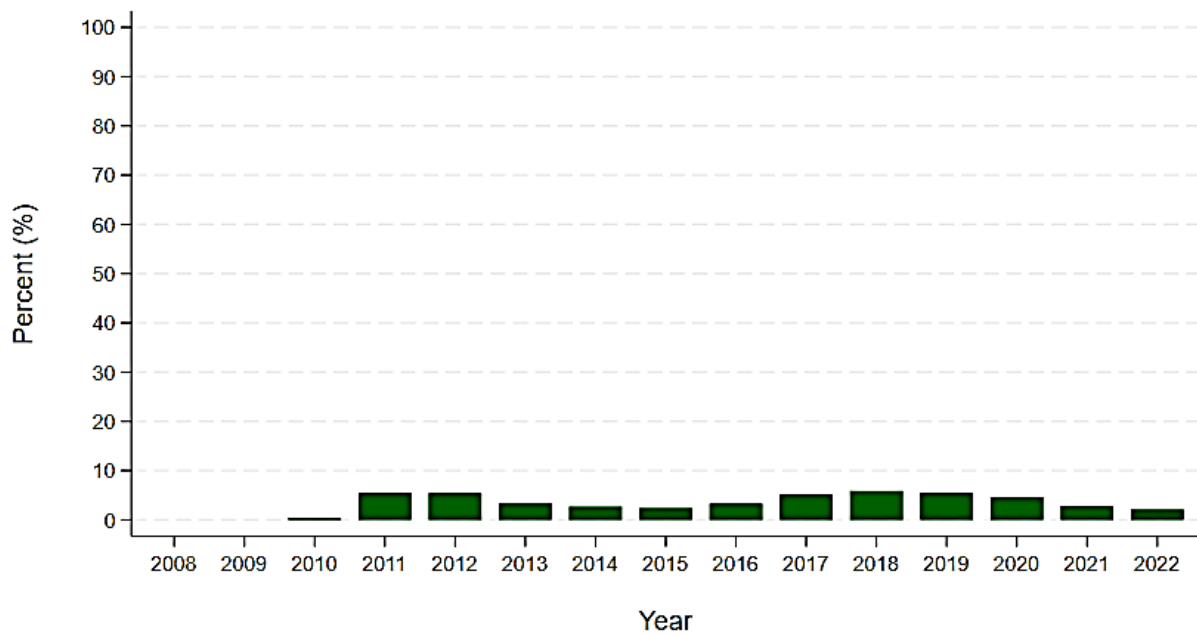


Figure 39. PUA-MGTOW Overlap over Time

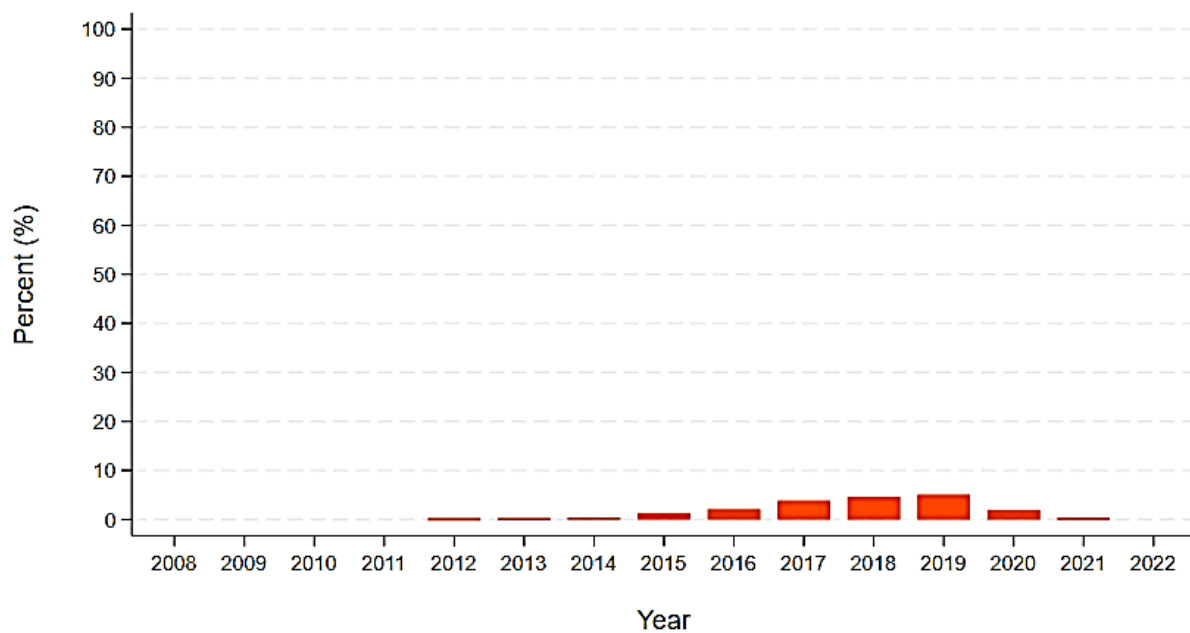
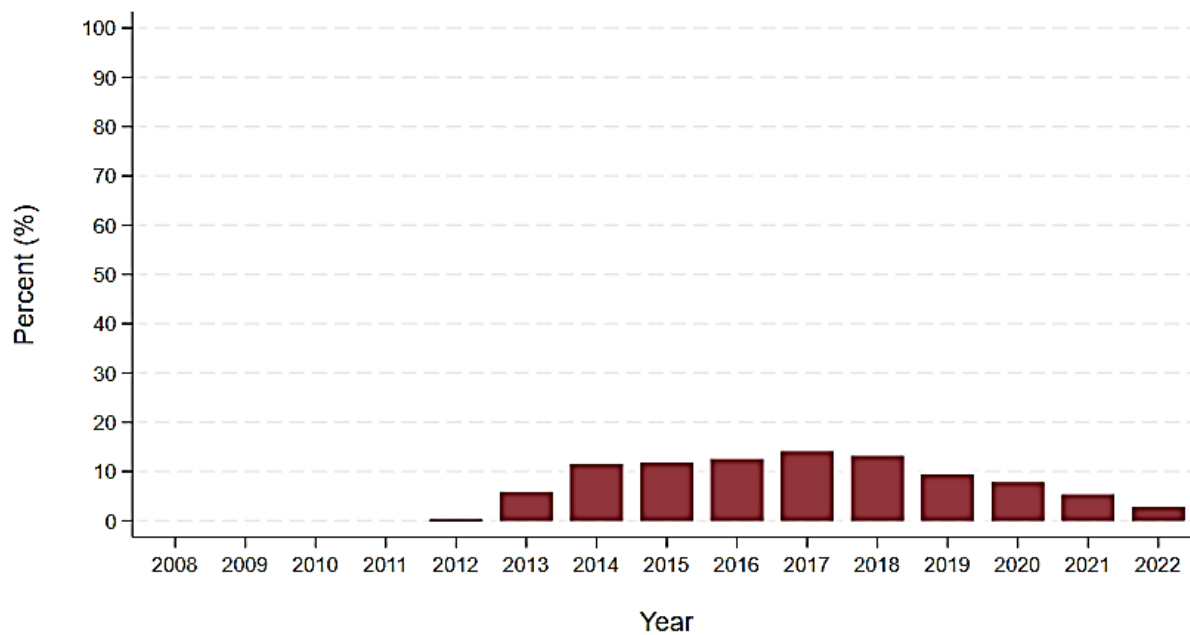


Figure 43. PUA-TRP Overlap over Time



User migration. **Error! Reference source not found.** through **Error! Reference source not found.** present the yearly rate of migration into and out of the PUA community, broken down by migration source (i.e., the community from which users migrated *into* PUA) and destination (i.e., the community users moved into when migrating *out of* PUA). A couple notable trends are identifiable in these visualizations. First is that users are not moving evenly between all communities; user migration from PUA to TRP is much more pronounced than other communities, reaching a high of 1,250 migrations in 2019, while movement from PUA to MGTOW appears to be much less common, with a maximum of only around 350 migrations in this direction that same year. Migration in the inverse direction—from MGTOW or TRP into PUA—shows a similar pattern, with MGTOW to PUA migrations being comparatively rare, and TRP to PUA migrations reaching higher levels compared to other communities. Note that these trends do not all map neatly on to trends in community overlap—overlap with MRA started high and decreased steadily, while migration between communities remains relatively level over time. Incel to PUA migration seems to match patterns of overlap as well, but this overlap is less visible in PUA to Incel migrations. Migration between PUA and the TRP communities also spikes early or late, while overlap between these communities is highest in the middle years, suggesting that overlap is driven by dual participation in both communities rather than migration.

Second, the findings show time-based shifts in migration patterns. In the first few years, user migration primarily occurs in the direction of MRA to PUA; it isn't until 2011 that the first MRA to PUA migrations occur. Through 2012, exchange between MRA and PUA—in either direction—also exceeds migration into or out of the Incel community, which is likely a consequence of the Incel community not emerging until 2010. From 2012 to 2020, PUA migration

into MRA is also greater than MRA migration into the PUA community, though the numbers are modest, with PUA to MRA migration reaching around 600 migrations at most.

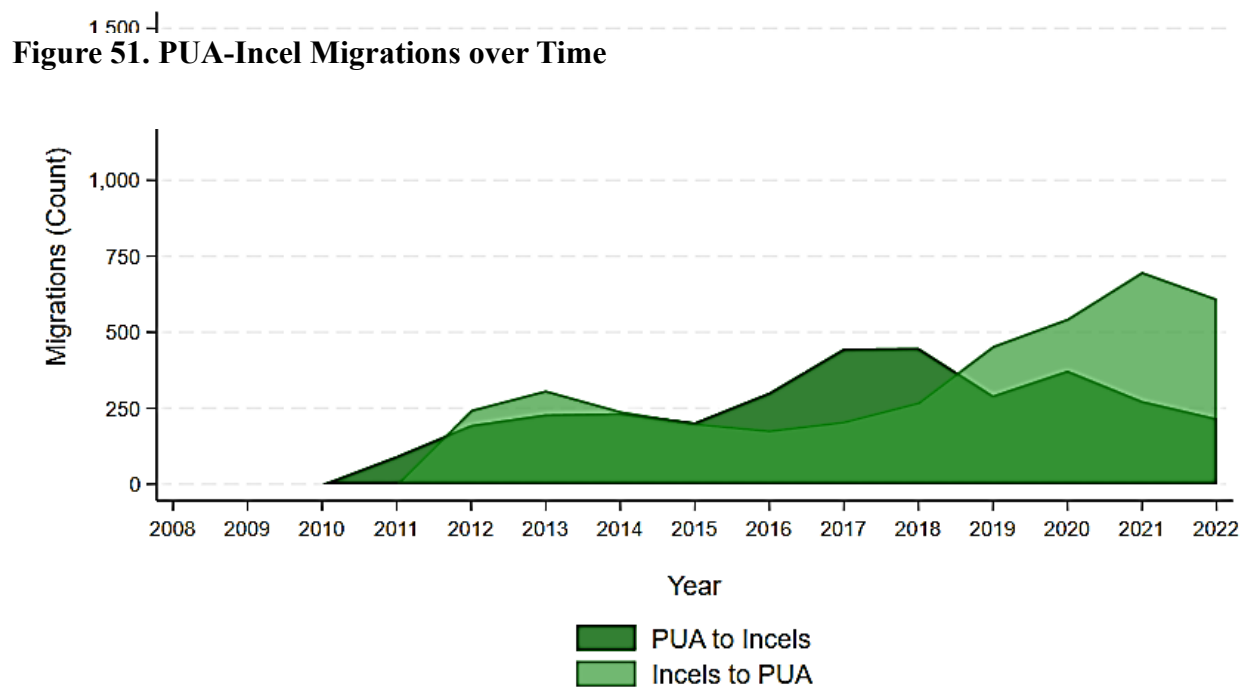
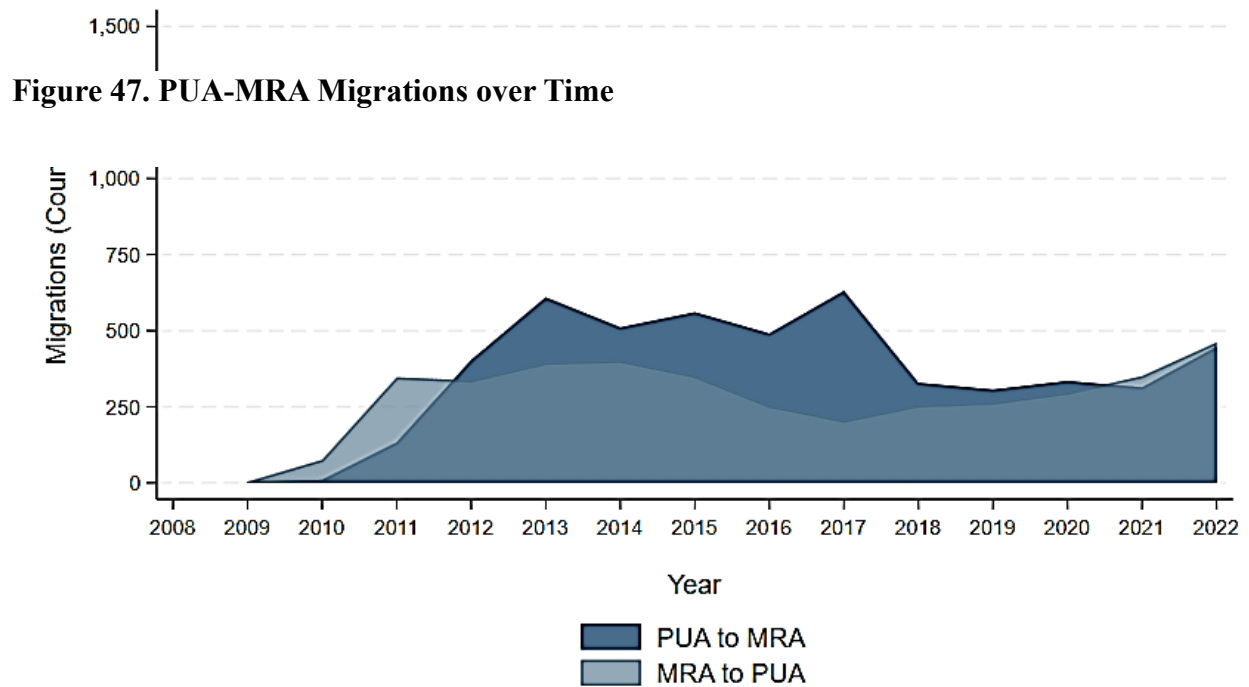


Figure 55. PUA-MGTOW Migrations over Time

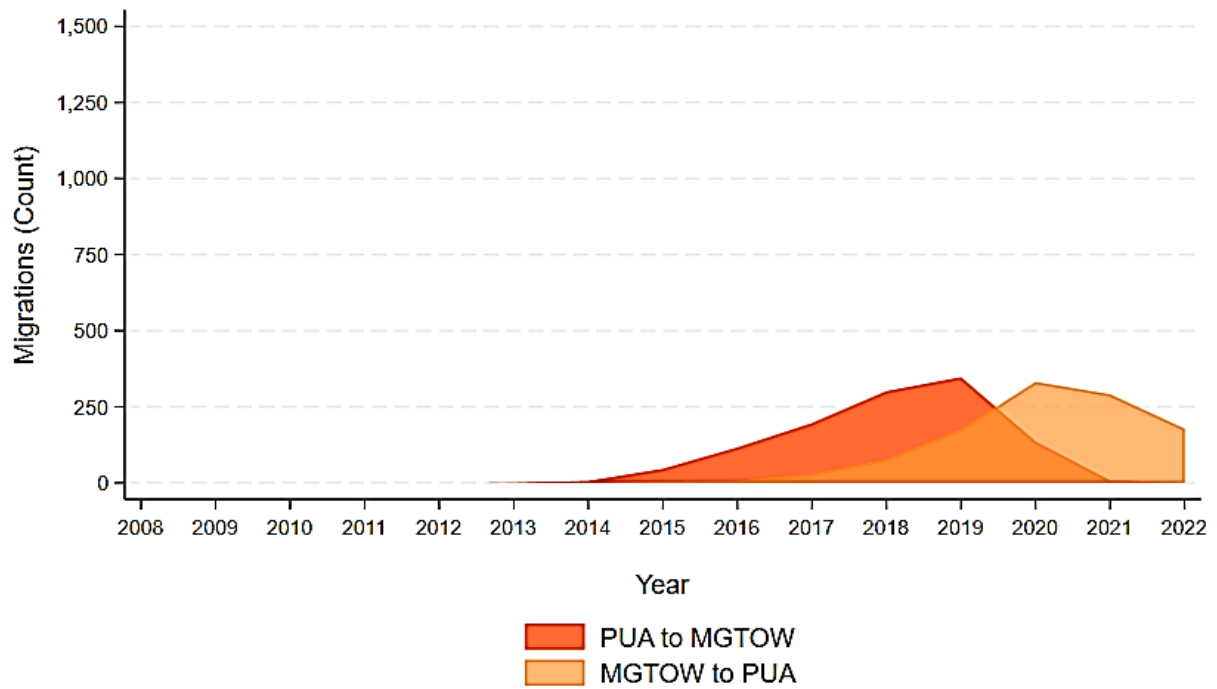
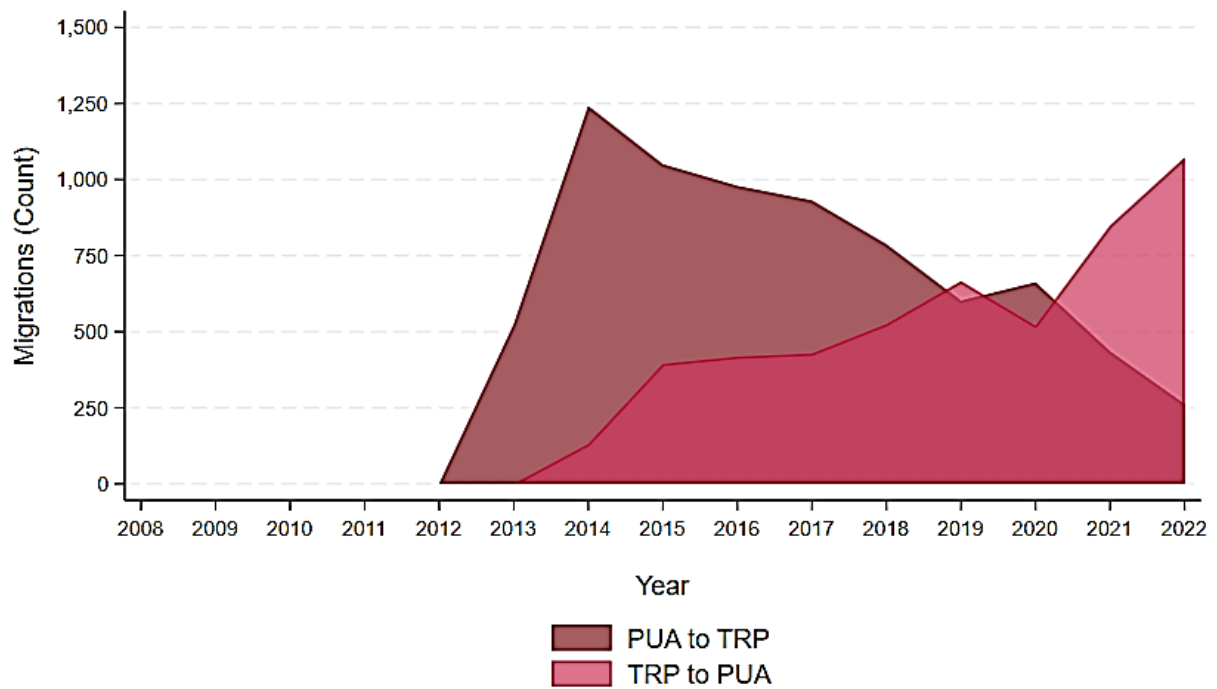
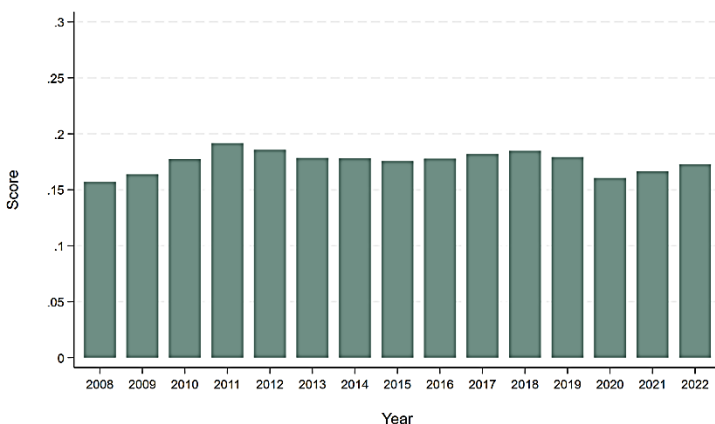


Figure 59. PUA-TRP Migrations over Time



After 2012, developments in migration occur. Incel migration into PUA spaces reaches rough parity with MRA to PUA migrations by 2013, then declines slightly; PUA to Incel migrations continue to grow during this period as well, peaking at just under 500 migrations in 2017 and 2018. These rates are, however, still exceeded by PUA migrations into Incel spaces. Additionally, PUA to TRP migrations see immense growth in this period; there are around 500 migrations from PUA to TRP in 2013, a figure that more than doubles in 2014, when just under 1,250 users move from PUA to TRP. After this peak, migration in this direction tapers off; this is likely a product of community introduction—TRP first emerges in 2012, and as such the sharp rates of migration into TRP from PUA may signal a mass exodus of users moving towards TRP as their primary community. The particular high degree of migration here may, again, also be in part driven by TRPs origins in the PUA community. Perhaps as a consequence, TRP migration into PUA also continues to grow over time, reaching around 375 in 2015, and increasing to almost 700 by 2019. Interestingly, TRP to PUA migration then dips slightly only to spike between 2020 and 2022; 2022 sees more than a thousand users migrating into PUA from TRP. There is similarly a late rise in Incel to PUA migrations, which reach nearly 750 in 2021. Note that this late influx of

Figure 68. PUA Toxicity over Time



users into PUA corresponds with the timing of late increases in PUA popularity and activity.

Toxicity. Figure 68. PUA Toxicity over Time

Figure 69Figure 70. PUA Toxicity over Time

Figure 71. MRA Subreddits over Time

Figure 72Figure 73. PUA Toxicity over Time

Figure 74Figure 75 presents PUA toxicity over time, for the toxicity metric only.³⁵ As a reminder, this score indicates the average probability that a reader would find a PUA post to be rude, disrespectful, or unreasonable; here, the scores presented reflect the mean toxicity score for all posts in a given year. Results show that PUA toxicity remains relatively stable over time, hovering between .15 and .2, and not increasing or decreasing substantially at any point, suggesting that the toxicity of this community is relatively unaffected by trends in user participation.

³⁵ Other attributes were examined, but showed negligible differences between communities when assessed over time.

Men's Rights Activists (MRA)

Community development. The MRA community emerges alongside PUA in 2008 and has a similarly modest start—a single subreddit from 2008 to 2009, with a second emerging in 2010. After this point, however, Figure 76. MRA Subreddits over Time

Figure 77. MRA Subreddits over Time

Figure 76. MRA Subreddits over Time

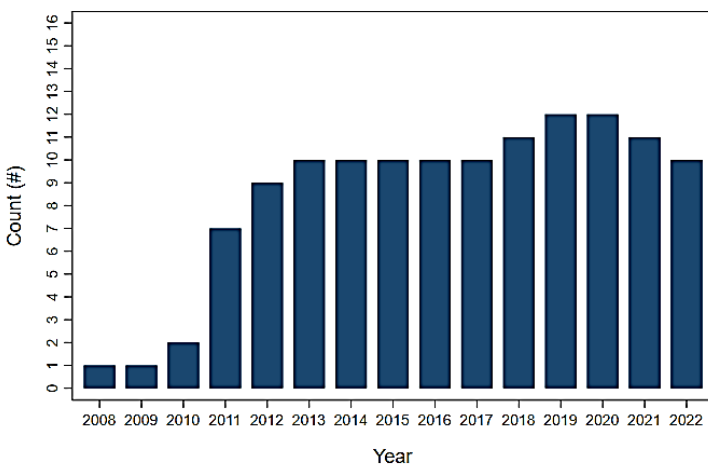


Figure 78. MRA Subreddits over Time

Figure 79 shows the number of associated subreddits increases somewhat dramatically, rising to seven subreddits in 2011, nine subreddits in 2012, and then leveling

off at 10 active subreddits in the 2013 to 2017 period. In 2019 this number increases again to 12 active subreddits, remaining here through 2020 before decreasing back down to 10 subreddits by 2022. In terms of activity and popularity, MRA starts strong relative to the PUA community despite originating in the same year. It begins with 684 active users and 11,158 posts

Figure 80. MRA Activity over Time

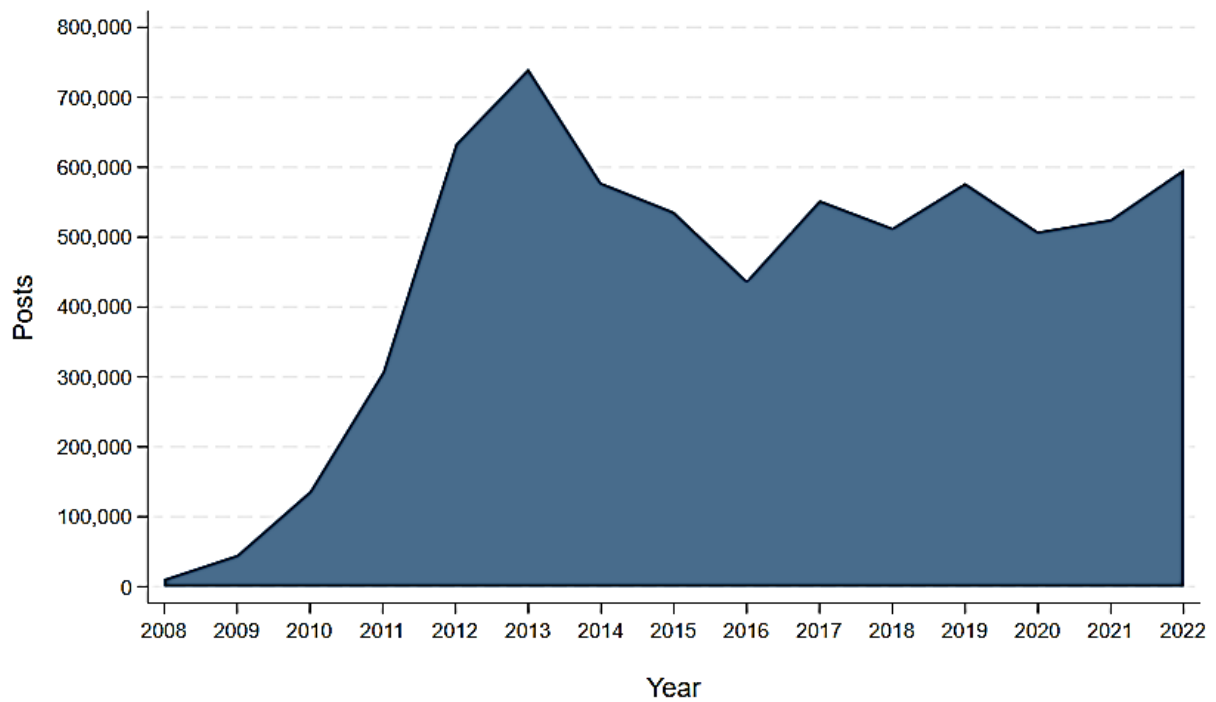
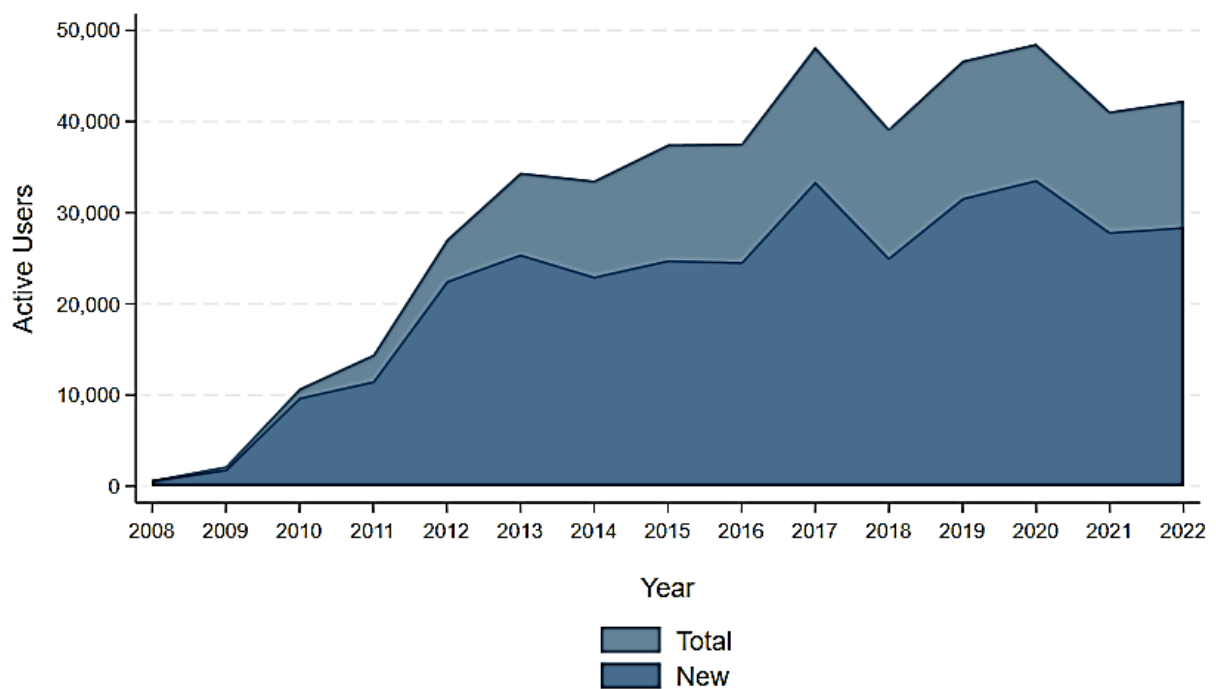


Figure 84. MRA Users over Time



made in MRA spaces (see **Error! Reference source not found.** and **Error! Reference source not found.**). This disparity is likely at least partly the result of MRA's relatively unique position within the manosphere; remember that, rather than emerging online, the men's rights movement existed offline for decades prior to its connections with other forms of organized male supremacism. Like PUA, the MRA community also sees sharp growth in its early years. Posting activity doubles every year from 2008 to 2013, and the rate of growth for the user base is not far behind; by 2013, more than 30,000 unique users are engaging in MRA subreddits, for a combined total of more than 700,000 posts. Also like with PUA, much of the year-to-year user base is comprised of users who are just entering the community.

From 2013 onward, MRA activity and popularity become less aligned; the number of users active in MRA spaces continues to grow slowly, reaching a new peak of just under 50,000 users in 2017, while posting activity declines to around 450,000 posts in 2016. Posting activity increases slightly again from here to nearly 550,000 and then remains more or less consistent through 2022, while the number of active users hovers between 40,000 and 50,000 in the last four years of the data.

Community overlap. Assessment of MRA's overlap with other communities, presented in Figure 92. MRA-PUA Overlap Over Time

Figure 93. MRA-PUA Overlap Over Time

Figure 94. MRA-PUA Overlap Over Time

Figure 95 through Figure 108. MRA-TRP Overlap Over Time

Figure 109. MRA-TRP Overlap Over Time

Figure 110. MRA-TRP Overlap Over Time

Figure 111, shows lower initial overlap with PUA than the inverse—potentially a consequence of MRA’s greater membership at the outset. In 2008, only 1% of MRA users are also posting in the PUA community, though that figure does grow slightly over time, reaching 10% by 2011. In 2010, the Incel community emerges and, similar to PUA, MRA-Incel overlap then sees slight growth as well. This figure reaches around 5% by 2012, declines slightly, and grows again to 8% in 2018 before once more tapering off. This pattern, which mirrors PUA in terms of overlap with the Incel community, seems to point to bursts of users joining Incel subreddits when the community first emerges, and then again when the community reaches a period of popularity after

Figure 92. MRA-PUA Overlap Over Time

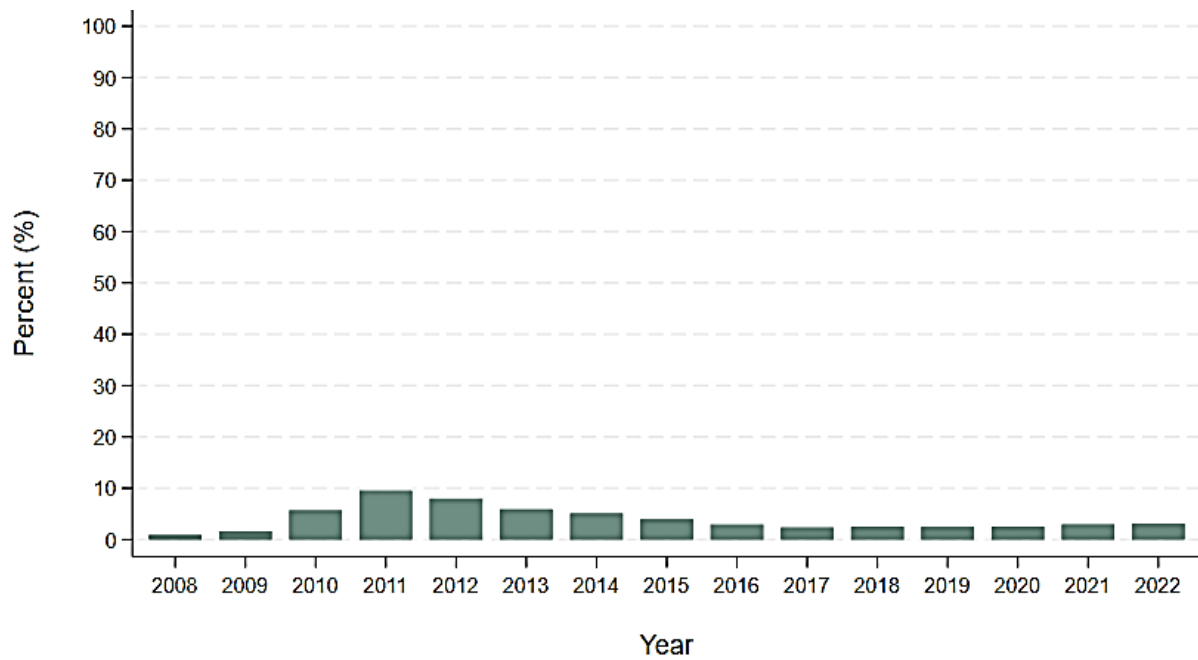


Figure 96. MRA-Incel Overlap Over Time

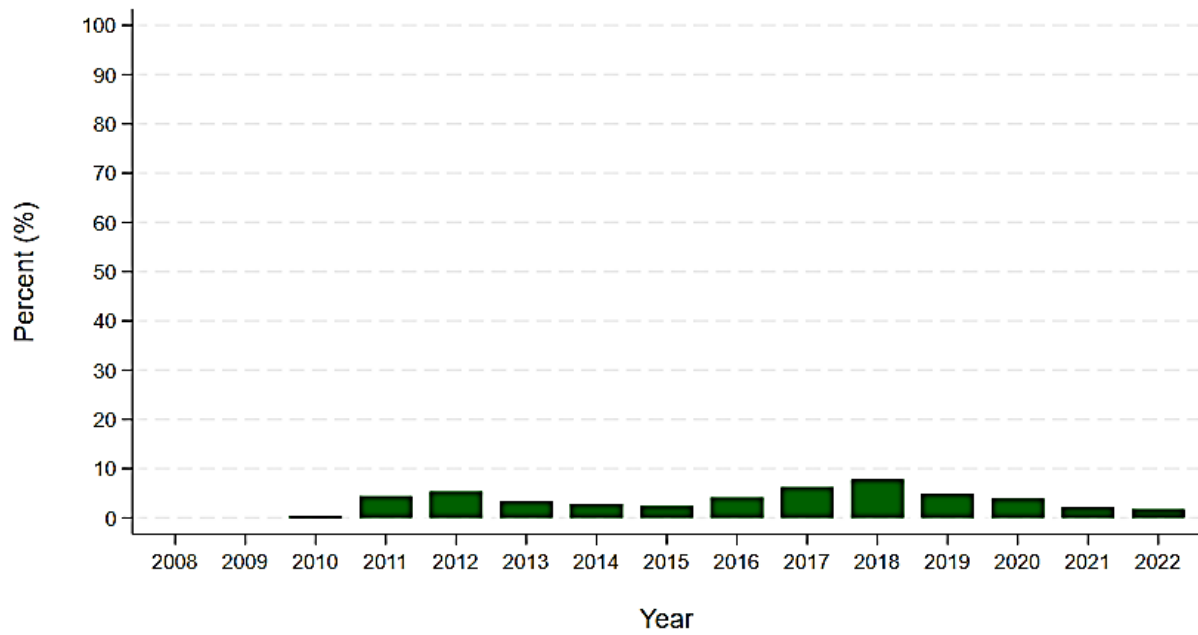


Figure 100. MRA-MGTOW Overlap Over Time

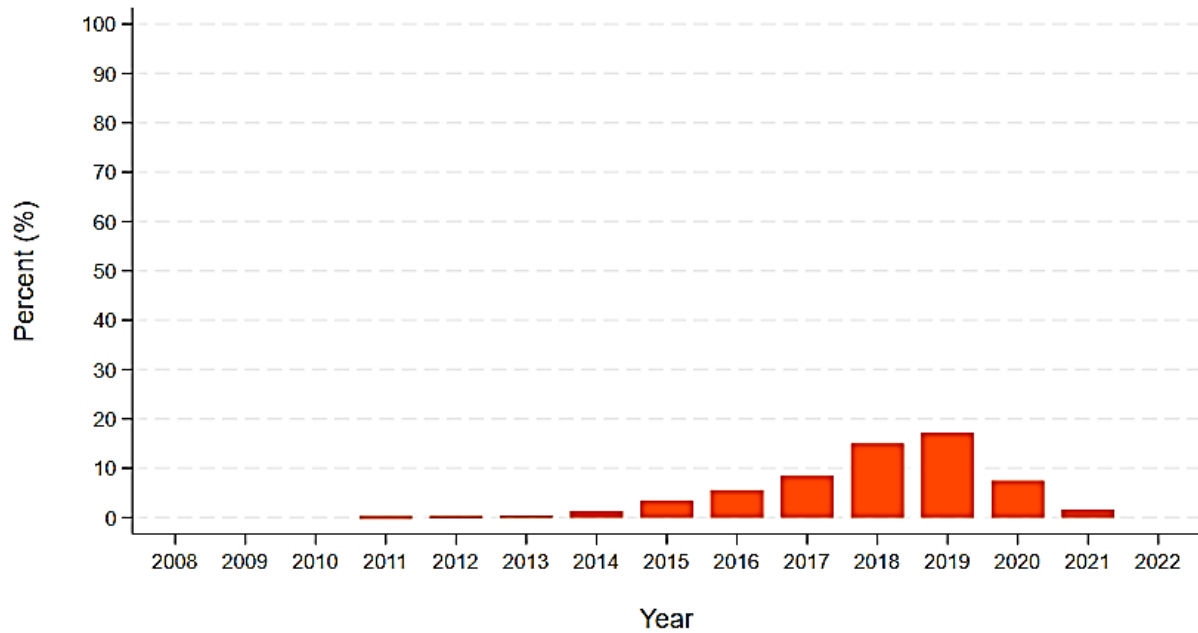
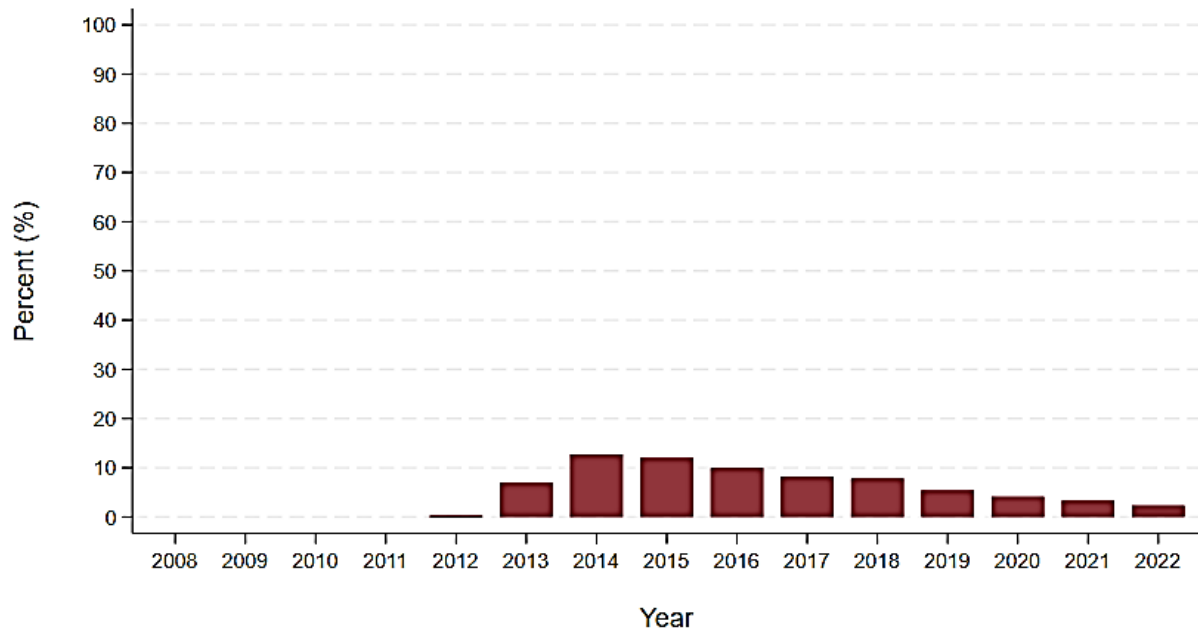


Figure 108. MRA-TRP Overlap Over Time



2015. These bursts in overlap are, however, still relatively small when compared to peaks in MRA overlap with the MGTOW and TRP communities. TRP first emerges in 2012, which corresponds with sharply increasing MRA-TRP overlap through 2014, where it reaches a high of 13%. MRA-MGTOW overlap sees slower growth, increasing consistently from 2011 to 2019, where it peaks at 17%. In the period immediately following, overlap more than halves each year, ending at only 1% overlap in 2021, the last year of the MGTOW community's existence on Reddit.

User migration. **Error! Reference source not found.** through **Error! Reference source not found.** present rates of migration into and out of the MRA community. Exchange with the PUA community is presented again despite previous discussion, as it useful to view trends for this community alongside the others; note that migration rates between PUA and MRA remains more consistent over time than migration between MRA and other communities. Also note that while PUA had relatively uneven rates of flow between communities, favoring migration with TRP and showing exceptionally low rates of migration into or out of the MGTOW community, MRA consistently reaches high rates of exchange with most communities, though the timing of these high migration periods differs.

Like with the PUA community, results also show that MRA migration trends vary over time; unlike with PUA, these trends also seem to map relatively neatly onto trends in user overlap between communities. MRA migration into the Incel community begins in 2011—the year after the Incel community first appears and, thus the first year in which MRA users are able to migrate to a community outside of PUA. Migrations in this direction remain relatively low for the first four years, staying at or below 250 MRA to Incel migrations through 2016. During this period, Incel to MRA migrations also occur, and at slightly higher rates; in 2012, MRA-Incel migration is

relatively equal in both directions, but in 2013 more users are migrating from the Incel community into MRA—around 375 in total. This rate remains relatively constant through 2016. The 2015-

Figure 112. MRA-PUA Migrations over Time

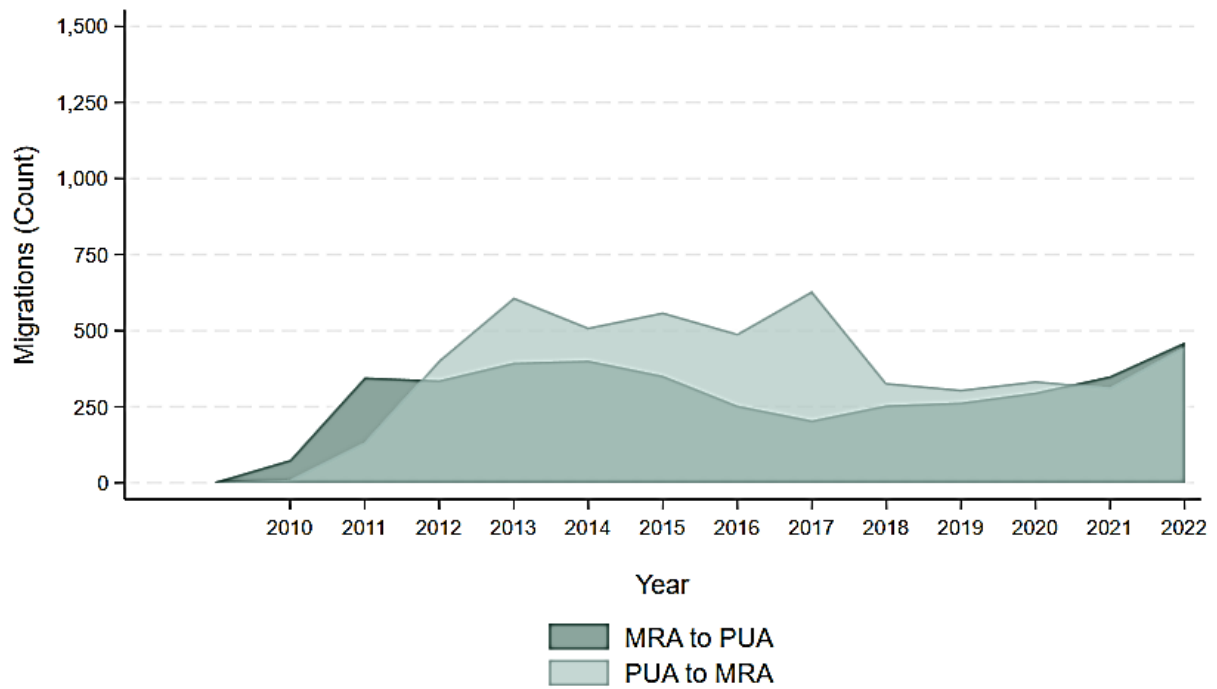


Figure 116. MRA-Incel Migrations over Time

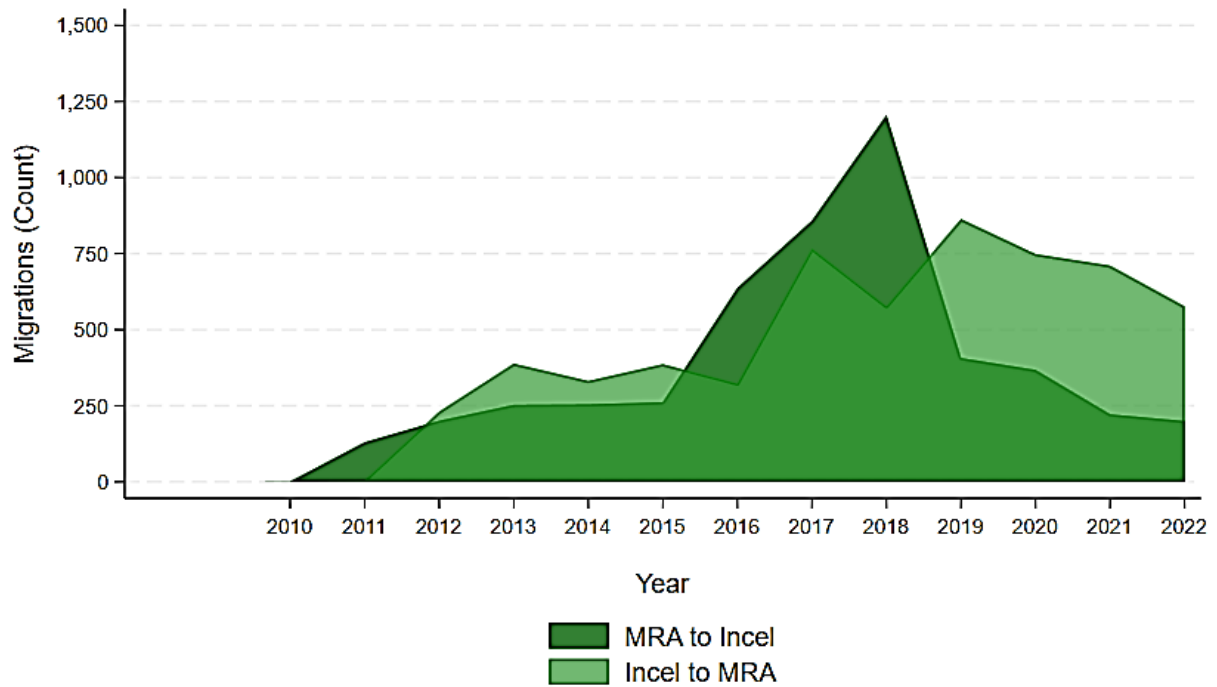


Figure 120. MRA-MGTOW Migrations over Time

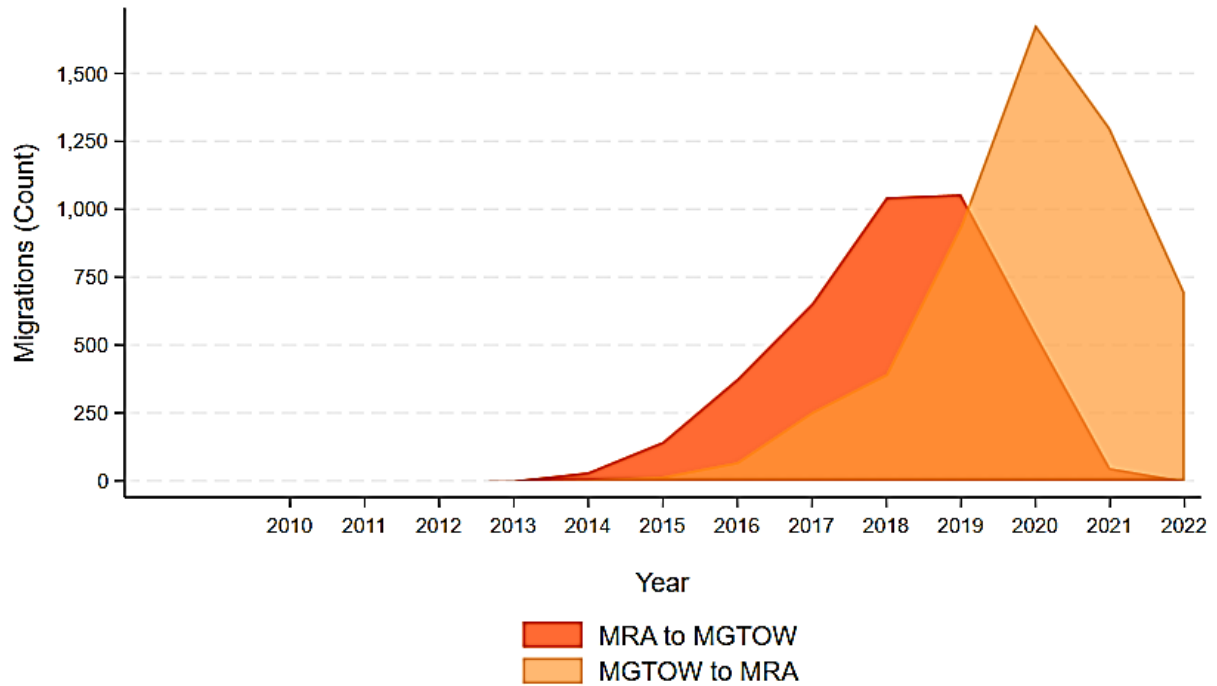
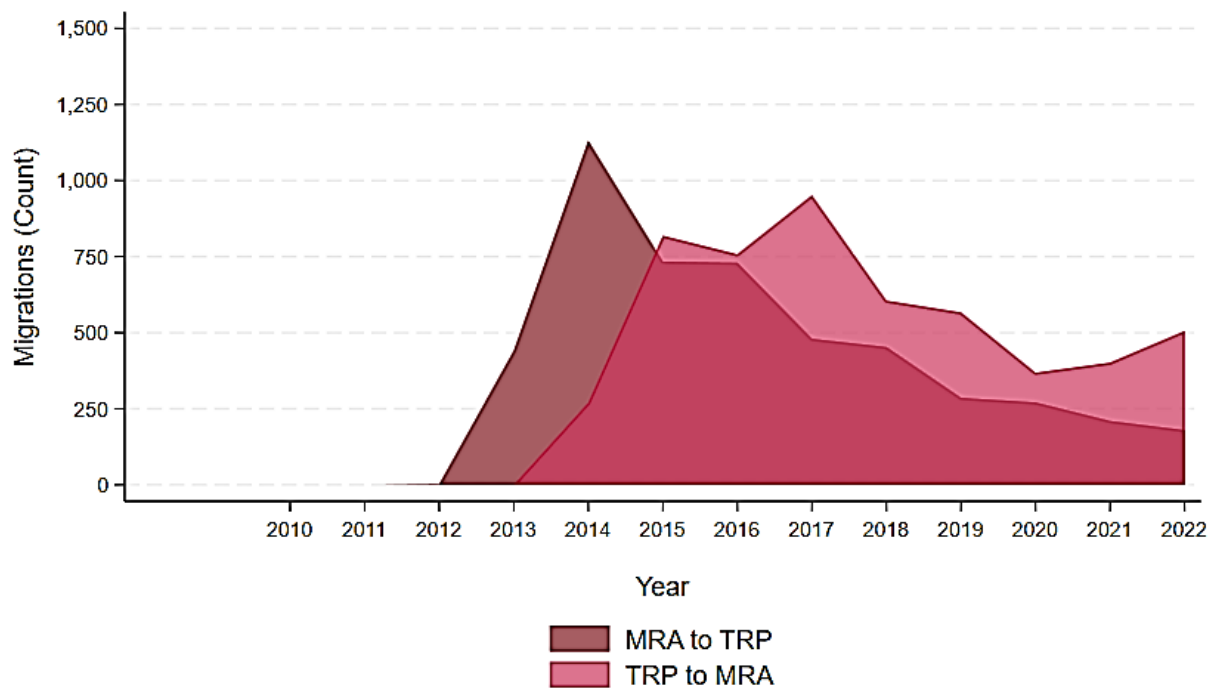


Figure 124. MRA-TRP Migrations over Time



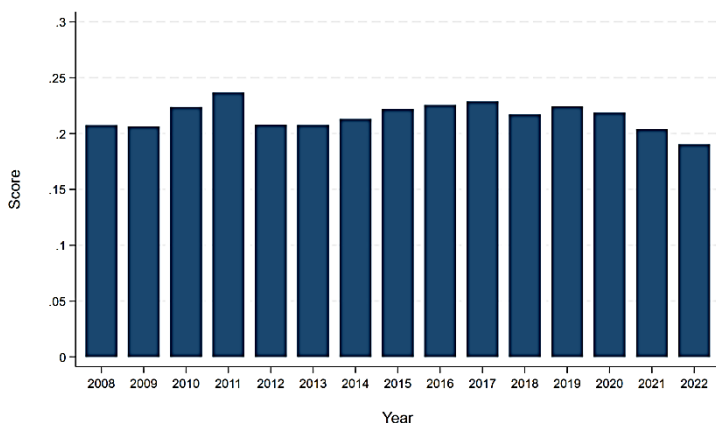
2016 period then marks the start of a shift in migration patterns—MRA migrations into the Incel community grow sharply between 2016 and 2018, reaching a high of around 1,200 before decreasing rapidly. This is potentially connected to the banning of several prominent Incel subreddits in 2017 and 2018. Incel to MRA migration also increases during this time, though not quite so substantially; it does, however, continue to grow through 2019, and remains comparatively high through 2022, ending with around 500 migrations from Incel to MRA.

In contrast, exchange between MRA and MGTOW starts later and grows more slowly, but also reaches more impressive rates. Prior to 2014 there is little migration between these communities, but MRA to MGTOW migration begins to grow after this period, increasing by roughly 250 migrations per year until 2018; 2018 and 2019 both then see more than 1,000 migrations from MRA into the MGTOW community, followed by a drastic decline. MGTOW to MRA migration rates follow a similar trend, though it is offset by two years, not seeing the first hints of steady growth until 2016. From 2016 until 2020, migration in this direction increases dramatically, even exceeding rates of migration from MRA to MGTOW—nearly 1,700 users migrate from MGTOW to MRA in 2020 alone. Once again, migration in this direction tapers off relatively sharply following this period of heightened exchange.

Finally, migration between MRA and TRP grows more quickly and reaches its peak earlier than other communities—a notable trend given that TRP is the last of the manosphere communities to emerge on Reddit. It is formed in 2012, and migration rates increase quickly, with more 1,100 MRA users migrating into TRP in 2014; rates decrease steadily after this point, indicating that MRA users were early to shift focus to participation in TRP. Similar to MGTOW, migration in the opposite direction lags slightly; the first migrations from MRA to TRP occur in 2013, with TRP to MRA migrations beginning to occur in 2014.

Exchange between MRA and TRP grows more quickly and spikes earlier than other communities; this is notable given that TRP is the last of the manosphere communities to emerge on Reddit. The community emerges in 2012, and in 2014 more than 1,100 MRA users migrate into TRP; rates decrease steadily after this point, indicating a sharp and early exodus of some MRA users. Like with MGTOW, migration in the opposing direction lags behind; the first migrations from TRP to MRA occur in 2014, and in 2015 and 2016 the exchange between MRA and TRP is relatively even, with only slightly more users migrating from TRP to MRA than the opposite. TRP to MRA migration continues to grow for another year, however, peaking in 2017 when nearly

Figure 133. MRA Toxicity over Time



1,000 users migrate to MRA from TRP. After this point, migration in this direction too decreases, though it remains higher than MRA to TRP migration rates.

Toxicity. MRA toxicity scores, presented in Figure 133. MRA Toxicity over Time

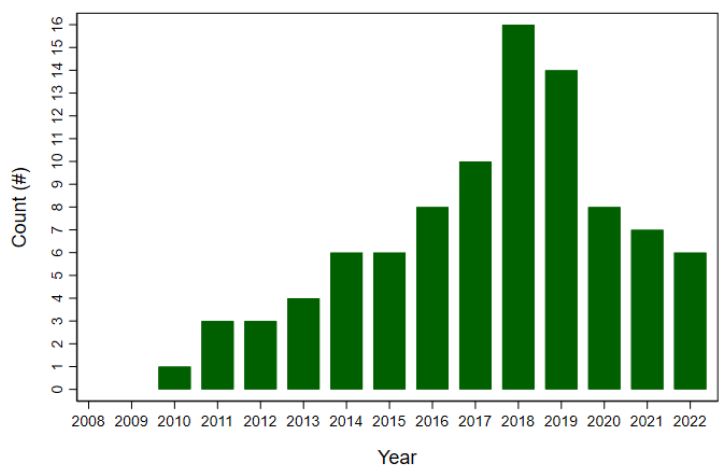
Figure 134Figure 135. MRA Toxicity over Time

Figure 136. Incel Subreddits over Time

Figure 137Figure 138Figure 139. MRA Toxicity over Time

Figure 140Figure 141, are slightly higher at the start compared to PUA, with a mean post toxicity of just over .20 in 2008. Like PUA, however, toxicity remains relatively consistent over time; there are small year-to-year fluctuations that reach a high of .23 in 2011, but overall scores

Figure 142. Incel Subreddits over Time



stay in the .20 to .23 range through 2021, and show no notable growth over time. Trends in scores also point to a slight overall decrease in toxicity in the later period of the data, with MRA toxicity decreasing slightly but steadily between 2019 and 2022—in this final year, scores reach an all-time low of

.19.

Misogynist Incels (Incels)

Community development. The first Incel subreddit emerges in 2010, two years after the first manosphere communities emerge on Reddit. Like PUA and MRA, it starts small before seeing growth; Figure 142. Incel Subreddits over Time

Figure 143Figure 144. Incel Subreddits over Time

Figure 145. Incel Activity over Time

Figure 146Figure 147Figure 148. Incel Subreddits over Time

Figure 149Figure 150 shows that the number of subreddits increases to three in 2011, with one to two new subreddits appearing every year through 2017. In 2018, the Incel community sees a sharp increase in growth when the number of active subreddits rises to 16—the highest number of subreddits to emerge in the data so far. It is important at this point to note that the data on active subreddits shows the number of subreddits active in a given year, but not necessarily the number of subreddits that are *simultaneously* active in any given period; remember that the original Incel subreddit, r/Incels, was banned by Reddit in November 2017, and that its initial replacement r/Braincels (created the month prior to the ban) was ultimately also banned in 2019 (Gillett and Suzor 2022). During this period, additional Incel subreddits were created as users attempted to subvert the initial ban or attenuate its impacts (Gillett and Suzor 2022); as such, it is possible, or even likely, that the high number of active Incel communities reflects attempts at community preservation rather than actual community growth or engagement.

A review of the duration of specific Incel subreddits, however, suggests that the high number of active subreddits from 2018 to 2019 is not primarily driven by the rapid creation and dissolution of additional Incel spaces. Only a handful of new subreddits, including r/maleforeveralone, r/blackpillscience, and r/gymcels, emerge within six months of the initial ban of r/Incels, and no new subreddits appear following the ban of r/Braincels. Further, of these new subreddits, only r/maleforeveralone was rendered defunct shortly after, with a lifespan of only five months. The other additional subreddits remained active for years following their creation. As such, the high number of active Incel subreddits appears reflective of a genuine proliferation of Incel participation on Reddit.

Unlike with subreddit growth, the Incel community sees rapid increases in activity and popularity compared to PUA and MRA; note the dramatically different scale of the axis in Figure

151. Incel Activity over Time

Figure 152Figure 153. Incel Activity over Time

Figure 154. Incel Users over Time

Figure 155Figure 156Figure 157. Incel Activity over Time

Figure 158Figure 159, which shows the annual number of posts extending into the millions at varying points, rather than the hundreds of thousands seen in previous communities. This growth begins from modest origins as well—only 188 active users and 507 posts in 2010 (Figure 160. Incel Users over Time

Figure 161Figure 162. Incel Users over Time

Figure 163. Incel-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 164Figure 165. Incel Users over Time

Figure 166Figure 167), which by 2012 has risen to more than 20,000 unique users and more than 200,000 posts.

Figure 151. Incel Activity over Time

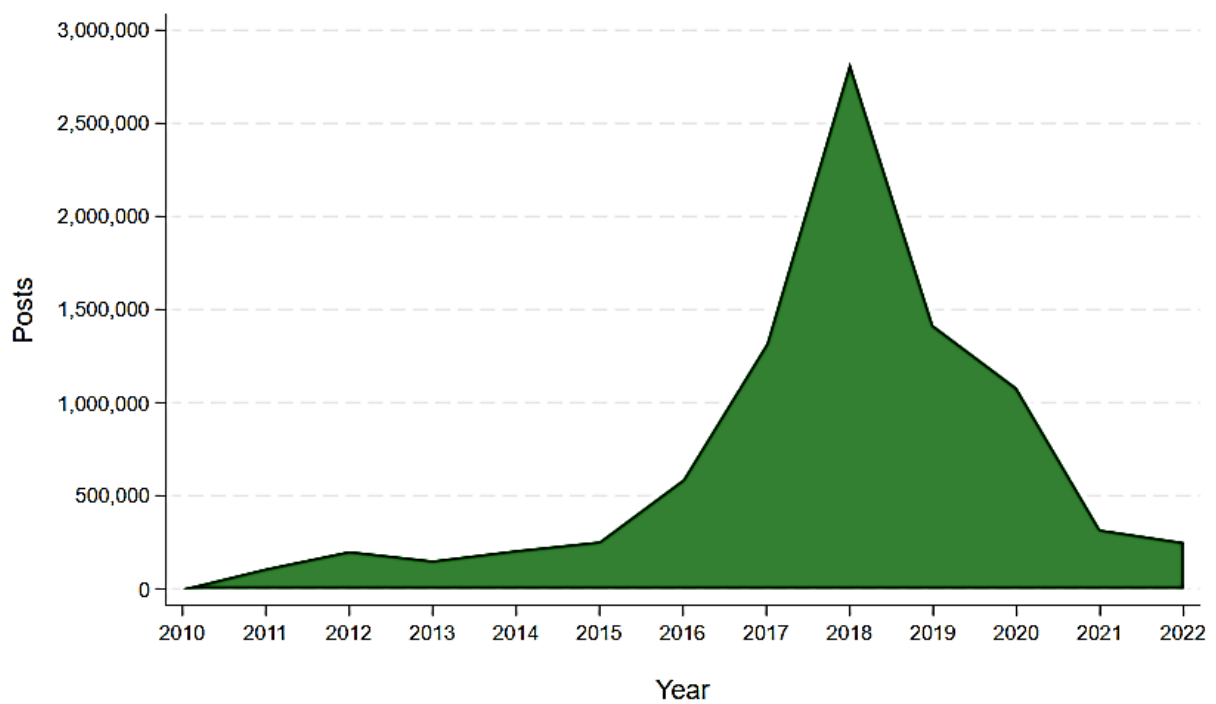
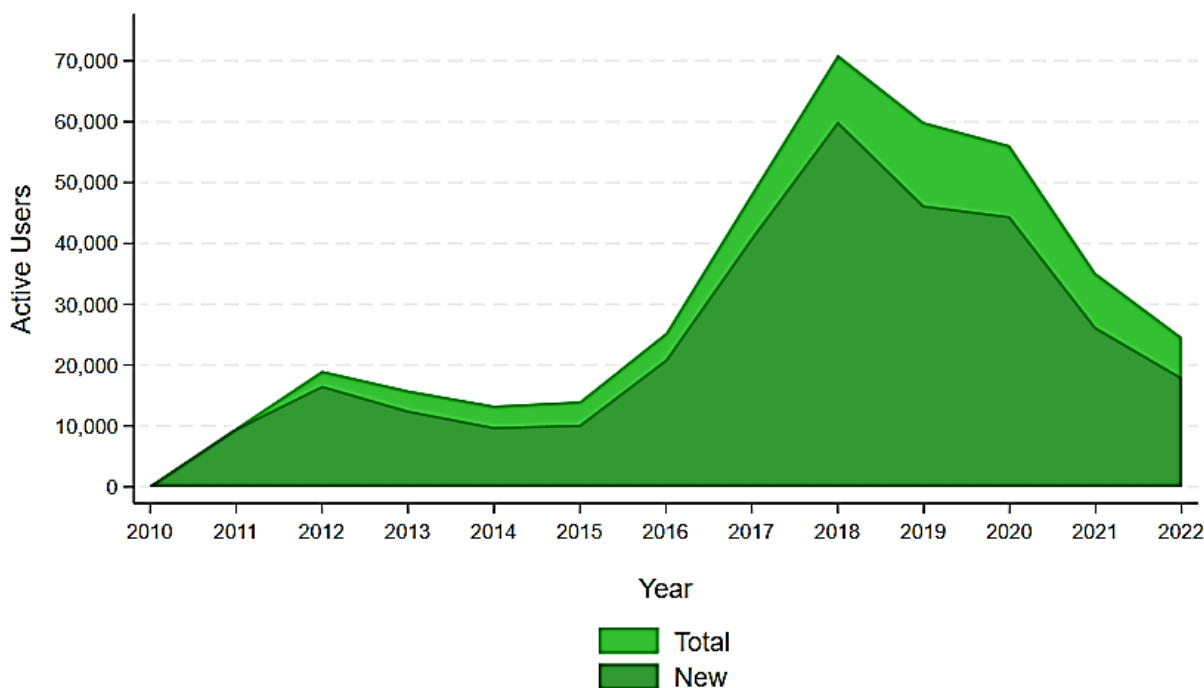


Figure 160. Incel Users over Time



Community activity and popularity dwindle slightly in the subsequent three years, but this period of abeyance is followed by increasing popularity and a rapid proliferation of activity—both metrics nearly double from 2015 to 2016, with the user base increasing from 14,056 users to 25,929 users (again bolstered primarily by swathes of new users entering the community rather than enduring users accumulating over time) and posting activity jumping from 255,223 posts in 2015 to 587,555 posts in 2016. Incel activity continues to double every year for the next two years, until the community ultimately reaches 2.8 million posts made in 2018; popularity lags slightly behind in terms of the rate of growth, but still increases substantially, reaching just over 70,000 users in this same year.

By 2018, then, the Incel community has surpassed PUA and MRA in terms of both popularity and activity, and by a wide margin—at its peak, the Incel community boasts 20,000 more users than MRA at its most popular point and sees rates of posting activity that are three to

four times higher than the other communities discussed so far. After this point, however, there are pronounced shifts in participation. The user base begins to decrease, down to roughly 60,000 users in 2019 and 55,000 users in 2020, at which point popularity declines more dramatically; the user base is reduced by nearly a third in 2021 and 2022, until only around 26,000 users remain active in Incel spaces.

Community overlap. Incel overlap with other communities, presented in Figure 168. Incel-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 169. Incel-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 170. Incel-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 171 through Figure 185. Incel-TRP Overlap over Time

Figure 186Figure 187. Incel-TRP Overlap over Time

Figure 188. Incel-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 189Figure 190. Incel-TRP Overlap over Time

Figure 191Figure 192, is somewhat smaller than that seen among the MRA and PUA communities. It shares the highest percentage of its userbase with MRA in 2010, when

approximately 13% of Incel users are also active in MRA spaces. During this time, around 10% of users are also posting in PUA spaces, likely reflecting PUA and MRA's foundational position in the Reddit manosphere. Overlap with these communities decreases slowly, albeit somewhat unevenly, from this point forward, while Incel participation in other spaces increases as new communities emerge, though trends in overlap with these later-emerging communities are also asymmetrical; the MGTOW community emerges in 2011 and grows slowly over time, reaching a high of 9% in 2019. Incel-TRP overlap, in contrast, grows relatively quickly after TRP's emergence in 2012, reaching near-parity with MRA and PUA overlap (around 7%) by 2014 and then slowly beginning to decrease after 2017.

User migration. Migration trends for the Incel community are presented in Figure 193.

Incel-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 194. Incel-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 195. Incel-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 196 through Figure 210. Incel-TRP Migrations over Time

Figure 211Figure 212. Incel-TRP Migrations over Time

Figure 213. Incel Toxicity over Time

Figure 214Figure 215Figure 216. Incel-TRP Migrations over Time

Figure 217Figure 218. Again, migration between Incel spaces and the PUA or MRA communities are included for ease of comparison, but are not discussed in-depth for a second time. It is, however, worth noting the existent differences and similarities across communities; both MRA and TRP see a similarly-timed rise in migrations out of their communities and into Incel spaces between 2015 and 2018, with migrations in this direction exceeding migrations *out* of Incel spaces. Migration between Incel and MGTOW spaces, in contrast, shows the opposite pattern, with more users

Figure 168. Incel-PUA Overlap over Time

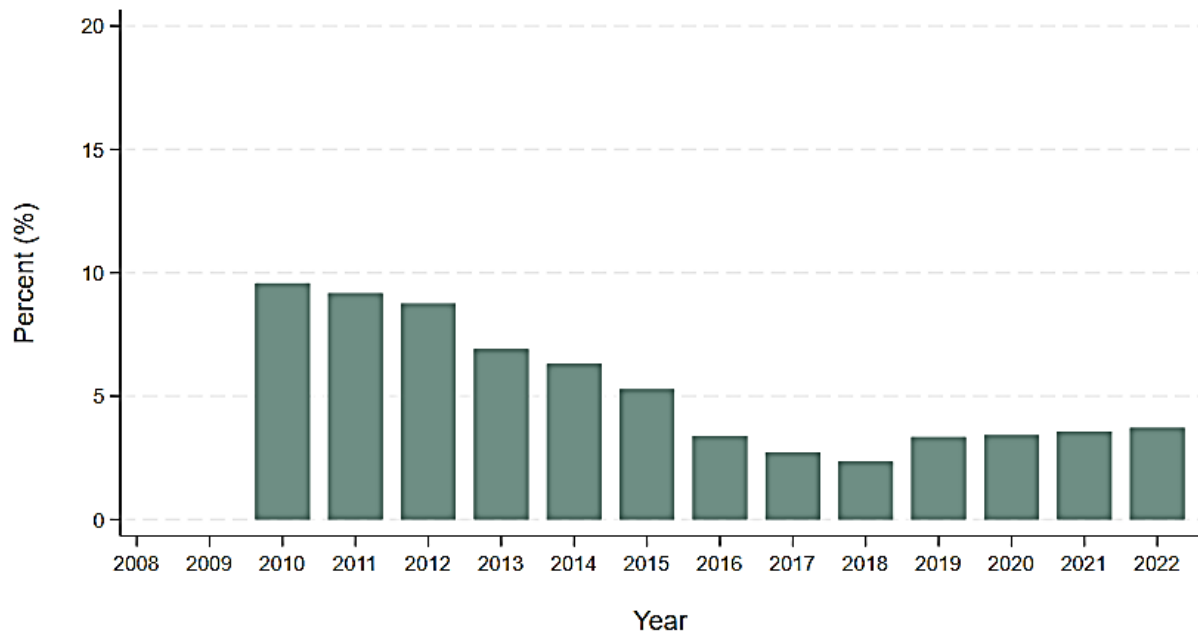


Figure 172. Incel-MRA Overlap over Time

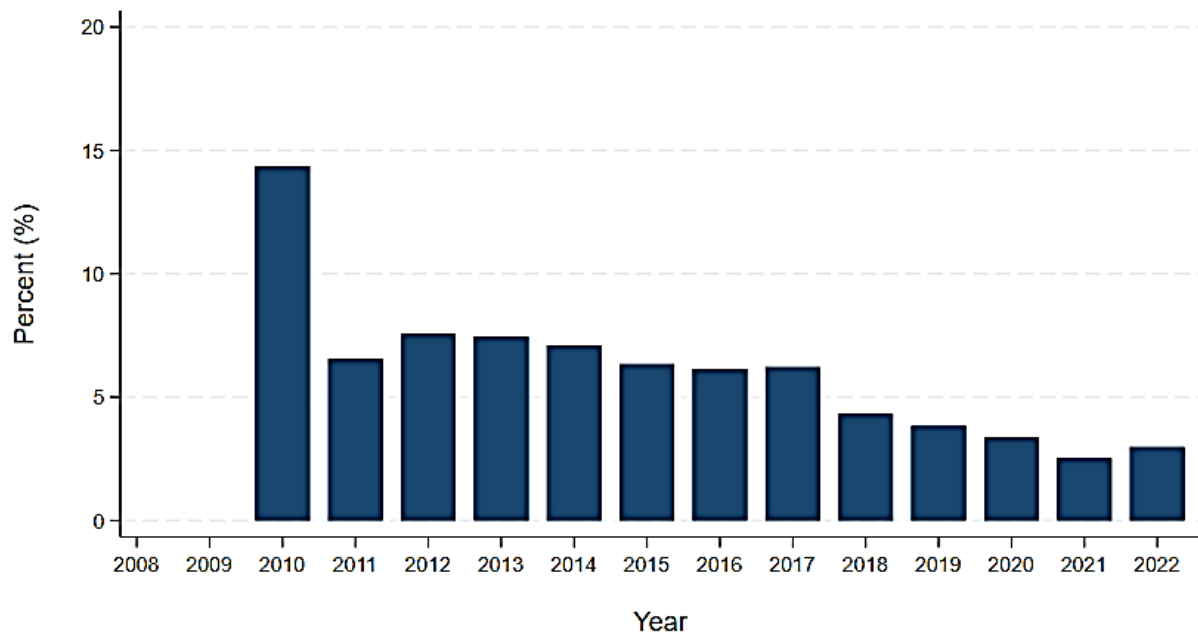


Figure 176. Incel-MGTOW Overlap over Time

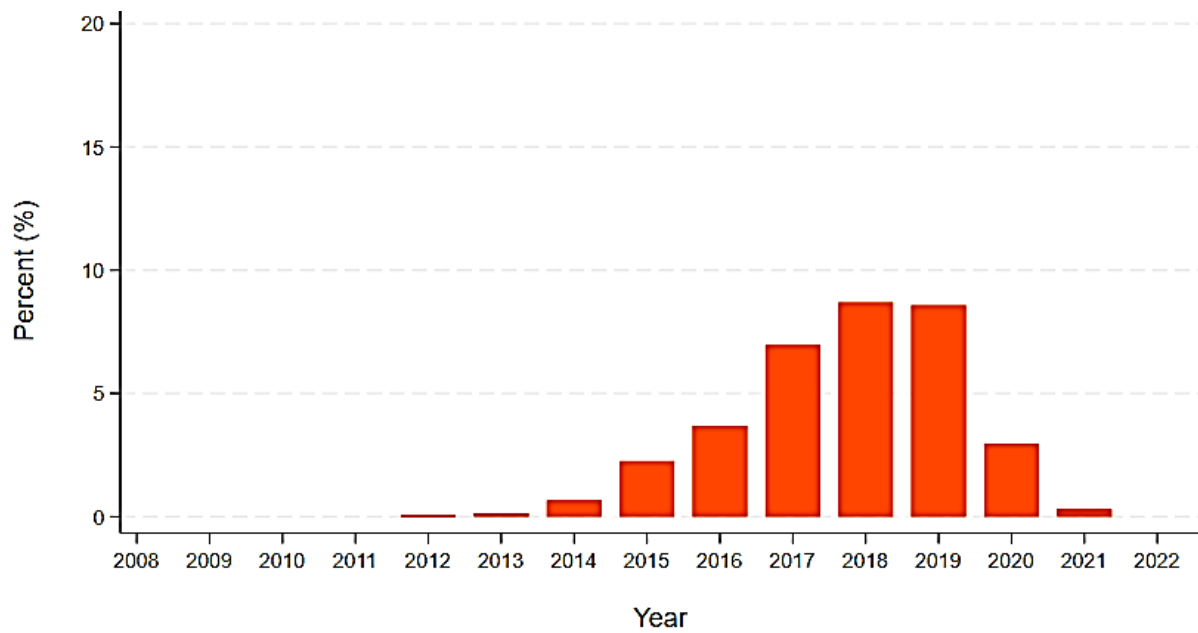


Figure 185. Incel-TRP Overlap over Time

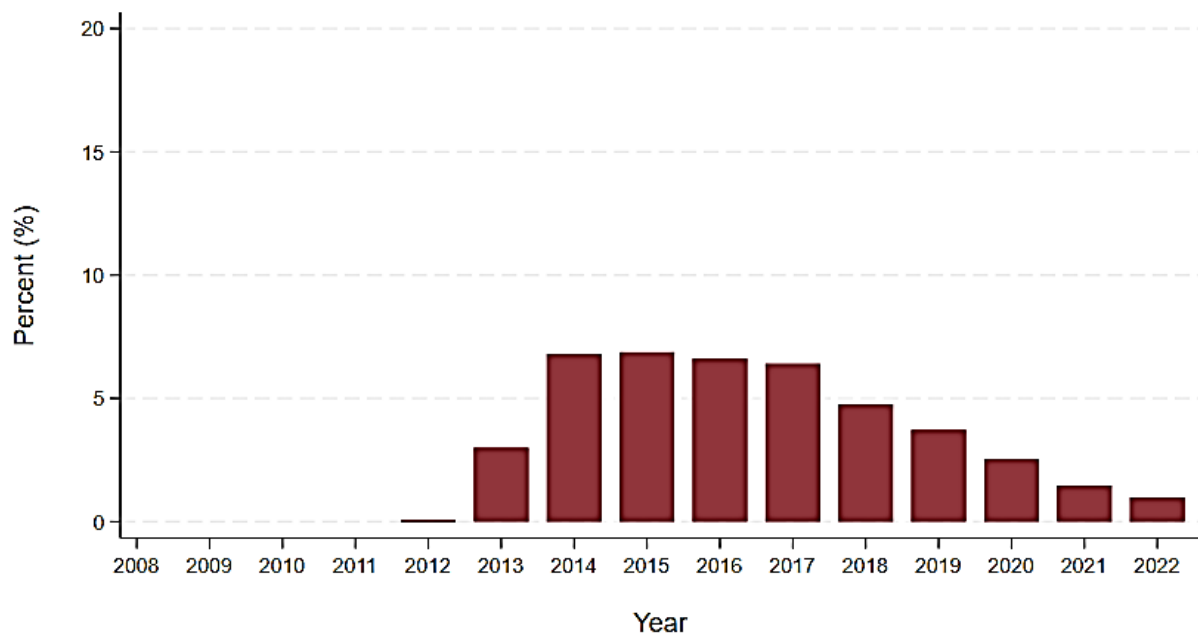


Figure 193. Incel-PUA Migrations over Time

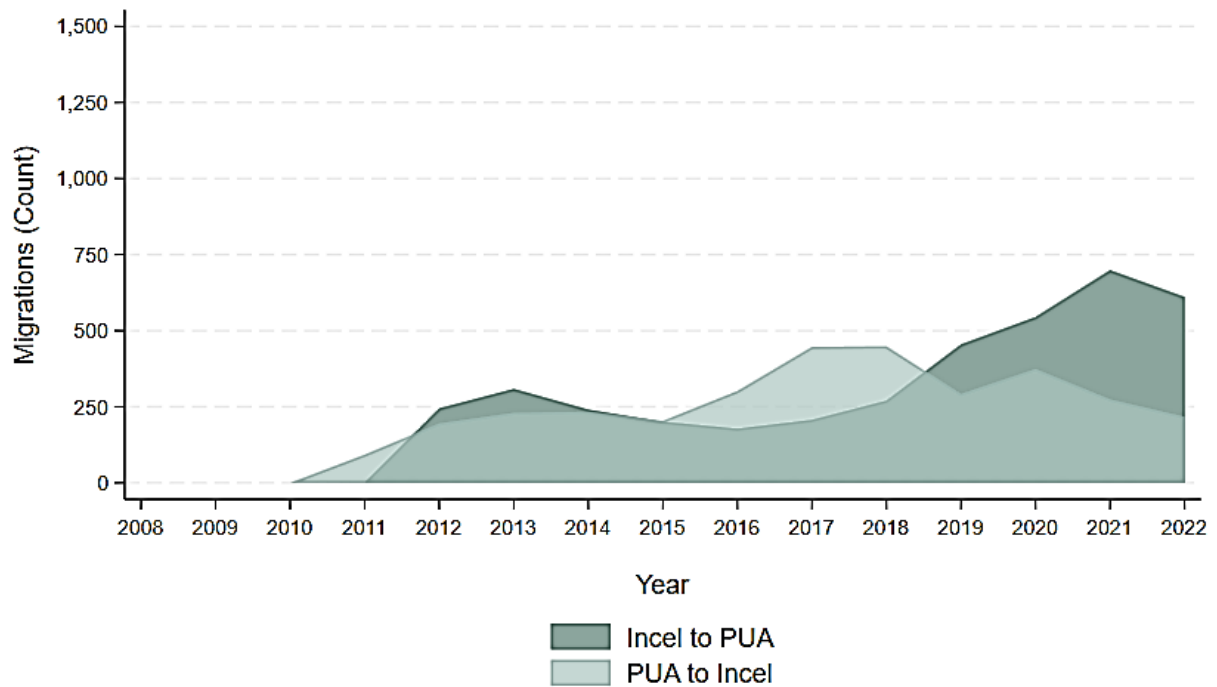


Figure 197. Incel-MRA Migrations over Time

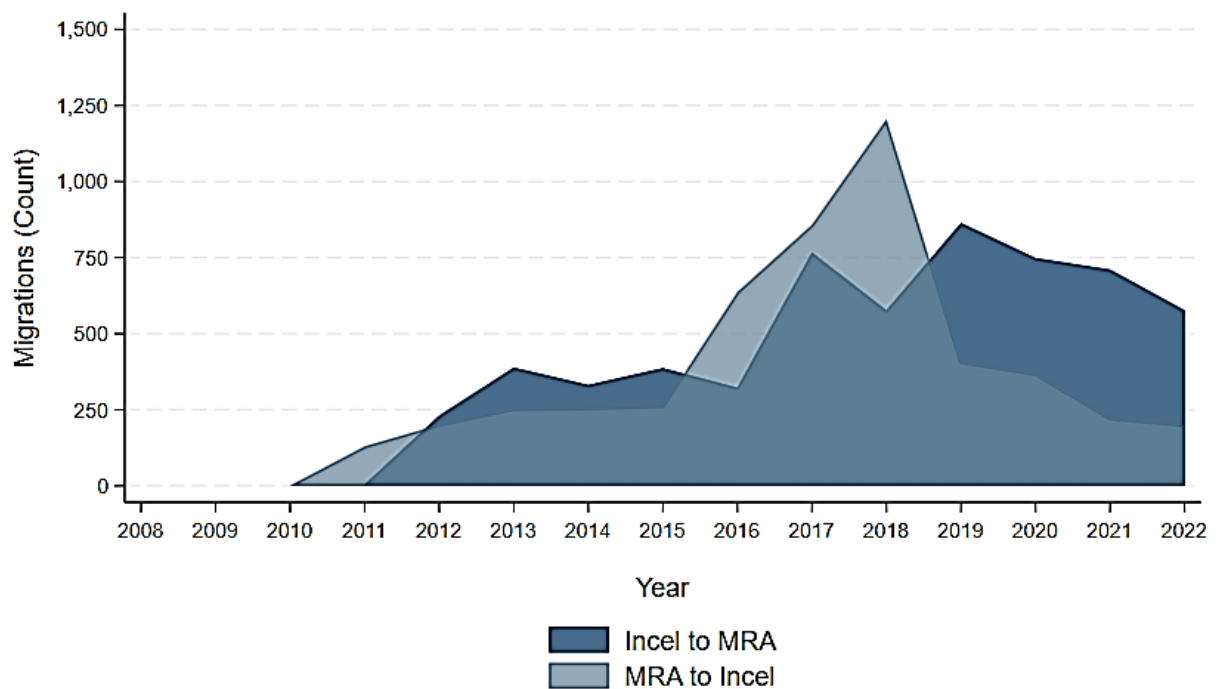


Figure 201. Incel-MGTOW Migrations over Time

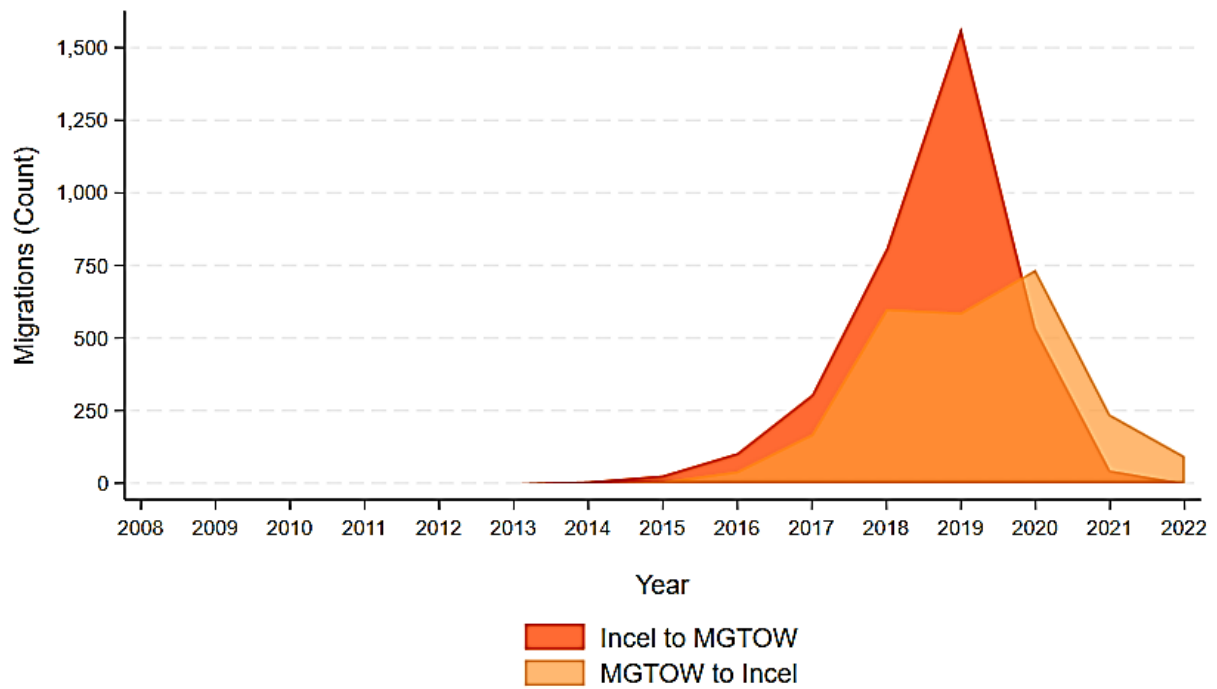
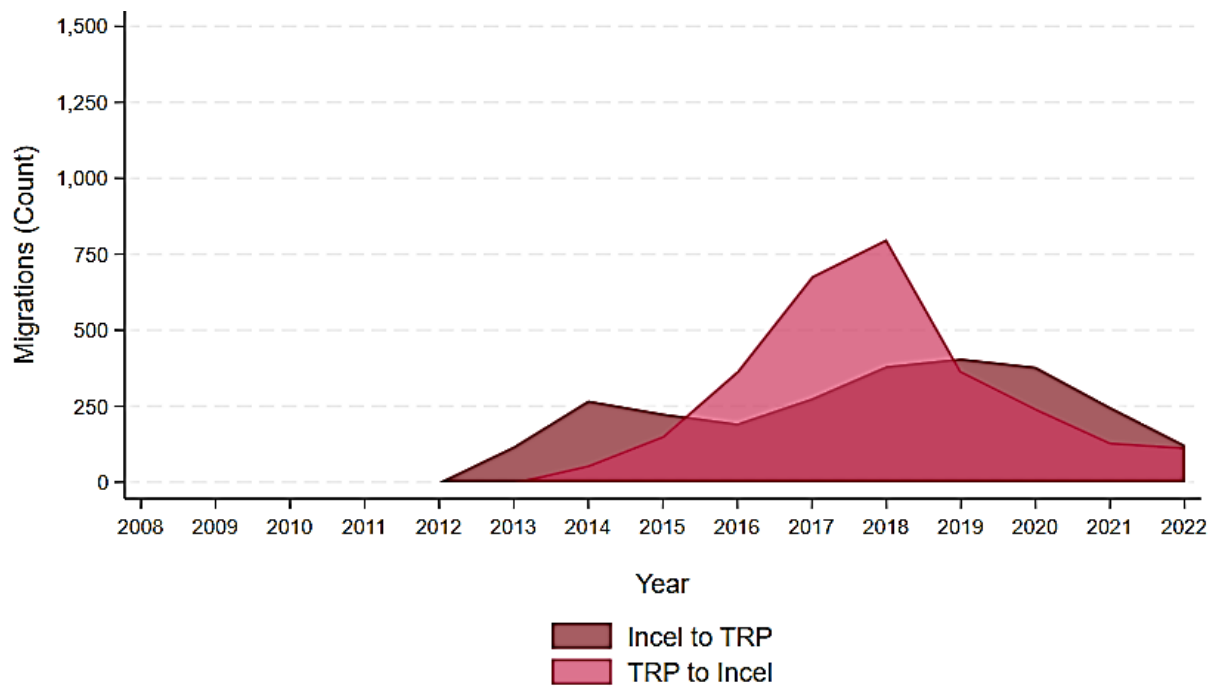


Figure 210. Incel-TRP Migrations over Time



migrating from Incel to MGTOW than vice-versa. Exchange between the PUA and Incel communities also appears somewhat unique here, in that rates of migration in either direction are relatively comparable overall, with migration in certain directions appearing more common during certain time periods—PUA to Incel migration occurs at higher rates from 2016 to 2018, after which point Incel to PUA migration is more prominent. This aligns with the overall trend towards increasing PUA participation from 2018 onwards.

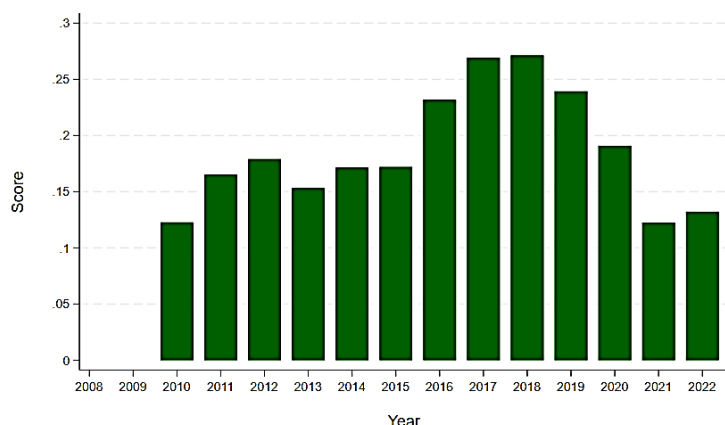
Trends in migration between Incel spaces and the MGTOW and TRP communities are also interesting in terms of timing. MGTOW originates earlier than TRP, yet Incel migration into the MGTOW community does not see much growth prior to 2015. After this period, however, it spikes dramatically—in 2019 alone, more than 1,500 Incel users migrate into the MGTOW community. Migration in this direction then decreases as rapidly as it grew. MGTOW to Incel migration follows a similar, though delayed, pattern of growth, seeing increases starting in 2016 that then peak in 2020. Yet, MGTOW to Incel migration still only reaches around half the rate of Incel to MGTOW migration, peaking at just under 750 migrations before ultimately declining. In contrast to this delayed growth in migrations seen with the MGTOW community, Incel migration into TRP remains relatively low across time; there is a small peak of 250 Incel to TRP migrations in 2014, and then another slight increase between 2016 and 2019 that ultimately reaches a new high of 400 migrations. TRP migrations into the Incel community, in contrast, see steady growth over time, reaching a high of 750 in 2018 before reducing sharply; note that this corresponds with the timing of the overall peak in Incel activity.

Also notable here is that migration patterns do not neatly follow patterns in overlap; PUA-Incel overlap decreases fairly steadily over time, despite the late growth of migrations from PUA to Incel; Incel-MRA overlap follows a similar trend of decreasing over time, despite growth in

migrations between communities. This is likely in part a consequence of the high number of users in the Incel community—migration may grow, but counts of the numbers of users migrating are still relatively small and, as such, still reflect only a small percentage of the Incel userbase that is captured when measuring community overlap.

Toxicity. Given the overall trends in community toxicity, it is somewhat surprising to see that the Incel community emerges with an average toxicity lower than MRA or PUA—Figure 219.

Figure 219. Incel Toxicity over Time



Incel Toxicity over Time

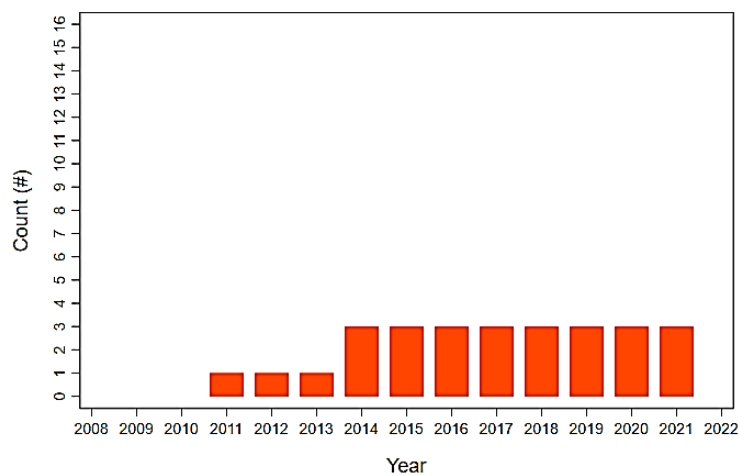
Figure 220Figure 221. Incel Toxicity over Time

Figure 222. MGTOW Subreddits over Time

Figure 223Figure 224Figure 225. Incel Toxicity over Time

Figure 226Figure 227 shows that it begins around .12, and from 2013 to 2015 hovers between .15 and .18. Starting in 2016, however, there is a notable increase in overall toxicity—in this year, MRA and PUA have an average toxicity of .23 and .17, respectively, while the Incel community reaches an average of .24. Toxicity in the Incel community grows from here, reaching .27 in 2018—the year that also corresponds with the peak of Incel popularity and activity. From here, toxicity decreases, potentially capturing both the decrease in popularity and activity, and the Reddit-implemented changes that banned Incel subreddits containing the most pronounced hate speech.

Figure 228. MGTOW Subreddits over Time



Community development.

MGTOW is the fourth community to emerge, entering the scene in 2011 with a single subreddit. Unlike previous communities, it sees little growth after this time. **Error! Reference source not found.**

highlights that an additional two

MGTOW subreddits become active in 2014, and remain the only MGTOW spaces through August 2021, when all three MGTOW subreddits were ultimately banned by Reddit administrators.³⁶

The relatively small number of MGTOW subreddits in later years belies the true presence of this community on Reddit. Initial growth is slow—MGTOW begins in 2011 with a single post by a single user—but activity and popularity increase slowly and steadily until 2015 (see Figure 246. MGTOW Activity over Time

Figure 247Figure 248. MGTOW Activity over Time

³⁶ In the wake of the MGTOW ban, a number of attempts at replacement subreddits emerged, starting with r/MGTOW2 and proceeding through r/MGTOW23. Data on these subreddits is not included in the analysis; while some participation likely occurred, evidence—including the existence of the 23 now-banned replacement attempts—suggests these attempts at subverting the ban were ultimately short-lived and unsuccessful.

Figure 249. MGTOW-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 250Figure 251. MGTOW Activity over Time

Figure 252Figure 253 and Figure 237. MGTOW Users over Time

Figure 238Figure 239. MGTOW Users over Time

Figure 240. MGTOW Activity over Time

Figure 241Figure 242Figure 243. MGTOW Users over Time

Figure 244Figure 245). Note again that most growth in the user base is driven by increasingly high numbers of new users year after year, rather than a steady accumulation of participants over time. After this point, growth becomes more rapid, particularly in terms of activity; 2017 shows more than 800,000 posts across the three MGTOW subreddits—two to three times that seen in the MRA and PUA communities during this period—which are seemingly driven by a comparatively small but dedicated user base. Note that during this time there are still only around 25,000 unique users active on these subreddits—approximately the same number of users as PUA, and around half the number of active users in MRA, despite the comparatively higher levels of posting activity. By 2018, these figures have nearly doubled, with MGTOW surpassing MRA in terms of both

Figure 246. MGTOW Activity over Time

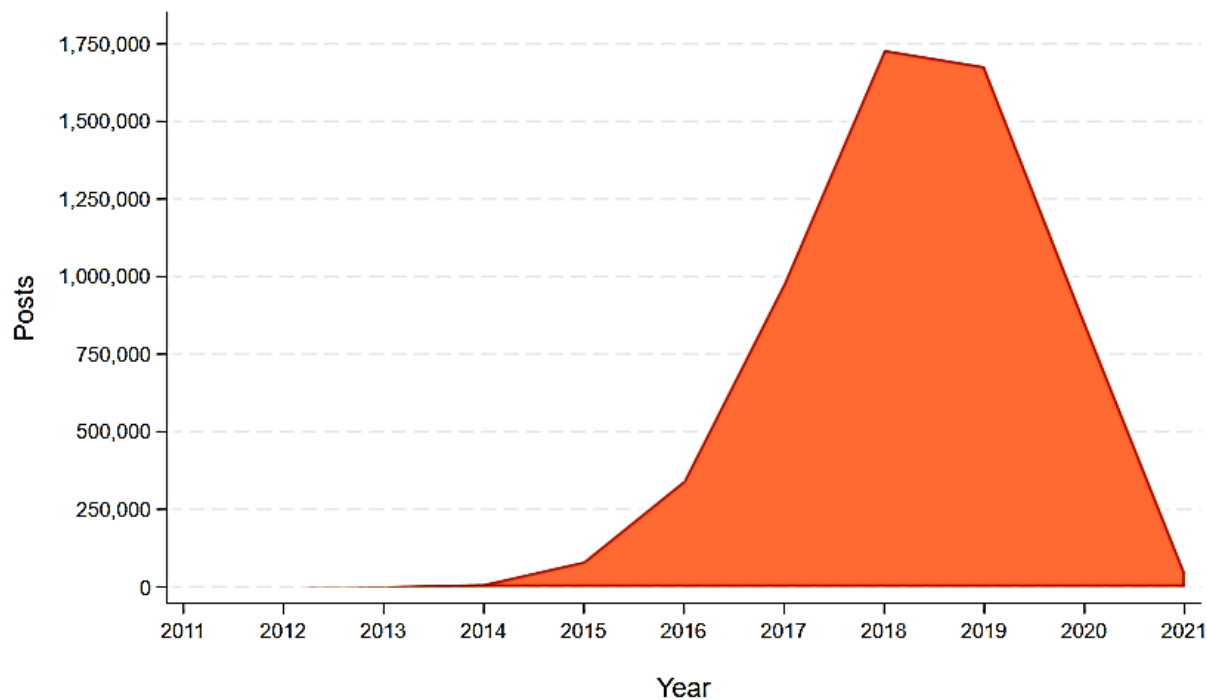
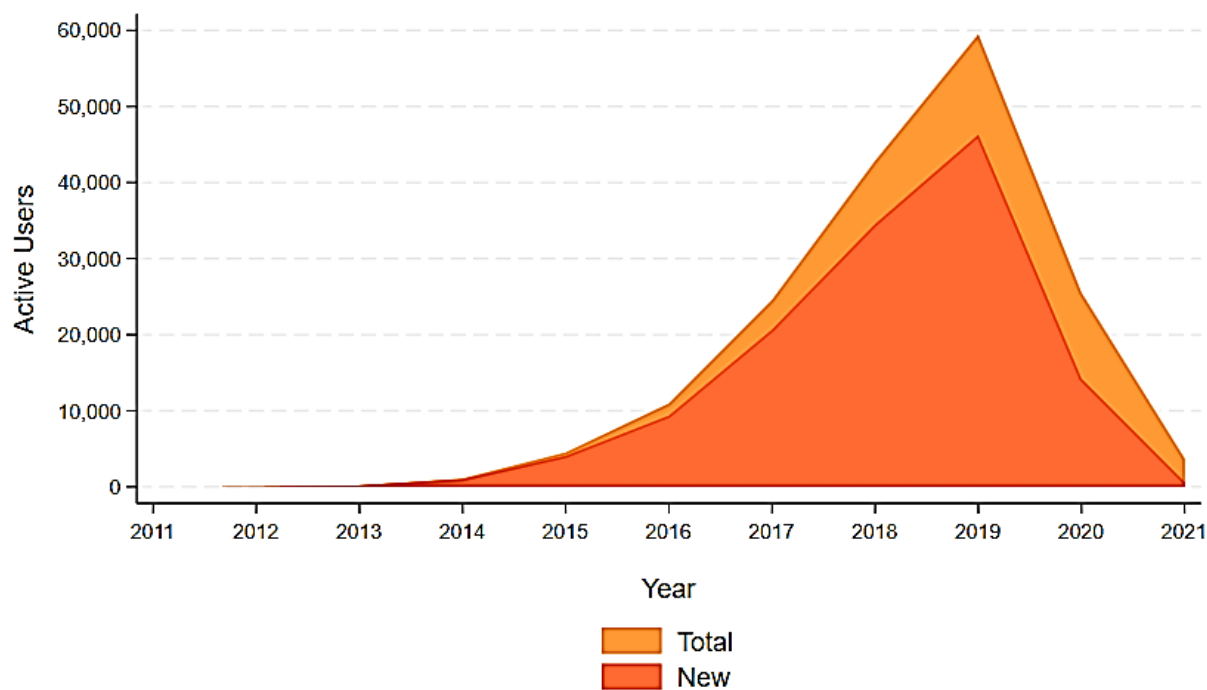


Figure 237. MGTOW Users over Time



popularity and activity; MGTOW users made more than 1.7 million posts in this year alone. MGTOW continues to appear as a dominant site of participation through 2020, at which point the user base is near-halved, declining from 59,573 active users in 2019 to only 25,486 active users in 2020. From here, activity and popularity both continue to decrease sharply; MGTOW participation drops by only 46,668 posts and 3,711 users in 2021, and then ceases entirely in 2022, in part capturing the ultimate banning of all three MGTOW subreddits that occurred in August 2021. However, given the notably sharp reduction in MGTOW activity, and the fact that the community was not banned until more than halfway through the year, it seems unlikely that the 2021 reduction in participation was solely the result of the MGTOW ban. This seems especially true given that the Incel community saw a similarly dramatic decrease in participation during this time period.

Community overlap. Figure 254. MGTOW-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 255. MGTOW-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 256. MGTOW-PUA Overlap over Time

Figure 257 through Figure 271. MGTOW-TRP Overlap over Time

Figure 272Figure 273. MGTOW-TRP Overlap over Time

Figure 274. MGTOW-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 275Figure 276. MGTOW-TRP Overlap over Time

Figure 277Figure 278 show that, at its inception, the MGTOW community shows uniquely high overlap with other parts of the manosphere. Overlap with the MRA community in particular is notable—in 2011 and 2012, its first and second years of existence, 100% and 92% of users, respectively, also posted in MRA spaces. 2012 also shows 20% and 24% overlap with the Incel and PUA communities.

When considering these figures, it is important to recall the notably small number of users active in the MGTOW community in the first two years—a single user in 2011 and 40 users in 2012. MGTOW-MRA overlap also decreases consistently over time, save for a small increase from 2020 to 2021, and MGTOW-PUA overlap similarly decreases steadily over time. Altogether, this suggests that the MGTOW community may have initially originated *from* MRA spaces, and that it was bolstered early on by a small number of members from other existing communities. This is further supported by the relatively small degree of reciprocal overlap between the MGTOW and

Figure 254. MGTOW-PUA Overlap over Time

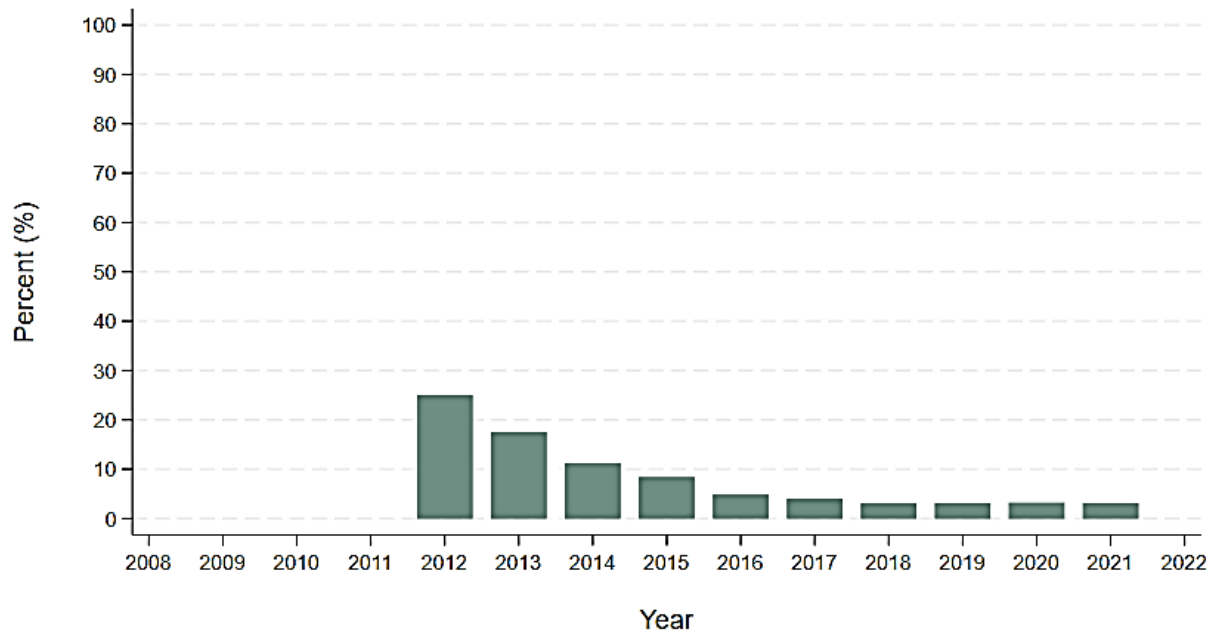


Figure 258. MGTOW-MRA Overlap over Time

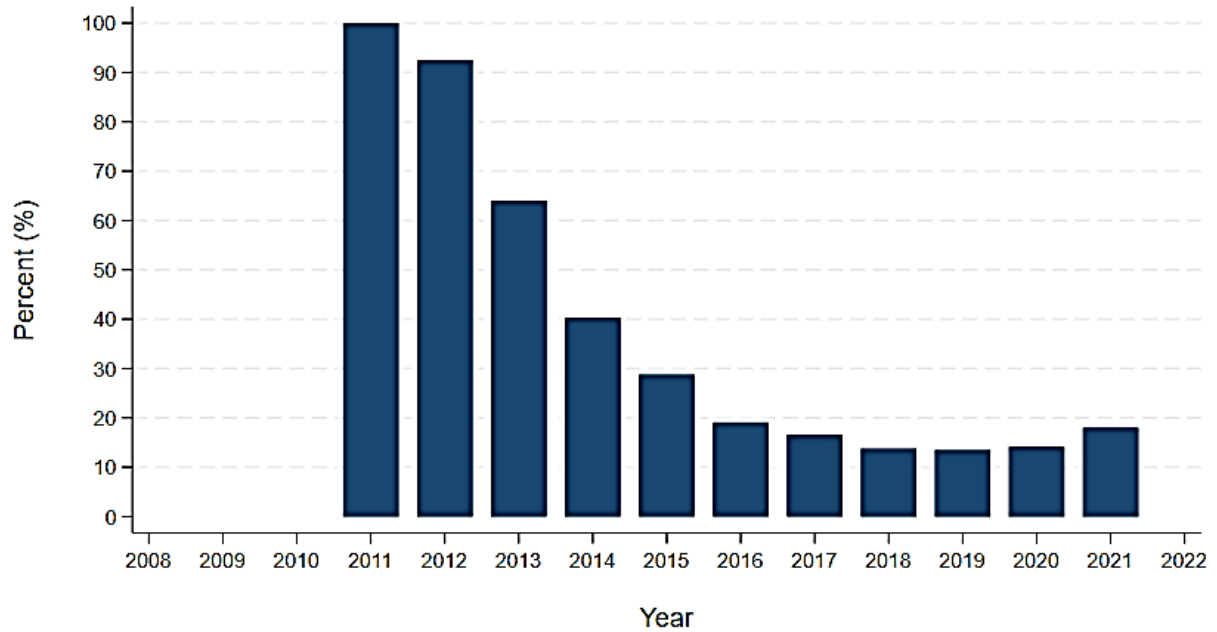


Figure 262. MGTOW-Incel Overlap over Time

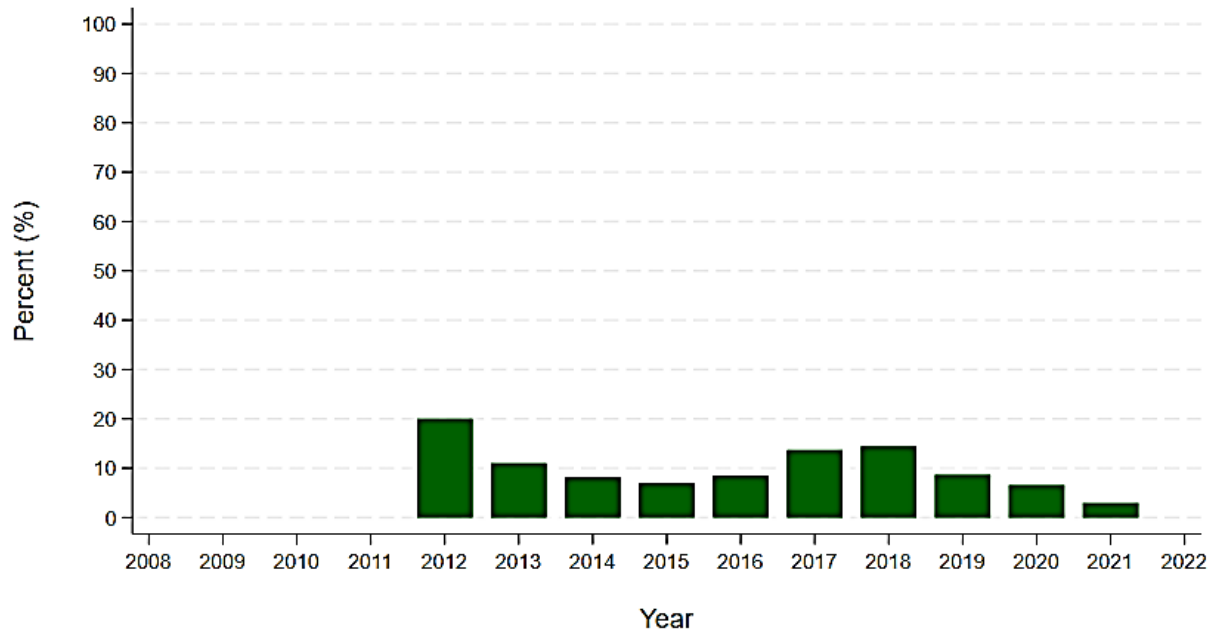
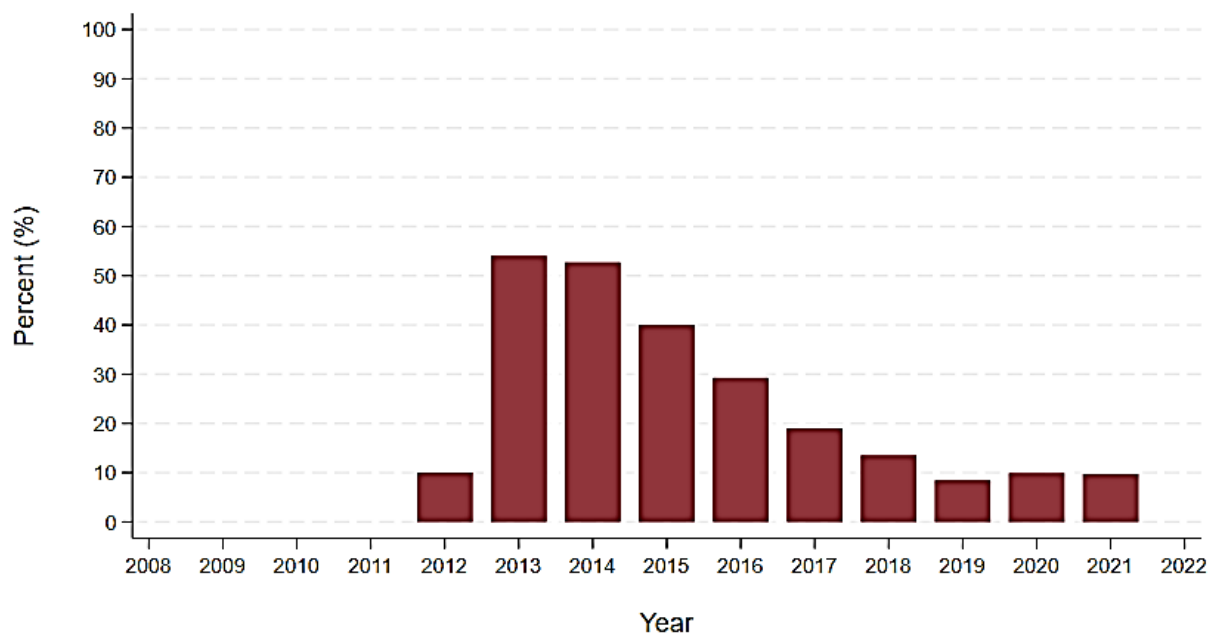


Figure 271. MGTOW-TRP Overlap over Time



PUA communities; remember that the overall percentage of PUA users also posting in MGTOW forums was comparatively small. MGTOW also shows high levels of early overlap with the TRP community; TRP emerges a year after MGTOW, in 2012, at which point 10% of MGTOW users are also posting in TRP. By 2013, this figure has increased to 54%. Again, it is important to note that MGTOW boasts a small number of users in these early years; combined with the trends regarding participation in other communities, it is quite possible that these high figures reflect that the small number of MGTOW posters were diverse in their manosphere participation. (Again, user-level trends in participation are assessed in greater detail in Chapter 6.) As the MGTOW community grows, overlap with TRP then decreases fairly steadily, ending at 20% in 2021.

User migration. The discussion in previous sections has highlighted that the MGTOW community shows very different patterns of overlap with the communities discussed so far; migration between MGTOW and PUA is comparatively low, regardless of which migration direction is considered, while MGTOW migration into and out of MRA and Incel spaces sees growth at varying points. Incel migration into the MGTOW community rises sharply between 2015 and 2019, and MGTOW migration into the Incel community sees late and less dramatic growth from 2018 to 2020. MRA migration into the MGTOW community, in contrast, grows steadily between 2014 and 2018, with MGTOW to MRA migrations reaching a more dramatic peak in 2020.

This leaves for further discussion the rates of migration between MGTOW and TRP, presented in **Error! Reference source not found.**; previously addressed trends are again presented in Figure 279. MGTOW-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 280. MGTOW-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 281. MGTOW-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 282 through **Error! Reference source not found.** for easy comparison. Like with other communities, TRP migrations into MGTOW do not see much growth until 2015, at which point migration rates steadily increase each year; this period of growth peaks in 2018, when roughly 1,000 users migrate from the TRP community into

Figure 279. MGTOW-PUA Migrations over Time

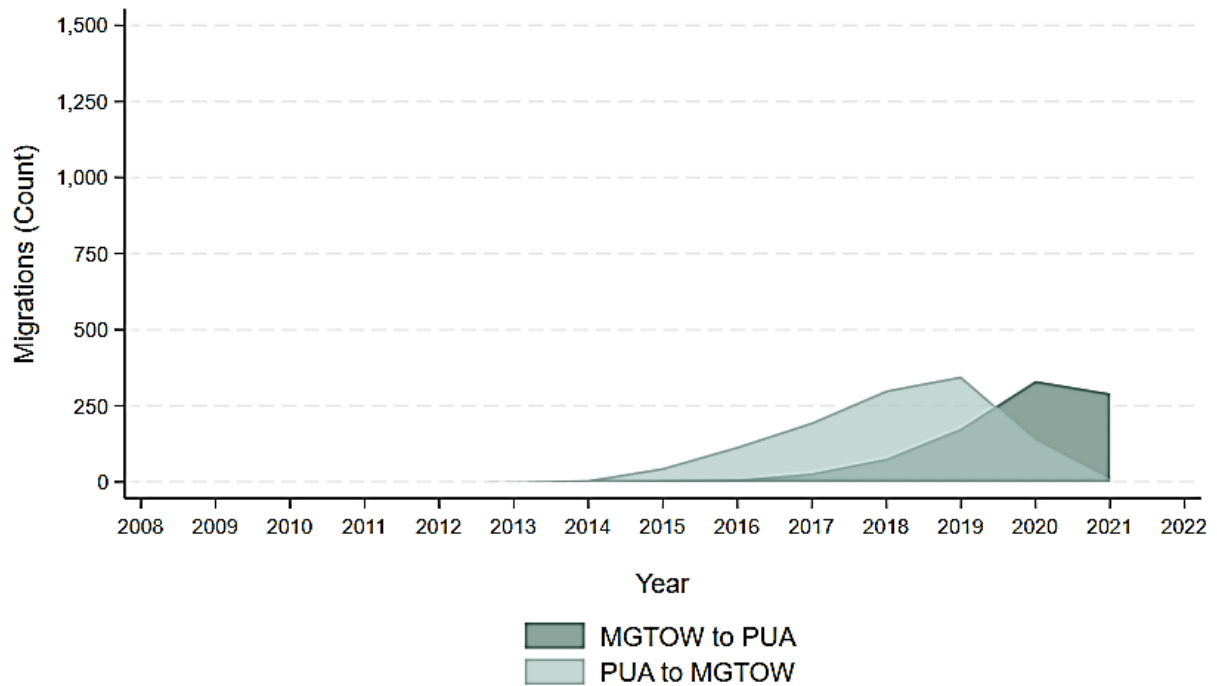


Figure 283. MGTOW-MRA Migrations over Time

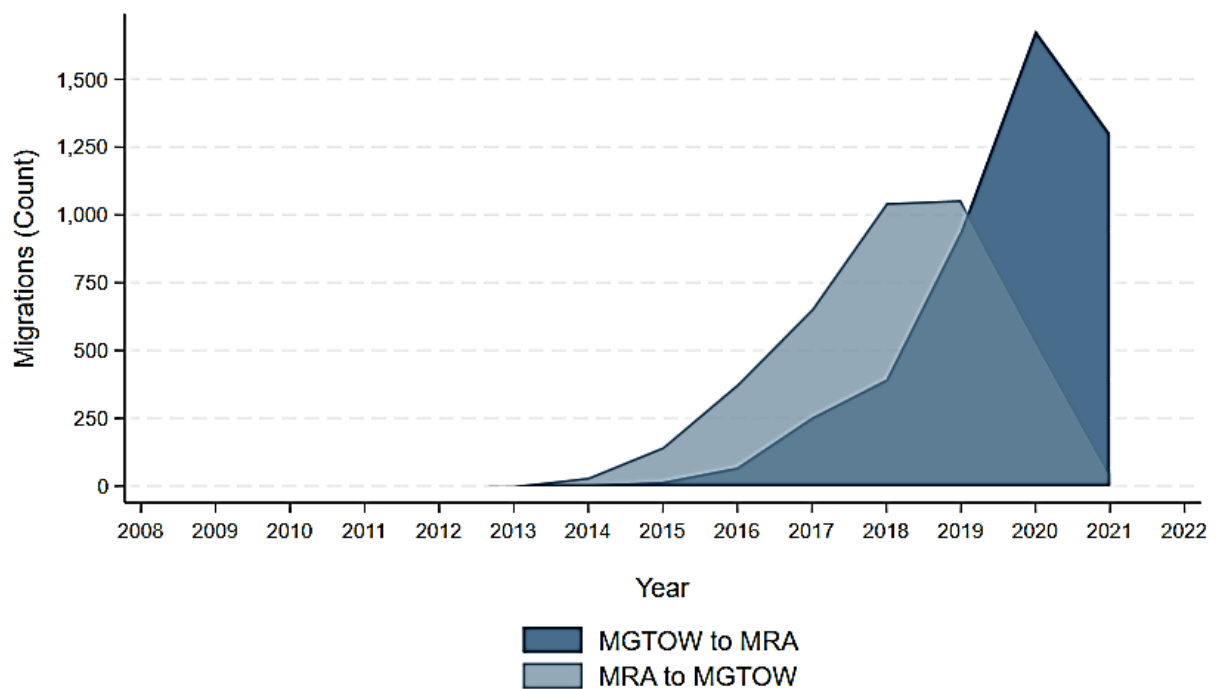


Figure 291. MGTOW-Incel Migrations over Time

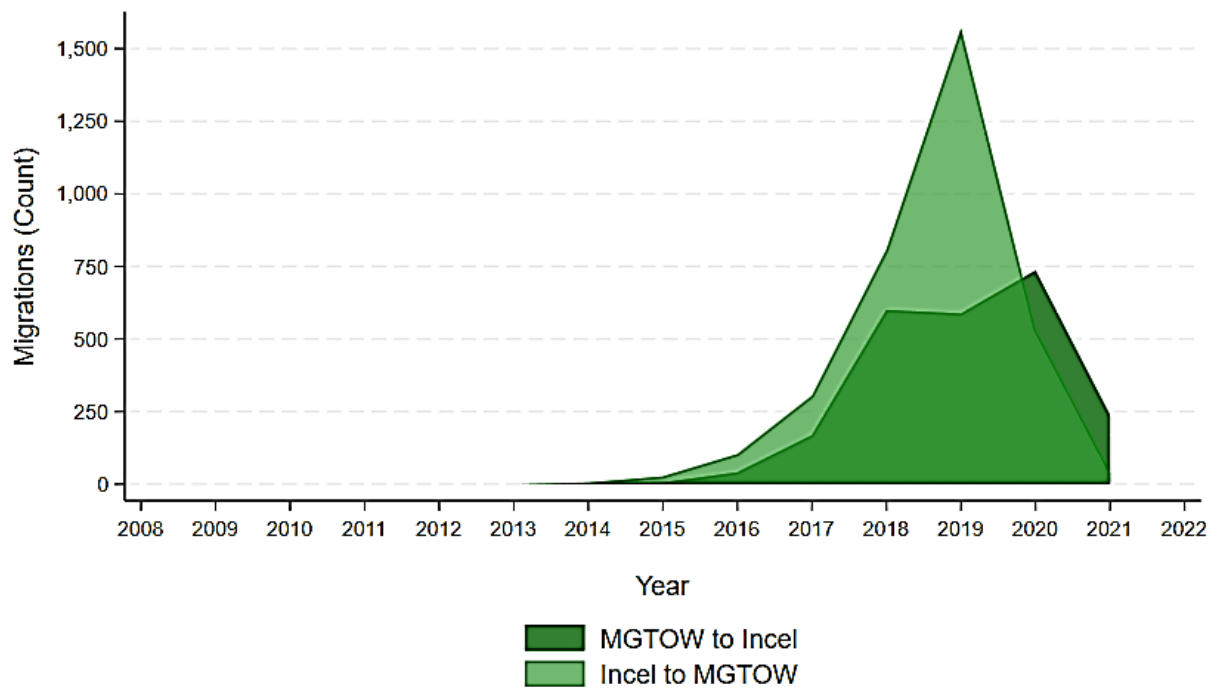
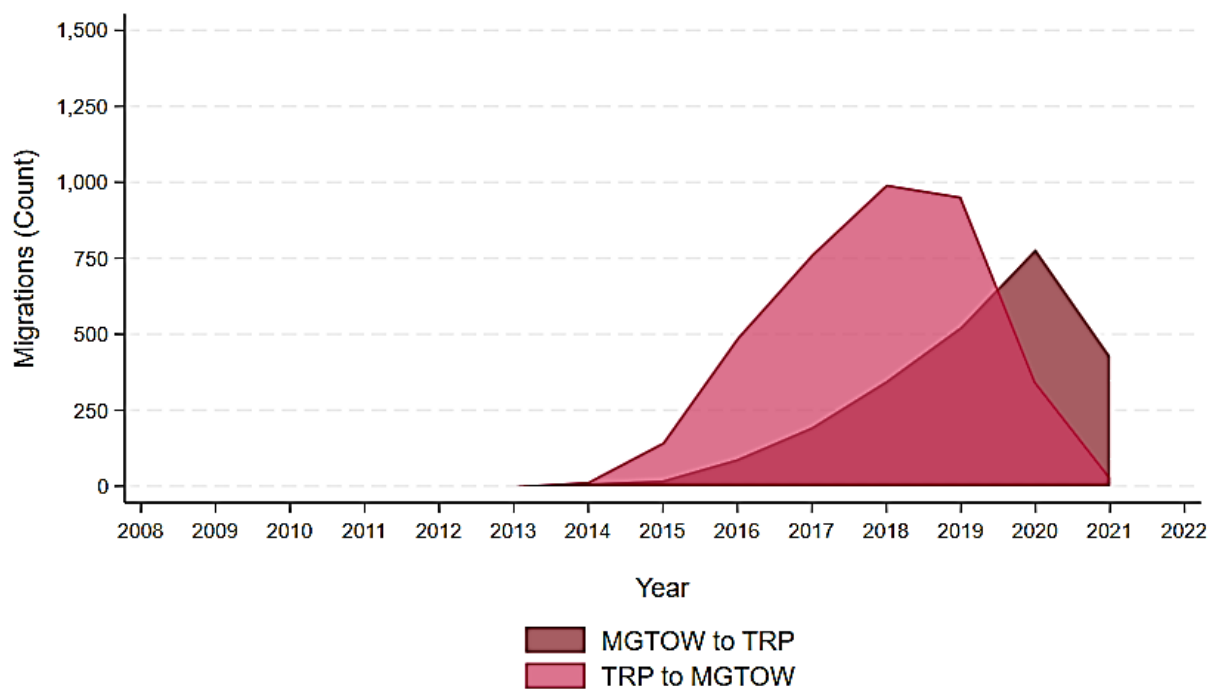


Figure 287. MGTOW-TRP Migrations over Time



the MGTOW community. TRP to MGTOW migration remains high in the following year, dipping slightly to around 900, then decreases sharply. MGTOW migration into TRP, in contrast, does not begin to increase until 2016; it also fails to reach quite the rate of migration in the converse direction, peaking at 750 MGTOW to TRP migrations in 2020 before declining dramatically.

Toxicity. Figure 300. MGTOW Toxicity over Time

Figure 300. MGTOW Toxicity over Time

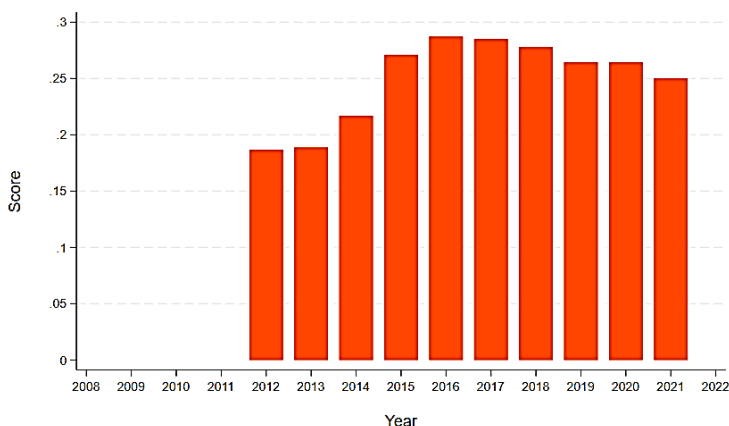


Figure 301Figure 302. MGTOW Toxicity over Time

Figure 303. TRP Subreddits over Time

Figure 304Figure 305Figure 306. MGTOW Toxicity over Time

Figure 307Figure 308 presents MGTOW toxicity over time. Immediately noticeable is the comparatively high rates of toxicity, both overall and in the first years of the community. Toxicity in the MGTOW community is higher in its inaugural year than any other community thus far, and from 2012 to 2014 it scores between .19 and .21—higher than both the PUA and Incel communities, and barely lower than that seen in the MRA community.

Again, the small number of users active in the first few years of MGTOW's existence on Reddit should be noted here; it is possible that toxicity in other subreddits is deflated by having a greater degree of variance in the toxicity of its users, and that MGTOWs is higher in part due to having a smaller number of users who are perhaps more dedicated or extreme in their views—a

possibility further supported by the apparent diverse participation of early MGTOW posters. A small user base, however, cannot fully account for MGTOW's overall greater toxicity—toxicity scores increase once the community hits its period of growth in 2015, remaining between .25 and .28—the highest levels seen thus far—until the community is ultimately banned in 2021.

The Red Pill (TRP)

Community development. TRP is the final manosphere community to emerge, and sees rapid proliferation relative to other communities. Figure 309. TRP Subreddits over Time

Figure 310Figure 311. TRP Subreddits over Time

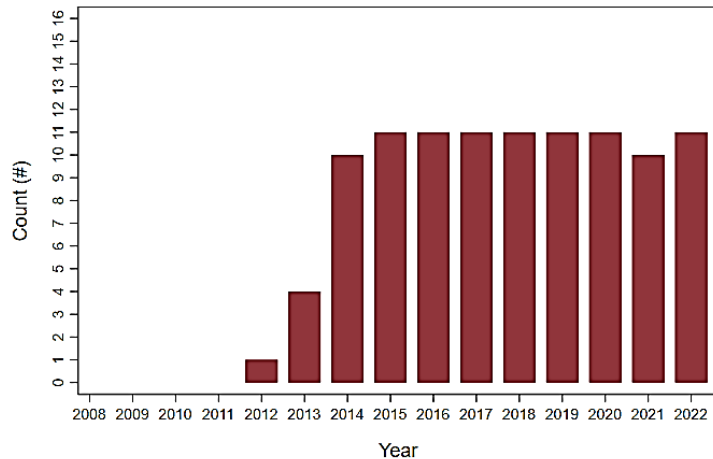
Figure 312. TRP Activity over Time

Figure 313Figure 314Figure 315. TRP Subreddits over Time

Figure 316Figure 317 shows a single subreddit created in 2012, and this number quadruples in the following year. By 2015, there are 11 active subreddits in the TRP community, and this figure remains relatively stable through 2022, save for the removal of a single subreddit in 2021 that is subsequently quickly replaced.

After its initial appearance in 2012, the TRP community also sees rapid growth in terms of

Figure 309. TRP Subreddits over Time



both activity and popularity, to a degree that surpasses any previous community.

Figure 318. TRP Activity over Time

Figure 319Figure 320. TRP Activity over Time

Figure 321. TRP Users over Time

Figure 322Figure 323. TRP Activity over Time

Figure 324Figure 325 shows that in 2013, there are nearly 250,000 posts in the community, a number that is on par with the far more firmly-established PUA community; TRP also firmly outstrips the similarly newer MGTOW community in terms of both posts and users, with **Figure 326. TRP Users over Time**

Figure 327. TRP Users over Time

Figure 328. TRP Users over Time

Figure 329 showing 10,000 active users in 2012. Note also that, over time, TRP appears to retain slightly more users than other communities, with around one-third of the total user base being comprised of users who were also active in previous years. These figures are especially

impressive when considering that the first TRP subreddit appeared in October of 2012, making 2013 its first year with any real growth opportunity.

By 2014, TRP is definitively the most active manosphere community on Reddit, with more than 960,000 posts; by 2015, it takes the number one spot in terms of both activity and popularity,

Figure 318. TRP Activity over Time

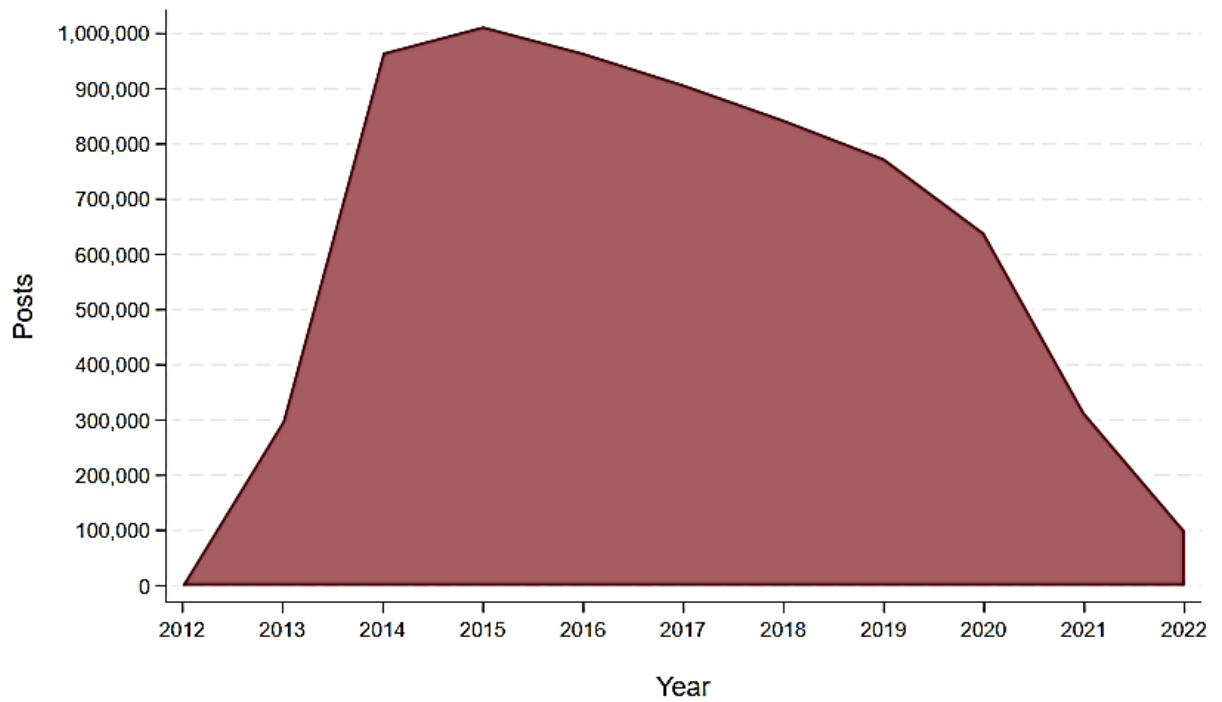
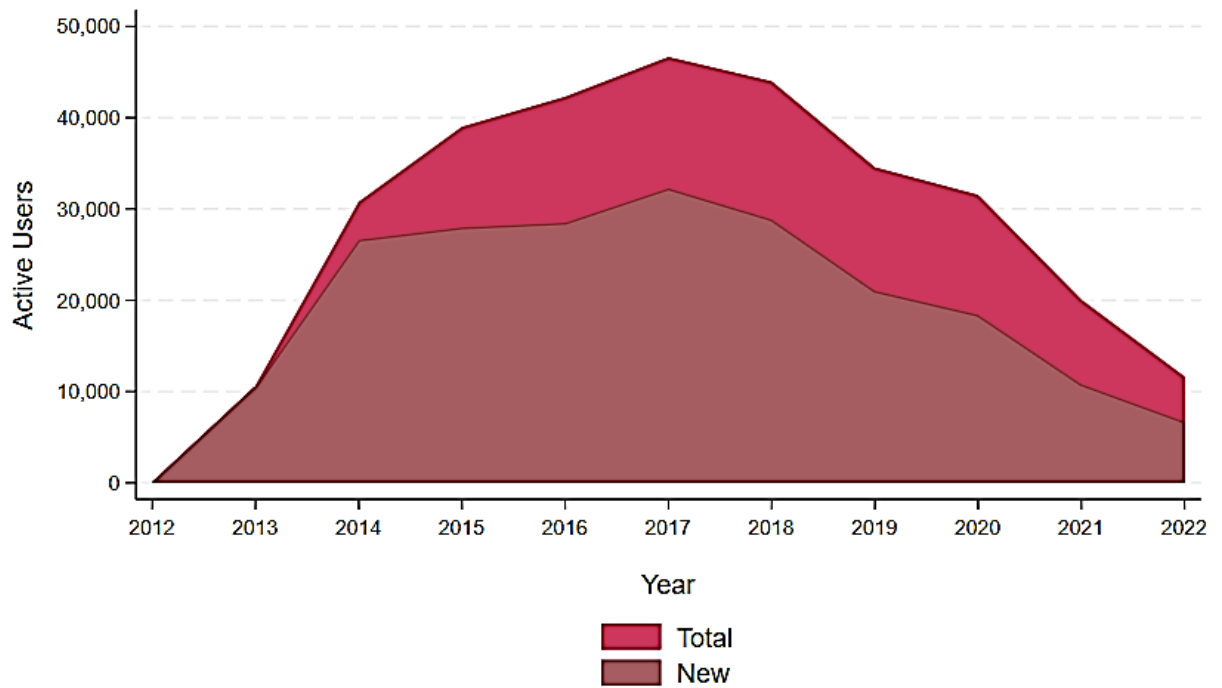


Figure 326. TRP Users over Time



with around 40,000 active users and just over one million posts made. From here, TRP sees slow decline in terms of activity, though the user base continues to grow through 2017, ultimately reaching just under 49,000 users; remember that at this point, it is no longer the most active or popular community on Reddit, with the Incel community ultimately surpassing TRP in terms of users and activity in 2017. After 2017, the TRP userbase also sees declines; this also corresponds with higher rates of migration from TRP into the Incel community. By 2022, TRP's activity and popularity is again greatly reduced, with the community generating 100,000 posts and hosting around 12,000 users.

Community overlap. Error! Reference source not found. through *Error! Reference source not found.* show that, at the outset, TRP has a high degree of overlap with both the MRA and PUA communities. 55% of TRP users also posted in MRA spaces in 2012, and nearly 45% also posted in the PUA community. This finding is perhaps unsurprising, given that TRP emerged in part as the product of ideological cross-pollination between these communities (Ribeiro et al. 2021; Rothermel et al. 2022). Overlap with the Incel and MGTOW communities is comparatively smaller, but still present from the outset, with 9% of TRP users posting in Incel spaces, and 4% posting in the MGTOW community.

Overlap with PUA and MRA diminishes significantly the following year, decreasing to 18% and 22%, respectively. (Note that findings on user activity also showed a sharp increase in overall participation in TRP spaces during this time. An influx of new users not associated with previous communities may account for the decreasing rates of overlap.) TRP overlap with PUA and MRA continues to decrease by 10-15% over the next several years, settling at around 8% for both communities by 2017 and remaining more or less stable through 2022. TRP overlap with the

MGTOW community, in contrast, starts low at 4% in 2012, and increases over time until peaks at 15% in 2019; as a reminder, this is the same year that the MGTOW community user base reaches

Figure 330. TRP-PUA Overlap over Time

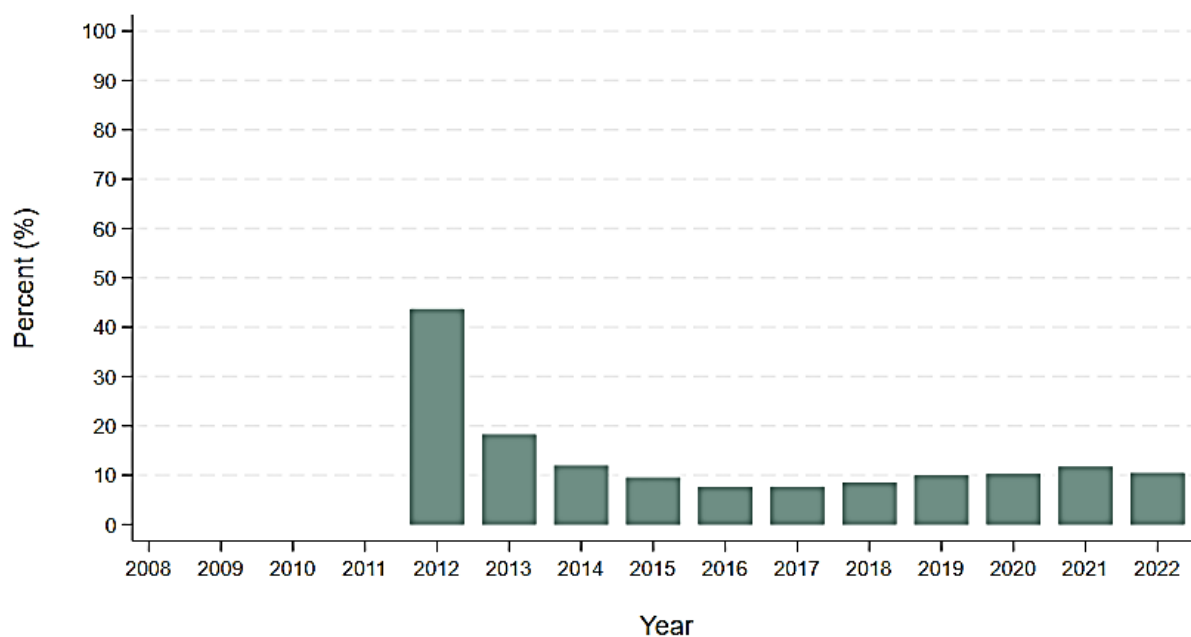


Figure 334. TRP-MRA Overlap over Time

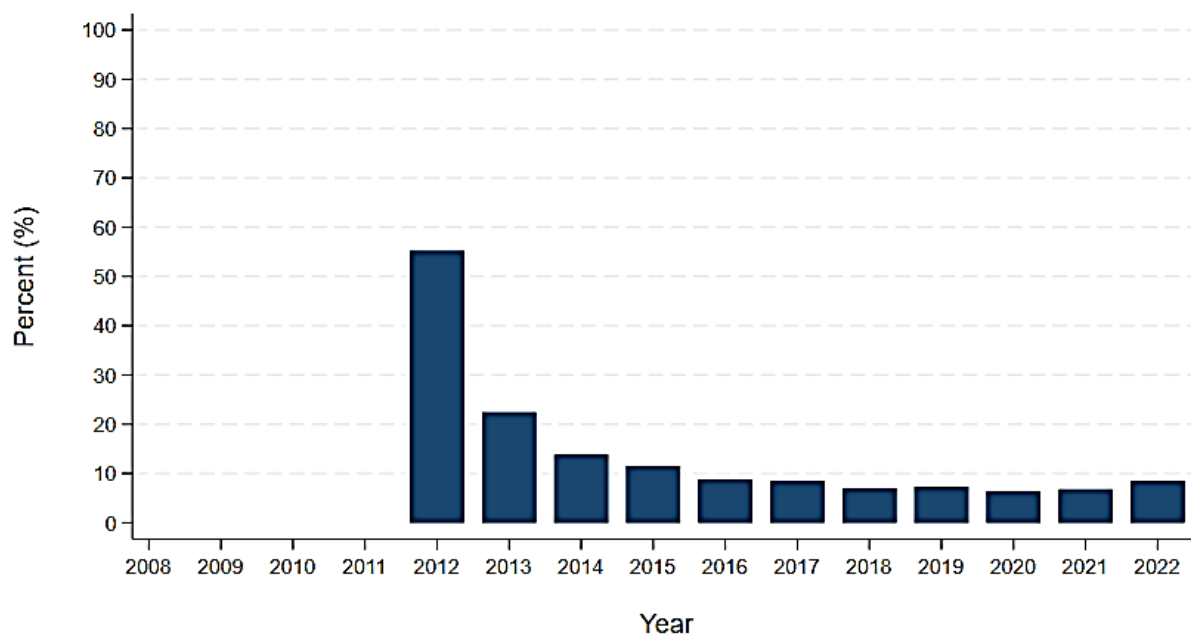


Figure 338. TRP-Incel Overlap over Time

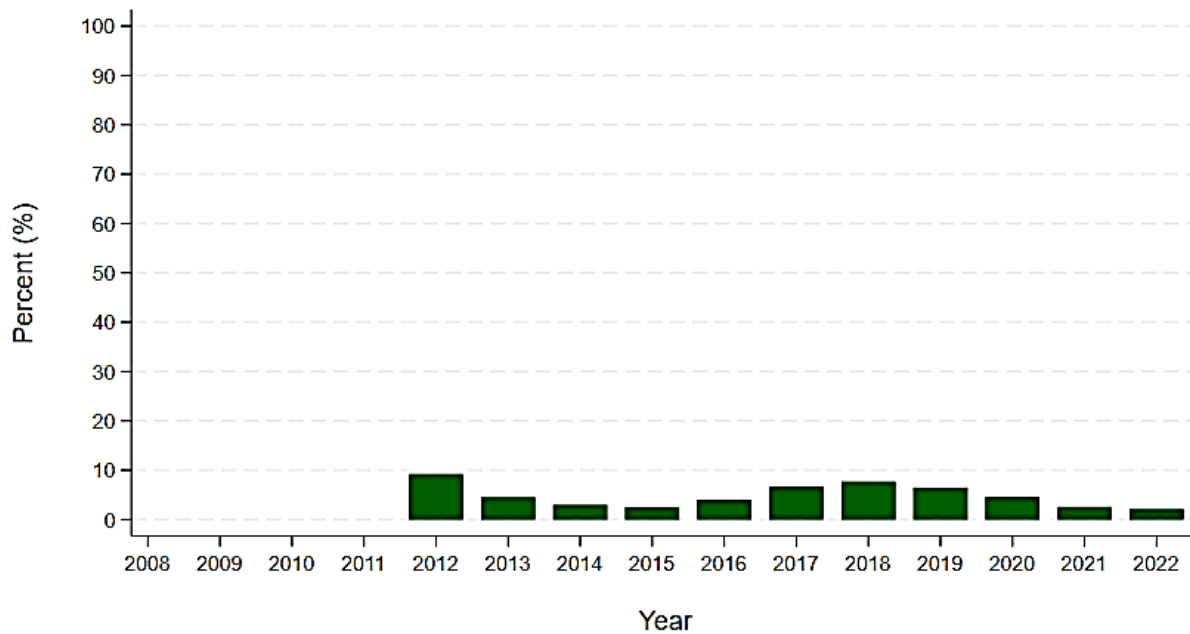
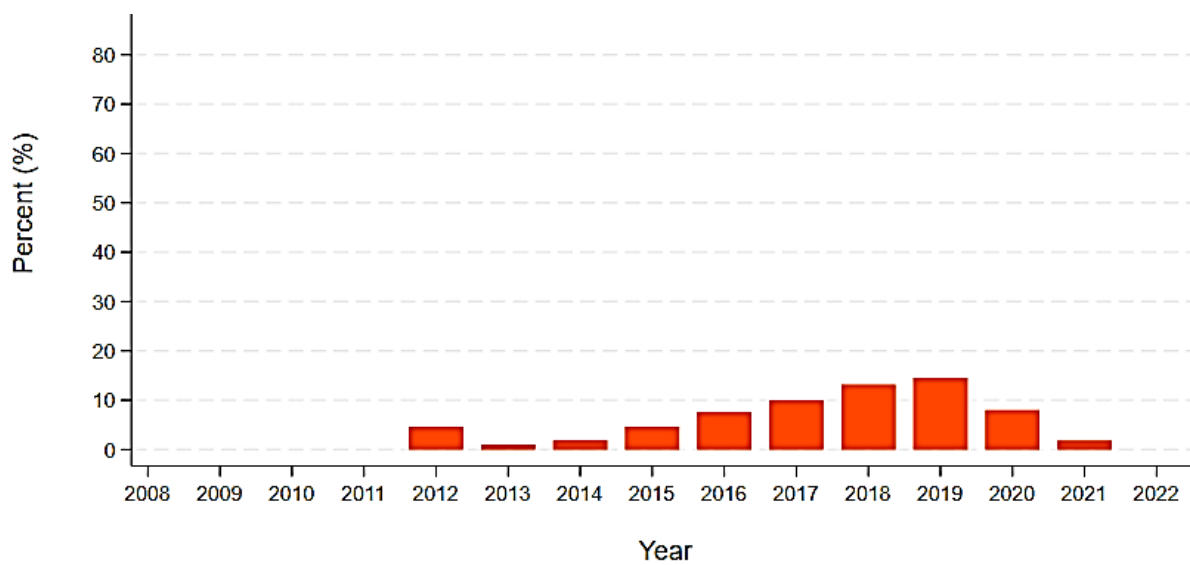


Figure 342. TRP-MGTOW Overlap over Time



its zenith. After this point, TRP-MGTOW overlap decreases sharply to only 1% in 2021, which is likely at least partly reflective of the ultimate banning of the MGTOW community in this same year. TRP overlap with MRA and PUA then diminishes significantly the following year, reducing to 22% overlap with MRA and 18% overlap with PUA. (Note that findings on user activity also showed that overall participation in TRP spaces jumps dramatically during this time.) TRP overlap with MRA and PUA then decreases by 10-15% over the next several years, settling at around 8% overlap with MRA and PUA by 2017; at this point, TRP-MRA and TRP-PUA overlap remains relatively stable, between 7% and 12% through 2022. In contrast, overlap with the MGTOW community follows a different trajectory, starting low at 4% in 2012, and increasing over time until it peaks at 15% in 2019. From here it decreases sharply to only 1% in 2021, which is likely at least partly reflective of the MGTOW community ban implemented that year.

User migration. Figure 350. TRP-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 351. TRP-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 352. TRP-PUA Migrations over Time

Figure 353 through **Error! Reference source not found.** re-summarize the migration trends identified in the discussion on previous communities, and allows for easy comparisons that center overall migrations trends in the TRP community. Several distinct patterns are identifiable here—a period of pronounced migration from the PUA and MRA communities into TRP spaces, which is accompanied by a small degree of Incel to TRP migration. This is followed by a period of increased migration out of TRP and into the MRA and Incel communities, which peaks between

2017 and 2018. This same year sees high levels of migration into the MGTOW community as well. In the last few years of the data, new trends emerge; there is increased migration from TRP to PUA, and from MGTOW into TRP.

Toxicity. Like the MGTOW community, TRP registers immediately as more toxic than earlier-emerging manosphere communities, particularly at the outset. It is the only community to emerge with a toxicity higher than .20, with Figure 371. TRP Toxicity over Time

Figure 372Figure 373. TRP Toxicity over Time

Figure 374. Posting Characteristics by Primary Community

Figure 375Figure 376Figure 377. TRP Toxicity over Time

Figure 378Figure 379 showing a score of .21 in 2012. By 2014,

Figure 350. TRP-PUA Migrations over Time

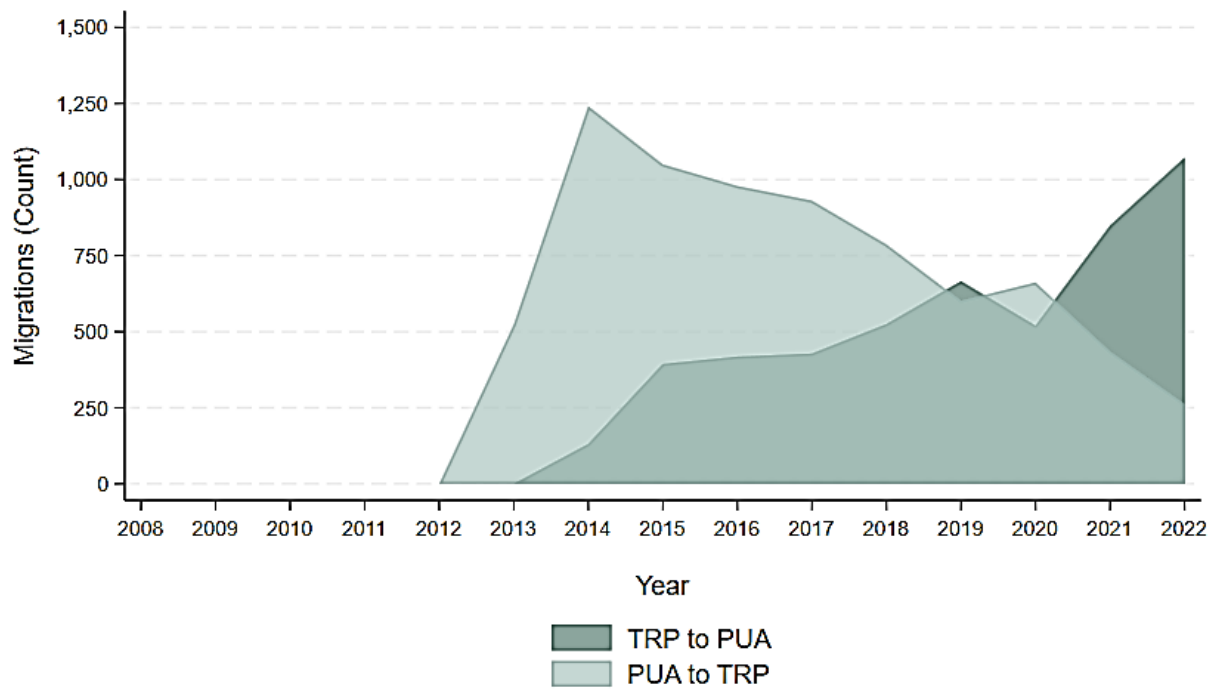


Figure 354. TRP-MRA Migrations over Time

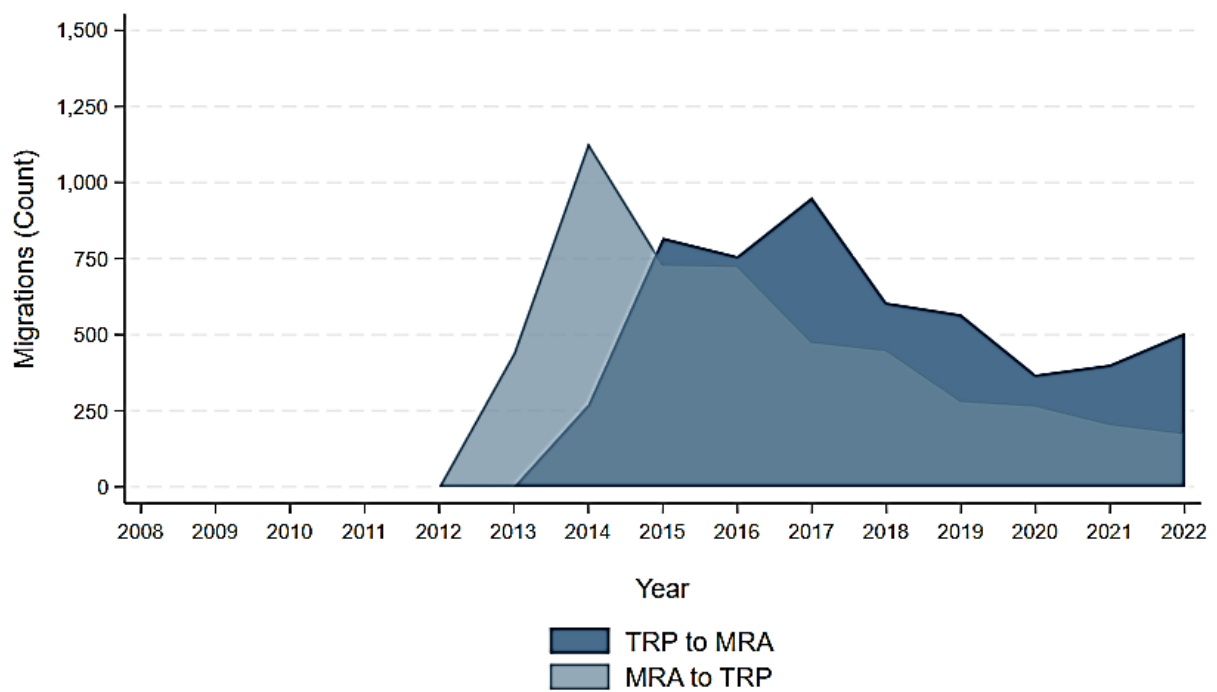


Figure 358. TRP-Incel Migrations over Time

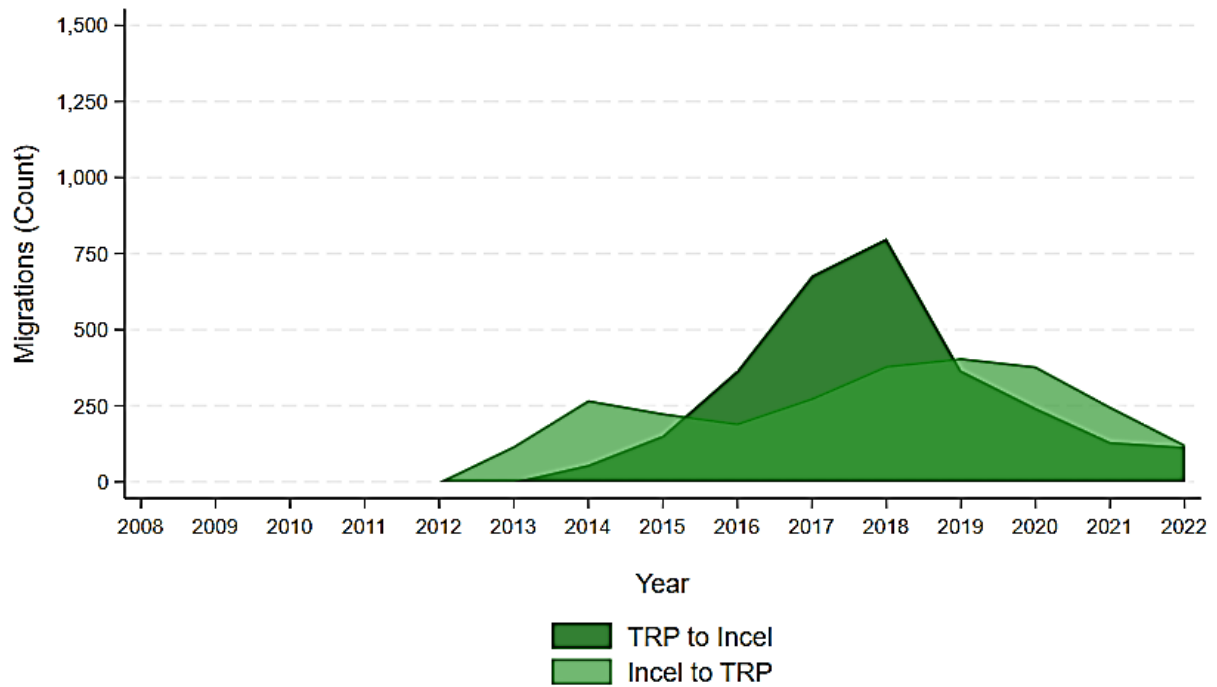


Figure 362. TRP-MGTOW Migrations over Time

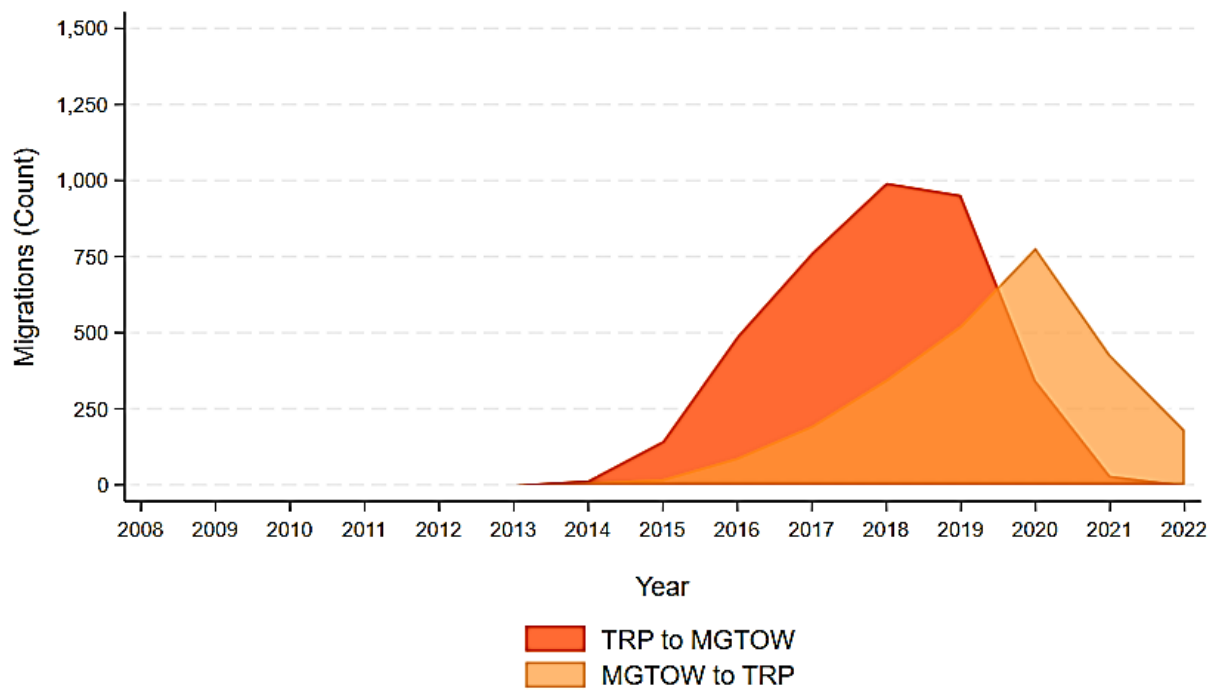
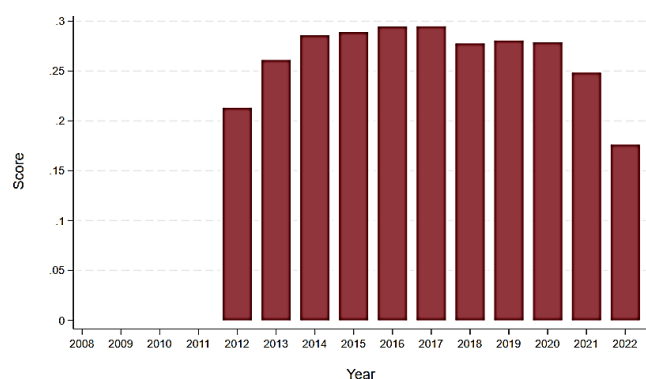


Figure 371. TRP Toxicity over Time



this has increased to .28—higher than the MGTOW community, which also evidenced quickly- increasing toxicity. TRP’s average toxicity then sits between .27 and .29 until 2020, after which point it does decline; this decline corresponds with the period of heavily decreasing TRP activity. By 2022,

TRP’s average toxicity has decreased to .18; at this point it becomes only the second-most toxic community, barely exceeded by MRA at .19. This change in ranking positions MRA as the most toxic community for this year, but this does appear to be driven by a decrease in toxicity in other subreddits. Remember that MRA toxicity remained relatively stable across time, hovering between .20 and .23 with little change.

CONCLUSION

Overall, the results presented here are congruent with previous work’s identification of three distinct periods in the data—early MRA and PUA dominance, a period of MGTOW and TRP growth and PUA decline, and Incel and MGTOW’s rise to prominence as TRP loses momentum (Ribeiro et al. 2021). An examination of more recent data than that analyzed in previous studies also shows a fourth distinct period of manosphere activity developing from 2018 to 2022, as the Incel and MGTOW communities falter, and PUA and MRA spaces see a resurgence. In most cases, these shifts are evidenced across all the metrics analyzed here—subreddit counts, community activity and popularity, user overlap, and user migration between communities. In the earliest years, the 2008 to 2013 period, the MRA and PUA community show the strongest presence in terms of subreddits, activity, and popularity; this is followed by large increases in the activity and popularity of TRP, and a steady degree of growth in the Incel and MGTOW communities, which

is in turn often accompanied by the proliferation of new subreddits within these growing communities (MGTOW being somewhat of an exception). Incel and MGTOW then see their own dramatic growth in popularity and activity in the later period of the data, as TRP participation levels off and ultimately wanes; this similarly corresponds with a record number of Incel subreddits being created between 2016 and 2018. In 2018, the first hints of faltering momentum for the Incel and MGTOW communities then appear, and by 2021 there is massive reduction in participation in these spaces. The sharp decline in MGTOW activity in 2021—and the complete absence of MGTOW participation in 2022—are almost certainly reflective, at least in part, of the banning of the three MGTOW-affiliated subreddits in August 2021. However, decreasing participation prior to this date, and the banning of MGTOW later in the year, suggest other processes are also at play. This is especially true because MGTOW and Incel are not the only communities that seem impacted; TRP sees declining participation from 2016 onward, and this trend becomes especially pronounced during the 2021 to 2022 period. More interestingly, as most communities see declines or stagnancy during these years, the PUA community shows small but steady growth, which is accompanied by increasing migrations into PUA spaces from faltering communities like Incel and TRP.

Analysis also shows that overlap between communities often, but not always, previews migration between communities; overlap tends to increase as a community's popularity increases, as does user migration into these growing communities. While MGTOW and Incel overlap with other communities is not nearly as strong as in earlier years, when the communities were still nascent, the MRA, PUA, and TRP communities do show small increases in MGTOW and Incel overlap from 2014 to 2018, and Incel-MGTOW overlap similarly increases slightly during this period. Pronounced spikes in migration into Incel and MGTOW from other communities also

appear in the data during this time, with the MRA and TRP communities in particular seeing rapid increases in migrations into Incel and MGTOW. Further, the tapering off of growth in the TRP community is accompanied by a doubling of TRP to Incel migrations from 2016 to 2017. Consider also that user base increases for most communities are driven primarily by an increasing number of new users participating each year—put differently, rather than manosphere communities attracting a relatively even number of new users each year and building up a base of dedicated users who participate over time, increases in popularity seem to be driven by the attraction of increasingly large sets of new users every year. This, in combination with frequently increasing overlap and migration as community popularity increases, aligns with assertions that the development of these communities was driven not necessarily just by influxes of users who are entirely new to the Reddit manosphere, but is bolstered in part by changes in where Reddit manosphere participants' engagement is taking place.

Toxicity analysis also confirms differences in the overall toxicity of the different manosphere communities, and supports notions that users are moving from less toxic communities towards more toxic communities. However, trends in toxicity over time also suggest that the correlation between migration and toxicity may be incidental; in nearly all communities, increasing popularity and activity seem to correspond to increasing toxicity, while the ultimate decreases in popularity and activity are accompanied by *decreases* in community toxicity. This suggests that the degree of toxicity present in any community may largely be a function of the number of users engaging in these communities. It is important to note, though, that this does not appear to be definitely the case in *all* instances; remember the relatively high degree of toxicity present in the MGTOW community from the outset, despite the small user base.

Taken together, the trends identified here raise a number of quandaries that connect back to the radicalization waypoints—engagement rates, migration, and disengagement—and their associated hypotheses overviewed in Chapter 3. For example, the descriptive findings outlaid here raise questions regarding the processes that drove increased migration into the Incel community *after* the implementation of community bans; Hypotheses 10a and 10b regarding user migration suggest these movements may be the result of users radicalizing in the wake of platform-level repression events. Or, if previous work has indicated that migration is occurring in the direction of less to more toxic or extreme communities (Farrell et al. 2019; Ribeiro et al. 2021), what explains the decrease in participation in these communities in the later years of the data, or the apparent shift in migration towards the longstanding PUA community? Hypotheses 22a, 22b, and 25d regarding the expected role of measures of fit in driving disengagement, and Hypotheses 11 through 14 suggesting that measures of fit may drive migration more generally (and thus sometimes in the direction of less toxic communities) may help to explain these trends. The results here also suggest that growing toxicity may be a consequence, rather than a cause, of migration to more toxic communities; if this is the case, the significance of repression events highlighted in Hypotheses 10a and 10b may again be relevant as an explanans for migration into newer communities, independent of user toxicity. Finally, given that user base increases appear driven largely by new users who do not persist, Hypotheses 22 through 32 regarding the processes of disengagement continue to be of significant interest, highlighting the relevance of all proposed relationships.

In the subsequent three chapters, I move towards answering these questions. Chapter 6 presents results of analyses predicting rates of engagement, and highlights factors that significantly drive user engagement. Chapter 7 then presents results of event history analysis modeling

migration, providing insights into the mechanisms that may drive post-ban migrations, migrations back towards the PUA community, or user trajectories towards newer communities. Finally, in Chapter 8 I present findings regarding the most salient factors driving disengagement.

CHAPTER 6: USER ENGAGEMENT IN THE REDDIT MANOSPHERE

Chapter 5 situates Reddit as a unique context in which misogynist extremism may flourish, and flourish it has: preliminary analysis of user engagement at the community level shows increasing activity over the last decade and a half, with participation trending towards more toxic iterations of male supremacist communities. In this chapter, I shift focus from the community to the user level, and ultimately move beyond descriptive accounts to predict user engagement rates. To begin, I provide more detailed summary statistics of users' posting behaviors and characteristics during their tenure within the Reddit manosphere, particularly as they relate to the factors expected to impact user engagement; then, I review how yearly engagement patterns differ among users with different primary communities, further teasing out the community-level distinctions identified in the previous chapter. Finally, I conclude by presenting results from a series of negative binomial regressions modeling the effect of key variables on posting rates for a subset of longer-term users within the Reddit manosphere. Overall, the results indicate that group identity is a salient predictor of engagement for long-term participants in secular male supremacist spaces on Reddit, with users in most newer communities engaging at significantly lower rates than those in older communities. Findings also show that measures of fit and reception for users' posts have little utility for predicting differential participation in these spaces, highlighting that this component of radicalization is largely unimpacted by separate processes impacting online engagement more generally; this supports prior assertions that radicalization processes are not necessarily fundamentally transformed in the digital context. Finally, measures of the manosphere context, particularly the spread of toxicity across communities and the number of subreddit bans implemented within these spaces, were found to significantly impact posting rates, indicating that higher-level experiences with movement homogeneity or repression can encourage or discourage engagement. Repression measures were further shown to interact with user-level toxicity, with

more toxic users being less affected by the negative effect of repression on engagement. Altogether, findings suggest that in terms of differential participation in degrees of engagement, radicalization in the Reddit manosphere may be primarily influenced by group identity and structural processes rather than user characteristics or in-group interactions, with the important caveat that user toxicity appears to intersect with more structural elements to shape engagement.

ANALYSIS

As detailed in Chapter 3, key variables covering four specific areas are expected to shape the outcomes under study in this dissertation: the characteristics of users posting behaviors, measures of fit reception within communities, measures of repression at the individual and/or community level, and the broader manosphere or community context. A review of the factors expected to predict engagement rates, and their corresponding hypotheses from Chapter 3, are presented in Table 11—note that this table highlights the expected relationships, but omits the predictor variables included in other segments of the analysis. Overall, posting characteristics are expected to have a mixed relationship with engagement, with users in newer or more generally active communities expected to engage more, and more long-standing users similarly predicted to engage to a higher degree. User toxicity, in contrast, is expected to decrease engagement. Measures of fit and reception, when positive (as measured through post scores, comments received, and gildings) are expected to drive engagement, and are expected to suppress engagement when negative (as indicated by post removals). Community context is expected to have a mixed effect; the number of active users and posting activity is predicted to positively predict engagement, while community toxicity and repression measures such as quarantines and bans are expected to hinder engagement. User-level toxicity is further expected to moderate the relationship between repression measures and engagement, with more toxic users expected to be less affected by bans or quarantines.

Table 11. Review of Key Variables Expected to Drive Engagement³⁷

	Expected Relationship to Engagement	Hypothesis
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
Primary Community		
PUA	Reference	H ₁
MRA	Positive	H ₁
Incel	Positive	H ₁
MGTOW	Positive	H ₁
TRP	Positive	H ₁
Tenure	Positive	H ₅
Number of posts	Positive	H ₄
Average toxicity	Negative	H ₆
<i>Measures of Fit & Reception</i>		
Average post score	Positive	H _{7a}
Comments received	Positive	H _{7b}
Gildings received	Positive	H _{7c}
Post removals	Negative	H _{7d}
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
Number of active users	Positive	H ₂
Average toxicity	Positive	H _{3a}
Toxicity spread	Negative	H _{3b}
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
Quarantines implemented	Negative	H _{8a}
Bans implemented	Negative	H _{8b}
User toxicity x quarantines	Negative	H _{8c}
User toxicity x bans	Negative	H _{8d}

³⁷ Table 11 is a partial reproduction of Table 1 presented in Ch. 3, but omits the variables expected to shape other outcomes.

A detailed account of the analytic procedures and their underlying rationale were presented in Chapter 4. To review, I choose here to utilize a fixed-effects negative binomial regression to predict rates of engagement in the form of posts made in a given year; the negative binomial regression is an appropriate choice for count models evidencing overdispersion, while the incorporation of fixed effects allows for accounting of unobserved user-level characteristics that may also shape rates of engagement (Allison and Waterman 2002; Guimarães 2008). The analysis proceeds in four stages, with each of the first three models incorporating sets of measures related to the three broad predictor areas: user characteristics, measures of fit and reception, and community context. As such, Model 1 incorporates only user-level measures of posting behavior, Model 2 incorporates reception characteristics, and Model 3 incorporates features of the broader Reddit manosphere. Model 4 then tests expected interactions between user-level toxicity and repression measures. Models 2 through 4 also include the percentage of users' posts that were submissions, rather than comments, as a control variable as the comments received measure for this portion of the analysis focuses on submission comments specifically. Measures of fit indicate model fit is improved by the addition of each set of covariates.

As thoroughly detailed in Chapter 4, the combination of lagged variables, fixed effects, and the negative binomial regression also requires that users be present for at least three years in order to estimate coefficients; as a result, the analysis here is limited to the sample of 133,662 users and 472,660 user-years, reflecting the subset of total users who met the analysis requirements. Prior to discussing regression results, I also present additional descriptive statistics for the range of user characteristics included in the analysis, providing a holistic account of users' engagement during their active years within the Reddit manosphere. Then, I summarize yearly participation patterns,

broken out by users' primary communities; here, I also highlight where average differences between users in different primary communities are statistically significant.

DESCRIPTIVE RESULTS FOR USER ENGAGEMENT BY PRIMARY COMMUNITY

As presented in Chapter 4, analysis of user participation in the Reddit manosphere shows 1,100,544 unique user profiles active at some point between June 2008 and December 2022.³⁸ Summary statistics for users' years active and community participation are presented in Table 12; note that summary statistics summarize users' active years of engagement. As previously addressed, some users participated for nonconsecutive years. Intermediary years are included in the regression analyses to account for time spent in the online community and the effect of zero values for key predictor variables, but are omitted from descriptive statistics so that frequencies and averages reflect characteristics of time spent actively participating in these communities. Broadly speaking, the results indicate that engagement within the Reddit manosphere is, for most users, highly limited—this is true in terms of both the duration and diversity of users' participation (i.e., in terms of how long they are engaging, and where this engagement is happening), and in terms of the interactivity of their participation (i.e., most users receive very limited engagement from others within these communities).

³⁸ Note again that this figure excludes any user profiles deleted by the account owner prior to the time of data collection, and that it also does not capture users who read or voted on community content, but who did not themselves post in of the communities under study. Further, it should again be considered that the number of active profiles cannot be expected to exactly reflect the number of active *individuals*; while there is no reason to assume a significant percentage of individuals utilized multiple Reddit accounts during the period under study, the practice of owning multiple accounts or ceasing participation on profile and starting anew on another has been documented (see Leavitt 2015). As such, it likely that at least some individuals are represented more than once within the data. For the sake of simplicity, however, the terms 'users', 'user profiles,' and 'individuals' are used interchangeably in the discussion.

Table 12. Frequency Counts and Percentages for Participation and Reception

	Count	Percent	Cum. Percent
Years Active			
1	831,485	75.55	75.55
2	167,556	15.22	90.77
3	54,836	4.98	95.75
4	23,259	2.11	97.86
5	11,116	1.01	98.87
6	5,570	0.51	99.38
7	3,086	0.28	99.66
8	1,698	0.15	99.81
9	944	0.09	99.90
10	530	0.05	99.95
11	286	0.03	99.98
12	113	0.01	99.99
13	52	0.00	100.00
14	17	0.00	100.00
15	6	0.00	100.00
Total Communities Participated In			
1	961,467	87.36	87.36
2	109,602	9.96	97.32
3	23,385	2.12	99.44
4	5,149	0.47	99.91
5	951	0.09	100.00
Changed Primary Community			
Yes	64,511	5.86	5.86
No	1,036,044	94.14	100.00
Had Gilded			
Yes	150,993	13.72	13.72
No	949,561	86.28	100.00

N = 1,100,554

What, then, does this limited engagement look like? Results show that the majority of these users—831,485, or around 75%—were active for a year or less, and only an additional 167,556 users participated for two years. Altogether, then, less than 10% of users were active for more than two years. The data is similarly skewed when considering the number of communities users participated in—961,467 users (87%) participated in only one community, with an additional

109,602 users (a cumulative total of just over 97%) participating in two communities during their tenure in the Reddit manosphere. Additionally, only 64,511 users—or just under 6%—ever experienced a change in their primary community over time. Finally, in terms of reception, gildings were relatively rare—just over 13% of users had at least one post gilded during their time in the Reddit manosphere.

The findings around participation here are interesting, and build off those on community-level trends presented in Chapter 5, which indicated that year-to-year community growth was driven primarily by new users entering into communities in which they had not previously been active, rather than through a committed user base accumulating over time. That users here have been identified as overwhelmingly participating in only one community further suggests that the new users driving community growth are most often new not only to any given community, but also to the broader Reddit manosphere. Previous work has frequently treated growth within these communities, in terms of both the total number of posts made and the number of users posting, as an indicator that increasing swathes of men are being radicalized into secular male supremacism (Ging and Murphy 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2021; Vu et al. 2021), but the trends identified here actually paint a slightly more optimistic—albeit still not ideal—picture: that these groups are succeeding in attracting increasing *attention*, but are not having the same degree of success in recruiting long-term adherents to their cause.

Let us now consider what other facets of participation look like for these users. Summary statistics for continuous measures of users' contributions and their receptions are reviewed in Table 13, with a few notable trends again becoming readily apparent. First, user engagement appears limited not only in duration and breadth, but also volume—the median number of posts made across all active years is only two. At the same time, note the higher mean value for this metric—

an average of 23 posts made across all years. This figure also boasts a large standard deviation and substantial range, indicating that inflation of the mean is the result of a smaller number of users posting more heavily.

Table 13. Summary Statistics for User Participation and Reception

	Median	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Total Posts	2	23.30	199.31	1	44,556
Mean Post Score	2.25	7.31	46.28	-266	13,687
Number of Submission Comments Received	0	18.72	236.52	0	69,132
Percent Submissions	0	16.88	33.01	1	100
Mean Toxicity	.10	.2011428	.2581077	.0000868	.9997219

That high post volumes are driven by a high number of dedicated users aligns with previous research on social media engagement, which has found that the bulk of content tends to be created by ‘heavy contributors’ or ‘highly active users’ who comprise somewhere between 1% and 20% of the user base (Brandtzaeg and Heim 2011; Nielsen 2006). In considering the significance of these descriptive trends for radicalization within the Reddit manosphere, the relatively low levels of engagement for most users, in combination with the presence of a small but highly active user base, suggests that the degree of differential participation is pronounced within these spaces and affirms that, even if these communities are less effective at recruiting lasting participants than measures of community growth alone might suggest, there is still utility in investigating what factors distinguish highly active users from those who engage only briefly and in limited fashion.

Measures of reception for users are similarly modest. The median post score was 2.25, with a slightly higher mean of 7.31. Here, it should be noted that this figure represents an ‘average of

averages’—that is, it reflects the average value of users’ average scores across all their posts, rather than the overall mean post score across all users, in order to better capture the ‘typical’ user in the analysis. The median number of submission comments received is 0, with a mean of 18.72, suggesting that most users receive no responses to their contributions while some outliers enjoy an abnormal degree of focused attention (see the standard deviation of 236.52 submission comments received). However, the median percent submissions is 0, indicating that many users were ineligible to receive submission comments because they did not post any submissions. Given that the interactive element of online communities has been identified in previous work as driving greater engagement (Davidson 2024; Khan 2017), as has the receipt of incentives (of which post scores are representative thanks to the karma accrued through upvotes) (Claussen et al. 2013; Richterich 2014), these findings suggest that low engagement may in part be a consequence of these low interaction rates. They also indicate that engagement within these spaces is limited not only in terms of how long or how much users post, but also potentially in terms of how much interaction is actually occurring with other users—further supporting the notion that the proliferation of online male supremacist communities is driven by the successful attraction of users’ attention, but that it is not necessarily accompanied by the effective recruitment of participants who meaningfully engage with the ideologies or views espoused within these spaces. Finally, the median average toxicity for users is .1 on a scale ranging from 0 (not at all toxic) to 1 (most toxic), with a mean of .2; again, this reflects the average values of users’ average toxicity across all posts. Overall, this indicates most posts are not especially high on toxicity, while the standard deviation and range show the mean being inflated by a smaller number of more toxic users.

Comparisons by Community

Given the trends identified in Chapter 5—which indicated different levels of active users, posting activity, and toxicity across communities—and given the interest in understanding user participation across spaces with different levels of extremism and somewhat different applications of red pill ideology, it is also interesting to assess how user participation patterns vary across the five communities of interest. It should be noted here that the figures presented in this section reflect yearly averages for users’ whose primary community was the community specified, rather than averages drawn from users’ entire post histories. This is a requisite for comparisons between communities, as users’ primary communities can vary from year to year. Overall, findings point to significant differences in participation patterns between groups: PUA users engaged less overall and showed lower levels of toxicity; MRA users engaged less than most other groups but had more highly upvoted content and moderate toxicity; Incel users have the most limited engagement in terms of longevity and breadth of participation, and also evince toxicity levels lower than would be expected based on community-level trends; and MGTOW and TRP show some of the most consistent levels of engagement and interaction among users while also demonstrating some of the highest levels of average toxicity.

Comparisons of means and percentages for relevant variables are presented in Figure 380. Posting Characteristics by Primary Community

Figure 381Figure 382. Posting Characteristics by Primary Community

Figure 383. Toxicity and Measures of Fit and Reception by Primary Community

Figure 384Figure 385Figure 386. Posting Characteristics by Primary Community

Figure 387Figure 388 and Figure 389. Toxicity and Measures of Fit and Reception by Primary Community

Figure 390Figure 391. Toxicity and Measures of Fit and Reception by Primary Community

Figure 392. Summary Stats for Participation and Comments, by Migration Status

Figure 393Figure 394. Toxicity and Measures of Fit and Reception by Primary Community

Figure 395Figure 396. The differences charted at statistically significant ($p < .01$) in most cases, with the exception of years active (no significant difference between TRP and MRA users), average toxicity (no significant difference between MGTOW and TRP users), and average comment score (no significant difference between TRP and Incel, PUA and Incel, and PUA and TRP users). Below, I summarize the most notable trends for each community; as with Chapter 5, I address communities in order of their chronological emergence and, correspondingly, in order of least to most toxic

Figure 380. Posting Characteristics by Primary Community

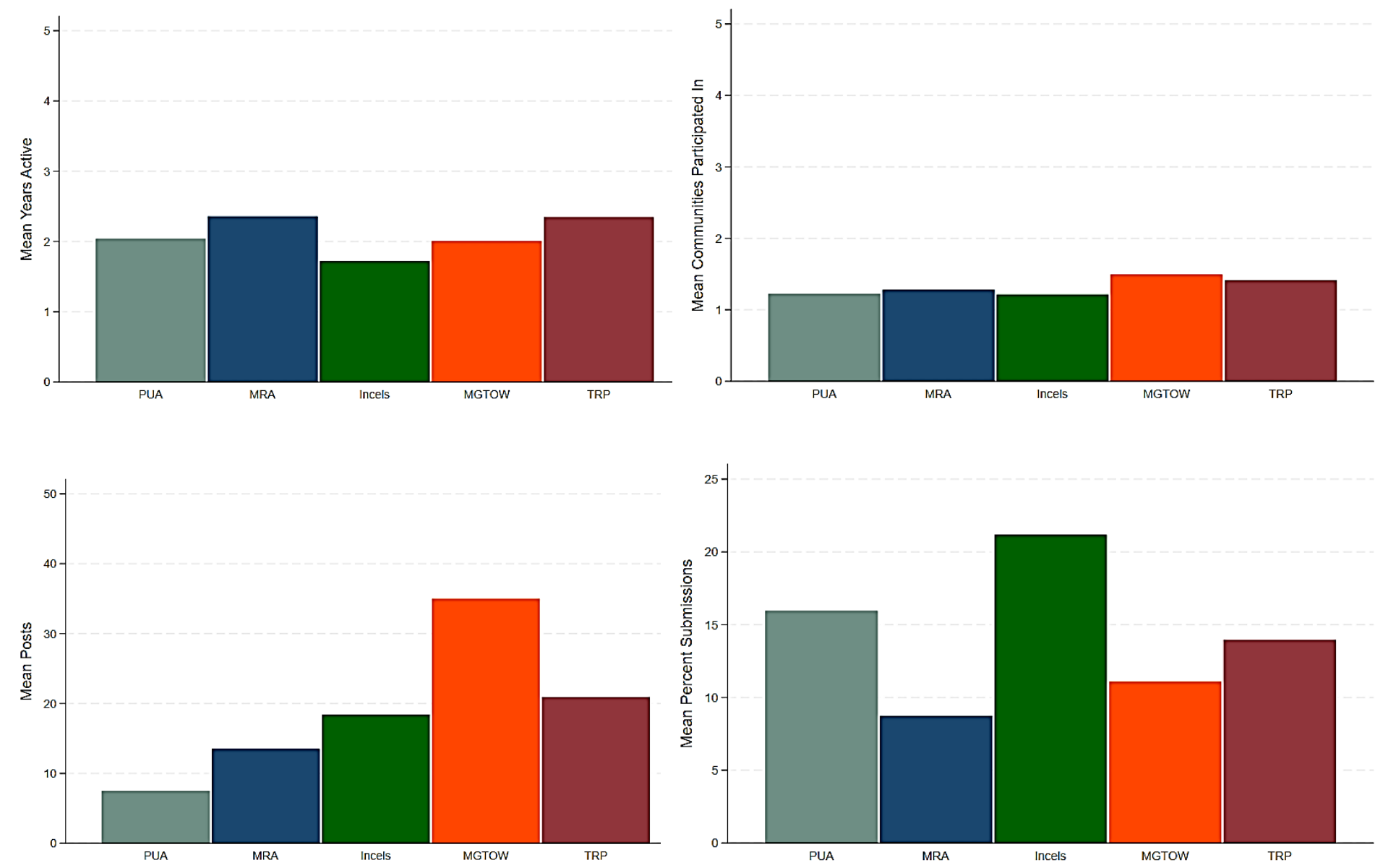
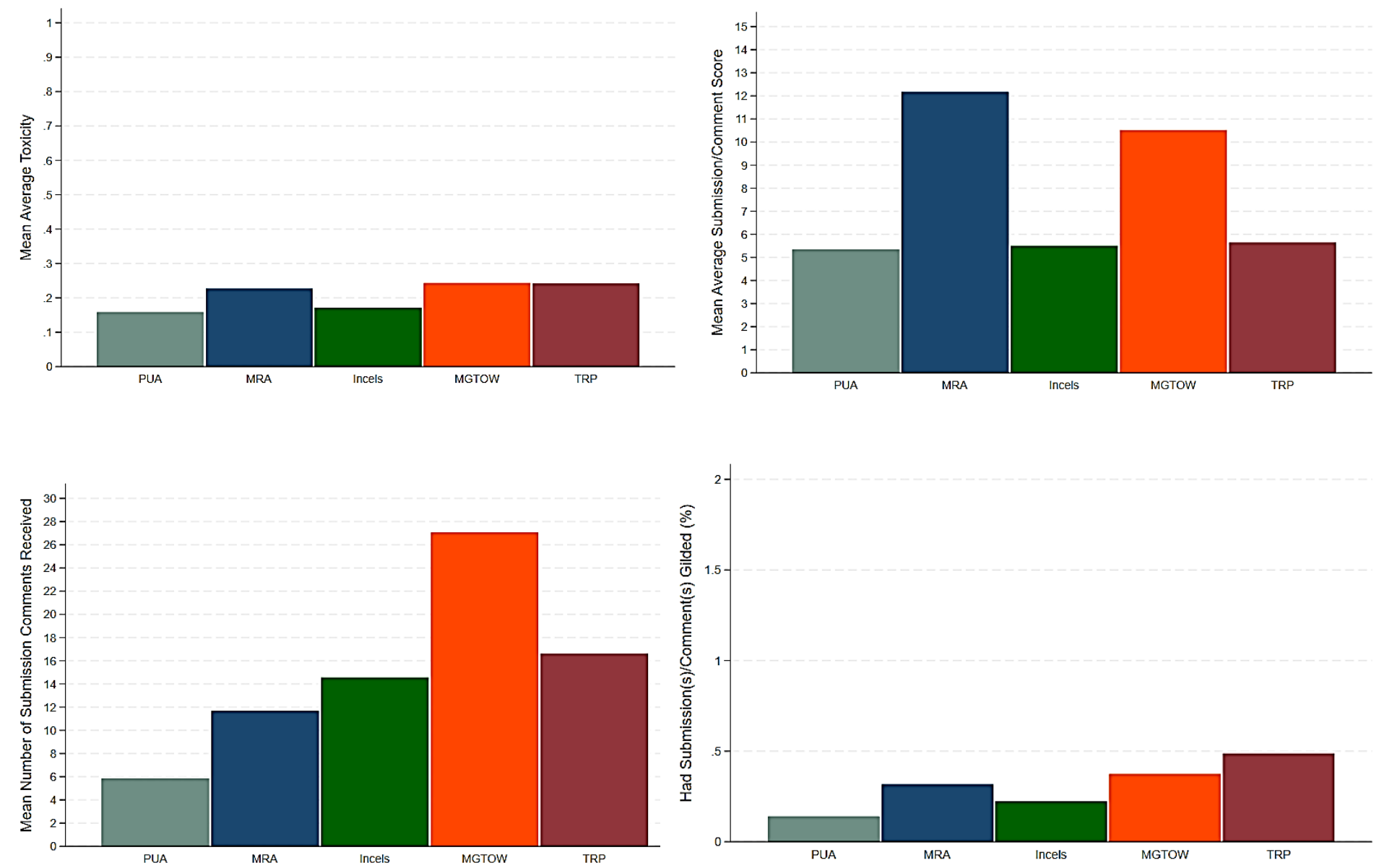


Figure 389. Toxicity and Measures of Fit and Reception by Primary Community



overall, though—as is discussed in the subsection on the MRA community—findings on user-level toxicity do not map neatly on to findings on community toxicity in all cases.

PUA. On average, users for whom PUA was the primary community in a given year had been active in the Reddit manosphere for just over two years; these users also participated in just over one community per year, on average. The mean number of yearly posts made by these users was 8 posts—the lowest of any of the five communities by a notable margin. The average mean score for these users was around 5 (again, taken as the average of users’ mean post scores), which is similar to users in Incel and TRP communities, but notably lower than those in the MRA and MGTOW community. These users also had the lowest average number of submission comments received by half (6 comments), despite having the second highest average percentage of posts that were submissions—16% on average. Finally, users had the lowest average toxicity of any community at just over .1, as well as the lowest percentage of users receiving a gilding in a given year.

These findings are in many ways congruent with both previous work and the community-level descriptive results presented in Chapter 5. Ribeiro et al. (2021) found that despite being one of the oldest communities in the manosphere, the PUA community saw less activity compared to other manosphere spaces, and these findings were corroborated by the Chapter 5 results; the user-level descriptives thus add further weight to the PUA community being the least active of the manosphere spaces, and lend preliminary support to the hypothesis that users in other communities will post at higher rates than those in the PUA community. That users within this community have the lowest average toxicity similarly affirms findings from the community-level toxicity analysis showing that PUA was less toxic, and supports prior research indicating that older manosphere communities evince less extremity and toxicity than their newer iterations (Farrell et al. 2019;

Ribeiro et al. 2021). At the same time, that users within this space had the second highest percentage of posts that were submissions while also receiving the fewest submission comments on average suggests that PUA users have a somewhat distinct pattern of engagement. This may be the result of the unique and somewhat narrower focus of the PUA community relative to other spaces within the Reddit manosphere; remember that PUAs are primarily focused on the application of sexual strategy to overcome potential disadvantages in the sexual marketplace. Previous research has indicated that a common practice within PUA spaces is the posting of ‘field reports’—personal accounts of success or failure in the application of the PUA techniques colloquially known as ‘game’ (Cousineau 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022). This may account for the comparatively high percentage of submissions relative to most other communities, while the combination of individual focus of PUA’s application of red pill ideology (Lilly 2016; Rothermel et al. 2022), and its comparatively smaller number of users, may similarly contribute to less overall interaction.

MRA. In reviewing trends for users for whom MRA was the primary community, a few notable observations emerge. These users had the second lowest mean number of yearly posts (12 posts), the lowest average percentage of posts that were submissions (8%), and the second lowest average number of comments received. The last of these findings may simply reflect the relatively low number of submissions; at the same time, MRA users also received the highest average comment scores at just over 12 points. The statistics regarding low engagement in terms of posting and low commenting somewhat align with previous critiques of the MRA community as less focused on any kind of sustained or engaged activism, and more focused on providing an affective function in the form of a place to share grievances or ‘evidence’ of male victimization at the hands of feminism (Gotell and Dutton 2016; Menzies 2007; Rothermel et al. 2022; Schmitz and Kazyak

2016); low engagement rates may then suggest that the MRA community operates primarily as a site wherein users can casually seek or provide support for their views, rather than engaging in the substantive development or discussion of a particular vein of red pill ideology. The comparatively high post scores relative to other communities, then, may similarly reflect a predisposition towards the lowest-effort activism; alternatively, or in addition, it is also possible that higher post scores amongst MRA users are reflective of a higher number of ‘lurkers’ within the community, who read and upvote content but do not otherwise engage. The nature of lurkers, however, makes this difficult to empirically investigate.

The MRA community also had the third highest level of average toxicity; this is somewhat surprising in that it does not quite align with the overall community-level toxicity rates discussed in Chapter 5, which showed the Incel community to be more toxic. Because community-level toxicity was assessed using the average toxicity score across all posts within a community, whereas users’ average toxicity reflects their within-posts average, it is possible this indicates that for users for whom MRA is the primary community, toxicity is moderate but consistent, while other communities may have a subset of users with extremely high toxicity rates that shape overall community trends. The brief overview of toxicity attributes and relevant example posts presented in Chapter 4 supports this notion, as the MRA community was less well-represented among the most toxic texts compared to some other communities.

*Incel*s. Several noteworthy trends emerge regarding users in the Incel community. First, their mean years active is the lowest of all five spaces under study; these users are also tied for the lowest average number of communities participated in. This suggests that within a broader context already defined by low engagement in terms of duration and breadth, the Incel community sees participation that is significantly lower still along both metrics. At the same time, users for whom

this is the primary community also have the third highest mean post rates, and the highest percentage of posts that are submissions at 21%—nearly five points higher than was seen within the PUA community. These findings are especially interesting given that the community-level analysis in Chapter 5 identified the Incel community as the most popular community within the manosphere—remember that at its peak in 2018, the community boasted more than 70,000 active users and 2.8 million posts made in a single year.

Taken together, descriptive findings paint a picture of users who enter the community, engage heavily (relative to many other communities), but then burn out on participation quickly. This is, potentially, a consequence of the unique fatalism associated with Incels’ ‘black pill’ variation of red pill ideology, which positions Incel men as not only excluded from sex and relationships due to feminist gains, but also as suffering from social exclusion more broadly. This sense of exclusion contributes to loneliness and frustration as key affective components of the Incel worldview (Baele et al. 2019; Hoffman et al. 2020; Maxwell et al. 2020; Rothermel et al. 2022); users within this community, then, may have a higher rate of posts that are submissions because they are more inclined to share personal accounts of how they have been affected by the perceived disadvantages facing Incel men, or because they are seeking a place to vent about personal issues they perceive as not understood by broader society. Their more limited tenure within the Incel community may at the same time be driven by a lack of support within this environment; previous research has identified that while Incels share a worldview and a set of grievances, there is also a degree of unexpected competition within the community, with users at times engaging in discursive work to distinguish ‘real’ Incels from those who are not, or suggesting that only people with specific physical deficiencies (for example being short or a racial minority) truly qualify as Incels (Gheorghe 2024; Halpin 2022; Jaki et al. 2019; James 2020).

Alternatively, it is possible that some of the less engaged users posting in the Incel community are not actually those who identify as Incels; the unique fatalism of the black pill, as well as the prominent instances of misogynist violence originating from the Incel community, mean the community has attracted greater attention from the media and the general public than other communities within the manosphere—enough so that media reporting has been criticized for incorrectly using the term ‘Incel’ when referring to men aligned with any of the secular male supremacist groups.³⁹ While a review of the low-level posters within the community confirms many are genuine, it is possible some proportion of activity within this community is driven by those who visited Incel spaces specifically to argue *against* the black pill worldview, though it should also be noted here also that many Incel spaces specifically moderate out users and comments attempting this (Gillett and Suzor 2022). Future research attempting to distinguish those earnestly embracing the Incel worldview from those who are not may be helpful in teasing out the nuances of these descriptive findings.

Also interesting, again, is Incels’ position for average toxicity, where users are identified as the second least-toxic, on average, despite the community having the third-highest rates of toxicity. As discussed in the MRA section, this suggests that the Incel community’s overall toxicity rates were inflated some by a subset of highly toxic users; the degree of toxicity, and its at times violent messaging, has contributed to the banning of a higher number of Incel subreddits than seen in other communities (Binder 2019; Gillett and Suzor 2022; Hauser 2017), which may additionally explain the comparatively short tenure within this community despite its apparent popularity.

³⁹ <https://www.theirms.org/forjournalists>

MGTOW. Users for whom the MGTOW community was their primary community in a given year stand out in several ways. They have a notably higher mean rate of yearly posts at 34, and also have the second highest average post scores at nearly double that of the PUA, Incel, and TRP communities. Users in the MGTOW community also received the highest average numbers of submission comments at 27, which is nearly ten more comments on average than the next highest community, TRP. MGTOW also ties for the highest average toxicity among users, and had more users who had posts gilded than most other communities.

Taken together, these findings suggest that users for whom MGTOW is the primary community are overall highly engaged in the interactive sense—upvoting and replying to other users’ contributions, and contributing a moderate number of submissions as well as comments. These findings align neatly with previous work on MGTOWs, which has noted the tension that can emerge when attempting to create a shared identity based on *not* engaging in a particular behavior—in their case, not engaging in relationships with women (Jones et al. 2020). Research has also found that MGTOW men combat this through both the production of passive harassment in the form of performing misogynist speech on digital platforms, and working to discursively define and theorize the MGTOW application of red pill ideology (Jones et al. 2020; Wright et al. 2020). The moderately high degree of interaction identified in the MGTOW community, then, is likely driven by the combination of MGTOW men’s commitment to homosociality and their need to ‘perform’ their antifeminism and misogyny in order to cultivate and affirm their MGTOW identity. The latter of these considerations is also likely the driver of MGTOW users’ high levels of average toxicity as well.

TRP. Users primarily engaging in the TRP community show the second highest rates for average yearly posts made (21 posts) and the average number of comments received (at 17

submission comments received, on average); this community is also third in terms of the percentage of users' posts that are submissions, with 14% of users' posts being submissions on average. Aligning with the community-level trends identified in Chapter 5, which identified TRP as the most toxic community within the Reddit manosphere, users within this community also show some of the highest rates of average toxicity (tied with MGTOW). TRP users also had the highest percentage of users who had a post gilded in any given year, though this figure is still substantively quite small at half a percent.

These findings suggest that the TRP community is more interactive than many other communities, though not quite to the same degree as MGTOW. This higher degree of interactivity is likely the product of a confluence of factors—TRP was identified in Chapter 5 as the second most popular community within the Reddit manosphere; it is widely focused on red pill ideology and thus draws on topics also addressed by a number of other manosphere communities (Mountford 2018; Ribeiro et al. 2021; Rothermel et al. 2022); it, like the PUA community, encourages the posting of 'field reports' where users describe instances of their applications of red pill 'theory' (Mountford 2018; Van Valkenburgh 2018); and it has been shown, at times, to be a site for organizing support for far-right political agendas (Dignam and Rohlinger 2019). This breadth of focus is likely both an explanatory feature of TRPs popularity, and a feature that operates alongside that popularity to keep users more engaged within the space—note that users here also have the highest average tenure of any manosphere community at just over two years.

RESULTS: PREDICTING USER ENGAGEMENT

Results from fixed-effects negative binomial regression models predicting user posting rates are presented in Table 14. Model 1 incorporates user characteristics, with Model 2 adding additional measures of fit and reception; Model 3 then incorporates measures of manosphere context, including repression events, and Model 4 assesses interactions between user toxicity and

Table 14. Results from Fixed-Effects Negative Binomial Regression on Post Rates

	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3		Model 4	
	IRR	(SE)	IRR	(SE)	IRR	(SE)	IRR	(SE)
<i>User Characteristics</i>								
Manosphere tenure	0.87706*	(0.00093)	0.87628*	(0.00093)	0.88273*	(0.00110)	0.88213*	(0.00110)
Primary community								
PUA (Reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
MRA	0.94511*	(0.00699)	1.00021	(0.00747)	0.99631	(0.00745)	0.99695	(0.00746)
Incels	0.96152*	(0.00861)	0.96869*	(0.00874)	0.96907*	(0.00878)	0.96867*	(0.00878)
MGTOV	0.97309	(0.00970)	0.99499	(0.00997)	0.99040	(0.01015)	0.99392	(0.01019)
TRP	0.89470*	(0.00688)	0.91202*	(0.00705)	0.90671*	(0.00710)	0.90746*	(0.00710)
No primary	0.02071*	(0.00031)	0.01833*	(0.00027)	0.01852*	(0.00028)	0.01861*	(0.00028)
Post count (lagged)	0.99982*	(0.00001)	0.99979*	(0.00001)	0.99980*	(0.00001)	0.99980*	(0.00001)
Average toxicity (lagged)	1.00890*	(0.00099)	0.99664*	(0.00099)	0.99711	(0.00099)	1.01000*	(0.00140)
Percent submissions (lagged)	--	--	1.00017	(0.00012)	1.00018	(0.00012)	1.00018	(0.00012)
<i>Measures of Reception and Fit</i>								
Average post score (lagged)	--	--	1.00004	(0.00006)	1.00007	(0.00006)	1.00007	(0.00006)
Submission comments received (lagged)	--	--	0.99996	(0.00001)	0.99996 ⁺	(0.00001)	0.99996 ⁺	(0.00001)
Received gilding (lagged)	--	--	0.98061	(0.02022)	0.98498	(0.02027)	0.98298	(0.02022)
Post removal (lagged)	--	--	0.95360*	(0.00396)	0.95590*	(0.00396)	0.95768*	(0.00397)
<i>Manosphere Characteristics</i>								
Number of users	--	--	--	--	1.00000*	(0.00000)	1.00000*	(0.00000)
Average toxicity	--	--	--	--	1.01002*	(0.00077)	1.00991*	(0.00077)
Toxicity spread	--	--	--	--	0.85324*	(0.00719)	0.85549*	(0.00721)
Bans implemented (lagged)	--	--	--	--	0.94141*	(0.00236)	0.96472*	(0.00299)
Quarantines implemented (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.00613	(0.00310)	1.00321	(0.00401)
User toxicity x bans	--	--	--	--	--	--	0.98626*	(0.00103)
User toxicity x quarantines	--	--	--	--	--	--	1.00093	(0.00135)
Constant	1.06615*	(0.00666)	2.03635*	(0.01689)	2.12821*	(0.02854)	2.06828*	(0.02811)
Observations	471,794		471,794		471,794		471,794	
Number of Users	133,394		133,394		133,394		133,394	

* p = .000, + p = .001

platform-level repression. The identified strength and direction of relationships varies little across models; as such, the discussion and interpretation addresses the final model only. For ease of interpretation, results are presented here as incident-rate ratios (IRRs) reflecting exponentiated coefficients, rather than as the impact on the log of the expected post count; individual IRRs can then be interpreted as either the factor increase/decrease in posting rates accompanying a one-unit change in the predictor, or as a percent increase/reduction in post rates (calculated as $[100(\beta-1)]$). Overall, findings highlight the importance of group identity in predicting rates of engagement within manosphere communities, though these relationships do not operate in expected directions; within the subset of users present for three years or more, post rates are significantly lower for users within the Incel and TRP communities compared to the oldest and least toxic community, PUA. Findings also point to the importance of tenure, community toxicity and repression events in predicting rates of engagement within secular male supremacist communities on Reddit, with all having a negative impact on users' post rates. Finally, results show interesting effects between user toxicity and repression, with toxicity appearing to slightly but significantly moderate the negative relationship between bans and engagement.

User Characteristics

Results for user characteristics show a few trends of note. First and foremost, years active within the broader Reddit manosphere shows a moderate negative relationship with rates of engagement, counter to what was predicted in Hypothesis 5; for every one-year increase in users' tenure, posting rates are expected to decrease by around 12%. This is in contrast to previous findings indicating that tenure within online communities positively drives engagement (Hamilton et al. 2017; Sadeque and Bethard 2019), suggesting that compared to other types of online spaces, there may be something novel about either extremist communities, or the Reddit manosphere

specifically, that contributes to decreasing engagement over time. There are a couple possibilities regarding what underlying processes might be at play. On the one hand, it is possible that most users' short tenure within the Reddit manosphere reflects a general tendency for users within these spaces to engage less and less over time until they cease participation entirely, and that for some users this process moves more slowly. On the other hand, to preview findings from Chapter 8, results analyzing the odds of disengagement show that tenure decreases the odds of users leaving these spaces entirely; this suggests that the predicted decline in post rates over time is driven by a process other than a general tendency for users to slowly fade out of communities.

It is likely, then, that the negative relationship between tenure and rates of engagement is capturing something truly relevant to radicalization into secular male supremacism. As discussed in Chapter 3, models of radicalization highlight that early in this process, openness to extreme beliefs pairs with either social ties or a 'seeker mentality' to expose individuals to extreme ideologies, and that users become radicalized as movement frames align with their own views regarding social injustices, and/or as they develop a sense of belonging within a movement (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; Vergani et al. 2020). One possibility, then, is that the early stages of radicalization into secular male supremacism are accompanied by a discovery process that drives greater interaction—users may be eager to connect with other movement members through posting, or to explore new ideologies by asking questions or sharing their own interpretations of movement messages. Over time, this effect may 'cool' as users become acclimated within an extremist community, and engagement may lessen. This possibility could be examined in future research by examining if and how the content of users' posts changes across their tenure within these communities.

In terms of the role of primary communities in predicting engagement rates, findings similarly run contrary to the expectations stated in Hypothesis 1, which predicted that users in communities other than the PUA community would have higher posting rates. Results indicate no significant difference between those who have PUA, MRA, or MGTOW as a primary community. Further, and again counter to expectations, users in the Incel and TRP communities are actually shown to have post rates that are 3% and 9% *lower* than for PUA users. Having no primary community is similarly significantly associated with lower post rates, and by a wide margin—98%. The effect for primary community intuitively makes sense, as these users are those for whom participation was evenly split between at least two communities, which is a more likely occurrence for users who make only a very small number of posts. The findings regarding significant differences between PUA, Incel, and TRP users, however, are less intuitive—descriptive results analyzing mean post rates for all users in these primary communities showed significantly *higher* post rates for those in the Incel and TRP communities, while PUA posters had the lowest average post rates. The notable difference between the descriptive findings and the regression results likely lies in their employment of very different samples—the analysis of average post rates incorporated all users present in the data, while the regression focuses specifically on longer-term users who were active for at least three years. This would also explain the lack of support for the hypothesis that PUA users would have the lowest post rates, as this expectation was based on research similarly analyzing which communities had the highest rates of engagement overall (Ribeiro et al. 2021)—research that was corroborated by the community-level analysis in Chapter 5.

What, then, might explain the patterns of difference identified among the subset of longer-term users within the PUA, Incel, and TRP communities? In considering the identified relationships, it is noticeable that the patterns for predicted engagement rates align fairly well with

the age of the respective communities: PUA and MRA are the oldest communities within the Reddit manosphere, both emerging in 2008, and no significant differences were identified between users within these two primary communities.⁴⁰ Rates of posting within the Incel community, in contrast, are predicted to be lower than those in PUA, but by a lesser degree than the predicted difference between PUA and TRP posters. This suggests that, at least among the longer-standing users present in the analysis, rates of engagement are higher within better-established communities. The MGTOW community is an exception to this pattern in that predicted engagement rates for users in this community do not significantly differ from those in the PUA community, but the MGTOW community is also subject to two unique contextual factors that could explain this lack of difference: its origins as an offshoot of the MRA community (Rothermel et al. 2022), which emerged on Reddit at the same time as the PUA community, and the previously discussed necessity of discursive engagement in order to perform group identity (Jones et al. 2020; Lin 2017).

The remaining user characteristics included in the analysis appear to have little effect on engagement, again going against the expectations outlined in Hypotheses 4 and 6. While the effect of prior year posting patterns is significant, the effect size is very close to zero; this is similarly true for the effect of users' average toxicity. As with the unexpected effect of tenure, these findings likely reflect that online extremist spaces are distinct from other types of online communities. In considering the negligible impact of toxicity, this suggests that the suppressing effect of negativity is potentially salient in more recreational online communities, and less so in extremist spaces,

⁴⁰ As noted in Chapter 5, ranking communities in order of age is also equivalent to ranking them in terms of toxicity. As such, it might initially be suspected that overall toxicity is what drives engagement; as is discussed in the section on measures of manosphere context, however, toxicity does not appear to significantly decrease rates of engagement.

either generally or in the context of spaces like the Reddit manosphere, which already evince measurably high levels of toxicity at times. Given that toxicity is used as a proxy for extremism, and these communities are of interest precisely because they are virulently misogynistic, negativity may have no effect because toxicity is an expected feature of these spaces.

The lack of effect for prior posting rates are also interesting, particularly because the expectation that prior participation would predict current engagement was shaped not only by literature on online engagement more generally (Mahmud et al. 2014; Sadeque and Bethard 2019), but also prior work on Twitter activism during Occupy Wall Street (Chen and Pirolli 2021). As with the unexpected effect of tenure, these findings likely again indicate that online extremist spaces are distinct from other types of online communities, including those oriented around engagement with non-extremist movements. This is likely the result of differing motivations for engagement: participation in extremist movements has been identified as motivated by unique features of individuals' ideological backgrounds, psychological characteristics, or desires to achieve a sense of belonging (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018; Vergani et al. 2020). While individual factors such as personal background, values, or biographical availability also shape engagement in non-extremist activism (Barkan et al. 1995; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019; Saunders et al. 2012; Yu and Zhao 2006), the specific background characteristics or ideological motivations are likely to differ, as motives for engagement in far-right extremism are frequently rooted in a sense of threat to, or victimization of, dominant social groups (Berbrier 2000; Gray 2018). Engagement in online communities generally, in contrast, may sometimes result from a desire for a sense of community or belonging (Lampe et al. 2010), but is often driven primarily by recreational motives (Khan 2017). As such, the insubstantial effect of post counts or toxicity likely indicate support for the premise that radicalization processes are not necessarily fundamentally

altered online, but that they instead are reproduced or eased within the online context (Caren et al. 2012; Daniels 2018; Winter et al. 2020); the lack of effects then also serve as evidence that the processes driving online engagement, either in non-extremist movements or for more general recreational purposes, do not operate the same in the context of radicalization into far-right extremism.

Measures of Fit and Reception

The notion that the processes at play in online extremist communities are distinct from those at play within more recreational online spaces is further supported by results regarding the impact of measures of fit and reception, which are fairly minimal. Average post scores, submission comments received, and the receipt of gildings are identified in the analysis as either insignificant, or as having no substantive effect once incident-rate ratios have been rounded. These findings are again contrary to expectations—Hypotheses 7a through 7c predicted a positive relationship between these characteristics and rates of engagement, again based on previous literatures which suggested that receiving interaction or incentives motivated greater engagement in online communities (Claussen et al. 2013; Khan 2017). This again suggests the unique context of the Reddit manosphere, relative to other non-extremist online communities, leads to differences in the factors predicting rates of engagement.

At the same time, post removals are confirmed to have a small negative effect, with predicted post rates decreasing by around 4% for users who had a post removed. While a sense of fit or belonging has been identified as motivating participation in extremist movements (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; Vergani et al. 2020), research has highlighted its importance specifically in motivating engagement, rather than in shaping differential participation through *degrees* of engagement. Findings here, then, suggest that the processes driving radicalization in the form of

differential participation (specifically as higher degrees of engagement) are not altered by most factors shaping differences in online engagement more generally, but are instead likely still impacted more by individual sociobiographical factors that shape differential participation in terms of degrees of engagement, such as biographical availability, preexisting values, or social networks (Barkan et al. 1995; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019; Passy and Giugni 2001; Yu and Zhao 2006). At the same time, the effect of post removals indicates that measures negatively impacting a sense of fit, or that could be perceived as individual-level repression, do have a discouraging impact.

Manosphere Characteristics

The third set of variables included in the analysis assesses how the landscape of the broader Reddit manosphere impacts users' rates of engagement. Results show that the number of users, overall toxicity, or number of quarantines implemented have little impact on users' rates of engagement, contrary to what was predicted (see Hypotheses 2, 3a, and 8a). Hypothesis 2 was informed by prior research showing that far-right organizations' Facebook pages generated more content as user participation increased—i.e., increased engagement encouraged an increased proliferation of extremist content (Davidson 2024)—while Hypothesis 3a predicting a positive effect for toxicity was informed by previous findings that negativity within political figures' posts on Facebook increased engagement with content. The null findings regarding the number of active users and manosphere toxicity here, then, suggests that this same feedback effect does not necessarily occur in spaces that are absent the distinct content creator-audience dynamic present on Facebook pages. The implementation of quarantines similarly shows no effect on rates of engagement; this is despite the fact that previous work has identified that quarantines do reduce participation (Copland 2020).

In contrast, toxicity spread and the implementation of bans both show a significant negative effect on posting rates, lending support to Hypotheses 3b and 8b. For every .1 increase in the difference between the least and most toxic community within the Reddit manosphere, post rates are expected to decrease by 14%. This supports the notion that because group identity shapes posting rates, greater homogeneity among Reddit manosphere groups spurs greater participation; it also aligns with previous research indicating that increasing heterogeneity can drive disengagement from extremist movements (Fillieule 2012), and expands on these findings by linking group homogeneity/heterogeneity to differential participation in terms of degrees of engagement, rather than merely to continued or discontinued participation. In terms of the impact of community bans, findings show that for each additional ban implemented within the Reddit manosphere in the previous year, post rates are shown to significantly decrease by 4%; this not only supports the initial prediction that bans would have a negative impact on posting behavior, but provides additional confirming evidence that, as found in previous work, bans in general do have some degree of efficacy in curbing engagement in extremist online spaces (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017). At the theoretical level, knowing that bans decrease engagement is useful, as the influence of repression on differential participation in terms of degrees of engagement is relatively under-addressed; findings here, then, indicate that repressive efforts do have an attenuating effect on engagement in online extremist spaces (though, as is discussed in later chapters, the relationship between repression and curbing engagement within the Reddit manosphere is not necessarily as clean cut and straightforward in all cases.) At the practical level, this finding also has salient implications: bans are one of the primary mechanisms through which Reddit as a site has attempted to curb the proliferation of unsavory content, and empirical evidence of their effectiveness is

helpful in deepening understandings of how to best intervene in extremist content on digital platforms.

Interactions between User Toxicity and Repression

Finally, results assessing the interaction between user-level toxicity and repression measures do show a small but significant moderating effect, with the discouraging effect of bans weakening as user toxicity increases. The predicted impact on the relationship is highlighted in Quarantines show no significant interaction with users' degree of toxicity. Overall, this lends support to Hypothesis 8d, but not hypothesis 8c, and aligns with findings that repression may have uneven effects on radicalization, impacting more moderate members of extremist movements more effectively than those who already evince a higher degree of extremism (della Porta 2018), though in terms of the impact on differential participation, these differences are small.

CONCLUSION

A summary of the relationships impacting users' rates of engagement within the Reddit manosphere are summarized in Table 15; overall, the analysis yields findings both surprising and useful. On the one hand, the characteristics of, and reception to, users' posts has a great deal less impact on overall engagement rates than was initially expected—prior year post counts, average toxicity, average post score, and submission comments received show no real impact on engagement. These findings highlight and reinforce previous claims that online radicalization processes are not fundamentally different from those occurring offline (Caren et al. 2012; Daniels 2018; Winter et al. 2020), providing evidence that online engagement in far-right extremist spaces is driven by processes that are distinct from those driving online engagement in other types of online communities. On the other hand, findings also highlight the significance of group identity and community context in shaping users' patterns of engagement. Users active in different primary

Table 15. Summary of Findings from Analysis Modeling Engagement Rates

Key Predictors	Expected Relationship to Engagement	Hypothesis	Identified Relationship	Result
<i>User-Level Variables</i>				
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>				
Primary Community				
PUA	Reference	H ₁	Reference	--
MRA	Positive	H ₁	Insignificant	Not supported
Incel	Positive	H ₁	Negative	Not supported
MGTOW	Positive	H ₁	Insignificant	Not supported
TRP	Positive	H ₁	Negative	Not supported
Tenure	Positive	H ₅	Negative	Not supported
Number of posts	Positive	H ₄	No effect	Not supported
Average toxicity	Negative	H ₆	No effect	Not supported
<i>Measures of Fit & Reception</i>				
Average post score	Positive	H _{7a}	No effect	Not supported
Comments received	Positive	H _{7b}	No effect	Not supported
Gildings received	Positive	H _{7c}	Insignificant	Not supported
Post removals	Negative	H _{7d}	Negative	Supported
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>				
<i>Context Characteristics</i>				
Number of active users	Positive	H ₂	No effect	Not supported
Average toxicity	Positive	H _{3a}	No effect	Not supported
Toxicity spread	Negative	H _{3b}	Negative	Supported
<i>Repression Measures</i>				
Quarantines implemented	Negative	H _{8a}	No effect	Not supported
Bans implemented	Negative	H _{8b}	Negative	Supported
User toxicity x quarantines	Negative	H _{8c}	No effect	Not supported
User toxicity x bans	Negative	H _{8d}	Negative	Supported

communities show different rates of posting activity, with those in more well-established communities engaging at higher rates; post rates are also positively impacted by greater homogeneity within the Reddit manosphere, suggesting that not only group identity, but also the relationships between these groups, shapes users' engagement in these spaces.

Finally, repression within the Reddit manosphere appear to impact these rates as well. In particular, that ban implementations have a negative impact on user engagement has positive implications for platform-level efforts to reduce engagement with extremist ideologies, as it indicates that banning individual subreddits. At the same time, the lack of effect for quarantines suggests that half-measures are less effective in suppressing rates of secular male supremacist activity on the site, and the interaction with user toxicity indicates that the efficacy of bans may be somewhat uneven. I return to these findings, and their broader contributions to both theoretical and practical concerns, in the concluding chapter.

CHAPTER 7: MODELING USER MIGRATION ACROSS THE MANOSPHERE

In Chapter 6, I presented results from analysis predicting differential participation in the form of degree of engagement. In this chapter, I shift focus to another potentially significant aspect of online radicalization processes—migration into new, and especially more toxic, communities. Based on previous descriptive findings indicating a relatively low level of engagement for most users, I also choose here to focus analysis on a subset of highly-engaged users within the Reddit manosphere. To begin, I briefly review the relevant hypotheses, methods used, and sample details; then, I present results summarizing differences between migrating and non-migrating users. Finally, I present results from an event history analysis modeling time to migration into a new community, utilizing a competing risks framework to account for migration into either more or less extreme spaces; here, I also connect findings back to the hypotheses and literatures outlined in Chapter 3. Overall, findings again show that group identity is one of the most salient factors predicting radicalization related outcomes, with certain spaces showing higher odds of migration into new communities; toxicity is also implicated as a significant factor in driving users to more extreme spaces. In the context of trajectories across spaces, findings from previous work on processes of online engagement in the context of migration are also more heavily supported than in the analysis focusing on engagement rates, suggesting that online radicalization processes are, to a certain degree, subject to the same push and pull factors that drive migration across online communities more generally. Finally, repression is again shown to have significant effects, operating to bifurcate users, radicalizing some while sending others to more moderate spaces; this relationship is once again identified as being moderated by toxicity, with the effect for migration into more extreme communities being stronger for users who are more toxic, further supporting previous work suggesting that repression efforts are at greater odds of further radicalizing individuals who are already more extreme.

ANALYSIS

A summary of the specific variables related to posting behaviors, fit and reception, and community context included in this portion of the analysis are reviewed in Table 16. Overall, most user characteristics are expected to have a negative impact on migration to either any new community, or to more toxic communities specifically; only having an older, less toxic community as a primary community, or having higher average toxicity, are expected to positively predict migration for this set of variables. Measures of fit and reception, when positive in the form of higher average scores, comments received, or gildings, are expected to have a negative relationship to migration as they encourage a sense of belonging for users within communities; only controversiality or sanctions in the form of post removals are expected to drive migration, with the latter expected to encourage migration to more toxic communities specifically. Context within primary communities—particularly increased activity or user base—is expected to contribute to lower odds of migration in any direction, while community-level repression events in the form of quarantines or bans are expected to drive migration to more toxic spaces, with the relationship moderated by user toxicity.

Chapter 4 details the specific data preparation and analytic procedures employed in the analysis. To summarize, I employ discrete-time event history analysis with a competing risks framework to model migration to more or less toxic communities. In addition to the variables summarized in Table 16, the percentage of users' posts that were submissions is again also included as a control due to the measure of comments received reflecting submission comments specifically. Additionally, in this stage of the analysis user tenure is constructed as a series of dichotomous indicators—a commonly used approach in event history analysis, because it allows the effect of time to vary across periods (Allison 1982; Singer and Willett 1993; Willett and Singer 1995). Tenure is also collapsed so that users present for ten years or more are aggregated, in order to

Table 16. Review of Key Variables Expected to Drive Migration

Key Predictors	Expected Relationship to Migration		Hypothesis
	Any Direction	More Toxic	
<i>User-Level Variables</i>			
<i>User Characteristics</i>			
Primary Community			
PUA	--	Positive	H ₁₉
MRA	--	Positive	H ₁₉
Incel	--	Negative	H ₁₉
MGTOW	--	Negative	H ₁₉
TRP	--	Negative	H ₁₉
Tenure	Negative	--	H ₁₈
Number of posts	Negative	--	H ₁₆
Posting frequency	Negative	--	H ₁₇
Average toxicity	--	Positive	H _{15a}
Toxicity alignment	Negative	--	H _{15b}
<i>Measures of Fit & Reception</i>			
Average post score	Negative	--	H ₁₁
Comments received	Negative	--	H ₁₃
Gildings received	Negative	--	H ₁₄
Controversiality	Positive	--	H ₁₂
<i>Repression Measures</i>			
Post removal	--	Positive	H ₉
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>			
<i>Context Characteristics</i>			
Number of active users	Negative	--	H ₂₀
Activity level	Negative	--	H ₂₁
<i>Repression Measures</i>			
Quarantines implemented	--	Positive	H _{10a}
Bans implemented	--	Positive	H _{10b}

ensure an adequate number of migration events in all periods. Covariates besides tenure are assumed to have a consistent effect across years. Models again proceed in four stages, with Model 1 incorporating user characteristics, Model 2 adding in measures of fit and reception, Model 3 incorporating measures of context for users' primary communities, including community-level repression measures, and Model 4 examining interactions between user toxicity and repression efforts. Pseudo-log likelihoods again show improved model fit with the addition of each subsequent set of variables. As discussed in detail in Chapter 4, the models here also focus on a subset of highly-active users—i.e., users who posted at or above the mean rate of 16 posts per year—in order to center users for whom migration could be seen as reflecting a substantive participatory shift. Altogether, this yields an analytic sample of 53,208 users and 107,295 user-years.

DESCRIPTIVE RESULTS FOR USER MIGRATION

Table 17 summarizes migration patterns for the subset of users included in this section of the analysis. Results show that even among highly-engaged users present for at least two years, migration is relatively rare—only 28% of users migrated during their tenure within the Reddit manosphere, and of those users who did migrate, a majority—76%—did so only once.

Table 17. Summary of Migration Patterns

	Count	Percent	Cum. Percent
Migrated			
Yes	10,898	27.99	27.99
No	42,458	72.01	100.00
Total Migrations for Migrating Users			
1	4,584	75.94	75.94
2	1,051	17.41	93.36
3	275	4.56	97.91
4	97	1.61	99.52
5	23	0.38	99.90
6	5	0.08	99.98
7	1	0.02	100.00

N = 53,356

Figure 397. Summary Stats for Participation and Comments, by Migration Status

Figure 398. Summary Stats for Participation and Comments, by Migration Status

Figure 399. Summary Stats for Participation and Comments, by Migration Status

Figure 400 through Figure 413 present means and percentages for user-level predictor variables included in the analysis, broken out by migration status. With the exception of average post scores, all differences presented were identified as statistically significant ($p < .01$) when conducting means/proportion testing. Results show several interesting differences. First, migrating users were, on average, active for nearly a year longer than their non-migrant counterparts. This finding is interesting given that tenure overall is expected to decrease the odds of migration—it suggests either that tenure operates differently than anticipated, or that users who migrate to new communities are subsequently motivated to engage for longer, perhaps because migration helps users transition to communities that are a better fit.

In contrast to the descriptive findings on longevity, non-migrating users had slightly higher yearly average post rates, though rates for both groups of users are relatively high—around 98 yearly posts for non-migrants, and 91 posts for migrants. Given that this sample excludes users posting at or below the mean rate of 15 posts per year, these inflated post counts are not necessarily unexpected. That rates are higher for non-migrants lends preliminary support to Hypothesis 16, predicting that users who engage more in their communities are less likely to migrate to new spaces.

Differences in toxicity also emerge, with non-migrating users showing slightly lower average toxicity rates; this again aligns with predictions that greater toxicity will increase the odds of migration, either because more toxic users will be pushed out of more moderate communities due to the greater extremity of their views, or because more toxic users are more likely to be pulled to more toxic spaces that better align with their preexisting dispositions. The fact that non-migrant users also have slightly lower levels of toxicity alignment with their primary communities suggests that the apparent relationship between toxicity and migration is more likely the result of the latter ‘pull’ factors, rather than users being pushed out of community due to any ideological differences that might be captured through toxicity alignment. Non-migrant users also had a higher percentage of posts that were original submissions rather than comments on other users’ contributions—around 6% compared to just under 5% for non-migrant users. This may in part be an artifact of their slightly higher rates of engagement within their primary communities overall.

In terms of receptions to contributions, non-migrant users also received higher rates of submission comments, garnering an average of 70 comments compared to non-migrants’ average of 60 comments received. While this may in part be the result of the slightly higher submission rates, this group does also appear to fare better in terms of reception in general; a slightly higher percentage of non-migrants—about 1.7% compared to 1.4%—had a post gilded in any given year. Fewer of these users had posts marked controversial as well, which suggests more alignment in how other users’ ranked their contributions. (Remember that controversiality is the result of receiving a relatively equal ratio of upvotes to downvotes from other users). This appears true even despite the slightly lower toxicity alignment scores for this group. Overall, this does suggest that a stronger sense of fit may serve to anchor users within primary communities, reducing their likelihood of being pushed or pulled towards new or more extreme spaces. The only exception to

these differences in reception is in regard to post removals; non-migrants experienced higher rates of post removal than migrant users, with 79% of non-migrating users having a post removed in a given year, compared to 76% of migrating users. This relatively small difference may be the result of non-migrating users' higher rates of posting, and of posting submissions specifically; intuitively, the more users post, the greater their chances are of having a post removed. Alternatively, it is possible that the slightly higher rates of post removal capture a response to the slightly lower

Figure 397. Summary Stats for Participation and Comments, by Migration Status

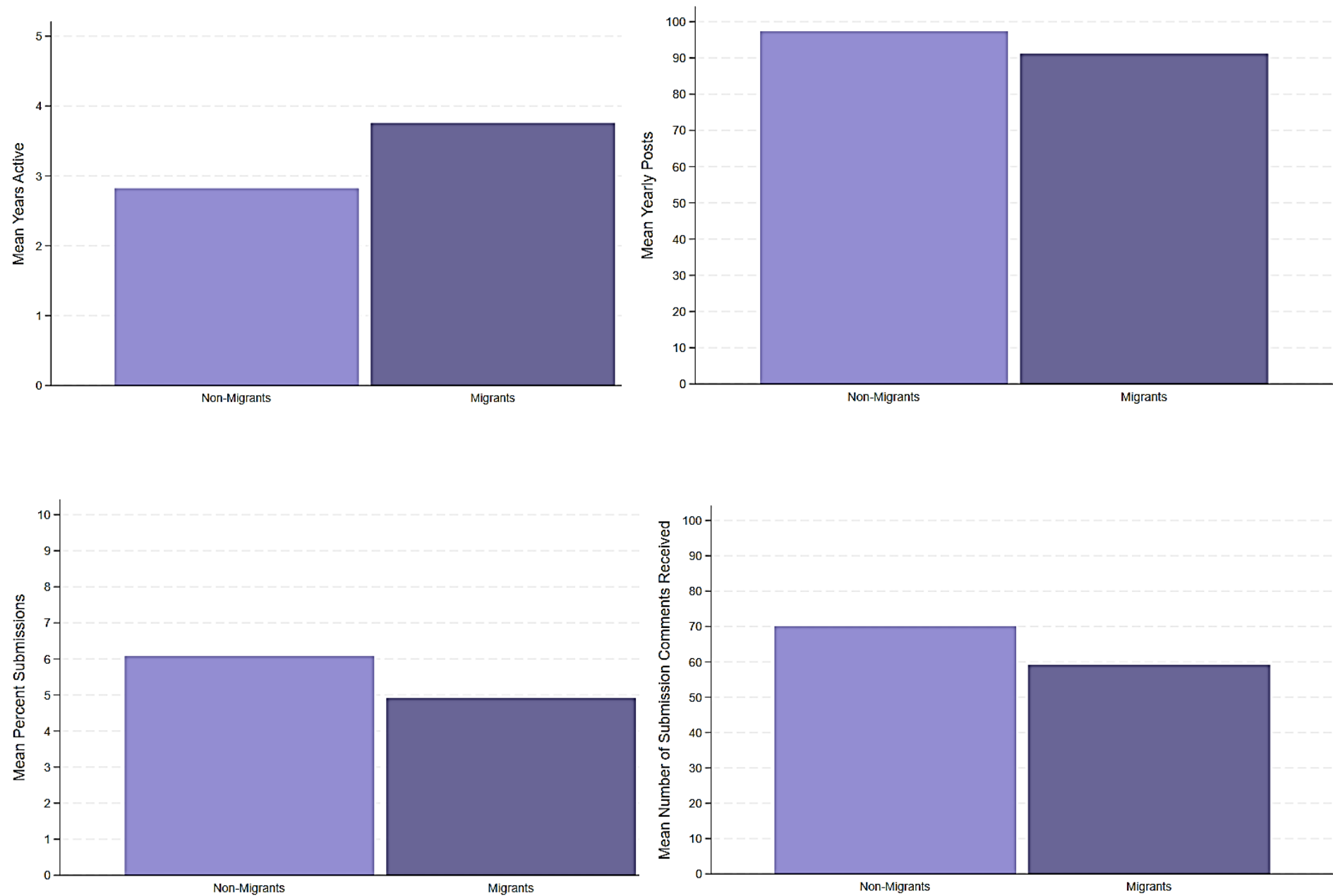


Figure 406. Summary Stats for Reception, by Migration Status

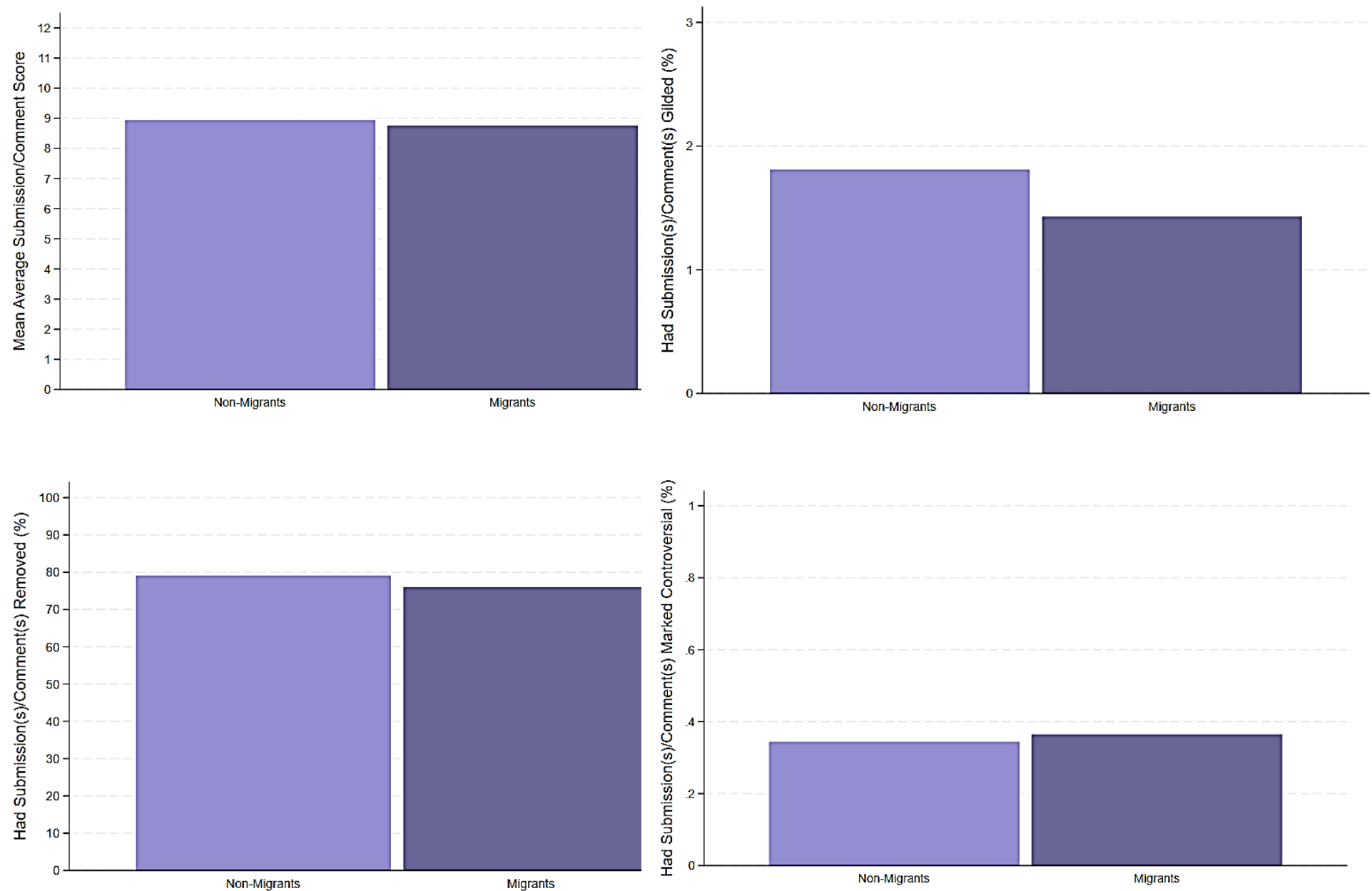
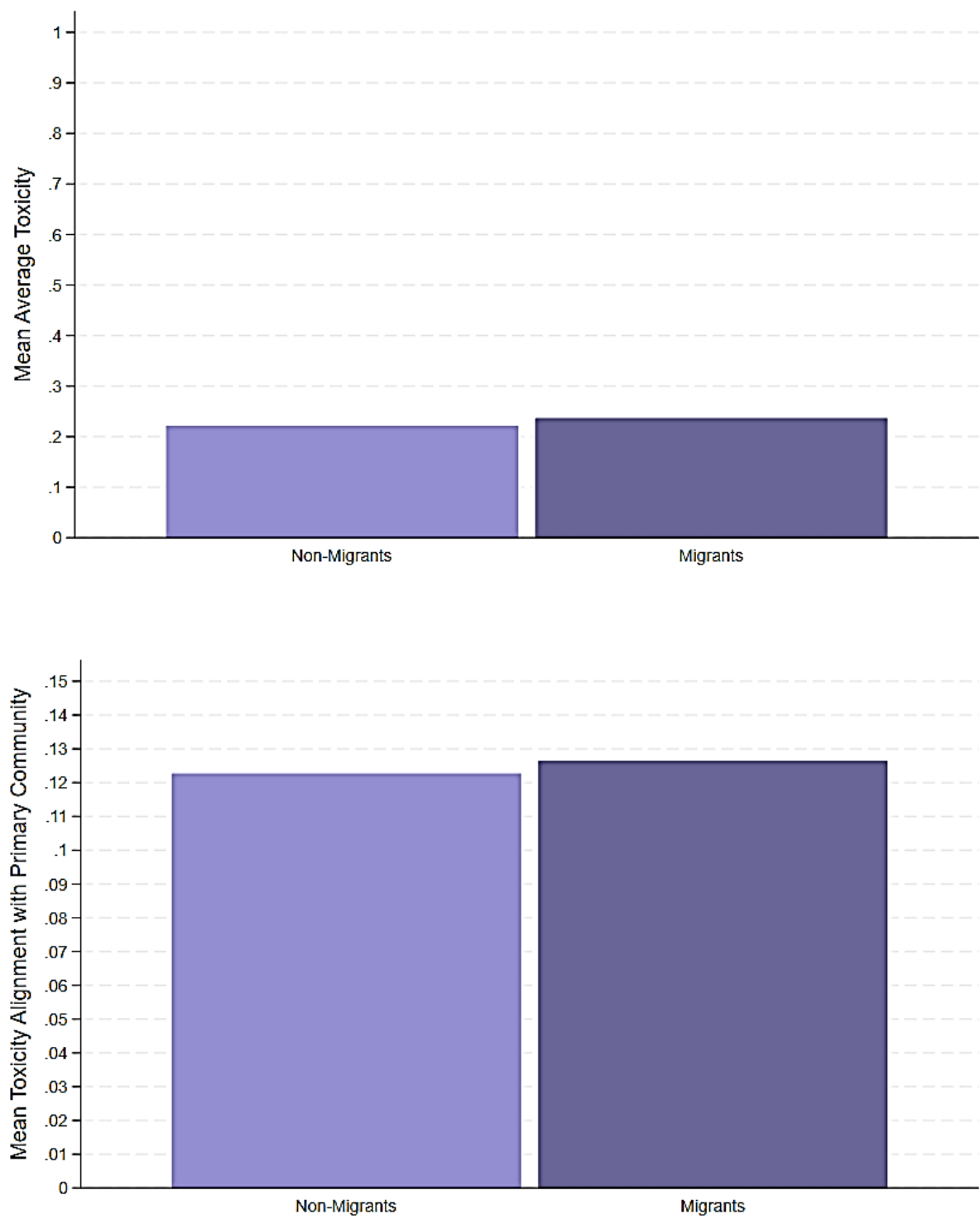


Figure 413. Mean Toxicity and Toxicity Alignment, by Migration Status



degree of toxicity alignment within primary communities for non-migrating users; post removals, alongside controversiality, may serve as sanctions penalizing users whose post content does not uphold the views within primary communities. I return to this consideration when discussing results from the regression analysis.

RESULTS: PREDICTING USER MIGRATION

Results from event history analysis of migration into more or less extreme communities are presented in Table 18 and 19. Coefficients are presented as odds-ratios reflecting predictor variables' effects on the odds of a user migrating during a given time interval, and can again be interpreted as either a factor increase/decrease, or converted to a percent increase/decrease in the odds of migration (calculated as $[100(\beta-1)]$). It is important to note here that the inclusion of random effects to account for unobserved heterogeneity within subjects also shapes the interpretation of the coefficients, which represent the effect on a user's odds of migration, "holding constant the values of their other covariates and their (unobserved) random effect" (Steele and Washbrook 2013:14). It is also again important to note that the inclusion of period dummies allows the effect of time to vary across periods, but that the effects of other covariates are assumed to be time-constant. Overall, the findings support predictions that preexisting extremity, in the form of greater toxicity, drives extremism to more toxic or extreme communities, and that repression events such as community bans or quarantines can have a radicalizing effect that similarly push users to more extreme spaces—this appears especially true of users with higher pre-existing levels of extremity. However, this radicalizing effect does operate alongside a deradicalizing influence. Findings also indicate that, at least terms of radicalization in the form of trajectories *through* spaces, the factors expected to predict loyalty to online communities more generally *do* also at times anchor users within specific extremist spaces within the Reddit manosphere.

Migration to Less Extreme Communities

Results for migration to less extreme communities are presented in Table 18. After excluding users whose primary participation occurred in the PUA community, from which migration to a less extreme community is not possible, the total sample for this section of the analysis is 47,254 users and 93,113 user-years. A few trends are immediately noticeable in the results: first, users in the MRA and Incel community have significantly different odds of migration to less extreme spaces; second, measures of fit appear to matter more for migration than they did for engagement rates, suggesting that these factors may significantly impact differential participation in terms of where users engage, but not in terms of how *much* they engage; third, bans—but not quarantines—are again shown to be somewhat efficacious in combatting radicalization, insofar as they show a positive relationship with migration to less extreme communities. I will now review findings for individual sets of predictors in greater detail in turn.

User characteristics. To begin, let us review the effects of tenure on user migration; here, it is helpful to remember that users only enter the risk set for migration in their second year of activity within the Reddit manosphere, as this is the point at which a shift in primary community can be identified. Similarly, because each spell in a primary community must end in an event—i.e., the shifting of participation to a new primary community—year 1 within a second spell represents the second year of activity in a new primary community. Findings show that tenure does not have a significant effect on the odds of migration to a less extreme community after accounting for all user, fit and reception, and community characteristics. Given that tenure has been shown to increase loyalty in online communities (Hamilton et al. 2017), the lack of effect for tenure is somewhat surprising; I return to this when discussing the results on migration to more toxic communities.

Table 18. Results from Multilevel Event History Analysis Predicting Migration to Less Toxic Primary Community

	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3		Model 4	
	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)
<i>User Characteristics</i>								
Tenure (Years)								
1 (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
2	1.19358*	(0.04372)	1.17819*	(0.04349)	1.13116 ⁺	(0.04194)	1.10311	(0.04055)
3	1.00353	(0.05132)	0.98530	(0.05072)	0.91791	(0.04754)	0.88606	(0.04550)
4	1.05250	(0.07270)	1.02522	(0.07155)	0.91276	(0.06385)	0.87184	(0.06024)
5	0.65880*	(0.07673)	0.63667*	(0.07449)	0.55669*	(0.06473)	0.52705	(0.06086)
6	0.80130	(0.11934)	0.77568	(0.11661)	0.67971	(0.10191)	0.62732	(0.09429)
7	0.67030	(0.16117)	0.64629	(0.15599)	0.59285	(0.14279)	0.53313	(0.12845)
8	0.56204	(0.20062)	0.52404	(0.18660)	0.46487	(0.16620)	0.40528	(0.14528)
9	0.93459	(0.41719)	0.90090	(0.39891)	0.76565	(0.33715)	0.62194	(0.28149)
10+	0.66040	(0.45451)	0.62516	(0.43130)	0.54762	(0.37808)	0.47810	(0.32752)
Prior Primary Community								
MRA	0.09895*	(0.00692)	0.09511*	(0.00672)	0.07822*	(0.00622)	0.03707*	(0.00341)
Incels	0.46244*	(0.01870)	0.45100*	(0.01843)	0.38745*	(0.02248)	0.10737*	(0.01096)
MGTOV	1.12484*	(0.03584)	1.13543*	(0.03670)	1.41410*	(0.06102)	0.94654	(0.04684)
TRP (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
Post count (lagged)	0.99966*	(0.00010)	0.99957*	(0.00012)	0.99959 ⁺	(0.00012)	0.99960 ⁺	(0.00012)
Posting frequency (lagged)	0.93261*	(0.00460)	0.93406*	(0.00487)	0.93508*	(0.00485)	0.93311*	(0.00485)
Average toxicity (lagged)	1.00245	(0.00822)	0.99766	(0.00824)	1.00280	(0.00831)	1.00956	(0.00966)
Toxicity alignment (lagged)	1.06187*	(0.01449)	1.04526	(0.01460)	1.04435	(0.01461)	1.05273*	(0.01478)
Previous migrations	1.77310*	(0.03683)	1.73742*	(0.03640)	1.72328*	(0.03640)	1.72131*	(0.03676)
Percent submissions (lagged)	--	--	0.99671	(0.00116)	0.99666	(0.00115)	0.99721	(0.00114)
<i>Reception Characteristics</i>								
Average post score (lagged)	--	--	0.99965	(0.00079)	0.99959	(0.00080)	0.99864	(0.00109)
Submission comments (lagged)	--	--	0.99989	(0.00010)	0.99992	(0.00009)	0.99996	(0.00009)
Received gilding (lagged)	--	--	0.90492	(0.10215)	0.90226	(0.10213)	0.89554	(0.10138)
Controversial post (lagged)	--	--	1.36674*	(0.04253)	1.37803*	(0.04289)	1.41017*	(0.04412)
Post removal (lagged)	--	--	0.67311*	(0.02464)	0.67857*	(0.02480)	0.68395*	(0.02510)
<i>Primary Community Characteristics</i>								
Number of users (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.00001*	(0.00000)	1.00001	(0.00000)
Post activity (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.00000*	(0.00000)	1.00000	(0.00000)
Bans implemented (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.31210*	(0.03870)	1.54106*	(0.00000)
Quarantines implemented (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.18834*	(0.05226)	1.06392	(0.05810)
User toxicity x bans							1.01294	(0.01098)
User toxicity x quarantines							0.99839	(0.07375)
Constant	0.15275*	(0.00727)	0.20375*	(0.01105)	0.21237*	(0.01467)	9.16773*	(2.21701)
Observations	93,190		93,113		93,113		93,113	
Number of Users	47,295		47,254		47,254		47,254	

* p < 0.001, ⁺ p = 0.001

Differences in the odds of migration to a less toxic community do emerge for users in different primary communities; while no specific hypotheses were formulated regarding migration in this direction, as predictions were informed specifically by prior work addressing a trend towards migration into *more* toxic communities (Ribeiro et al. 2021), findings here are still of interest, as they provide insight into the ways that users within the Reddit manosphere flow between spaces. Results show that, after holding constant the values of all user, reception, and community context measures, as well as the subject-specific random effects, users in both the MRA and Incel communities have significantly lower odds—98% and 90%, respectively—of migrating to a less extreme community than do users for whom TRP is the primary community. MGTOW users, in contrast, show no significant relationship to migration in this direction after accounting for all other factors included in the analysis.

Taken together, these findings are likely influenced primarily by the *availability* of less toxic communities. For TRP users, who are active in the most toxic community within the Reddit manosphere, migration into any new community by definition results in movement into a less toxic space. MRA users, in contrast, have only one possible destination that can be considered less toxic—the PUA community—and it is a community with a very different focus; as detailed in Chapter 2, PUA users draw on a limited application of red pill ideology that centers sexual strategy, while MRA users draw on the red pill framework to justify and reinforce perceptions of men suffering structural disadvantage at the hands of women and feminism (Rothermel et al. 2022). That MRA users are much less likely than TRP users to move into a less toxic space, then, can be considered predominantly a function of both MRA’s position within the toxicity rankings of the Reddit manosphere, and its ideological position in relation to the only less toxic community.

For Incel users, interpretation can be considered similar in that the comparatively low odds of migration to less toxic communities can be explained through a combination of the community's place in the toxicity rankings, and its unique attributes. As the midpoint in the toxicity rankings, Incels have equal opportunity to migrate to more or less toxic communities, but still have fewer options for less toxic destinations relative to TRP; this can in large part account for their odds of migration to a less toxic community being lower, though not to quite the same degree as MRA. The notion that toxicity rankings are a heavy determining factor are further supported by the lack of a significant difference between TRP and MGTOW in terms of the odds of migration; remember that MGTOW was close to tied with TRP for most-toxic community.

In terms of other posting characteristics, many predictors show results that are either insubstantial, statistically insignificant, or both—at least when considering migration to less toxic communities specifically. The number of posts made by users, and their average toxicity, are non-substantive and insignificant, respectively, though it should be noted that these factors were expected to impact migration to more toxic communities, rather than being expected to impact migration more generally. As such, discussion of specific hypotheses related to these predictors is included in the subsequent section covering migration to more toxic spaces. Toxicity alignment shows a positive relationship to migration to less toxic communities, indicating that for each .1 increase in the difference between a users' average toxicity and the average toxicity of their primary community, the odds of migration to a less toxic space increase by around 5%; this supports notions that poor fit may serve as a 'push' factor driving users out of communities. Finally, posting frequency shows a negative relationship with migration to less toxic spaces, decreasing the odds by around 7%; this provides initial support for Hypothesis 17, which—based on previous literature highlighting posting frequency as a measure of continued commitment to online

communities (Hamilton et al. 2017; Sadeque and Bethard 2019)—predicted that posting frequency would have an anchoring effect for users.

Measures of fit and reception. Characteristics of fit and reception show a mixed impact on migration to less toxic communities, suggesting that these factors matter more for migration than for engagement rates, but that they are still not necessarily the most salient factors shaping radicalization processes within the Reddit manosphere. Average post scores, the number of submission comments received, and the receipt of Reddit gold (gildings) do not show any significant effects, contrary to the predictions stated in Hypotheses 11, 13, and 14.

Controversiality and post removals, in contrast, are associated with a significant change in the odds of migration to a less toxic community; having a post removed decreased the odds of migration to a less toxic community by around 32%. No specific relationship between removal and migration to less toxic communities was expected, but removal was predicted to drive migration to *more* toxic communities, and it is possible that negative relationship identified here lends preliminary support for that prediction. It is also possible, however, that this relationship is explained by the negative effect of post removals on engagement overall. I return to interpretation of the finding regarding removals after considering results on migration to more toxic communities.

Having a post marked controversial increases the odds of migration to less toxic spaces by around 41%, which supports Hypothesis 12 stating that controversiality—as a measure of fit—would be positively associated with migration, serving as a ‘push’ factor driving users out of communities. It is interesting, however, that controversiality is the only other measure of fit to shape migration in this direction, while post scores, comments, gildings have no impact. On the one hand, hypotheses regarding the role of measures of fit were partially informed by general work

on online migration that did not necessarily center extremist communities specifically (Chang et al. 2014; Fiesler and Dym 2020); as such, the negligible impact of post scores, comments, and gildings may again reflect that the processes guiding engagement with more recreational online communities do not translate to the extremist context. On the other hand, previous work on the far-right has noted that users who do not feel a sense of fit may switch to different communities or platforms (Kor-Sins 2021), and a general sense of belonging has been identified as an important motivation for engaging with extremist communities (van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018; Vergani et al. 2020). In the case of the former findings regarding platform switching, a sense of ‘fit’ has been largely defined by whether users feel welcome within platforms, rather than within specific communities; as such, measures of fit relying on interactions from other users in their same community may not capture that particular component of fit well. That the metrics of fit made available through Reddit’s API and infrastructure are simply lacking in their ability to truly capture fit is further supported by the substantial impact of having a post marked controversial. This is especially true because controversiality and post score metrics are to some degree related: the Reddit algorithm specifically marks as controversial those posts which receive a more equal portion of upvotes to downvotes, which in theory will also yield lower post scores, since scores reflect the sum of upvotes minus downvotes. Because the visibility of posts is determined by post scores, there should also be little difference in the visibility or opportunity for engagement on controversial posts versus those that simply do not receive many upvotes. The fact that post scores alone do not shape migration also suggests that controversiality is not simply capturing some measure of the popularity or unpopularity of a given opinion. This ultimately means that the effect of controversiality is likely due to some qualitative component of controversial posts, either in that they reflect a particular type of contentious view that already leaves users predisposed to migrate,

or that there is something qualitatively different in their reception—such as more contentious comment threads, though the lack of impact for number of comments alone suggests that the *degree* of discussion controversial posts generates is not necessarily a factor. Future analysis could compare the qualitative aspects of controversial and non-controversial posts in order to identify the specific mechanisms that connect having a post marked controversial with increased odds of migration to a less toxic community.

Community context. As far as user numbers and activity levels are concerned, the features of a user's primary community appear to have little substantial impact on the odds of migration to a less toxic community, showing little preliminary support for Hypotheses 20 and 21. These hypotheses were again informed primarily by general work on online engagement that found group size and activity levels impact loyalty within online communities, even within an ecosystem of competing spaces (Hamilton et al. 2017; Sadeque and Bethard 2019); as such, this again suggests that processes regarding differential participation or radicalization are subject to their own unique logics, rather than being influenced by processes that shape online engagement more generally.

In contrast, subreddit bans again show a significant positive effect on migration to less toxic communities, suggesting these efforts may in fact have a deradicalizing effect. Results show that for each subreddit banned by Reddit administration in the previous year, the odds of a user shifting participation to a less toxic community increased by 54%. This finding is particularly interesting; hypotheses 10a and 10b predict a positive relationship between these measures of repression and migration to more toxic communities specifically, as work on Reddit has shown community bans drive migration, and that this frequently involves movement to more extreme off-platform spaces (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016), and because experiences of repression have been shown to drive radicalization (della Porta 2018). The findings

thus far leave two possibilities: first, that measures of repression in the form of bans have a wholly deradicalizing effect; or second, that the effects of platform-level repression increases the odds of migration in any direction. The former possibility is somewhat supported by Chapter 6 findings indicating that bans specifically decreased engagement. At the same time, the latter possibility would align with previous work on Reddit that has indicated some users active in extremist communities go on to participate in other, non-extremist following ban implementations, and would also be supported by previous work on social movement radicalization that has noted a bifurcating effect, where more moderate movement members are deradicalized and more committed members move deeper into extremism (della Porta 2018; Zwerman, Steinhoff, and della Porta 2000). I return to this discussion after also interpreting the results modeling migration to more toxic communities.

Interactions between User Toxicity and Repression. In terms of the effect on migration to less toxic communities, there is no apparent interaction between user toxicity and repression; this is not necessarily unexpected, as toxicity—taken as a measure of extremism—is again specifically expected to influence migration specifically into more toxic communities, and to impact the expected radicalizing effect of platform-level interventions like bans.

Migration to More Extreme Communities

Table 19 presents results of analysis on migration to more extreme communities. After excluding users whose primary participation occurred in the TRP community, from which migration to a more toxic community is not possible, the total sample for this section of the analysis is 40,344 users and 76,424 user-years. Several trends are again immediately noticeable; first, that tenure within communities operates as expected to discourage migration to more toxic communities; second, that primary community matters in all cases, rather than only for a subset of

Table 19. Results from Multilevel Event History Analysis Predicting Migration to More Toxic Primary Community

	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3		Model 4	
	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)
<i>User Characteristics</i>								
Tenure (Years)								
1 (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
2	0.81748*	(0.03272)	0.81214*	(0.03266)	0.80505*	(0.03228)	0.80325*	(0.03219)
3	0.62285*	(0.03643)	0.61425*	(0.03609)	0.61234*	(0.03587)	0.61090*	(0.03578)
4	0.51174*	(0.04352)	0.50092*	(0.04271)	0.50173*	(0.04264)	0.49920*	(0.04239)
5	0.28986*	(0.03999)	0.28251*	(0.03901)	0.28508*	(0.03939)	0.28512*	(0.03937)
6	0.28867*	(0.05107)	0.28310*	(0.05009)	0.28770*	(0.05088)	0.28610*	(0.05055)
7	0.27628*	(0.06199)	0.26724*	(0.06009)	0.27443*	(0.06176)	0.27424*	(0.06171)
8	0.22956*	(0.07113)	0.22130*	(0.06840)	0.22711*	(0.07014)	0.22717*	(0.07017)
9	0.16854*	(0.07696)	0.16254*	(0.07429)	0.16896*	(0.07722)	0.16900*	(0.07727)
10+	0.03329 ⁺	(0.03330)	0.03252 ⁺	(0.03253)	0.03400 ⁺	(0.03401)	0.03381 ⁺	(0.03381)
Prior Primary Community								
PUA (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
MRA	0.49069*	(0.01828)	0.48037*	(0.01854)	0.48099*	(0.01925)	0.48415*	(0.01934)
Incels	0.35652*	(0.01566)	0.34433*	(0.01549)	0.18067*	(0.01345)	0.18089*	(0.01346)
MGTOW	0.23930*	(0.01294)	0.23800*	(0.01312)	0.18103*	(0.01228)	0.18374*	(0.01243)
Post count (lagged)	0.99986	(0.00007)	0.99981	(0.00010)	0.99977	(0.00010)	0.99977	(0.00010)
Posting frequency (lagged)	0.94332*	(0.00488)	0.94836*	(0.00525)	0.94824*	(0.00526)	0.94891*	(0.00527)
Average toxicity (lagged)	1.05112*	(0.01055)	1.05773*	(0.01083)	1.05328*	(0.01069)	1.03597*	(0.01171)
Toxicity alignment (lagged)	1.09011*	(0.01614)	1.06286*	(0.01640)	1.06420*	(0.01631)	1.07214*	(0.01669)
Previous migrations	1.47340*	(0.03487)	1.45427*	(0.03474)	1.46963*	(0.03564)	1.46828*	(0.03551)
Percent submissions (lagged)	--	--	1.00119	(0.00096)	1.00100	(0.00098)	1.00083	(0.00098)
<i>Reception Characteristics</i>								
Average post score (lagged)	--	--	0.99666	(0.00174)	0.99631	(0.00185)	0.99618	(0.00189)
Submission comments (lagged)	--	--	1.00002	(0.00007)	1.00002	(0.00008)	1.00002	(0.00008)
Received gilding (lagged)	--	--	0.68479	(0.10355)	0.71052	(0.10733)	0.71438	(0.10799)
Controversial post (lagged)	--	--	1.24058*	(0.04051)	1.23171*	(0.04162)	1.23105*	(0.04164)
Post removal (lagged)	--	--	0.72964*	(0.02701)	0.72875*	(0.02703)	0.73147*	(0.02716)
<i>Primary Community Characteristics</i>								
Number of users (lagged)	--	--	--	--	0.99999*	(0.00000)	0.99999 ⁺	(0.00000)
Post activity (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.00000	(0.00000)	1.00000	(0.00000)
Bans implemented (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.47469*	(0.05075)	1.29553*	(0.05481)
Quarantines implemented (lagged)	--	--	--	--	1.63385*	(0.13815)	1.70809*	(0.18120)
User toxicity x bans	--	--	--	--	--	--	1.06194*	(0.01215)
User toxicity x quarantines	--	--	--	--	--	--	0.98061	(0.02455)
Constant	0.22320*	(0.01010)	0.27756*	(0.01441)	0.32824*	(0.02348)	0.33255*	(0.02380)
Observations	76,501		76,424		76,424		76,424	
Number of Users	40,386		40,344		40,344		40,344	

* p < 0.001, ⁺ p = 0.001

communities; third, that toxicity *does* drive migration to more toxic spaces; and finally, that repression again shows positive effects on migration to new spaces, with the relationship between bans and radicalization again moderated by user toxicity. This again suggests that the processes shaping online engagement more generally may matter more for migration than they did for engagement rates, and provides support for the notion that repression in the form of bans has a bifurcating effect on users. Findings and their implications are discussed in greater detail in turn in the following sections.

User characteristics. Results for the effect of tenure on the odds of migration to more toxic communities are in stark contrast to the models for migration to less toxic communities; here, all period effects are significant, with a negative relationship to migration relative to year 1 increasing over time. Compared to the first possible migration year, year two shows around a 20% decrease in the odds of migration, and year three shows a 39% decrease; for users in year 10, the odds of migration to a more toxic community are nearly 97% lower than for users in their first year of a community. This provides strong support for Hypothesis 18, and aligns with previous findings that tenure within communities decreases the likelihood of community switching on Reddit (Hamilton et al. 2017). At the same time, that the effect for migration is significant here but not for migration to less toxic communities suggests that migration in these respective directions are shaped by distinct processes; this is supported by other differences in effects between models.

Group identity again also appears to play a salient role in shaping the odds of migration; here, the least toxic community—PUA—serves as the reference category, with all other communities having comparatively lower odds of moving to a more toxic space: the odds of migration to a more toxic primary community were 52%, 82%, and 82% lower for users in the MRA, Incel, and MGTOW communities. This also supports Hypothesis 19, which—based on prior

research identifying migrations from older, less toxic communities to newer, more toxic communities (Ribeiro et al. 2021)—predicted that PUA and MRA users would have higher odds of migration to more toxic spaces. As with migration to less toxic spaces, it is also still important here to acknowledge the very likely influence of the toxicity rankings on the identified effects; users in communities that rank higher for overall toxicity have fewer opportunities to move to more toxic spaces. That said, it can also not be ignored that there are also intuitive ideological reasons why PUA and MRA users might have higher odds of migrating to more toxic spaces—PUA users may be drawn to TRP’s expanded application of ‘game,’ for example, while MRA users may similarly find alignment between their preexisting views and those found in the MGTOW or TRP communities. Future work could potentially separate out the effect of group ideologies from the effect of positions within a network of more or less toxic spaces by assessing user flows between specific communities, rather than simply towards more or less toxic spaces.

In terms of other user characteristics, post counts from the previous year are not just insubstantial but also insignificant, while posting frequency again shows a negative relationship with the odds of migration, lending further support to Hypothesis 17 and aligning with prior literature indicating that the temporal characteristics of posting habits matter (Sadeque et al. 2016; Sadeque and Bethard 2019); for each additional month a user posted in the prior year, the odds of a user migrating to a more toxic community are decreased by 5%. Previous migrations also again have a positive effect on the likelihood of migration, though this effect is somewhat smaller compared to migration to less toxic communities—the odds of migrating to a more toxic community increase by 47% for each previous migration.

Unlike with migration to less toxic communities, average toxicity also shows a significant effect, this time positive; for each .1 increase in a user’s average toxicity, their odds of migration

to a more toxic community increases by just under 4%.⁴¹ Toxicity alignment is also again shown to significantly impact migration in this direction; for each .1 increase in the difference between a user's average toxicity and the average toxicity of their primary community, the odds increase by just over 7%. This supports hypotheses 15a, and lends additional credence to previous work suggesting that users with greater ideological extremism—for which toxicity serves as a proxy in this analysis—may be either pulled toward more toxic communities that better reflect their own attitudes, or pushed out of more moderate communities through moderation or informal sanctions (Ribeiro et al. 2021). Which of these possibilities—being ‘pushed’ out or ‘pulled’ in—is most likely is further discussed after assessing the impact of measures of fit and reception. These findings also fail to support Hypothesis 15b, which presumed that toxicity alignment, as an indicator of alignment between user and group views, would decrease the odds of migration. I again return to this discussion after also accounting for measures of fit and reception.

Measures of fit and reception. Once again, controversiality and post removals are the only characteristics of fit and reception that appear significantly related to the odds of migration. Here, having at least one post marked controversial is associated with a 23% increase in the odds of migration to a more toxic community, again lending support to Hypothesis 12, while having a post removed was associated with a 27% decrease in the odds of migration in this direction—the opposite of the direction of the relationship predicted in Hypothesis 9. Given that Chapter 6 findings found post removals to have a negative effect on engagement, the likely explanation here

⁴¹ As a reminder, user toxicity scores may range from 0 to 1, and that average toxicity showed a median of .1 and a mean of .2, with a standard deviation of .25. A .1 increase in toxicity, then, is equivalent to just under a half standard deviation increase.

is that post removals also reduce the odds of migration by discouraging participation more generally. As previously noted, removals could—depending on the motivations for removal—operate or be perceived as indicative of either fit, or repression by community moderators; given that measures of repression are generally expected to drive radicalization processes, and individual perceptions of censorship have been identified as having an intensifying effect or driving migration to more extreme spaces (Gillett and Suzor 2022; Newell et al. 2016), these findings also suggests that users perceive removals as an indicator of fit rather than a form of repression, likely because removal decisions are made by moderators rather than platform administrators. Hypotheses 11, 13, and 14 regarding the role of post scores, comments received, and gildings, are not supported.

These findings yield interesting insights into the role of push factors that drive users out of communities. First, the lack of effect for post scores, comments, and gildings across both migration models indicates that most measures of community fit captured by Reddit’s platform affordances—that is, built in features such as comments or upvotes that rely on engagement and interaction from other users—matter little for users’ trajectories across extremist spaces. Second, that controversiality has a consistent positive effect on migration in any direction despite the absence of effect for other metrics, including post scores, again suggests that there may be something regarding the *qualitative* aspects of controversial posts that shapes users’ sense of fit and encourages them to seek out new spaces; this suggests that interaction and reception may matter, but that they may do so in ways that are not easily quantifiable.

The absence of effect for most other measures of fit and reception also provides some additional insights into the mechanisms that may drive the relationship between toxicity or toxicity alignment, and migration to more toxic spaces. Both metrics appear to operate as ‘pull’ factors—given that post scores or comments had no effect, it appears unlikely that more toxic users or

unaligned users are being pushed out of less extreme spaces due to a negative reception, but rather that they are ultimately drawn in to spaces better aligned with their views. These findings also add to the previous literature regarding toxicity and user flows within the manosphere community, which indicated that growing toxicity may be a consequence, rather than a cause of migration (Ribeiro et al. 2021); more concretely, they implicate toxicity as a causal factor driving migration, rather than a property that emerges after users shift into newer, more toxic spaces.

Community context. In terms of community characteristics, the number of active users or levels of post activity are insubstantial and, in the case of activity levels, insignificant; this again fails to support hypotheses 20 and 21, and suggests online extremist spaces are subject to their own internal logics compared to other types of online communities. Bans and quarantines, however, are again both significantly associated with migration to more toxic communities, which supports hypotheses 10a and 10b. Each additional subreddit ban in a user's primary community increased the odds of migration to a more toxic community by 30%, and each additional quarantine increased the odds by 71%. These reflect a slightly weaker effect for bans, and a notably stronger effect where quarantines are concerned—the effect size here is more than ten times that seen when considering migration to less toxic spaces. This indicates that bans and quarantines do increase the odds of migration in any direction, indicating a shuffling effect, but also that this shuffling effect operates unevenly. This aligns with previous work indicating that repression can drive radicalization, but that this propensity may not affect all movement members in the same ways, discouraging more moderate members (della Porta 2018). These findings also align with previous work on online migration across extremist communities, which found community bans had potential to drive users to more extreme spaces (Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016), while others went on to participate normally in more moderate spaces (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017). That the

radicalizing effect of quarantines is stronger than that of bans also suggests two possibilities. First, it could be that users perceive these two measures of repression differently, and perceive quarantines as more unfair or less justified; perhaps bans are perceived as more just because they are often implemented in the wake of concrete evidence of platform policy violations, rather than due to the controversiality of communities. Second, it is possible that the apparent difference is caused by deplatforming; rather than migrating to more extreme spaces, many users do seek out platforms more permissive of their views in the wake of subreddit bans (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017; Kor-Sins 2021; Newell et al. 2016). This may give the appearance of quarantines having a stronger impact on radicalizing, when in fact it is simply a more *visible* impact. While impacts on disengagement are assessed in Chapter 8, future work could explore these possibilities through case studies of user flows out of specific quarantined and banned subreddits within the Reddit manosphere.

Interactions between User Toxicity and Repression. Interaction effects show no significant interaction between user toxicity and quarantines. Findings do, however, highlight that user toxicity has an intensifying effect on bans' impact on the odds of migration to more toxic spaces specifically. These findings are important in that they highlight how predispositions to extremity impact the processes at play to drive radicalization; remember that neither interaction effect was significant for migration to less toxic spaces. This further supports previous work on radicalization noting that repression may further radicalize less moderate movement members, even as it suppresses participation for those who are less committed or invested in a cause (della Porta 2018; Zwerman et al. 2000). It also again highlights that while some factors do appear to drive migration more generally, the underlying processes that have shaped user trajectories across the Reddit manosphere operate differently in terms of driving migration to more or less toxic spaces.

CONCLUSION

Table 20 summarizes the results of the migration analysis, connecting the identified relationships to the relevant hypotheses presented in Chapter 3. Taken together, the findings regarding migration to more or less extreme communities offer several key insights into how user trajectories relate to radicalization within the Reddit manosphere. First, the risk of radicalization into more extreme spaces does appear uneven across groups, with users in the older, least toxic communities having higher odds of moving into more extreme spaces; this affirms previous findings that migration within the Reddit manosphere trends in the direction of greater extremism (Ribeiro et al. 2021). Second, findings regarding the influence of user toxicity suggests that this factor *does* have a radicalizing influence, increasing the odds of migration to more—but not less— toxic communities. This indicates that prior thinking suggesting rising toxicity was a consequence of migration was, at best, incomplete. Coupled with additional findings that most measures of fit matter little for migration, and that those that *do* matter shape migration risk more generally, rather than in any particular direction, this also suggests that ‘pull’ rather than ‘push’ effects are at play in driving users into more extreme manosphere spaces on Reddit. Third, the role of controversiality in driving migration, even absent the impact of most other metrics of fit or reception, highlights that there may be unobserved qualitative components of interaction that serve as mechanisms shaping migration risk. Finally, results showed that quarantines and bans drive migration to new communities in general, but that the effects on migration to more or less toxic spaces differ across repression measures. Bans have a stronger effect on migration to less toxic spaces, while quarantines show a much stronger impact on migration to more toxic communities; this indicates that within the Reddit manosphere, responses to received repression differ based on approaches, which has salient implications for platform-level interventions into extremism. That the relationship between bans and migration to more toxic communities is intensified by higher levels

Table 20. Summary of Findings from Analysis Modeling User Migration

Key Predictors	Expected Relationship to Migration		Hypothesis	Identified Relationship			Result
	Any Direction	More Toxic		Less Toxic	Both	More Toxic	
<i>User Characteristics</i>							
Primary Community							
PUA	--	Positive	H ₁₉	N/A		Positive	Supported
MRA	--	Positive	H ₁₉	--	Negative	--	Not supported
Incel	--	Negative	H ₁₉	--	Negative	--	Supported
MGTOW	--	Negative	H ₁₉	Positive	--	Negative	Supported
TRP	--	Negative	H ₁₉	Positive	--	N/A	Not supported
Tenure	Negative	--	H ₁₈	Mixed	--	Negative	Partially supported
Number of posts	Negative	--	H ₁₆	--	No effect	--	Not supported
Posting frequency	Negative	--	H ₁₇	--	Negative	--	Supported
Average toxicity	--	Positive	H _{15a}	No effect	--	Positive	Supported
Toxicity alignment	Negative	--	H _{15b}	Insignificant	--	Positive	Not supported
<i>Measures of Fit & Reception</i>							
Average post score	Negative	--	H ₁₁	Insignificant	-	No effect	Not supported
Comments received	Negative	--	H ₁₃	--	Insignificant	--	Not supported
Gildings received	Negative	--	H ₁₄	--	Insignificant	--	Not supported
Controversiality	Positive	--	H ₁₂	--	Positive	--	Supported
Post removal	--	Positive	H ₉	--	Negative	--	Not supported
<i>Context Characteristics</i>							
Number of active users	Negative	--	H ₂₀	--	No effect	--	Not supported
Activity level	Negative	--	H ₂₁	No effect	--	Insignificant	Not supported
Quarantines implemented	--	Positive	H _{10a}	--	Positive	--	Supported
Bans implemented	--	Positive	H _{10b}	--	Positive	--	Supported
User toxicity x quarantines	--	Positive	H _{10c}	Insignificant	--	Insignificant	Not Supported
User toxicity x bans	--	Positive	H _{10d}	Insignificant	--	Positive	Supported

of toxicity among individual users also affirms that previously-identified mixed effects regarding repression and its potential bifurcating effect carry over into manosphere spaces. Findings also highlight potential problems with reliance on bans as a measure of intervention into these spaces, because they may unintentionally drive users with higher preexisting levels of toxicity to further radicalize. The implications of these findings and their connections to broader radicalization processes are considered in further detail in Chapter 9.

CHAPTER 8: MODELING USER DISENGAGEMENT

Prior chapters have assessed the relationship between facets of engagement in online extremist communities, and radicalization in the form of differential participation and movement into more extreme spaces. In this final empirical chapter, I shift attention to the converse of intensifying participation within the Reddit manosphere—user disengagement. Here, I again draw on event history analysis, modeling the odds of disengagement for users whose posting activity ceases prior to 2022, which is the final year represented in the data under analysis. As noted in Chapter 4, some users do experience periods of disengagement before ultimately resuming their participation in secular male supremacist Reddit communities; as such, this portion of the analysis again uses a multilevel logit model with random effects to account for the possibility of recurring events and the influence of unobserved subject-level characteristics (i.e., frailty). This also means that users observed to have disengaged cannot necessarily have been positioned as having exited the Reddit manosphere permanently or entirely; these users may continue to engage in non-participatory ways (i.e., through ‘lurking’—reading content rather than posting) or may return after a period of abeyance in activity. It is also important here to remember that this also means disengagement should not be taken as synonymous with deradicalization; however, deepening understandings of what drives disengagement within these spaces still offers utility for understanding what factors shape differential participation and radicalization within this context. Findings again show that group identity is one of the most salient factors influencing disengagement, that the measures of fit and reception identified as important for predicting disengagement from non-extremist spaces matter unevenly and at times in unexpected ways, and that platform-level repression efforts may contribute to radicalization by increasing commitment to participation in these spaces, particularly for more extreme or toxic users.

ANALYSIS

As in previous chapters, I argue that a range of factors related to user characteristics, fit and reception, and community context—including experiences of community-level repression—can be expected to drive rates of disengagement for users within the Reddit manosphere. An overview of these factors, and their expected relationship to disengagement, is presented in Table 21. Posting characteristics are expected to have a primarily negative relationship to disengagement, with the exception that users in newer communities more subject to repression—the Incel and MGTOW communities—are expected to have higher rates of disengagement. Positive measures of reception such as higher post scores, comments, or gildings are expected to negatively predict engagement, while time to first reply—as a measure of interaction—is expected to be positively associated with disengagement. Finally, in terms of community context, community size and activity are expected to decrease the odds of disengagement, while new users or experiences of community-level repression are expected to increase the odds of user disengagement. This last relationship is expected to be weaker for more toxic users.

To test the proposed relationships, I again employ a discrete-time event history analysis, similar to that presented in Chapter 7. However, I here employ a multilevel logit with random effects rather than the competing risks framework for multiple outcomes employed in the analysis of migration; utilizing a multilevel model allows for multiple periods of activity and abeyance, which (as discussed in greater detail in Chapter 4) were present for some users. (Note that initial tests yielded similar results for models that incorporated or excluded users with periods of abeyance.) The effects of time are again allowed to vary across period, while the impact of other covariates is assumed to be time-constant. Prior to reporting results from the discrete-time event history analysis, I briefly summarize descriptive findings regarding periods of engagement and disengagement. Then, I again present a series of four regression models; Model 1 assesses the

Table 21. Review of Key Variables Expected to Drive Disengagement⁴²

Key Predictors	Expected Relationship to Disengagement	Hypothesis
<i>User-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>		
Primary Community		
PUA	Negative	H ₂₈
MRA	Negative	H ₂₈
Incel	Positive	H ₂₈
MGTOW	Positive	H ₂₈
TRP	Negative	H ₂₈
Tenure	Negative	H ₂₄
Number of posts	Negative	H ₂₃
Posting frequency	Negative	H ₃₁
Average post length	Negative	H ₂₉
<i>Measures of Fit & Reception</i>		
Average post score	Negative	H _{25a}
Comments received	Negative	H _{25b}
Gildings received	Negative	H _{25c}
Average time to first reply	Positive	H ₃₂
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>		
<i>Context Characteristics</i>		
Number of active users	Negative	H ₂₆
Activity level	Negative	H ₂₇
Percent new users	Positive	H ₃₀
<i>Repression Measures</i>		
Quarantines implemented	Positive	H _{22a}
Bans implemented	Positive	H _{22b}
User toxicity x quarantines	Negative	H _{22c}
User toxicity x bans	Negative	H _{22d}

⁴² Table 21 is a partial reproduction of Table 1 presented in Ch. 3, but omits variables expected to shape other outcomes.

impact of users' posting characteristics and behaviors alone, Model 2 incorporates user-level measures of reception and fit, and Model 3 incorporates predictors summarizing the context within users' primary communities, including community-level repression measures. Model 4 then assesses interactions between user toxicity and repression. As with prior analyses, pseudo log-likelihoods indicate improved model fit with the addition of each new set of variables. User-level predictors excluding primary community and tenure are lagged to avoid issues of reverse causality or mutual influence. The number of prior disengagement events is also included as a control.

DESCRIPTIVE RESULTS FOR USER DISENGAGEMENT

Error! Reference source not found. presents a descriptive summary of patterns of disengagement for all users present in the Pushshift Reddit dataset. Of the 1,100,554 unique user profiles present between 2008 and 2022, 90% (998,276) had at least one disengagement event; of the remaining users for whom

Table 22. Frequency Counts and Percents for User Disengagement Patterns

	Count	Percent	Cum. Percent
Disengaged			
Yes	998,276	90.71	90.71
No (Entered 2022)	76,255	6.93	97.64
No (Entered prior to 2022)	26,023	2.36	100.00
Repeat Disengagement Periods			
Yes	69,714	6.33	6.33
No	1,030,840	93.67	100.00
Time to Disengagement (Years)			
1	1,178,362	75.17	75.17
2	241,479	15.40	90.57
3	79,890	5.10	95.67
4	33,962	2.17	97.84
5	16,090	1.03	98.86
6	8,239	0.53	99.39
7	4,452	0.28	99.67
8	2,462	0.16	99.83
9	1,365	0.09	99.92
10+	1,328	0.08	100.00

N = 1,100,554

disengagement is right censored, most entered into the Reddit manosphere in 2022, making them ineligible for identifiable disengagement, while the remainder had persisted for at least two years.⁴³ Descriptive results also indicate that multiple periods of disengagement are relatively rare; only 69,714 users (around 6%) had periods of abeyance where they paused active participation only to resume it in a later year. Results also align with the descriptive statistics regarding the average length of overall participation in the Reddit manosphere—the bulk of disengagements occurred after only one year of participation, and 90% of disengagement events occurred within two years

Table 23. Frequency Counts and Percents for Multiple Disengagements

	Count	Percent	Cum. Percent
Number of Disengagement Periods			
1	63,230	89.39	89.39
2	6,730	9.65	99.05
3	628	0.90	99.95
4	36	0.05	100.00
Length of Disengagement Periods (Years)			
1	45,479	58.45	58.45
2	16,749	21.53	79.98
3	7,648	9.83	89.81
4	3,893	5.00	94.81
5	2,029	2.61	97.42
6	1,033	1.33	98.74
7	547	0.70	99.45
8	262	0.34	99.78
9	122	0.16	99.94
10	33	0.04	99.98
11	13	0.02	100.00

N = 69,714

⁴³ Sensitivity checks were conducted to assess the impact of late joiners, who may not have yet had a chance to disengage, on the regression results; comparisons between models including and excluding those users whose entered the manosphere after 2020 showed no substantive differences in the strength, direction, or significance of relationships.

of the start of a period of active participation. Table 23 further summarizes disengagement patterns for users with at least one period of abeyance ($N = 69,714$). Most of these users (89%, or 63,230 users) experienced only one such period of abeyance, and most (80%, or a cumulative 62,228 users) returned to active engagement after a year or two. At the same time, frequencies for abeyance duration do show some users who resume active engagement after a more extended absence, with the max time between disengagement and reengagement spanning 11 years.

RESULTS: PREDICTING USER DISENGAGEMENT

Results from the discrete-time survival analysis predicting time to disengagement are presented in Table 24. Results are again presented as odds-ratios summarizing the effects of each individual predictor on the odds of disengagement, which can be interpreted as the percentage increase/decrease in the odds of migration (calculated as $[100(\beta-1)]$). It should again be noted here that the inclusion of random effects to account for unobserved heterogeneity within subjects also shapes the interpretation of the coefficients, which represent the effect on a user's odds of disengagement after holding constant both other covariates and the unobserved, subject-level random effect. Details on identified significant relationships are discussed in turn below.

User characteristics. As predicted, tenure within the Reddit manosphere shows a significant negative effect on the odds of disengagement, with the strength of this effect increasing over time. Compared to users in their first year, users in their second year have odds of disengagement that are 24% lower; this effect size increases to 32% in the third year of tenure, and continues to increase through the observed tenure periods, with users in their tenth or higher year of tenure having an expected odds of disengagement that is 75% lower than users with one year of tenure. This supports Hypothesis 24 predicting a negative relationship between tenure and disengagement, and aligns with previous findings regarding factors driving or hindering churn in

Table 24. Results from Multilevel Event History Analysis Predicting User Disengagement

	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3		Model 4	
	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)	Odds Ratio	(SE)
<i>User Characteristics</i>								
Tenure (Years)								
1 (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
2	0.73692*	(0.01036)	0.73894*	(0.01040)	0.75955*	(0.01079)	0.75718*	(0.01081)
3	0.66329*	(0.01310)	0.66434*	(0.01311)	0.68323*	(0.01397)	0.67984*	(0.01376)
4	0.55232*	(0.01435)	0.55395*	(0.01439)	0.57307*	(0.01546)	0.57029*	(0.01519)
5	0.46407*	(0.01506)	0.46573*	(0.01511)	0.48688*	(0.01631)	0.48631*	(0.01612)
6	0.41638*	(0.01676)	0.41790*	(0.01682)	0.43919*	(0.01804)	0.43766*	(0.01783)
7	0.42994*	(0.02083)	0.43180*	(0.02092)	0.45306*	(0.02226)	0.45152*	(0.02207)
8	0.36685*	(0.02220)	0.36821*	(0.02229)	0.39278*	(0.02388)	0.39152*	(0.02368)
9	0.27483*	(0.02156)	0.27633*	(0.02167)	0.30381*	(0.02371)	0.30479*	(0.02367)
10+	0.21636*	(0.01910)	0.21744*	(0.01919)	0.24895*	(0.02168)	0.24856*	(0.02166)
Prior Primary Community								
PUA (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	--
MRA	1.04363*	(0.00928)	1.04170*	(0.00928)	0.79293*	(0.00810)	0.78671*	(0.00814)
Incels	1.57864*	(0.01672)	1.57200*	(0.01667)	2.17788*	(0.03567)	2.22175*	(0.03676)
MGTOW	1.99966*	(0.02443)	1.98123*	(0.02430)	1.75984*	(0.03323)	1.75451*	(0.03348)
TRP	1.32355*	(0.01250)	1.31923*	(0.01248)	0.92164*	(0.01235)	0.91331*	(0.01240)
Post count (lagged)	1.00005	(0.00002)	1.00006	(0.00002)	1.00008*	(0.00002)	1.00007*	(0.00002)
Posting frequency (lagged)	0.88713*	(0.00121)	0.88937*	(0.00130)	0.88578*	(0.00135)	0.88635*	(0.00135)
Average post length (lagged)	0.99954*	(0.00005)	0.99950*	(0.00005)	0.99945*	(0.00005)	0.99944*	(0.00005)
Prior disengagements	0.78017*	(0.00801)	0.78163*	(0.00802)	0.76450*	(0.00787)	0.76462*	(0.00791)
Average toxicity (lagged)	--	--	--	--	--	--	1.12669*	(0.01816)
<i>Reception Characteristics</i>								
Average post score (lagged)	--	--	0.99666	(0.00174)	0.99631	(0.00185)	0.99905*	(0.00021)
Comments received(lagged)	--	--	1.00002	(0.00007)	1.00002	(0.00008)	1.03784*	(0.00394)
Received gilding (lagged)	--	--	0.68479	(0.10355)	0.71052	(0.10733)	0.89043	(0.03953)
Average time to first reply (lagged)								
No reply (reference)	--	--	--	--	--	--		
Less than 1 hour	--	--	1.00603	(0.00945)	1.00650	(0.00965)	0.99620	(0.00976)
1 to 12 hours	--	--	0.96964*	(0.00921)	0.98241	(0.00953)	0.97187	(0.00962)
More than 12 hours	--	--	0.89904*	(0.01433)	0.91258*	(0.01488)	0.90283*	(0.01488)
<i>Primary Community Characteristics</i>								
Number of users	--	--	--	--	1.00001*	(0.00000)	1.00001*	(0.00000)
Post activity	--	--	--	--	1.00000*	(0.00000)	1.00000*	(0.00000)
Percent new users	--	--	--	--	0.97058*	(0.00052)	0.97020*	(0.00053)
Bans implemented	--	--	--	--	0.61790*	(0.00492)	0.58771*	(0.00550)
Quarantines implemented	--	--	--	--	0.74373*	(0.01219)	0.75900*	(0.01583)
User toxicity x bans	--	--	--	--	--	--	1.24755*	(0.02921)
User toxicity x quarantines	--	--	--	--	--	--	0.92336	(0.04941)
Constant	2.30711*	(0.03487)	2.27690*	(0.03569)	12.18831*	(0.52401)	12.39969*	(0.53913)
Observations	459,396		458,724		458,724		450,818	
Number of Users	266,642		266,206		266,206		266,206	

* p < 0.001, + p = 0.001

online communities (Arguello et al. 2006; Hamilton et al. 2017); as with the findings regarding tenure and migration, it also suggests again that certain processes shaping online engagement do translate into extremist spaces like the Reddit manosphere, despite the fact that tenure's impact on engagement rates, presented in Chapter 6, did not operate as expected.

Results also again highlight the importance of group identity in shaping users' trajectories within the Reddit manosphere. Hypothesis 28 predicted that disengagement rates would be significantly higher for users in the Incel and MGTOW communities, which were both newer and subject to higher degrees of sanctioning than other communities; this prediction is strongly supported. Compared to the PUA community, users in the Incel and MGTOW communities have odds of disengagement that are 122% and 75% higher, respectively. At the same time, results also show significant differences in the odds of disengagement for MRA and TRP users as well—compared to PUA, odds of disengagement were 21% lower for users in the MRA community, and 9% lower for users in TRP.

The higher odds of disengagement for the Incel and MGTOW communities make intuitive sense based on the logic informing initial hypotheses—that communities experiencing greater sanctioning, often alongside explosive activity, may ultimately see more users drop out. For the Incel community, this result also aligns with the descriptive findings, which showed that Incel users on average have the shortest tenure within the Reddit manosphere, and participate in the least number of communities; it also lends some additional support to the possibility that the Incel community, which has received a particularly high degree of attention from the media and other segments of Reddit, may have a higher number of posters who engage briefly not because they identify with the ideology, but because they are operating essentially as 'tourists' within the community. Again, future work attempting to assess to what degree un-earnest users are present

within the community could help in teasing out whether the shorter tenure of Incel users, and their higher odds of disengagement, are driven by something unique about the black pill ideology, by the Incel community's increased attention relative to other spaces within the manosphere, or by instances of repression. At the same time, the high odds of disengagement among the MGTOW community do suggest that users' are more likely to disengage from newer, more heavily-sanctioned spaces.

The lower odds of disengagement for MRA and TRP users relative to those in PUA, in contrast, may be explained by the practical and ideological differences implicated in other outcomes as well. The narrower focus of PUA relative to many other manosphere communities has been noted at several points; further, previous work has shown that many users who engage in PUA spaces ultimately come to be disillusioned with the promises of sexual success and personal transformation offered on these forums (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019). The MRA community, in contrast, is an iteration of the long-standing men's rights movement, with a focus on more structural factors (Messner 2016; Rothermel et al. 2022); these characteristics may contribute to lower odds of user disengagement. Similarly, TRP's broader topical focus, and its emphasis on the development of sexual strategy as a tactic for navigating not only relationships but life within a supposedly feminist-dominated society (Rothermel et al. 2022; Van Valkenburgh 2018), may similarly lead fewer users to become disillusioned, and decrease the odds of disengagement.

As with previous outcomes assessed, the impact of other posting characteristics on disengagement appears mixed. Post counts and average post length appear significant but show no substantive effect, leading to the rejection of Hypotheses 23 and 29. Given that these factors were expected to be important based on previous work on factors driving churn or persistence in online spaces (Arguello et al. 2006; Sadeque and Bethard 2019), this again points to a limited ability to

extrapolate processes driving engagement in general online communities to those shaping differential participation in extremist communities. Posting frequency, in contrast, shows a negative relationship with disengagement; for each additional month in the prior year that a user posted, their odds of disengagement decrease by 12%. This supports hypothesis 31, and aligns with previous findings that indicate frequency of engagement decreases the odds of user disengagement (Sadeque et al. 2016); it is also consistent with the findings regarding user migration, which similarly saw a negative relationship with posting frequency. Prior disengagements are also shown to be negatively related to the odds of disengagement in a given period; for each additional prior period of abeyance, the odds of disengagement decrease by 24%. This reinforces the descriptive findings, which showed periods of disengagement—and especially multiple periods of disengagement—are relatively rare; it also suggests that users who leave but are ultimately motivated to re-engage may do so with renewed commitment.

Measures of fit and reception. Results show little support for Hypothesis 25a through 25c, which predicted that post scores, comments, and gildings would have a negative relationship to disengagement; post scores are significant but have no substantive effect, while the number of comments received shows a slight but *positive* relationship to user disengagement. For each additional comment received, the odds of disengagement increase by around 4%. As with the impact of controversiality on migration identified in Chapter 7, it is possible—likely even—that this relationship is the result of the unobserved qualitative aspects of reception. Given the overall high levels of toxicity within the Reddit manosphere communities, it is possible that toxicity, incivility, or other negative aspects of comments may be responsible for the positive effect. This, combined with the negligible impact of most other factors, further adds to the mounting evidence that the impact of indicators of fit, as measured by interactive components of Reddit’s platform

affordances, matter less within these spaces than they may in other online communities, and that if fit matters for users, they are assessing it through different metrics than those easily quantified through Reddit's platform affordances.

The unexpected effect of average time to first reply further supports this notion. Relative to receiving no replies, receiving a reply within an average of twelve hours (the mean reply time) had no significant effect. Yet, receiving a reply later on average—more than 12 hours after posting—appears to have a negative impact on the odds of disengagement. An average first reply time of more than 12 hours is associated with a 10% decrease in the odds of disengagement. Here, it again seems plausible that the qualitative characteristics of comments may shape the identified relationships; first comments received later may include more substantive engagement, for example, or may lead users to feel their initial post had greater relevance if it warranted a response even hours after posting.

Community context. Characteristics of users' primary communities show no relationships in the expected directions. The number of active users and activity levels are significant but show no substantive effect on the odds of disengagement, counter to the expectations stated in Hypotheses 26 and 27. Additionally, the percent of new users in a primary community has a significant negative relationship with the odds of disengagement, counter to what was predicted in Hypotheses 30; for each 1% increase in the proportion of new users in a community, the odds of user disengagement decrease by 3%. This suggests that contrary to prior findings on online engagement more generally, users in the Reddit manosphere may be incentivized to stay in communities that are attracting higher numbers of new members. That this is true even when also accounting for total user numbers and activity levels suggests that new users in and of themselves drive continued engagement to some degree. This finding is especially significant, because it

suggests that even though most users' presence within the Reddit manosphere is short lived, these influxes of short-term users still have potential to contribute to radicalization by encouraging some users to persist longer than they might otherwise.

Also interesting is the unexpected finding that quarantines and bans show a negative relationship with disengagement, counter to the expectations outlined in hypotheses 22a and 22b. For each additional ban within users' primary communities, the odds of disengagement decrease by 42%; for quarantines, the odds of disengagement decrease by 25%. Also interesting is that the strength of these relationships contrast with findings regarding migration; quarantines were found to have a stronger effect radicalizing effect in terms of migration to more toxic communities, but here we see that bans have a greater impact on commitment.

Previous literature on Reddit more generally has indicated that both bans and quarantines do lead some users to disengage (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017, 2021). At the same time, results from Chapter 7 also indicated that bans and quarantines increased the odds of migration into more and less toxic communities; as such, it is possible that—at least within the Reddit manosphere—these measures have an impact on where users engage, but do not ultimately serve to curb engagement more broadly. This does also align with previous findings that have indicated users participating in banned subreddits do frequently go on to engage in other spaces within the platform, even as others move off site (Chandrasekharan et al. 2017). These findings similarly lend credence to theorizing suggesting that repression measures can reinforce or increase radicalization by positively impacting users' commitments to extremist movements (della Porta 2018).

Interactions between User Toxicity and Repression. The final model also examines interaction effects between user toxicity and repression. Here, user toxicity is also included as a control, and shows a positive relationship with disengagement; for each .1 increase in user toxicity,

the odds of disengagement increase by 12%. As with previous models, results assessing interactions between user toxicity and repression also point to a moderating effect for bans, but not quarantines, suggesting that the negative effect of bans on disengagement increases in strength as user toxicity increases. This again provides significant evidence of the mixed impact of repression, and indicates that users already evincing greater extremity are more likely than others to be further radicalized by repression efforts.

CONCLUSION

Table 25 summarizes the identified direction of relationships, comparing results to hypotheses presented in Chapter 3. Overall, findings show mixed support for hypotheses related to user disengagement, but nonetheless yield interesting insights into how differential participation and radicalization operate within the Reddit manosphere. Group identity is once again implicated as especially salient, with certain communities showing higher odds of disengagement and, conversely, certain communities showing greater efficacy in drawing in users in a more lasting fashion; this suggests that the different ideologies present within the manosphere may differ in their ability to inspire true radicalization by retaining, rather than discouraging, ongoing engagement. Findings also again show that measures of fit and reception operate differently than initially anticipated. Most notably, these findings suggest that the interactional components that may encourage a sense of fit within these spaces are poorly understood, and that more attention should be paid to the qualitative elements of user interactions. As such, understanding how the qualitative components of interactions—within comment chains especially—shape users' participation is an important next step. That a higher percentage of new users has a negative impact on disengagement also serves as an important insight into the negative effects of the popularity of these communities; while initial findings that community growth is driven largely by influxes of new users who do not persist initially seems optimistic, the negative impact of this popularity on

Table 25. Summary of Findings from Analysis Modeling User Disengagement

Key Predictors	Expected Relationship to Disengagement	Hypothesis	Identified Relationship	Result
<i>User-Level Variables</i>				
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>				
Primary Community				
PUA	Reference	H ₂₈	Reference	--
MRA	Negative	H ₂₈	Negative	Supported
Incel	Positive	H ₂₈	Positive	Supported
MGTOW	Positive	H ₂₈	Positive	Supported
TRP	Negative	H ₂₈	Negative	Supported
Tenure	Negative	H ₂₄	Negative	Supported
Number of posts	Negative	H ₂₃	No effect	Not supported
Posting frequency	Negative	H ₃₁	Negative	Supported
Average post length	Negative	H ₂₉	No effect	Not supported
<i>Measures of Fit & Reception</i>				
Average post score	Negative	H _{25a}	No effect	Not supported
Comments received	Negative	H _{25b}	Positive	Not supported
Gildings received	Negative	H _{25c}	Insignificant	Not supported
Average time to first reply	Positive	H ₃₂	Positive	Partially supported
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>				
<i>Context Characteristics</i>				
Number of active users	Negative	H ₂₆	No effect	Not supported
Activity level	Negative	H ₂₇	No effect	Not supported
Percent new users	Positive	H ₃₀	Negative	Not supported
<i>Repression Measures</i>				
Quarantines implemented	Positive	H _{22a}	Negative	Not supported
Bans implemented	Positive	H _{22b}	Negative	Not supported
User toxicity x quarantines	Negative	H _{22c}	Insignificant	Not supported
User toxicity x bans	Negative	H _{22d}	Negative	Supported

disengagement suggests that commitment to extremism is positively influenced through increasing attention to these communities. Finally, findings regarding quarantines and bans suggests that these efforts in some ways serve to further the radicalization process, by increasing commitment to participation, and that this relationship is moderated by user toxicity; the negative relationship between bans and disengagement is strengthened as users grow more toxic. This suggest that not only is the effectiveness of platform-level repression measures not necessarily as high as might be hoped, but that these measures are specifically less likely to discourage the most virulent members within extremist communities. These implications, and their broader connection to the analyses in prior chapters, are discussed in the concluding chapter.

CHAPTER 9: DISCUSSION & CONCLUSION

The previous three chapters presented results of analyses testing how user posting characteristics, measures of fit and reception, individual and community experiences with repression, and community context shape differential participation and radicalization in male supremacist communities on Reddit. Overall, findings show that radicalization processes within the Reddit manosphere are impacted primarily by group identity, individual features of engagement or extremity (most notably tenure within communities and toxicity-related metrics), elements of interactions with other users (at times), and platform-level repression efforts that simultaneously discourage and exacerbate engagement in secular male supremacist communities. More specifically, group identity was found to matter across all outcomes under study, as did tenure within primary communities or the broader manosphere; user toxicity, in contrast, matters specifically for predicting trajectories into more extreme spaces. Measures of fit and reception—capturing elements of interactions with other users—appeared to matter little for most components of online radicalization processes and, where significant, seemed to implicate the qualitative components of users’ interactions as factors driving users out of online spaces more generally, rather than indicating anything specific about trajectories into extremism. Finally, instances of platform-level repression, such as the implementation of quarantines or bans, served to reduce engagement rates, but increased the odds of migration into new communities—with a stronger effect for migration into more toxic spaces. Instances of repression also decreased the odds of user disengagement, suggesting a radicalizing effect in terms of renewed commitment to extremism. In all instances, the effect of repression in the form of bans was moderated—and intensified—by user toxicity.

These findings represent several advances in theoretical understandings of online radicalization, both generally and in the context of secular male supremacism specifically. They

identify how the diversity of views present within the manosphere helps to bolster secular male supremacism; deepen understandings of the role of toxicity in moving users through these spaces; affirm that online radicalization processes are most often subject to their own logic, rather than being transformed by the relationships that shape online engagement in other spaces; and both support and problematize common forms of intervention into online extremism. In the remainder of this concluding chapter, I address these contributions and their implications more thoroughly, moving beyond summarizing and interpreting the results of hypothesis testing in order to connect back to the initial research questions and situate findings within the broader body of research focused on secular male supremacism, and on online radicalization more generally. I conclude by discussing limitations, directions for future research, and broader implications.

DISCUSSION

I began this dissertation with the goal of answering two specific questions: 1) what individual and community-level factors drive differences in engagement in male supremacist communities; and 2) what individual and community-level factors predict user migration to more extreme male supremacist spaces? These questions were developed in response to theoretical gaps in knowledge surrounding differential participation and radicalization in the online context, as well as around increasing engagement with secular male supremacist movements specifically. These questions were also informed by practical, as well as theoretical concerns; participation in far-right extremist movements—including male supremacist movements but also within other segments of the far-right such as the alt-right and conservative authoritarian movements—is on the rise (Kaiser 2022), and these groups frequently leverage the affordances of the digital context to recruit and organize (Caren et al. 2012; Daniels 2018; DeCook 2020; DiBranco 2022b; Frenkel 2021; Miltner 2014). As such, understanding the underlying processes that drive or hinder online engagement in far-right extremism is more important than ever.

The outcomes under study here can be positioned as waypoints along pathways within online radicalization processes. Engagement in extremist spaces serves as a requisite first step, while migration into more extreme spaces serves as a significant marker of trajectories into greater extremism (Mamié et al. 2021; Ribeiro et al. 2020, 2021; Russo et al. 2022). Disengagement, in contrast, highlights an alternative trajectory to increasing extremism—one that is important to understand in order to develop effective interventions into radicalization. Throughout the empirical chapters, three distinct sets of measures have been assessed to determine their impact on these waypoints: characteristics of users’ posting behaviors, measures of fit and reception, and measures of community context (including platform-level repression measures). Table 25 summarizes the identified relationships, with those operating in the expected direction based on the hypotheses outlined in Chapter 3 highlighted in bold. I now discuss each of these sets of measures in turn, identifying which individual metrics within each set matter most across all stages of the analysis, and articulating how the identified patterns deepen understandings of online radicalization processes and secular male supremacism.

Posting Characteristics

Variables related to users’ posting characteristics covered a range of factors expected to shape radicalization processes, such as group identity, tenure within communities or the broader Reddit manosphere, and the quantifiable components of users’ posts, including number of posts made, posting frequency, toxicity, toxicity alignment, and average post length. With the exception of number of posts made, all these characteristics were shown to matter at least some of the time for the outcomes under study; at the same time, the theoretical utility of the identified findings does vary some, with certain results having more salient implications for theorizing on online extremism in general, and on radicalization within the Reddit manosphere specifically.

Table 26. Summary of Identified Relationships between Key Variables and Radicalization Outcomes

		Radicalization Area			
		Engagement Rates	Migration		Disengagement
Key Predictors		Less Toxic	Both	More Toxic	
<i>User-Level Variables</i>					
<i>Posting Characteristics</i>					
1	Primary community				
	PUA	<i>Reference</i> (H ₁)	N/A	--	<i>Reference</i> (H ₂₈)
	MRA	Insignificant (H ₁)	--	Negative (H ₁₉)	Negative (H ₂₈)
	Incels	Negative (H ₁)	--	Negative (H ₁₉)	Positive (H ₂₈)
	MGTOW	Insignificant (H ₁)	Positive (H ₁₉)	--	Positive (H ₂₈)
	TRP	Negative (H ₁)	<i>Reference</i>	--	N/A
2	Tenure	Negative (H ₅)	Negative (H ₁₈)	--	Negative (H ₁₈)
3	Number of posts	No effect (H ₄)	--	No effect (H ₁₆)	No effect (H ₂₃)
4	Posting frequency	--	--	Negative (H ₁₇)	Negative (H ₃₁)
5	Average toxicity	No effect (H ₆)	No effect (H _{15a})	--	Positive (H _{15a})
6	Toxicity alignment	--	Insignificant (H _{15b})	--	Positive (H _{15b})
7	Average post length	--	--	--	No effect (H ₂₉)
<i>Indicators of Reception & Fit</i>					
8	Average post score	No effect (H _{7a})	Insignificant (H ₁₁)	--	No effect (H ₁₁)
9	Comments received	No effect (H _{7b})	--	Insignificant (H ₁₃)	--
10	Gildings received	Insignificant (H _{7c})	--	Insignificant (H ₁₄)	--
11	Controversiality	--	--	Positive (H ₁₂)	--
12	Average time to first reply	--	--	--	Negative (H ₃₂)
13	Post removal	--	--	Negative (H ₉)	--
<i>Community-Level Variables</i>					
<i>Context Characteristics</i>					
14	Number of active users	No effect (H ₂)	--	No effect (H ₂₀)	--
15	Activity level	--	No effect (H ₂₁)	--	Insignificant (H ₂₁)
16	Percent new users	--	--	--	--
17	Average toxicity	No effect (H _{3a})	--	--	--
18	Toxicity spread	No effect (H _{3b})	--	--	--
<i>Repression Measures</i>					
19	Quarantines implemented	No effect (H _{8a})	--	Positive (H _{10a})	--
20	Bans implemented	Negative (H _{8b})	--	Positive (H _{10b})	--
21	User toxicity x quarantines	Insignificant (H _{8c})	--	Insignificant (H _{10c})	--
22	User toxicity x bans	Negative (H _{8b})	Insignificant (H _{10d})	--	Positive (H _{10d})

Arguably, one of the largest contributions of this research comes from the findings surrounding group identity and its relationship to radicalization waypoints within male supremacist spaces—users’ primary communities were shown to be one of the most consistent and substantive predictors influencing differential participation and trajectories across the Reddit manosphere. As the broader manosphere has received increasing academic and media attention, scholars studying secular male supremacist groups have increasingly cautioned against treating these groups as distinct or interchangeable, arguing instead that discussions and theorizing should account for the disparate origins and applications of red pill ideology housed within the manosphere (Ging and Murphy 2021; Rothmel et al. 2022). At the same time, these arguments have largely been informed by empirical work outlining the ideological differences within these groups, or of descriptive accounts of the relative harms emerging from each group, rather than by evidence of substantive causal differences in the outcomes of groups’ varying application of red pill ideology. As such, the findings showing significant differences in terms of rates of engagement, movement into more extreme spaces, or disengagement serve to advance previous work by identifying how the different applications of male supremacist ideology present within these spaces substantively impact the intensity or efficacy with which men are radicalized.

The analytical focus on enduring or highly-active users, and the sometimes-unexpected relationships identified, also adds additional depth and nuance to scholarly understandings of how secular male supremacism operates in the online context. Much previous work, both scholarly and journalistic, has focused on the notable growth, and detrimental consequences, of newer, more toxic manosphere groups, such as the Incel or TRP communities (Bratich and Banet-Weiser 2019; Gillett and Suzor 2022; Mamié et al. 2021). However, the analyses presented here highlight the importance of communities that are often given less attention in conversations on organized male

supremacism. For example, the Incel community—given its connection to instances of mass violence—has drawn heavy attention (Baele et al. 2019; Carian, DiBranco, and Kelly 2023; Hoffman et al. 2020; Zimmerman et al. 2018), with concerns being raised about the high levels of growth in Incel spaces (Ribeiro et al. 2021). Yet, the users within the Incel community were shown to have the shortest average tenure within the Reddit manosphere, and comparatively higher rates of disengagement. While these facts do not mean that attention should not be paid to the Incel community and the alarming trend of Incel violence, they do highlight that in terms of lasting engagement with secular male supremacist ideologies, attention should also be paid to the other groups that manage to draw in more substantial or enduring engagement, particularly because these groups appear to provide a foundation through which newer communities may be bolstered or protected.

Consider the PUA community, which has received comparatively little attention relative to other segments of the manosphere. Analyses show significantly higher predicted rates of engagement for PUA users, as well as higher odds of migration to more toxic spaces; the odds of disengagement were also lower for users within this primary community compared to the newer Incel and MGTOW spaces. Prior research has also indicated a decrease in PUA activity in the post-2011 period, initially driven by a shift away from PUA or MRA participation and towards MGTOW and TRP participation, facilitated in part by user migrations between communities (Ribeiro et al. 2021). Yet, descriptive findings from Chapter 5 also indicate that participation has shifted back *towards* the PUA community from 2018 onward. In combination, these findings suggest that the PUA community—the least popular, least toxic segment of the manosphere—actually plays a relatively significant role within the network of communities. In particular, findings surrounding the odds of migration to more toxic communities, and descriptive findings

indicating increased movement back towards PUA (possibility as a result of increased sanctions in other communities) suggests that this less extreme community serves as both a launching point into extremism, *and* a fallback position for other communities. Users who endure in PUA are predicted to be more active, providing a robust community; users may also be at higher risk of movement into more toxic communities, but the space also sees an uptick in incoming migrants as participation in the Incel, MGTOW, and TRP communities begins to taper. This positions these longer, more enduring communities as a more consistent base that supports continued engagement with secular male supremacism even when newer communities evince greater volatility. This notion is further supported by the findings that indicate having the other long-standing manosphere community, MRA, as a primary community is associated with lower odds of migration to any other community, and lower odds of disengagement as well. Altogether, then, the results surrounding group identity not only add to understandings of how group differences shape radicalization processes within the Reddit manosphere, but also highlight the utility—and arguably the *necessity*—of accounting for secular male supremacism as a movement comprised of distinct groups that operate in relation to one other, and that bolster one another by providing an array of spaces through which users can flow, or into which they can settle.

Of course, group identity does not operate alone to shape these processes; with the exception of prior posting rates, other characteristics of users' posting behaviors were also shown to matter at least some of the time for the outcomes under study, indicating that group identity operates alongside the features of individual users to shape outcomes. The theoretical utility of these findings varies some across the other metrics assessed. That tenure and posting frequency evince negative relationships with the outcomes under study largely supports previous work on online engagement more generally (Arguello et al. 2006; Hamilton et al. 2017; Heiss et al. 2019;

Sadeque et al. 2016); this indicates that the processes playing out in online extremist communities do at times mirror those present within other online spaces, and offers in utility in identifying features that can be used to predict differential participation even in the absence of observable sociobiographical characteristics. At the same time, that tenure had a negative relationship with engagement rates suggests that some relationships *are* altered in the online extremist context; rather than building momentum over time, movement participants in these spaces may engage more during the early period of exposure to extremist ideologies, perhaps as part of a discovery period wherein users are more highly motivated to engage with other movement members, or to actively develop an understanding of the ideologies in question. This adds to understandings of online radicalization processes by highlighting the importance of an initial exposure period.

Finally, the findings regarding the positive effect of toxicity—here a proxy for extremism—on the odds of migration to more toxic communities supports work implicating initial extremism as a predictor of radicalization via migration to more extreme spaces (Ribeiro et al. 2021). Results also add to understandings of the relationship between toxicity and radicalization by providing insight into the specific mechanisms driving this relationship. That toxicity alignment, as well as toxicity, was positively associated with migration to more toxic spaces suggests that toxicity operates as a ‘pull’ factor guiding users out of communities and into new ones. Put differently, it appears that there is an encouraging, rather than discouraging, effect at play, and that users do not migrate due to poor reception or a perception of poor fit along toxicity lines; more toxic users instead appear to ultimately find themselves drawn to more toxic communities rather than being pushed out by other users. This also builds on previous work questioning whether toxicity drove migration to more toxic spaces, or whether users grew more

toxic after migration (Ribeiro et al. 2021); while both processes may be at play, these findings implicate toxicity as a causal driver of further radicalization, rather than a mere consequence.

Measures of Fit and Reception

A sense of fit within movements or communities, and receptions to contributions, have been identified as playing a significant role in both offline radicalization into extremist movements (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018; Vergani et al. 2020), and in shaping engagement patterns in online spaces more generally (Arguello et al. 2006; Claussen et al. 2013; Davidson 2024; Fiesler and Dym 2020; Karnstedt et al. 2011; Khan 2017; Kor-Sins 2021). The findings presented in the prior three chapters suggest that—at least as captured by elements of Reddit’s interactive features, such as post scores, comments, or gildings—the measures of fit and reception that shape online engagement more generally do not neatly translate to the online extremist context, despite remaining relevant at times. Post scores and the receipt of Reddit gold were shown to have no impact on the radicalization-related outcomes under study, and the receipt of comments only impacted the odds of disengagement—and not in the expected direction, as it was shown to *increase* the odds of disengaging. Nor were these the only unexpected findings; a higher average reply time was also shown to decrease the odds of disengaging rather than discouraging participation as expected. At the same time, controversiality was positively associated with the odds of migration to a new community.

Taken together, the findings regarding controversiality, comments, and reply times suggest that the measures of fit and reception that do shape radicalization outcomes are those that operate as mechanisms ‘pushing’ users out of communities; that these pushes do not appear to nudge users in one direction significantly more than others, however, suggests that in this regard, online extremist spaces are subject to some of the same effects online communities more generally, but

that these processes do not necessarily drive radicalization. Further, that controversiality, received comments, and long reply times show effects despite the negligible impact of other metrics such as post scores, and that these effects are sometimes in unexpected directions, heavily suggests that there is something about the *qualitative* components of interaction that explain these relationships, and which should be further explored.

Despite the absence of any identifiable radicalizing effect in terms of trajectories to more extreme spaces, these findings do offer utility for understandings of differential participation in secular male supremacist spaces by highlighting when and how interaction within these spaces shapes men's continued engagement. That the qualitative components of the interactions underlying controversiality, comment counts, and reply times have an impact on participation indicates that in terms of fit and reception, *how* users engage with each other matters far more than the *degree* to which they engage. This contributes to research on differential participation in the online context by identifying which elements of interpersonal interactions matter in extremist online spaces, and highlighting an area fruitful for future research.

Community Context

The final set of measures expected to shape radicalization outcomes among users in secular male supremacist spaces were those related to community context. Overall, findings show that features of the communities analyzed here matter very little—levels of posting activity, total users, community or manosphere toxicity, and the spread of toxicity across communities had no impact on the outcomes for which they were assessed. The singular exception appears to be the percentage of new users within primary communities and—as with so many findings—the effect was opposite what was expected; based on prior research on online communities, the percentage of new users was expected to have a positive impact on the odds of disengagement (Arguello et al. 2006), and

instead it showed negative effects, indicating that new users actually decrease the odds that existing users will cease participation. Though narrow, this finding connects interestingly to the descriptive results presented in Chapter 5 and Chapter 6; remember that most users engage for only a year, and that the descriptive account of the development of the Reddit manosphere found that year-to-year community growth was driven primarily by influxes of these new and short-term users, rather than by the amassing of an enduring user base. Remember also that the analysis of disengagement includes only users present for at least two years. Taken together, this indicates that within the Reddit manosphere, the attraction of new users has a preserving or invigorating effect—that those already participating become less likely to cease engagement as their communities gain new attention. Put succinctly, the explosion in popularity seen among a number of manosphere communities appears to help retain users in these extremist spaces, even when new users do not necessarily persist. This finding advancing understandings of differential participation in the online extremist context by highlighting one specific mechanism through which engagement is prolonged—the attraction of new, even if fleeting, members.

In contrast to the internal features of communities, external influence in the form of platform-level repression efforts were also found to have a consistent and substantive effect—one of the factors besides group identity and tenure to show such. This is in many ways unsurprising: repression has been identified as a salient component of the radicalization process, serving as one of the primary drivers of extremism in the offline context (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018). Findings also show that not all platform-level repression efforts matter equally: quarantines had no substantive effect on rates of engagement, but did show effects on migration and disengagement, with an especially strong influence on migration to more toxic spaces. Further, the results indicate that these repression efforts do not always operate as intended: bans were

associated with a decrease in engagement rates, and both bans and quarantines had a positive impact on migration into new communities. This suggests that while bans and quarantines are effective for pushing users out of specific spaces, this comes with the risk of encouraging radicalization by driving at least some of these users into even more extreme communities. This aligns with previous work on repression, which has found that repression may have dual effect, serving to temper engagement from more moderate members while simultaneously further radicalizing those already more committed to the cause (della Porta 2018; Zwerman et al. 2000). Further, both quarantines and bans had a negative effect on the odds of user disengagement, suggesting that the impact of these repressive measures may be more broadly reinforcing of commitment to secular male supremacist ideology, which again aligns with previous findings that repression can intensify commitment to extremist movements (Borum 2011; van den Bos 2020; della Porta 2018). Findings also showed that the radicalizing effect of bans as a measure of repression interacted with user-level toxicity, such that users with higher levels of toxicity saw stronger radicalizing effects. Taken together, it appears that while platform-level repression efforts have a shuffling effect driving users to new (and more likely more toxic communities), that these interventions ultimately may not work as intended.⁴⁴ The findings regarding quarantines and bans also build on previous literature on online radicalization and secular male supremacism by confirming that the forms of digital repression most often utilized in the Western democratic

⁴⁴ This is, of course, assuming that intention of community quarantines and bans is to reduce the spread or impact of extremist ideologies. Given the reluctance of Reddit platform administrators to intervene in highly problematic communities prior to the attraction of notable negative media attention or high levels of public criticism (addressed in Chapter 5), a more cynical perspective could argue that quarantines and bans are effective in that they remove specific communities attracting negative attention, regardless of impact on the overall ecology of extremism present on the platform.

context operate similar to those identified offline, and by identifying specific processes that drive users in particular male supremacist communities into other, more toxic spaces.

CONCLUSION

So then, the results of the analyses presented in this dissertation point to two broad but notable findings: that radicalization within secular male supremacist communities on Reddit is shaped primarily by group identity, individual features of engagement or extremity, and indirect components of users' interactions; and that these factors operate alongside platform-level repression efforts, which intersect with individual extremism, to influence differential participation and user trajectories across these spaces. These findings advance literatures on secular male supremacism, differential participation, and online radicalization in a number of ways. First, the findings showing significant differences across manosphere groups advance theorizing beyond the level of describing ideologies, and towards developing understandings of how the different applications of red pill ideology found within these spaces impact the intensity or efficacy with which men are radicalized into secular male supremacism. The analyses also show how the existence of distinct groups within the manosphere actually helps it to function and endure, bolstering the broader male supremacist movement by providing an array of spaces into which users can settle, or through which they can flow in response to both increasing radicalization or attempts at repression. Second, the findings regarding toxicity highlight not just that there *is* a relationship between user toxicity and online radicalization, but move towards isolating toxicity's radicalizing effects. Third, the qualitative components of user interactions are implicated as an important factor in differential participation, and one that needs further attention to fully understand how some users, but not others, ultimately move into, through, or out of from these spaces. Finally, the results highlight the mixed effectiveness of platform-level interventions into extremism identifying that—at least within the context of far-right communities—these

interventions are not as efficacious as may be hoped, and affirming that even in the online context, repression may have a notable and undesirable radicalizing effect.

In the remainder of this final section, I move beyond these findings to discuss their limitations and potential suggestions for future research, as well as their broader social implications.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

While the current study advances understandings of online radicalization processes, it is not without its limitations. First and foremost is the absence of any additional sociodemographic or background characteristics for the users under study; while the incorporation of fixed/random effects in the analyses presented aids in accounting for unobserved subject characteristics, an ideal analysis of online radicalization processes would allow for a more comprehensive account of both the digital *and* sociobiographical characteristics that have been shown to impact extremism. While it may be especially difficult to collect such information about users engaging in misogynist movements due to both their predilection for harassment of feminist thinkers (Banet-Weiser and Miltner 2016; Massanari 2017; Sobieraj 2020), and expressions of contempt for those who seek to study these online communities (DiBranco 2022a; Sobieraj 2020), future research would benefit from the incorporation of this data. This is especially true given that previous work has implicated racial masculinities specifically as playing a significant role in some secular male supremacist spaces (Gheorghe 2024; Jaki et al. 2019; Rothermel et al. 2022). Given one particularly salient consequence of secular male supremacism is the potential for expanding far-right recruitment to groups previously excluded by an emphasis on white nationalism, accounting for racial identity in the processes driving radicalization within these spaces would provide wide benefits for further understanding the implications of these groups. Alternatives to collecting such data from users

directly—which comes with risks of both researcher harm and biased data—may include using computational approaches to extract details on user characteristics from users’ post histories.

A second key limitation is the absence of any qualitative analysis. As previously discussed in Chapters 7 and 8, the qualitative elements of interactions between users may offer explanatory power in understanding the relationship between controversiality, comments, reply times, and key outcomes; accounting for these components of interactions in extremist spaces would thus offer utility for better understanding how interactional processes shape radicalization. More generally, a deeper understanding of the qualitative contents of users’ contributions to the communities under study may identify additional factors that shape engagement rates, migration, or disengagement; this is particularly true when considering the migration component of user trajectories into extremism, where understanding how users construct discursive boundaries between groups may be especially useful. Further, the negative effect of tenure on engagement seemingly points to something novel about users’ initial introductions into the Reddit manosphere; qualitative assessment of users’ contributions during earlier and later periods of engagement would provide further insight into how radicalization operates within these spaces.

Third, and related, is the analyses’ emphasis on toxicity as a measure of extremism. On the one hand, the analysis of community-level toxicity aligned fairly well with prior research’s qualitative assessments of the relative extremity of the views expressed within each community under study, which identified newer communities as more toxic or misogynistic (Farrell et al. 2019; Ribeiro et al. 2021). On the other hand, using toxicity as a proxy for extremism at the user level runs the risk of conflating incivility, vulgarity, or similar facets of speech with ideological extremism; this is an unavoidable risk when assessing toxicity through the use of pretrained models aimed at assessing general toxicity rather than specific forms of extremity, but is also one that

should be more carefully considered by scholars attempting to use computational approaches to assessing ideology. Potential solutions include the construction of machine learning models aimed specifically at identifying far-right extremist speech, or the application of multiple computational assessments in combination—for example, combining toxicity metrics with misogyny dictionaries and sentiment analysis to better capture the multi-faceted nature of discourse within these spaces. Particularly in a climate of mounting far-right extremism, the ability to confidently and accurately highlight the degree to which users embrace extremist ideology would offer great utility.

Finally, the analysis of migration here focuses specifically on migration to more or less toxic communities, rather than incorporating any causal assessment of migration between specific facets of the manosphere. Given that previous work identified shifts between ideologically disparate spaces (Ribeiro et al. 2021), and that the descriptive findings in Chapter 5 confirmed these findings, work that more squarely centers movements between the different communities may yield additional insights into how secular male supremacism operates in the online context, and may help to highlight where movements between more or less extreme communities are shaped purely by toxicity rankings, or are informed by broader ideological relationships.

Concluding Remarks

This dissertation contributes to understandings of online radicalization processes by highlighting the user characteristics, measures of reception and fit, and community context measures that shape radicalization at three points: engagement, migration into new or more toxic spaces, and disengagement. Throughout, I have identified that group identity and tenure within communities are some of the most significant factors, while measures of fit matter less for radicalization specifically, and more for pushing users out of specific online extremist spaces and into different ones. Findings also suggest that the less easily quantifiable components of users’

interactions may matter most for understanding how fit and reception push or pull users through these spaces.

Finally, results highlight the uneven efficacy of platform-level measures of repression, which may succeed in pushing users out of extremist spaces, though with the caution that this may ultimately drive users to more extreme iterations of these communities, and renew their commitments to these movements. This appears especially so for users evincing higher levels of extremism. In a context of increasing online organizing for far-right extremist groups, this finding in particular has salient practical implications—deplatforming in general is one of the most accessible interventions through which platforms may attempt to curb extremism, and quarantines and subreddit bans are one of the few efforts made by Reddit administrators to prevent extremist groups from organizing and recruiting on the platform. Yet, the findings outlined here suggest the need to think critically about the consequences of easy interventions, and to develop alternative or more comprehensive solutions to these issues. In particular, platforms such as Reddit that draw on a more libertarian ethos should consider the long-term costs of permissiveness—extremist communities grow more-so over time, and within an ecology of related yet distinct spaces, more moderate iterations of extremist groups seem to provide scaffolding upon which intensification can occur, and through which repression can be weathered. This suggests that intervening earlier and more comprehensively—by deplatforming far-right views like secular male supremacism before communities take a strong hold, and by eliminating entire communities or networks of communities, rather than individual subreddits—may help to attenuate the potential negative consequences of bans by enacting them before a critical mass of users can accrue. Such strong stances are important now more than ever given the general trend towards increasing far-right engagement in the contemporary United States.

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